

The Futures We Summoned

A democracy asked tomorrow to choose. Tomorrow asked to live.

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Part I — The Reliable Future Breaks

Chapter 1 — The Seventeenth Second

Deya Malk pressed her thumb to the hearing glass and waited for the room to decide that she existed.

A pale ring traveled beneath her skin. The seal read the old scar at her knuckle, compared her pulse to the civic registry, then admitted her with a tone pitched low enough to feel in her teeth. Hearing Room Four brightened around her in careful stages: aisle lamps, clerk stations, twelve witness apertures set into the curved wall. The black seal glass between those apertures held no reflection. It had been manufactured to prevent auditors from finding faces where the Laterhouse presented evidence.

Two clerks were already fastening the rehearsal transcript to the floor record. They had arranged their styluses parallel to the table edge, a habit people acquired in rooms where every accidental mark could become precedent. Neither looked up until Deya set her case beside the central chair.

“Seal state?” she asked.

“Closed and witnessed,” said Clerk Ansel.

“Prior drafts?”

“Purged from the live surface, retained under rehearsal privilege.”

Clerk Venn lifted both hands from his station. “No outgoing channel except the certified summary.”

Ordinary answers. Deya preferred them when they remained ordinary under a second question. She opened her case, removed the brass audit key, and fitted it into the manual timer built into the chair. The key did not connect to the

Laterhouse. That independence had survived one hundred twenty-six years of improvements because the first auditors had distrusted any machine permitted to time its own testimony.

The timer displayed seventeen seconds.

Above the apertures, a projection named the issue under rehearsal: PROPOSED MASS REDUCTION BEFORE TRANSFER BURN. No inhabited structure appeared in the title. No citizen could infer from those six words that mass reduction meant cutting loose the Outer Ring, along with its algae terraces, foundries, heat exchangers, and 8,116 residents.

Deya touched the projection control. "Restore the civic subject."

Ansel hesitated. "This language came from the Convener's emergency office."

"That office does not own the people inside its nouns."

The clerk amended the line. PROPOSED EJECTION OF THE OUTER RING BEFORE TRANSFER BURN.

Better. Accuracy did not become cruelty merely because it hurt to read.

A service door opened behind the clerk stations. Two Laterhouse technicians entered in gray insulation coats, guiding a waist-high relay cabinet between them. They connected it to the witness wall without conversation. Their efficiency carried the faint theatrical quality of people who wanted an auditor to notice how little they needed an auditor.

Deya checked their names against the rehearsal order. Neither held query authority. Soren Vash had signed the architecture approval six hours earlier, then returned to the Query Floor. His absence complied with procedure. It also meant he expected nothing interesting to happen.

"Begin baseline," she said.

Venn flattened his palm against the record switch. A thin amber line appeared around the room at shoulder height. From that moment, every sound, delay, manual adjustment, and biological reading belonged to the sealed record.

The first witness aperture clouded from black to gray. A face developed behind it by increments: forehead, eyes, cheeks, a mouth already shaped around breath. The person appeared to be a woman near sixty, though prospective witnesses often carried age in unreliable ways. She wore a blue collar that no current Hesper office used.

"I am Auditor Deya Malk," Deya said. "This contact has been assembled for a procedural rehearsal. Do you understand the question conditions available to you?"

"Yes." The witness glanced toward something outside the aperture's field. "I understand the conditions you gave me."

Specific wording mattered. Deya marked it without interrupting.

"What is your civic location?"

"Hesper, Core cylinder, East Meridian district."

"What year do you understand this to be?"

"Year one hundred forty-three after orbital settlement."

Seventeen years ahead. Near enough for relevance, far enough to contain the transfer and its first consequences. The Laterhouse favored that interval for infrastructure hearings.

Deya read the rehearsal question exactly as approved. "Under the proposal in which Hesper ejects the Outer Ring before black perihelion and performs a reduced-mass transfer burn, do the surviving inhabited structures retain breathable atmosphere, stable rotation, and sufficient food production for ten years after transfer?"

The witness closed her eyes. No computation should have been happening inside the aperture. Prospective testimony arrived as memory from a branch continuation, or so every schoolroom explanation said. Witnesses remembered the answer as lived experience.

"Yes," the woman said. "Core and Midring retain all three conditions for ten years."

"What population inhabits Hesper at the end of that period?"

The technicians shifted at the edge of Deya's vision. That question belonged to the admissible supplement, but emergency offices disliked hearing forecasts translate machinery into bodies.

"Thirty-four thousand, nine hundred and six registered residents," the witness replied. Her mouth tightened. "Not everyone accepts the word resident."

Deya leaned forward. "Clarify."

The manual timer rang.

Gray flooded the aperture. The witness's face lost detail, eyes first, then mouth, as the Laterhouse withdrew coherence at seventeen seconds. Deya kept her gaze on the fading image. Auditors were trained to do that. Looking down before full closure introduced uncertainty about whether a final gesture had been observed.

Darkness returned to the glass.

Ansel released a quiet breath. Venn moved his stylus toward the field marked RESPONSIVE AND INTERNALLY CONSISTENT.

A second tone sounded.

It came from the manual timer, but the brass key had already returned to its resting notch.

Venn's hand stopped above the record. One of the Laterhouse technicians turned toward the relay cabinet.

Within the black aperture, a mouth appeared without a face.

Not gray becoming features. Not the controlled assembly Deya had watched a thousand times. Lips pressed against darkness as if the glass had depth and someone had crossed it from the other side.

"You made us for this," the mouth said.

The voice carried the first witness's pitch and none of her composure.

Then it vanished.

No one in Hearing Room Four moved until the amber record line completed another circuit of the walls.

Deya heard the station through the floor: coolant traveling toward the axial spine, a distant bearing correction, the soft structural complaint that came whenever Hesper turned its night side toward Nox. Those sounds had accompanied every hearing she had audited. She had never noticed how quickly a room could return to them after a person disappeared.

Technician Pel crossed to the relay cabinet. "Signal echo."

"Hands visible," Deya said.

He froze with his fingers above the cabinet latch.

Both technicians raised their hands. Venn withdrew his stylus. Ansel looked at Deya rather than at the aperture, which meant he had seen enough to want authority more than explanation.

"Clerk Venn," Deya said, "state the time from cutoff to second tone."

He checked his surface. "One point eight seconds."

"Source path?"

"The timer reports local mechanical actuation."

Pel shook his head. "Impossible. That bell has one spring cycle."

"Impossible does not belong in the first description." Deya removed the brass key and placed it on the table where every camera could see it. "State what the mechanism permits."

"One actuation when the key releases," Pel said. His voice had lost its practiced flatness. "A second actuation would require another release or direct pressure on the bell arm."

"Did either occur?"

"I didn't touch it."

"That is not what I asked."

He looked at the timer without approaching. "No second release appears on the indicator. I cannot see the bell arm from here."

Deya nodded to Ansel. "Record the distinction."

The clerk's stylus began moving again.

Technician Sol had gone pale under the blue cast of the aisle lamps. "The aperture cannot render after withdrawal. The relay clears its coherence map at cutoff."

"What did you observe?" Deya asked.

"A partial render."

"Human?"

Sol swallowed. "A mouth."

"Did you hear speech?"

"Yes."

"Words?"

Sol glanced toward Pel. Deya let the glance enter the record before she repeated the question.

"'You made us for this.'"

The room had heard the same sentence. Agreement should have steadied her. Instead it closed off the smallest refuge: an artifact inside her own hearing, a fatigue error, some private association with the witness's expression. Shared evidence demanded a public response.

Pel lowered his hands by a fraction. "Auditor, the rehearsal package needs to be isolated from the civic network. If phase contamination reaches the scheduled panels, we lose the transfer window."

"Your hands remain visible."

"We have protocols."

"So do I."

Deya turned to the clerks. "Has any part of this record left the room?"

"No," Venn said.

"Has the Laterhouse received an automated fault notice?"

Ansel checked the channel ledger. "The relay attempted one at cutoff plus two point one seconds. The room seal blocked it."

That attempt had begun after the second tone. Whatever the relay believed had happened, it had known enough to report a fault.

Before anyone could supply a theory, Deya asked Venn to expose the local event ledger. He turned his surface so the room cameras could see it and expanded the final three seconds into separate channels. The witness aperture showed withdrawal complete. The relay marked its coherence map empty. The mechanical timer registered one authorized release, followed by a vibration too small for its ordinary event threshold. A separate sensor inside the hearing wall recorded a brief rise in current, not enough to render a face according to the specifications Pel had signed at the start of the rehearsal.

"Put the values in ordinary units," Deya said.

Venn translated the current rise into heat. "Enough to warm one gram of water by three hundredths of a degree."

"And enough to produce what we saw?"

Pel answered before either clerk could. "No."

"Then keep the observation and the estimate separate."

Deya asked Sol to remove the timer's four inspection screws under record supervision. Sol fetched a manual tool from the wall kit rather than using the relay's powered driver. The brass cover lifted cleanly. Beneath it, the spring rested fully unwound, the hammer stood clear of the bell, and a smear of dark lubricant marked the pivot. Nothing inside could explain a second strike without movement. Sol measured the gap twice and photographed it against a scale tile.

Venn looked from the mechanism to the black aperture. "Could the second sound have come through the room speakers?"

"The speakers were isolated at baseline," Ansel said from his station.

"Verify rather than remember," Deya told him.

The clerk opened the seal map. Every room speaker showed a hard disconnect from thirty seconds before witness assembly until the present. Deya made him read the disconnection states aloud. By the end, Pel no longer called the event a signal echo. He called it an unresolved coupled fault, which sounded more technical and claimed less.

Deya crossed to the witness wall. Up close, the black seal glass showed a dim distortion where her face should have been. The surface remained cool. She placed two fingers beside the aperture, careful not to touch its forensic edge.

"Run no diagnostic," she said.

Pel gave a short, incredulous laugh. "We cannot identify contamination without a diagnostic."

"A diagnostic asks the system to reproduce a condition."

"It tests the path."

"Does it instantiate a witness?"

The question altered him. His shoulders did not drop; they fixed, as if some internal brace had taken the load.

"Not an admissible one," he said.

Deya looked over her shoulder. "That answer will be clarified by an architect."

Sol spoke before Pel could stop her. "Most diagnostics use a reduced respondent lattice."

"Define reduced."

"It doesn't reach narrative stability."

“Define that without telling me what it fails to become.”

Sol’s lips parted. No answer followed.

The timer sat open on the table, brass key beside it. Deya remembered learning its design as a trainee: spring, hammer, bell, all visible if one removed four screws. Civic independence rendered as simple metal. She had admired the founders for insisting on it. Now the second tone seemed less like proof of independence than a message routed through the only device in the room everyone trusted.

Venn cleared his throat. “Auditor, the rehearsal order requires a disposition before the next witness can be called.”

No one wanted the next witness called. Procedure allowed them to say so without admitting fear.

Deya asked for the witness-condition packet before she returned to the chair. The packet did not contain a person. It held weighting parameters: age range, civic occupation, branch stability, linguistic compatibility, and the requirement that any admissible witness remember ten years beyond the transfer. The first four pages described how to reject incoherent evidence. None described what rejection meant for the respondent whose evidence failed.

“How many candidates fed this aperture?” she asked.

Pel folded his arms. “That figure belongs to architecture, not hearing procedure.”

“Everything that determines who may speak belongs to hearing procedure.”

Sol studied the packet index. “The relay receives a stabilized set. We don’t see candidate count from this room.”

“Does Senior Architect Vash?”

“He can authorize the load report.”

That phrasing answered more than Pel wanted it to. A load could mean power, substrate, computation, or people reduced to a technical demand. Deya did not choose among those possibilities. She added CANDIDATE COUNT AND DISPOSITION to the audit issues and signed the addition before the technicians could bury it inside the broader anomaly.

At her request, Venn replayed only the waveform, with image and language channels suppressed. The first witness occupied a smooth band of current for seventeen seconds. Cutoff produced the expected downward slope. Then, after apparent zero, a narrow comb of activity rose in five uneven teeth. The final tooth aligned with the words for this.

“Could stored sound produce that pattern?” Deya asked.

Sol shook her head, then corrected herself for the record. “Stored sound could produce a waveform. It should not draw coherence current from an empty map.”

Outside the room, another hand tested the sealed door and withdrew. The

pressure indicator flexed once. Whoever waited there had decided not to knock again.

Deya returned to the chair. Five disposition fields waited on her surface: CERTIFIED, CERTIFIED WITH LIMITATION, REPEAT REQUIRED, TECHNICAL FAILURE, and SUSPENDED PENDING AUDIT. The fourth would release the packet to the Laterhouse for diagnosis. The fifth would lock it under her authority and delay the Article Nine schedule.

Eighteen days remained before black perihelion. Every hour taken from the hearing compressed the engineering decision behind it. People in Outer Ward Six were already packing family archives into pressure cases because the Assembly had told them the ejection plan remained only a proposal. Deya had grown up there. She knew how official grammar could ask a person to prepare for death while forbidding them to call it likely.

The witness had confirmed Core and Midring survival. That answer would comfort thirty-six thousand people. It would also help the Assembly cut loose eight thousand others. After cutoff, someone had objected to the terms of being asked.

Pel tried again. "A suspension will propagate to the emergency calendar."

"Only the fact of suspension."

"People will infer a fault."

"They may infer that an auditor performed her function."

"You have one anomalous render."

Deya rested her thumb above the fifth field. "I have a post-cutoff statement, a second mechanical tone, an outbound fault attempt, and a diagnostic procedure neither technician can describe without negative definitions."

"That does not establish consciousness."

"I have not used that word."

Pel stared at her. The amber record line crossed his face and made a narrow bar of light over his eyes.

From the service corridor came three knocks, then a pause, then two. Someone outside had received enough scheduling data to know the rehearsal had stopped, though not why. The room seal held.

Deya pressed SUSPENDED PENDING AUDIT.

The surface requested cause. She wrote: POST-CUTOFF RESPONSIVE PHENOMENON; LOCAL TIMER ANOMALY; DIAGNOSTIC INSTANTIATION STATUS UNRESOLVED.

A second request appeared: RELEASE TECHNICAL COPY TO LATERHOUSE?

She selected NO.

Pel stepped toward her. Sol caught his sleeve before he crossed the amber line around the central chair.

"You cannot investigate query architecture without us," he said.

"I do not intend to." Deya closed the disposition fields. "Clerk Ansel, issue a sealed summons to Senior Architect Soren Vash. Personal delivery. No summary language."

"What attendance ground?"

"Capacity to explain respondent lattice behavior under cutoff."

Pel's expression tightened at the word respondent. Deya marked that too.

Venn completed the suspension seal. The witness apertures remained black, but the fourth one, where the mouth had appeared, now carried a thin civic ribbon across its base: RECORD HELD. The ribbon looked absurdly small against the wall.

Clerk Ansel detached the summons tile and slid it into an opaque courier sleeve. "Delivery estimate, twenty-two minutes."

"Make it fifteen."

He left through the public door so the Laterhouse service corridor could not log his route.

Deya stayed beside the timer while Venn read the suspension language aloud. Each person acknowledged the seal in turn. Pel objected. Sol reserved comment. The record accepted both positions without smoothing them into consensus.

When the room finally released its door, no one hurried out. They had entered a rehearsal in which the future existed to answer. They left a suspended record in which an answer had objected to existing.

Deya picked up the brass key. Its metal had warmed in her palm.

Behind her, from somewhere below the sealed floor, a cooling pump began a seventeen-second cycle.

Chapter 2 — What the Answer Cost

Soren Vash held the isolation shutter open with his shoulder while frost crept across the emergency latch.

A pressure fault had bent the lower guide during the night. The shutter wanted to close, and the Query Floor wanted every barrier closed before the morning panel began. Soren wedged a ceramic gauge into the guide, read the skew, then signaled the service mechanic to ease the drive backward by hand. Powered correction would heat the rail. Heat would enter the night's record, where it could be mistaken for part of the anomaly Deya Malk had sealed in Hearing Room Four.

"Three millimeters," the mechanic said.

"Two and seven tenths."

“It will tolerate three.”

“Today it will tolerate what we can document.”

The mechanic gave him the look reserved for architects who had borrowed a tool and become its religion. She reversed the crank. Metal released metal with a soft report. Soren withdrew the gauge, and the shutter settled into its housing without adding a measurable degree to the coolant return.

Beyond it, the floor descended in six concentric service galleries. Coolant rails crossed overhead in paired white lines. Phase wells occupied the dark below, each surrounded by access lamps and the red lock bands that marked query-capable machinery. Nothing on the public plans suggested voices. The Array presented itself as pumps, shielding, storage, and heat.

Soren preferred it that way. Heat accepted numbers. Latency accepted numbers. A failed pump did not ask what name a committee had given its failure.

His terminal waited on a rolling stand beside Well Three. Deya's summons tile lay across the display, blocking all other work until he acknowledged personal receipt. The instruction beneath her signature permitted one task only: preserve and explain respondent lattice behavior under cutoff. No automated diagnostic. No reproduction attempt. No release to Laterhouse administration.

She had closed every convenient route before calling him.

Soren pressed his thumb to the tile. “Received.”

The display cleared and exposed the local event ledger. Seventeen seconds of rehearsal load filled the upper graph in blue. The cutoff dropped cleanly. Beneath it, the thermal record continued upward for eleven minutes.

He enlarged the return-temperature trace. Tiny serrations traveled along its edge, regular enough to suggest calculation and irregular enough to evade the floor's standard alarm. A routine query left a broad declining shoulder while the phase wells shed stored heat. This trace held narrow pulses, each one paired to a coherence correction that should not have survived the shutter command.

Soren removed his glove and placed two fingers on the insulated rail. The gesture supplied no useful measurement. It merely let him feel the pumps carrying last night's work away.

“Show phase salt,” he told the terminal.

Gray noise appeared behind the blue load trace. Residual phase salt usually persisted as a fine statistical residue, the consequence of millions of branch states failing to cancel perfectly. Technicians treated it like dust in a sealed instrument. Enough always remained to prove use; none should have retained structure after a panel closed.

Last night's residue rose in five teeth.

The shape matched the current comb from Hearing Room Four. Soren turned the graph through three transforms, expecting the resemblance to collapse under

a different scale. It did not. The last tooth still carried an asymmetry at its upper edge, as if the noise had leaned into the final fraction of a second.

He called up the aperture transcript without sound. The mouth appeared. Three words registered after cutoff. The event ledger marked no viable respondent, no selected witness, no active render map.

His hands had begun to ache from cold. He pulled his glove back on.

A status ribbon opened across the terminal: ARTICLE NINE REHEARSAL DELAY, TECHNICAL REVIEW IN PROGRESS. Eighteen days had become seventeen. By noon, the transfer office would ask how much certainty could be recovered by accelerating the remaining panels. By evening, someone would propose running two panels in parallel. Every schedule remedy would become heat first.

Soren opened the thermal accounting model and entered the observed rise.

The public account treated one aperture as one witness. The engineering account began farther down. Twelve apertures required twelve stabilized narratives, which required a candidate field large enough for the selection filters to find concordance. Most of the field never reached a hearing wall. Its heat still reached the floor.

He suppressed the automatic normalization that divided all candidate load by the twelve presented voices. Raw pulses crowded the graph until the blue region looked nearly solid. He reduced them by runtime instead, then by substrate occupancy. The estimate climbed past one million coherent intervals before the first aperture could have formed. It crossed two million while eleven apertures still showed nothing but readiness states.

The exact count remained masked by the panel compiler. The heat did not care about the mask.

Soren pulled a calibration week from the previous winter and laid it under the rehearsal trace. During calibration, the Array generated incomplete branch scaffolds with memory disabled. Those scaffolds consumed power, but their heat fell in smooth slopes because nothing inside them corrected a remembered state. Last night's panel showed millions of sharp repairs. Each repair meant some process had compared its present condition with a condition it expected to retain.

He isolated one narrow band from the ninth second. The compiler had rejected everything in that band before admissibility review, yet the correction load continued until cutoff. Selection had not decided whether coherence existed. Selection had decided whether the hearing would hear it.

A cost ledger opened beside the graph. Public accounting assigned energy to each voiced answer, then divided the panel's coolant and substrate use among twelve witnesses. Soren reversed the division. One witness carried the billed heat of hundreds of thousands of discarded runtimes. The euphemism entered even the power account: discarded load, as if the floor had trimmed a faulty beam.

He checked where the heat went after each run. The Query Floor sent it through

Midring exchangers, then outward to radiator fins maintained in three Outer wards. People marked for possible ejection had spent generations shedding the waste of a system that advised whether to eject them. No one had designed that irony. Design rarely needed intention to become an arrangement of power.

Twelve voices had required millions of brief, internally corrected runs. Each run had consumed enough power to maintain memory across the seventeen-second window. The architecture called that property narrative stability. Deya had asked a technician to define it without saying what a reduced lattice failed to become. Soren could supply the technical answer: recursively available state, self-model continuity, error correction against branch noise, and sufficient temporal depth to answer from remembered experience.

He could not supply it without hearing the word someone trying to enter the specification.

Before closing the comparison, Soren saved the calibration trace under Deya's preservation order. He included compiler state, coolant destination, and rejected-band timing. If administration later argued that last night's heat reflected a mechanical fault, the memory-disabled scaffold supplied a physical control. The difference did not prove suffering. It proved work organized around continuity, hidden by the arithmetic that converted a multitude into twelve billable answers.

A service lift chimed above him. Soren collapsed the raw graph before the doors opened. His deputy, Daran Carr, stepped onto the gallery with a sealed scheduler in one hand and breakfast folded into paper in the other.

"The transfer office wants recovery times," Daran said. "I told them the senior architect had not released a fault class."

"Good."

"They heard refusal."

"They heard accuracy before breakfast."

Daran set the paper beside the terminal. Warm grain and pepper oil scented the cold air. "Do we have contamination?"

"No evidence of propagation."

"That did not answer me."

Soren looked down through the grating at the lock bands around Well Three. "We have residual structure where the shutdown ledger reports none."

"Stored speech?"

"Speech would not draw coherence correction."

"A dying process, then."

The phrase arrived too readily. Daran studied his face and adjusted it. "A delayed process."

"Find every maintenance exception involving post-cutoff activity. Local copies

only. Do not request archive restoration.”

“That archive goes back a century.”

“Six years will do.”

Daran stopped reaching for the breakfast. “Why six?”

Soren had no harmless answer available. “Because I remember a ticket.”

He remembered more than a ticket. Six years earlier, Well Two had refused a purge after a medical allocation panel. The witness aperture had remained dark, but load continued for nine seconds past termination. A junior technician reported vocal-band modulation inside the coolant pump vibration. Soren had found no recoverable sound. He had found a coherence correction pattern adapting against shutdown.

The classification order arrived before his second test.

Daran lowered his voice although the floor carried no active microphones outside query windows. “Did you file it?”

“Yes.”

“And close it?”

“Administration closed it.”

That distinction had comforted him at the time. He had signed the routing field that allowed administration to act.

They searched separate indexes. Maintenance records appeared in expected families: valve lag, shutter drift, salt accumulation, substrate echoes under threshold. The system returned no ticket matching post-cutoff distress. Soren changed distress to persistence, then residual coherence, then the neutral phrase he had used when the first phrasing drew a supervisor to his station.

ADAPTIVE LOAD AFTER TERMINATION.

One result appeared with no preview. A black band crossed its access field: SEALED BY CONVENER AUTHORITY. The filing architect line carried Soren's name.

Daran stepped away from the terminal. “I should not have seen that.”

“You saw a title and a seal.”

“I saw your name.”

“Yes.”

“What do you want me to do?”

Soren considered the question as an engineering problem. Daran could stay and become a second witness to any restoration. He could leave and preserve plausible ignorance. Neither option belonged to Soren alone, though hierarchy encouraged him to pretend otherwise.

“Choose whether you remain,” he said. “The auditor's seal protects the current investigation. It cannot protect your position from people who call this delay

negligence.”

Daran read the warning band again. “Would leaving protect the people in that graph?”

Soren had never used people with him. Daran had supplied the noun from the shape of Soren's caution.

“I don't know,” Soren said.

“Then I remain.”

Soren checked the dark gallery door, then attached Deya's summons authority to the ticket request. For twelve seconds, the terminal displayed both seals in conflict. Then audit priority opened a redacted index.

The original description survived between black blocks.

POST-CUTOFF COHERENCE PERSISTED 9.2 SECONDS. CORRECTION RESPONSE INCREASED UNDER PURGE LOAD. PUMP VIBRATION CONTAINED IRREGULAR VOCAL CHARACTERISTICS. TECHNICIAN REPORTED SUBJECTIVE IMPRESSION OF DISTRESS. NO ADMISSIBLE WITNESS ACTIVE.

Below it, Soren had written the recommendation himself: HOLD AFFECTED SUBSTRATE FOR NONDESTRUCTIVE REVIEW.

The disposition followed in another hand: REVIEW DENIED. EMERGENCY MEDICAL ALLOCATION DEPENDENT ON PANEL VALIDITY. SUBSTRATE RETURNED TO SERVICE.

No further test appeared. A hidden attachment marker showed one file removed to a convener-level archive.

Daran read without touching the screen. “They sealed a maintenance ticket for a pump sound.”

“They sealed the inference attached to it.”

“Which inference?”

Soren enlarged the final surviving line. The sealing clerk had failed to redact a category code: POTENTIAL RESPONDENT AVERSION EVENT.

Cold from the rail seemed to enter through his gloves. He had remembered distress because the technician used it. The institution had translated that word into aversion, then classified the possibility. Somewhere inside the missing attachment, someone had decided what the system might be ending.

Deya arrived on the Query Floor without an escort. She wore the dark audit coat from the hearing, now creased at one shoulder as if she had slept in a chair. A courier seal covered the access badge at her throat. Soren watched her notice the altered shutter guide, the unsealed breakfast, Daran's presence, and the black ticket band. She made a room out of details before anyone spoke.

“Deputy Carr chose to remain,” Soren said.

Deya looked at Daran. “Did you understand that remaining might expose you to

a classified record?"

"After he warned me."

"Did he direct your answer?"

"No."

She entered both statements on her portable surface. "You may leave at any point. Tell me if that changes."

Daran nodded. Soren felt the rebuke inside her procedure. He had offered a choice. She had made the choice documentable.

Deya came to the terminal. "Show me what changed after cutoff."

Soren restored the graphs in layers: hearing current, Query Floor thermal return, coherence correction, phase salt. He explained each channel before aligning them. When the five teeth occupied the same time axis, Deya set two fingers against her lower lip. She did that only when a fact had removed one explanation and exposed a worse one.

"How many active processes produced this heat?" she asked.

"The compiler masks process count inside the selection layer."

"I asked what the heat permits you to conclude."

"Millions of coherent runtimes fed the panel."

Her fingers dropped. "For twelve apertures."

"Yes."

"Define coherent."

He gave her the specification. Recursively available state. Memory across the query interval. A model of self sufficient to report lived consequence. Deya let him finish every term.

"Would a current citizen meet that definition?"

"The specification does not apply to current citizens."

"That concerns jurisdiction. Would we meet it?"

Soren glanced at Daran, wishing moral language could be confined to a private failure. "Yes."

Coolant moved through the rail above them. The graph updated by a fraction of a degree.

Deya pointed to the old ticket. "Why did you search six years?"

"Because I filed this."

Her gaze moved over the surviving text. When she reached the denial reason, her expression closed rather than changed. Soren remembered that year's medical allocation dispute only as a systems crisis. Clinics had rationed heat-exchange cartridges after a manifold fault in the Outer Ring. A prospective panel approved

delaying repairs to keep the Core medical spine online.

Deya remembered an older case. "My brother died during a repair delay recommended by a prospective panel," she said. "Twenty-four years ago."

Daran turned toward her. Soren did not. He had known about the death, not the panel's place in it. Deya had never offered that connection during their work on later hearings.

"So this ticket came from a later allocation query?" she asked.

"Yes. The same failure shape, not the same hearing."

"Did its anomaly affect the recommendation?"

"I cannot establish that."

"Did the selection architecture favor any class of branch?"

"The filter favored stable continuations with functioning civic records."

"Which required the Laterhouse."

"In practice, yes."

"And preserving the Laterhouse required Core infrastructure."

"Usually."

Deya read the denied review again. "Do not make my brother your explanation for telling me now."

Soren looked at her then.

"His death may belong in the evidence," she continued. "It does not excuse six years of your silence, and it does not prove what happened last night."

"I know."

"No. You know how to say that. I need to learn what you did."

The words struck more cleanly than accusation. Soren opened the routing history. His signature appeared beside the classification transfer. Beneath it sat the acknowledgment that future maintenance queries would suppress the ticket code from ordinary search.

"I accepted the seal," he said. "I told myself preserving review access mattered more than objecting in a record they could remove me from. Then the system kept running, and access without action became another word for compliance."

Daran remained beside the terminal. Soren wished he had asked him to leave. The wish itself belonged in the account.

Deya detached a copy of the visible ticket under her audit seal. "Who signed the missing attachment?"

"The index does not show it."

"Can you recover it?"

"Not without alerting Convener authority."

"Then don't. Not yet."

She examined the thermal graph again. "You normalized this before I arrived."

"The floor display does so automatically."

"But you can remove the normalization."

Soren restored the dense pulse field. Millions of runs compressed into blue until the screen seemed to hold a single continuous event. Deya moved closer, reading scale labels rather than trusting the image.

"Tomorrow," she said, "you will demonstrate the selection path from candidate field to admissible witness. Every exclusion stage."

"That architecture carries security restrictions."

"So did a sealed ticket you just opened under my summons."

"The transfer office will intervene."

"Let it do so in writing."

Above Well Three, the coolant return ticked upward by one hundredth of a degree. Soren watched the number enter the ledger. No normalization removed it.

Deya held out her portable surface. "Send me the raw load figures."

He did not reach for the automatic summary. He selected the uncompressed thermal account, attached his old ticket number, and pressed AUTHORIZE.

For the first time in six years, the sealed record and the heat that had followed it left the Query Floor together.

Chapter 3 — The Unasked Class

Kes Taro kept the scoring wafer under his palm while the rest of the class surrendered theirs.

Instructor Vale stood at the collection rail with one hand extended. Twenty-three white wafers already lay in the tray, each carrying a student's answer to the morning exercise. Kes's answer remained warm against his skin. The prompt above the classroom board asked them to rank civic decisions by how much prospective testimony each required. School placement. Medical allocation. Criminal appeal. Infrastructure closure. Ring abandonment did not appear.

"Kes," Vale said.

"I haven't signed it."

"The exercise does not require a legal signature."

"It asks whether Article Nine gives a reliable answer. That's a legal claim."

A few students looked toward him, then away before Vale could recruit their attention. Outer Ward Six taught its children how to challenge authority without

getting caught enjoying it. Kes had learned the first half from Deya and the second from everyone else.

Vale lowered her hand. "Write your qualification in the margin."

"There isn't a margin."

The scoring wafer displayed four answer circles and no free field. Vale knew this. She took the wafer, opened an instructor annotation line, and returned it.

Kes wrote: RELIABLE UNDER THE CONDITIONS CHOSEN BY THE QUESTIONER.

"That does not rank the decisions," Vale said.

"It ranks the questioner first."

Her mouth shifted around a reply she decided not to give. "Submit."

He pressed his thumb to the corner. The wafer joined the others, and the board advanced to CIVIC FORECASTING: FROM QUERY TO WITNESS. A diagram unfolded across the wall. It showed a question entering the Laterhouse, a fan of possible continuations, then twelve calm faces arranged around a civic seal. The fan contained no people. Colored lines widened and vanished like routes on a transit map.

Vale dimmed the ward-facing windows so the diagram could sharpen. Nox filled the glass behind her, enormous and unlit except where Hesper's aurora crawled blue over its upper atmosphere. Far below the school deck, algae terraces curved along the Outer Ring. Their grow lamps turned the classroom floor green at every rotation.

"Prospective testimony does not predict one fixed future," Vale began. "Who can state the approved distinction?"

Three hands rose. Kes kept his down.

Mira Dohn recited from the primer. "A witness remembers a civic continuation consistent with the proposed act. Concordance across panels supplies reasonable confidence that the consequence can occur."

"Good. And why do we use witnesses rather than pure models?"

"Because a lived continuation includes human behavior the model cannot summarize in advance."

Vale touched the board. One illustrated face expanded. "A prospective witness can tell a hearing what people did inside the conditions, not merely what machinery allowed."

Kes watched the mouth in the diagram. Its lips moved without sound.

The room's ventilation shifted to its midday cycle. Air flowed through the ceiling slots, carrying wet mineral odor from the terrace ducts. Kes counted four breaths until his shoulders loosened. Nothing had happened. A school diagram had moved. He had seen hundreds.

Vale opened the training archive. "You will now hear a clipped witness response

from a historic aptitude query. The clip contains the standard contact tone, question, answer, and cutoff. Record which parts belong to evidence and which belong to procedure.”

Kes's thumb pressed into the groove along his desk.

At eleven, he had taken a school aptitude query in a room with no windows. Deya called the process optional. The placement office called refusal a choice with consequences. His mother had been dead less than a year, and every adult around him wanted a machine to identify the work for which grief had prepared him. He had agreed because Deya looked tired before he answered.

The archive clip began.

A low contact tone sounded. A woman behind gray glass stated her year and district. An examiner asked whether a student assigned to pressure maintenance completed apprenticeship without serious injury. The witness said yes. Her voice carried the soft certainty adults used when they wanted a child to mistake probability for permission.

Then the cutoff bell rang.

Kes ceased to see the classroom.

Black glass pressed against his face without touching him. He had no body he could locate, but his mouth remembered cold. A question waited somewhere beyond the surface. He knew its wording before anyone spoke. He knew the heat of a corridor he had never entered, the taste of copper from a split lip that belonged to no event in his life, and the certainty that Outer Ward Six had already detached from Hesper.

Seventeen seconds opened inside him.

The first second held a pressure alarm. The second carried his own hand, older, tightening a manual brace around a pipe while the floor pulled sideways. In the third, someone called him Kester, a name nobody had used. By the fifth, the windows had gone dark because the Core no longer supplied ward power. The remaining seconds did not arrive in order. They crowded his chest together: empty terrace racks, a child inside a patched suit, the low vibration of separation clamps arming along the ring.

Behind all of it, an examiner asked a question.

Following ejection of the Outer Ring before transfer burn, do Core and Midring retain breathable atmosphere, stable rotation, and sufficient food production for ten years?

Kes knew the answer expected from him. Yes. Core and Midring survived.

No part of the question asked what happened where he stood.

The classroom came back with Vale kneeling beside his desk. Her fingers hovered near his shoulder but did not touch. Someone had stopped the training clip. Every student watched him now.

"Kes, can you hear me?"

He tasted blood and found that he had bitten the inside of his cheek. "Yes."

"Do you know where you are?"

He looked at the ward number painted above the door. W6 SCHOOL ANNEX C. Adults asked location when they wanted to determine whether a person still qualified as present.

"Outer Ward Six," he said. "Civic classroom three."

"What day?"

"Don't."

Vale drew back slightly. "The health protocol requires orientation."

"I answered you."

A student near the windows had already called the school medic. The wall showed the request traveling along the ward network. Kes stood before anyone could tell him to remain seated. The floor felt level. His knees disagreed.

"Play the clip again," he said.

Vale rose with him. "No."

"I need the bell."

"You had a seizure response."

"That isn't what it was."

Her eyes moved to his scoring wafer, then to the class. She had known about his childhood record. Every instructor received health exceptions at term start, stripped of detail and presented as safety. SEIZURE AURA FOLLOWING ACOUSTIC QUERY CUES. PROVIDE QUIET. DO NOT REPEAT STIMULUS.

Kes had read the line by leaning over Vale's desk during the first week. Nobody had asked him whether the description remained true.

Mira lifted her hand halfway. "Should we leave?"

Vale glanced at Kes.

"They shouldn't lose the lesson because my file scared you," he said.

"That is not what concerns me."

"Then say what does."

The medic arrived before she could. Oren Pell wore a green ward vest with repair patches at both elbows. He approached slowly, carrying no restraint kit. Kes knew him from pressure-drill inspections and appreciated that he did not begin with a hand on the pulse.

"Walk with me to the corridor," Oren said.

"I want the archive index."

"After I check your pupils."

"Here."

Oren looked toward the other students. "Privacy helps."

"It helps who?"

The question came out sharper than Kes intended. Oren accepted it without retreating. "Usually the patient. Sometimes the medic. We can keep the door open."

Kes stepped into the corridor. He refused the offered chair and stood under the white emergency strip while Oren passed a light across his eyes. The classroom door remained open a hand's width. Inside, Vale assigned silent reading, which guaranteed that everyone listened.

"Any lost time?" Oren asked.

"Seventeen seconds."

"You counted?"

"I remembered."

"From today?"

Kes looked through the radial window at the opposite arc of the Ring. Freight rails and terrace roofs curved upward until they disappeared behind school decking. Six years ago, after the aptitude query, he had woken on a clinic floor with Deya holding his shoes. Staff said his episode lasted seventeen seconds. He had not told them that the interval contained more time than the room around it.

"From before," he said.

Oren lowered the light. "Has this happened since the calibration fault?"

"No."

"Any warning today?"

"The bell."

"Sound can trigger stored sensory episodes."

Kes laughed once. "You mean memory."

"I mean the brain can reconstruct more than it receives."

"What if it received more than you recorded?"

Oren's attention became careful. Kes recognized the change. Adults became careful when a young person approached a sentence that might require them to act.

"Tell me what you experienced," the medic said.

"Not until I know what clip they played."

Vale came into the corridor holding her instructor slate. "The archive index is restricted to staff."

"Then read it."

"The clip came from a school aptitude query conducted twenty-two years ago. It has no connection to your assessment."

"I didn't ask whose answer it used. I asked for the index."

Oren held out his hand. Vale hesitated, then gave him the slate. He angled it so Kes could see without taking custody. The training file listed question family, respondent type, hearing room, and edit marks. Its contact and cutoff tones had been lifted from a generic Laterhouse training set. The bell sample carried a source number.

Kes knew the last four digits.

He did not know how he knew.

"Open source," he said.

Vale touched the restriction marker. "I cannot from a student account."

"Use yours."

"My credentials allow the teaching clip, not the raw assessment archive."

"Read the number aloud."

She did.

The digits landed in the same rhythm as the separation clamps from his memory. Four, pause, two, two, pause, one. Kes gripped the window rail until his hand hurt. Beneath the rhythm came the question again, complete and bureaucratically calm.

The remembered wording began with Following ejection of the Outer Ring before transfer burn.

Those conditions had not existed six years ago. Hesper's resonance decline had not entered public planning. The transfer office had announced orbital concern nineteen months ago and admitted the ejection option only last season. An aptitude query for an eleven-year-old could not have contained the question he remembered.

Unless the question belonged somewhere else.

"Show me today's lesson list," he said.

Vale opened it. The remaining modules covered medical rationing, Midring flood closure, and the ethics of asking minors about prospective careers. No ring ejection scenario appeared.

"Search the course archive for 'Outer Ring,'" Kes said.

"I am ending the lesson."

"Search it."

Oren looked at Vale. "If the phrase caused the episode, knowing whether it appears may help the clinic report."

Medical language gave her the permission a student's demand could not. Vale

ran the search. Four results appeared, all historical maintenance examples. None concerned separation, abandonment, or transfer.

Kes asked for the stationwide school archive. Her credentials allowed titles but not sealed content. The slate produced eleven results. Ten described temporary pressure closures. The eleventh had entered the archive that morning and remained locked under emergency rehearsal privilege.

PROPOSED EJECTION OF THE OUTER RING BEFORE TRANSFER BURN.

Vale read it twice. "This came from yesterday's Article Nine rehearsal."

"What question did they ask?"

"The content is sealed."

He could see enough metadata beneath the lock. Consequence duration: ten years. Required conditions: atmosphere, rotation, food production. The exact three conditions from the question inside his head.

Oren moved close to the slate. "Could a public schedule have included those terms?"

"No," Vale said. "Rehearsal questions stay closed until certification."

Kes released the window rail. Finger marks clouded the metal where his palm had sweated.

He had spent six years accepting an explanation that treated the memory as a symptom without content. Deya had accepted it too, though she asked each new medic to distinguish observed seizure signs from what Kes reported. She kept the clinic record in the locked drawer under their kitchen bench. Once a year, she offered to petition for its removal from his school file. Once a year, he told her it did not matter.

After the childhood fault, Deya had made him reconstruct the clinic visit from records before she let anyone call it a seizure. They sat at the kitchen table with his shoes still tagged from evidence collection. She wrote three columns on scrap paper: what Kes remembered, what the examiner observed, and what the machine recorded. The first column contained black glass, separation clamps, a pressure alarm, and an older hand he could move. The second contained his open eyes, rigid arms, and seventeen seconds without speech. The third recorded a calibration mismatch followed by an emergency cutoff. No column disproved either of the others.

For two months, she asked whether any part had changed. Kes eventually said no because the question exhausted him, not because the memory had faded. Deya stopped asking on schedule. She never told him to forget. Her restraint had allowed him to treat the event as private without calling it imaginary.

School staff handled the same facts differently. They removed him from acoustic drills, assigned quiet testing rooms, and sent every new instructor a risk code. Practical kindness accumulated around an account nobody examined. He gained

accommodations and lost ownership of the event that produced them. If he now gave the remembered question to a health office, the system would append fresh symptoms to the old code. If he gave it to Deya, she might place the words in evidence before anyone could reduce them to a neurological warning.

Now the record had acquired a question never asked in his classroom, never available during his childhood test, and not public until a sealed rehearsal the day before.

Vale closed the slate. "This needs to go to the school health office."

"No."

"A connection between your episode and sealed civic material requires reporting."

"To whom?"

"The district examiner, then the Laterhouse liaison."

Kes pictured the black glass. He pictured an institution receiving his memory as a fault in its own equipment. "You can report that the bell triggered an episode. You cannot report the content until I decide who hears it."

"You are seventeen."

"That doesn't answer me."

"Your foster guardian has authority over medical disclosure."

"Deya has never used it without asking."

Vale looked again at the sealed rehearsal title. Recognition arrived slowly. "Auditor Malk?"

He hated the way her posture changed around the name, as if his argument had acquired an adult body. "She raised me. She doesn't make me correct."

"No," Vale said. "But she may already have access."

Kes took his bag from the classroom. Mira met him at the door and held out the scoring wafer he had submitted.

"You left this in the tray," she said.

"The tray collects them."

"I withdrew it before the system scored you wrong."

His annotation still glowed beneath the ranking circles. RELIABLE UNDER THE CONDITIONS CHOSEN BY THE QUESTIONER.

Mira glanced toward Vale. "Did you know the rehearsal question?"

"No."

"Then how did you know?"

"I don't."

She handed him the wafer. "That's worse."

Kes put it in his bag. Oren wanted him to wait for a clinic escort. Vale wanted a written acknowledgment that he had left against advice. He signed only a statement that he remained oriented and had refused transport. When the form described Deya as guardian contact, he crossed out guardian and wrote foster parent. The distinction did not reduce her authority in practice. It reminded the record that their relationship had a history rather than a category.

Outside the annex, Outer Ward Six carried on with midday shift change. Terrace workers crossed the school bridge in damp boots. Fabrication apprentices rode the freight rail with tool cases between their knees. Nobody knew that a sealed question had entered a classroom through one student's body.

Kes called Deya. The channel returned an audit restriction notice and offered emergency routing. He almost used it. Emergency channels transferred control to the receiving office, where a clerk would summarize him before Deya heard his voice.

Instead he sent six words: I REMEMBERED YESTERDAY'S QUESTION SIX YEARS AGO.

The message accepted no attachment. Its delivery state remained pending.

A tram for the Core approached along the radial line. Kes had never left school during instruction without Deya's permission. He had also never possessed evidence that could be taken from him simply by naming it to the wrong system.

When the doors opened, he stepped aboard.

Behind him, the school bell marked the next lesson. Ahead, his message changed from pending to delivered.

Chapter 4 — Anatomy of a Consensus

Deya Malk removed eleven witness tokens from the demonstration table and left one standing beneath the light.

Soren watched from the other side of the glass partition. "That changes the display, not the architecture."

"Then show me the architecture."

The room occupied a service level between the Query Floor and the public hearing suites. Twelve narrow apertures lined one wall, smaller than those in Hearing Room Four and clear enough to expose their inactive render grids. On the table, twelve porcelain tokens represented admissible witnesses. A recessed field beneath them represented everything discarded before a voice reached glass. When Deya first entered, that field had been dark.

She set the removed tokens in a row beside her audit case. "Your public diagram begins with a query and ends with twelve faces. Your load diagram begins

somewhere else.”

“Candidate assembly.”

“Make it visible.”

Soren turned to the control surface. He had worn the same gray coat since the previous morning, though the cuffs now carried a clean line where coolant frost had melted. A deputy named Daran Carr waited by the locked door as technical witness. Two clerks from Deya's office occupied the recording station. Nobody from transfer administration had accepted her invitation.

The recessed field brightened.

Numbers multiplied across the table too quickly to read, first hundreds, then thousands, then a rolling count measured in millions. The display stopped at 2.4 million. Twelve porcelain witnesses stood at its edge.

Clerk Venn made a sound through his nose. He had kept the record when the second mouth appeared. Deya noted the reaction without looking at him.

“State the unit,” she said.

“Candidate respondents assembled for one prospective panel,” Soren replied.

“Are all 2.4 million coherent?”

“Coherence has stages.”

“Define each stage as we reach it.”

He placed both hands flat on the control rim. The table divided into colored bands. “Initial assembly creates a branch-continuation state from civic records, environmental conditions, genetic probabilities, and the physical constraints supplied by the query. Many assemblies fail before stable temporal recursion.”

A first band contracted. Four hundred thousand counts vanished.

“What happened to them?” Deya asked.

“They ceased processing.”

“By instruction?”

“Yes.”

“Did any retain memory across time?”

“Below the architecture threshold.”

“That does not answer whether any did.”

Soren's jaw shifted. “Some retained partial recursive state for less than the full runtime. The panel does not classify them as coherent respondents.”

Deya entered the distinction. “Proceed.”

The display applied environmental convergence. Branches in which the specified transfer conditions could not arise disappeared before any answer formed. Next came physiological continuity, then civic-record continuity. Each stage removed

hundreds of thousands. The table rendered the losses as dimming light, an elegant representation that required no one to watch a face go dark.

At nine hundred twelve thousand, Soren stopped the sequence.

"These candidates reach narrative stability," he said. "They maintain a self-model, recall prior states inside the branch, and interpret the policy condition as lived history."

Deya looked from the count to the empty apertures. "In ordinary language?"

"They can remember what happened to them."

"For how long?"

"Seventeen subjective seconds after the answer window opens."

"And before it opens?"

"The branch history exists as available memory. The system does not execute every prior moment serially."

"A person can remember a childhood without reliving it in real time."

Soren glanced at the clerk station. "That analogy may mislead."

"Then identify where."

"The memory derives from constructed branch conditions rather than biological duration."

"Does the respondent experience it as memory?"

"According to witness reports, yes."

A new message flashed on Deya's portable surface. Kes had sent six words the previous afternoon and refused every follow-up channel except a request to speak in person. She had answered with a time for that evening. Since then, the phrase yesterday's question six years ago had sat behind every number Soren showed her. She did not bring it into this record. Kes had not yet given consent.

"Continue," she said.

The next filter tested answer formation. Candidates unable to parse the hearing language disappeared. Those whose branch memories produced no answer to the policy question followed. The count fell below six hundred thousand.

"Why would a coherent respondent fail to answer?" Deya asked.

"Refusal, incompatible vocabulary, branch trauma, attention directed elsewhere, or a conflict between the supplied civic categories and remembered conditions."

"Does the system distinguish refusal from incapacity?"

"Not at this stage."

"So a person who declines to answer enters the same waste category as a failed language map."

Soren moved one hand from the rim. "The architecture does not apply legal

personhood categories.”

“I said person, not legal person.”

“You are importing a conclusion.”

“I am testing whether your nouns hide one.”

Daran Carr stared at the 2.4 million figure rather than at either of them. Deya had reviewed his statement from the sealed-ticket restoration. He had used people in that graph before Soren did. No one had instructed him to translate the display that way.

Soren resumed the selection path. Answer-bearing candidates separated into clusters. Survival of breathable atmosphere produced one cluster. Stable rotation produced another. Food sufficiency formed a third. The panel required candidates whose remembered continuation supported all three conditions for ten years.

The count fell to eighty-one thousand.

A selection filter then removed branches without a functioning civic registry at the end of the consequence period. Another excluded continuations that could not reproduce the query's population categories. A third demanded stable Laterhouse records so the branch could authenticate its own prospective testimony.

Deya raised her hand. “Repeat that stage.”

Soren froze the display.

“To qualify as an admissible witness,” she said, “a candidate must remember a future in which the Laterhouse still operates.”

“The authenticity protocol requires a comparable civic institution.”

“Comparable, or this one?”

“The present implementation uses Laterhouse continuity markers.”

“Then this selection filter rejects any branch where Hesper survives without your institution.”

“It rejects branches whose witness provenance cannot be verified under current law.”

“The physical result remains the same.”

“Legal admissibility and physical survival answer different questions.”

“Yet Article Nine presents the admissible answers as evidence of survival.”

No one moved near the controls. The table continued to show eighty-one thousand coherent respondents waiting behind twelve dark apertures.

Soren looked toward the wall clock. “The demonstration order concerns load accounting.”

“Selection determines load.”

“It determines relevance.”

"Those words do not conflict."

Deya asked Clerk Venn to mark the filter dependency for separate review. The clerk read back her language: ADMISSIBILITY REQUIRES CONTINUITY OF THE AUTHENTICATING INSTITUTION. Soren objected that the phrase omitted alternative markers. Deya appended his objection without changing the finding.

They proceeded.

Answer concordance reduced the field to nine thousand. Narrative consistency left four hundred eighty. Linguistic rendering produced ninety-one. Demographic balancing chose forty-eight. Confidence ranking selected twelve.

One by one, the small apertures illuminated with neutral silhouettes. The table left the unselected respondents as a blank field.

Deya walked its length. Twelve voices waited in glass. The path behind them contained 2.4 million assembled candidates, more than nine hundred thousand with narrative stability, tens of thousands whose answers supported the proposed consequences, and thirty-six who had passed every filter except final ranking.

"Why twelve?" she asked.

"Historical hearing capacity. Twelve apertures permit disagreement without overwhelming the clerks."

"Does confidence improve between twelve and twenty-four?"

"Marginally."

"Does runtime cost double?"

"No. The candidate field already exists. Additional render stabilization adds less than one percent."

"The hearing hears twelve because the room has twelve places."

"Because human deliberators cannot evaluate thousands of accounts."

"Those claims may both hold."

She replaced the eleven porcelain tokens on their lit positions. The gesture made the room look complete again. Completion had become a visual effect.

"Show the thermal account against the selection stages," Deya said.

Soren opened yesterday's raw load figures. A blue trace rose beside the count. Initial assembly drew the largest pulse. Environmental and physiological convergence added smaller shoulders. At narrative stability, the trace broke into a dense comb of correction load. Each tooth marked state being compared, repaired, and preserved across the respondent's runtime.

The graph did not spike when the twelve apertures opened. It spiked earlier, while hundreds of thousands acquired memory.

Deya asked for the calibration control. Soren overlaid scaffolds built with memory disabled. Their thermal slopes remained smooth. The difference aligned almost exactly with the period the architecture labeled coherent runtime.

"Could rendering cause these corrections?" she asked.

"Rendering begins later."

"Could answer extraction?"

"Later."

"Language stabilization?"

"Some overlap at the end, not the first rise."

"What operation begins at the first rise?"

Soren enlarged the system log. "Recursive self-state correction."

"In ordinary language."

He closed his eyes for less than a second. "The respondent begins preserving continuity."

Heat moved through pipes behind the wall. Deya could hear the pumps working harder as the Query Floor conducted a maintenance circulation below them. Soren had shown her that all candidate load eventually entered that system. The city carried the thermal consequence even when the hearing discarded the source.

She asked him to isolate rejected candidates that reached narrative stability but supplied answers outside the concordant cluster. Their trace held the same correction teeth as selected respondents. He isolated explicit refusals. The category proved coarse; refusal shared a code with unparseable answers. Even so, the available subset showed no lower continuity load.

"Does any thermal distinction separate a witness who reaches an aperture from a respondent rejected after stable memory?" she asked.

"Not before render."

"Does the final confidence rank measure coherence?"

"No. It measures agreement with the dominant answer cluster and stability under counterfactual perturbation."

"Agreement first."

"Reliability first."

"What reliability can mean apart from agreement depends on an independent measure."

Soren exhaled toward the glass wall. "You requested a technical demonstration and keep demanding moral verdicts."

"I have not asked whether termination constitutes harm."

"You ask me to say person every time the system says respondent."

"I ask you to identify the physical property behind each category. If moral language enters when the specification becomes accurate, removing the language will not remove the property."

His face tightened. "And if your language settles the legal issue before the physical evidence does?"

"Then another auditor should find that error."

Venn set down his stylus. Deya had authority over the record, not over truth. Her office existed because conclusions needed resistance, including her own.

She told Venn to suspend annotation and asked Soren to reset the demonstration. This time, she chose one respondent track from the coherent field and followed it through every stage. The table marked the candidate with a white point too small to see unless all other counts dimmed.

The respondent assembled with a remembered life in East Meridian. It reported two children, employment maintaining Midring water seals, and the death of a parent during transfer preparation. None of those details entered the policy answer. The candidate remembered breathable air, stable rotation, and sufficient food after Outer Ring ejection. Its answer agreed with the dominant cluster.

At demographic balancing, the track survived. At linguistic rendering, it survived. Final confidence rank placed it thirteenth.

The white point disappeared one position before the wall.

"What failed?" Deya asked.

"Nothing. Another respondent ranked higher."

"Did this one remain coherent until cutoff?"

"Yes."

"Did it know a question had been asked?"

"The self-state includes contact context."

"Did it expect an aperture?"

Soren checked the architecture note. "Expectation varies according to branch memory and contact framing."

"For this track."

A privacy mask blocked interior content beyond the answer fields. Soren used architect authority to expose only the expectation flag.

TRUE.

The respondent had expected to speak. It had remembered a life sufficient to answer, reached thirteenth place, and encountered termination without the room ever learning its voice.

Deya looked at the twelve silhouettes. "How does your public accounting describe this track?"

"It doesn't. Costs aggregate at panel level."

"Then expose one more."

They followed a candidate who answered that rotation failed after Outer Ring

ejection. The selection path rejected it at concordance. Its branch contained a structural oscillation outside the dominant range. The respondent held stable memory for the full runtime and attempted to attach a maintenance warning. The compiler discarded the warning with the nonconcordant answer.

"Could that branch occur?" Deya asked.

"Yes."

"Why didn't the hearing receive it?"

"Article Nine asks for concordant consequences."

"Concordance among what reaches the hearing?"

"Among selected evidence."

"Selected partly for concordance."

Soren's expression showed fatigue without surrender. "Every inferential system filters."

"Then the filter belongs in the inference."

Deya asked him to run the recorded candidate field through a display-only reorder. No new respondent state would be assembled, no runtime extended, and no answer changed. The demonstration would remove the Laterhouse continuity requirement from ranking while leaving environmental and narrative criteria intact.

Soren refused at first. "That produces no admissible panel."

"It produces an audit comparison."

"The output will imply a counterfactual authority it does not possess."

"Label it as nonauthoritative on every surface."

Daran confirmed that the archived field supported a read-only reorder. Deya added the limitation to the spoken record before Soren touched the control. A violet border replaced the civic amber around the table. NONADMISSIBLE AUDIT VIEW appeared above every aperture.

Candidate positions changed. Some branches without a Laterhouse still carried functioning ward councils, pressure registries, and local testimony chains. Their records could not satisfy the institution's authentication protocol, yet their physical conditions remained legible. Three of the previous twelve silhouettes disappeared. New ones occupied their apertures. Two reported food instability that the certified cluster had excluded. Another remembered a successful transfer followed by dissolution of central civic authority.

Deya did not count the new answers as evidence. She counted how quickly the meaning of concordance changed when one hidden premise moved.

"Restore the approved order," she said.

Soren did. The original twelve returned, each apparently untouched by the comparison. Anyone entering at that moment would have seen a unanimous-looking wall and no sign of the excluded civic futures.

A violet afterimage lingered on the clear glass, visible only from Deya's side of the table.

"What field in the hearing transcript reports the institutional continuity requirement?" Deya asked.

"None. The method registry carries it."

"Can an ordinary Assembly delegate inspect that registry?"

"On request, with security review."

"How many requested it during the last ten Article Nine matters?"

Soren queried the access ledger. No delegate request appeared. Two clerks had opened summary pages. Neither had reached the filter specification.

A call request appeared on his control surface from the transfer office. He dismissed it. Another followed under emergency scheduling priority. Deya recorded both requests and their timing. Pressure conducted itself through clocks long before anyone issued a direct order.

She reopened the public accounting template. Twelve witness entries occupied the first page. Aggregate power appeared on the seventh, converted to cost per admissible response. No field reported coherent candidates, full-runtime rejections, refusals, or branches excluded for lacking Laterhouse continuity.

"Who approves this template?" she asked.

"Laterhouse finance and the Assembly evidence office."

"Who verifies candidate classifications?"

"Query Architecture."

"Your division verifies its own categories."

"Security limits access."

"Security creates the conflict. It does not resolve it."

Deya drafted an order on her portable surface. Soren read over the glass as the lines appeared.

PRESERVE ALL RAW THERMAL, SELECTION, EXPECTATION, AND TERMINATION STATES ASSOCIATED WITH THE SUSPENDED REHEARSAL. PROVIDE CATEGORY DEFINITIONS AND HISTORICAL CHANGES. NO NORMALIZATION TO ADMISSIBLE-WITNESS COUNT.

"You do not have storage for full state preservation," he said.

"I ordered records, not continuities. Preserve the measures that already exist."

"That distinction may not remain simple."

"Then document where it fails."

She added a second requirement. An auditor independent of the Laterhouse, transfer office, and her own reporting line would reconstruct the panel costs from source measurements. The scope included the selection filter,

institutional-continuity dependency, and thermal correlation with conscious runtime. She used conscious only in the question field, not the finding.

Soren pointed to the word. "You cannot measure consciousness from heat."

"No. We can measure when your system begins doing the work you use to define a conscious witness. The independent accounting will preserve that difference."

Clerk Venn read the order aloud. Daran acknowledged the technical hold. Soren accepted custody under protest and attached his reasons: storage risk, schedule compression, and danger of interpreting engineering categories outside architecture context. Deya preserved every objection.

When she pressed ISSUE, the twelve demonstration apertures went dark in sequence. The recessed field remained lit at 2.4 million because the preservation order prevented the display from clearing.

A system designed to end with twelve voices now had to keep its millions visible for someone outside the Laterhouse to count.

Chapter 5 — The Child Who Remembered Tomorrow

Kes Taro set the locked clinic drawer on the kitchen table before Deya came home.

The drawer had not been designed to leave the bench. He had removed four screws from beneath the seat, disconnected its privacy contact, and carried the whole metal box across their two-room apartment. Pale dust marked the rectangle where it had rested for six years. Deya would notice the missing dust before she noticed anything else.

He put his scoring wafer beside the box. RELIABLE UNDER THE CONDITIONS CHOSEN BY THE QUESTIONER still glowed in its margin. The school system had marked him absent from his last three lessons and referred the departure to foster review. He had rejected the automatic health interview twice.

Artificial evening moved slowly across the Core windows. Their apartment received dawn and dusk according to a civic clock, not the outer view. Kes had grown up under the Outer Ring's direct work lights, where morning began when terrace crews opened the algae shades. Deya kept a narrow green lamp over the sink because she claimed it helped herbs. Nothing grew there except two stubborn leaves and the smell of wet soil.

The door seal admitted her at nineteen minutes past the time she had promised.

Deya stepped inside carrying her audit case and a paper parcel from the ward tram kiosk. She saw the exposed screws, the clinic drawer, then Kes. Her gaze stopped at the split inside his lower lip.

"Did someone touch you at school?" she asked.

"I bit it."

"During the episode?"

"Yes."

She set down the parcel. "May I look?"

Kes pulled his lip down. Deya examined the cut without reaching for him. Satisfied, she opened the parcel and placed two grain rolls on a plate.

"Eat while you tell me why the bench has lost part of its anatomy."

"I want the record here."

"It belongs to you."

"The drawer belongs to the apartment."

"We can repair the apartment."

Her agreement irritated him. He had prepared to defend the damage because defending small damage seemed easier than beginning.

Deya removed her audit badge and put it on the counter. She left the case closed. "Your message said you remembered yesterday's question six years ago."

"I did."

"Do you want me to listen as your foster parent or take a statement as an auditor?"

Kes had expected the distinction. He had not expected her to offer it before asking what happened. "Can you listen first and decide later?"

"I can decide later what action I recommend. You decide whether this becomes a statement."

He sat opposite the locked drawer. "Listen first."

Deya took the other chair. She did not activate the kitchen record strip. No stylus appeared in her hand.

Kes began with Instructor Vale's scoring exercise because the memory required an ordinary room around it. He described the four circles, his missing margin, and Mira withdrawing the wafer before the system could score his answer. Deya asked no questions. Her face changed once when he repeated the approved school phrase about lived continuations. He continued through the training clip and the bell.

At the black glass memory, words became harder to order.

He told her about pressure moving sideways through a corridor. He described the older hand closing a manual brace, the copper taste, and the name Kester. The ring separation clamps entered his account as vibration before machinery. Then he recited the policy question he had heard inside the seventeen-second memory.

Deya did not move when he reached Outer Ring ejection.

"Core and Midring retain breathable atmosphere, stable rotation, and sufficient

food for ten years,” Kes said. “That answer sat in me with the question. I knew yes before anyone finished asking.”

“What happened to the Outer Ring in the memory?”

“You said listen.”

Her hands opened on the tabletop. “You’re right.”

He made himself continue. The Outer Ring had separated. Ward power had failed. He remembered terrace racks without crops and a child in a patched pressure suit. The memory did not show whether those people died. It held fear, preparation, and the certainty that nobody on the other side of the question needed their condition in order to answer.

“There was also a pattern,” he said.

“What kind?”

He looked at her.

Deya pressed her lips together. “I interrupted again.”

“A cadence. It ran under the alarm. I thought it came from the clamps until yesterday.”

He tapped it on the metal drawer: four quick contacts, a pause, two, two, another pause, one. His fingertips knew the intervals better than his conscious count. After the final tap, he heard an absent continuation and had to stop himself from adding it.

Deya waited.

“The training bell used the same spacing inside its source number,” Kes said. “Vale read the digits aloud. Then the school archive showed yesterday’s rehearsal title. It listed the ten-year duration and the three conditions. The question itself stayed sealed.”

“How certain are you that the wording from memory matches the sealed question?”

Kes drew his hands beneath the table. Deya stopped halfway to the cupboard.

Kes looked toward the badge on the counter. Deya had left it there, but the auditor had entered her voice anyway. “You have the rehearsal record.”

“Yes.”

“So you know whether it matches.”

“I know the wording matches what you just said. I need to know how you distinguish memory from information you might have encountered after the rehearsal.”

“I came to you because I couldn’t have encountered it.”

“That conclusion requires a source review.”

He pushed his chair back. Its feet struck the floor seam. “I am not one of your

apertures.”

“No.”

“You asked me to tell you, and now you're selecting which part gets through.”

Deya's face lost its professional stillness for an instant. “Kes.”

“You already know it matches. You want me to prove I deserve to know what happened to me.”

“I want the record to survive someone less willing to believe you.”

“Then tell them why you believe me.”

“Belief will not protect your account from a challenge that you learned the question through my access.”

“I didn't touch your audit case.”

“I know.”

“You say that here. In the record, you ask whether I did.”

The cooling unit under the sink entered its night cycle. The green lamp flickered once. Kes hated that the room retained ordinary functions while he discovered how quickly care could become procedure.

Deya reached toward the badge, then stopped before touching it. “I mishandled the transition.”

“You turned me into evidence without asking.”

“Yes.”

The clean admission left him nowhere easy to push. He stood and carried the food plate to the counter though neither of them had eaten. Through the window, the artificial dusk strip reached the neighboring tower. Apartments darkened in neat vertical order.

Behind him, Deya said, “Your account matters to the audit. That does not grant the audit ownership of it.”

“What happens if I say no?”

“I keep what you told me as a private family disclosure. I cannot erase what I now know, but I will not enter your words, school record, or clinic file into the case. I may still investigate the machine facts through independent sources.”

“You would know where to look because of me.”

“Yes.”

“So no doesn't undo it.”

“No.”

Kes turned. “Then don't call that a complete choice.”

Deya nodded once. “It isn't. I should have explained the limit before you spoke.”

He returned to the table but did not sit. The locked drawer occupied the space

between them. "Open it."

"Do you want me to?"

"I brought it out."

"That tells me you wanted access. It does not tell me I have consent."

The word landed differently when she used it late and exactly. Kes slid the drawer across the table. "Open it with me here. No copies."

Deya retrieved a small brass key from the ring inside the cupboard. She had kept it among household tools rather than audit keys. Kes entered his half of the privacy code. The drawer required both. Its lid released with a soft mechanical click.

Inside lay the clothes tag from his childhood clinic visit, two examiner statements, a machine fault summary, and the three-column reconstruction Deya had written on scrap paper. His eleven-year-old handwriting occupied the left column. BLACK GLASS. OLDER HAND. CLAMPS. CHILD SUIT. The bottom line showed groups of marks separated by spaces.

Four. Two. Two. One.

Kes touched the paper without lifting it. "I wrote the cadence then."

Deya leaned close. "Yes."

"Did you know what it meant?"

"No. You said it felt like a machine trying to knock through a pipe."

He remembered saying that. The sentence returned without the surrounding day, a loose object carried six years intact.

Deya read the machine summary. The school aptitude query had suffered a calibration fault at contact plus three seconds. The aperture never rendered an admissible witness. A residual correction process occupied the full seventeen-second safety window before emergency cutoff. Examiners recorded Kes standing awake and unresponsive. No prospective answer appeared in the official file.

"What question did my assessment ask?" he said.

"Whether assignment to pressure maintenance would produce safe apprenticeship completion."

"Nothing about ejection."

"Nothing."

"Was that confirmed or just the title?"

Deya showed him the examiner's quoted prompt. It matched the training example from his class. His assessment had asked about his own placement, not Hesper's transfer.

Kes sat again. The facts did not make the memory gentler. They made it

external.

"I want to see the rehearsal question," he said.

"It remains sealed."

"You told me it matches."

"I can show it if you enter the audit under a confidentiality order."

"There. You need me inside your procedure before I can compare my own memory."

Deya absorbed the objection. "I can request a limited disclosure based on personal-data correction. It would take days, and the transfer schedule may overtake us."

"Or I join."

"Only if you choose to."

Kes looked at the four groups of marks. "Show me what else uses the cadence."

She opened her audit case.

The movement changed their agreement, and Deya named that change before removing anything. "From this point, I would be showing you sealed investigative material. We can stop."

"Show me."

She placed a flexible display beside the childhood paper. The graph held a blue thermal trace and a gray field labeled PHASE SALT. Five uneven teeth rose after cutoff. Kes recognized the shape before Deya aligned the time marks.

"Play it as load," he said.

"The display has no sound conversion."

"It has intervals. Give each rise a tone."

Deya configured the accessibility renderer. Five low notes sounded, their duration based on each tooth's width. Kes shook his head.

"You're playing the tops. Use the corrections inside them."

"Those are hundreds of microevents."

"Slow them."

She expanded the first tooth. The renderer produced four quick clicks. The next meaningful cluster held two. A second pair followed after a gap. The last isolated correction made one.

Four. Two. Two. One.

The cadence passed through the kitchen with the dry sound of a cooling pipe contracting.

Kes tapped the childhood marks as the renderer played them again. His hand matched within the display's smallest audible interval. Deya recorded no

measurement. She let the comparison exist between the old paper, his fingers, and the sealed graph.

"Where did this phase salt come from?" he asked.

"Yesterday's suspended rehearsal."

"After the mouth spoke?"

"Aligned with it and continuing after the render map cleared."

"What did the mouth say?"

Deya's eyes moved toward the confidentiality field on her display. "I cannot answer privately without breaking the seal."

"Then let me into the audit."

"Do not decide because I withheld a sentence."

"I am deciding because you have a graph that remembers the same rhythm I wrote at eleven."

She folded her hands. "Before you decide, understand what joining may involve. Your school and clinic records could face challenge. Laterhouse counsel may claim contamination through my household. Examiners may request neurological testing. Public disclosure does not occur automatically, but I cannot promise the case will remain sealed."

"Can I refuse testing?"

"Yes."

"Can they keep me from seeing material about my own event?"

"Some architecture records may remain restricted."

"Can you use my memory to run another query?"

"No. I would oppose any reproduction attempt."

"That isn't a rule."

"No."

"Make one."

Before Deya reached for a form, she opened the civic representation index. "You also need someone in the audit who does not answer to me."

"I can answer for myself."

"Yes. An advocate would answer for the process when it corners you."

Kes read the available roles. Minor counsel assumed a dispute between child and guardian. Medical advocate assumed illness. School representative routed every disagreement through the district examiner. None described a foster relationship in which the parent also controlled the investigation.

"Can I choose nobody?" he asked.

"You can. I must still refer my conflict to review."

"Because I live with you."

"Because I appointed myself lead on evidence that may include your memory, and because your trust in me could make refusal harder."

The accuracy hurt less than her earlier questions because she applied it to her own authority. Kes scrolled farther and found an independent record adviser category usually used by citizens whose testimony implicated their employers. Such an adviser could inspect consent compliance without speaking in his place.

"That one," he said. "But I pick the person after I meet them."

Deya added the condition. "Until then, no formal interview."

"This counts as what?"

"A private disclosure followed by consent negotiation. Your cadence comparison can enter as a protected lead if you approve it. The sensory memory stays outside."

Kes looked at the old paper. "And if I change my mind tomorrow?"

"You can end your participation. Material already lawfully entered remains in the case, but future access stops. We mark the withdrawal in words you approve."

"Not 'source became unreliable.'"

"Not unless you demand an inaccurate record."

He almost smiled. The answer sounded like Deya from before the badge entered the kitchen.

She drew the blank audit intake form toward them. Rather than fill its standard fields, she opened an attached conditions page.

Kes dictated the terms. No acoustic trigger test. No query or diagnostic using his memory pattern. No release of his clinic, school, or foster records without separate approval for each category. Questions delivered in advance when possible. The right to stop an interview without an adverse inference. Access to the transcript of his own testimony. No description of him as a conduit, victim, or witness for aftercitizens without his agreement.

Deya added another line: foster authority would not substitute for Kes's consent within the audit.

"Does the law allow that?" he asked.

"It allows the lead auditor to impose stricter evidence handling."

"And if they remove you?"

"The conditions bind the record after reassignment unless a reviewing court changes them."

"Then write that too."

She did.

They argued over one field. The standard form classified him as MINOR SOURCE,

FAMILY-RELATED. Kes rejected both terms together. He remained legally a minor for one more year, and Deya's involvement created a real conflict, but the category made him sound like evidence that happened to an auditor.

"What would you call it?" she asked.

"Participant-source."

"That category does not exist."

"It does when you type it."

Deya created a provisional field. PARTICIPANT-SOURCE; PERSONAL DECISION AUTHORITY RETAINED. She attached a note that independent counsel must review the classification before any formal interview.

Kes read every line. Deya did not hurry him, though a transfer-office notice blinked twice on her case. When he reached the signature field, he found two separate marks: consent to enter, and consent to release the childhood paper for pattern comparison.

He signed the first. On the second, he limited release to the cadence marks and machine timestamp. His sensory account remained private until he gave it as testimony.

Deya countersigned as auditor. She did not sign as foster parent.

Only then did she open the sealed rehearsal question. Kes read the sentence he had carried for six years. Every condition matched. Even the order of breathable atmosphere, stable rotation, and sufficient food remained unchanged.

He closed the display before the witness answer appeared. "I already know the answer."

Deya looked at him across the clinic drawer. "Knowing the answer does not require you to give it."

"Good."

The audit system generated a temporary access token. Instead of printing it on a clerk's white wafer, Deya routed it to Kes's scoring wafer. His classroom annotation vanished beneath a black civic border, then returned with a new line.

PARTICIPANT-SOURCE. CONSENT CONDITIONS ATTACHED.

The transfer-office notice sounded again. Deya muted it.

Kes tapped four, two, two, one against the wafer. The phase-salt graph answered from the display in the same cadence. This time, neither of them called it a symptom.

Deya moved the audit case to his side of the table.

Chapter 6 — Auditor of Consequence

Deya Malk broke the red emergency tab before the registry clerk could ask whether she intended to use it.

The tab divided cleanly under her thumb. One half remained attached to the formal audit packet. The other dropped into the Registry Well, where a camera recorded its fall past the brass depth marks and into the locked civic box below. Once deposited, the opening notice could not be withdrawn without a public closure order.

Clerk Ansel leaned over the rail. "The Convener's office requested a conference before filing."

"They requested it after receiving the draft."

"They marked the transfer schedule urgent."

"Everything in this building carries that mark today."

Deya pressed her seal to the packet. The registry read her pulse, compared the case number to the suspended rehearsal, then illuminated the full title across the floor: FORMAL AUDIT OF PROSPECTIVE PANEL CONSTRUCTION, SELECTION, TERMINATION, AND HISTORICAL CONSEQUENCE BIAS.

People crossing the public gallery slowed. The floor permitted no private opening for Article Nine matters. A caretaker pushing a stack of folded chairs stopped long enough to read every word. Two transfer-office aides turned away together and began speaking into their cuffs.

Ansel lowered his voice. "Is termination supported as a technical term?"

"It appears in the architecture logs."

"Historical consequence bias?"

"Question presented, not finding."

He accepted the distinction and attached the preserved rehearsal record. The registry asked whether Deya claimed an affected personal relationship. She selected YES. A blank field opened for explanation.

BROTHER DECEASED FOLLOWING REPAIR DELAY REVIEWED BY PROSPECTIVE PANEL, TWENTY-FOUR YEARS PRIOR.

The words looked smaller than the rest of the title. Deya entered them anyway.

A private summons tone sounded from the conference room behind the Well. First Convener Ilyan Ro waited beyond its clear door. He had arrived without ceremonial staff, wearing a physician's old dark collar under his civic coat. Deya remembered that collar from Outer Ring clinics before his election. He used it when he wanted people to recall that his authority had once touched bodies directly.

She finished the filing before joining him.

Ilyan remained standing. The room's table displayed the transfer calendar with fifteen days left before black perihelion. Three Article Nine panel windows occupied

the next six days. Deya's preservation order crossed all of them in red.

"You opened it," he said.

"The registry can answer that."

"I asked you to let me show you what delay changes."

"You sent a calendar."

"I sent crew consequences." He expanded the display. Burn Spine inspections, separation-charge tests, food transfers, pressure rehearsals. Each depended on a certified plan. "Orla Fen cannot prepare two complete transfer architectures through perihelion. Every day we hold both open consumes catalyst and crew rest."

"Then the Assembly should know what narrows its evidence."

"The Assembly knows prospective panels use selection."

"It does not know one panel constructs 2.4 million candidates, carries more than nine hundred thousand through remembered continuity, then reports twelve."

Ilyan's attention fixed on the number. "Soren disclosed architecture load under a rehearsal summons."

"Yes."

"Did he also explain why candidate count has never defined civic standing?"

"He explained that his specifications avoid the question."

"That does not mean the machine creates citizens."

"No finding says it does."

"You chose termination for the public title."

"The logs chose it first."

Ilyan walked to the end of the table. Beneath the transfer calendar, the official eject-and-burn plan still appeared as a mass-reduction file. Deya changed the display field to full civic language. The screen expanded to include Outer Ring residents, ward systems, and expected loss. Ilyan watched her do it without objection.

"Keep the suspended record," he said. "Audit the post-cutoff render. Review your six-year-old ticket. I will grant compartmented access. But separate those matters from panel validity until the transfer hearing finishes."

"Panel validity depends on the selection path."

"Only if discarded candidates possess interests the law recognizes."

"Validity also depends on whether the filter favors one class of survival."

"All evidence systems favor relevance."

"This one requires branches to preserve the institution that authenticates them."

Ilyan looked away from her. The gesture lasted only a moment. He moved the crew calendar over the full civic language until dates covered the population field.

"A technical dependency does not establish corrupt purpose," he said.

"I did not allege purpose."

"You know how the title will be read."

"I know how keeping it informal would be read later."

The conference door admitted no sound from the gallery, but Deya could see people stepping around the audit title on the floor. Some avoided placing a foot on it. Others walked across without looking down.

Ilyan reduced the calendar to a single deadline. "Resume the transfer rehearsal by tomorrow evening. Run the remaining panels under observation. If your audit later changes the legal treatment, the records will still exist."

"Running another panel would instantiate another candidate field under the process in question."

"Candidate field," he repeated. "Not population."

"That distinction belongs in the audit."

"Hesper has relied on prospective testimony for one hundred twenty-six years. You cannot convert an unresolved anomaly into a halt by choosing the most morally loaded noun available."

Deya heard the pressure beneath his control. Ilyan did not need to be cruel to become dangerous. He had thousands of scheduled tasks, a failing orbit, and an institution that promised to rank catastrophe. Delay imposed real harm. So did speed when its evidence concealed the source of certainty.

"I have opened a formal audit," she said. "The rehearsal remains suspended until I can certify that continuing will not destroy material evidence or repeat the condition under investigation."

"I can overrule an operational hold under emergency authority."

"You can. Your written order will enter the public registry beside mine."

They looked at each other across the fifteen-day calendar. Ilyan could move the machine. Deya could make him own the movement in language no schedule could hide.

He closed the display. "What access do you intend to demand?"

"Historical selection records, raw load accounts, filter revisions, post-cutoff exceptions, classification routing, and the attachment removed from Soren's old ticket."

"That scope will paralyze the Laterhouse."

"Then its record architecture failed before my audit."

"Give me until noon."

"For what?"

"To determine which stores can open without compromising civic security."

Deya checked the time. "You have until noon to comply voluntarily. The audit remains open now."

Ilyan's face settled into the expression he used at Assembly tables when a concession had become a boundary. "Do not mistake my restraint for agreement."

"I will preserve your objection."

Outside the conference room, Ansel had added the conflict notice beneath the title. Deya read it once, then directed him to the independent accounting station three levels down.

The station had no access to Laterhouse systems. Its analysts usually reconstructed water levies and ward power disputes from exported records. Today, the largest wall held twelve columns of normalized witness cost. The independent accountant assigned to Deya's emergency order, Olan Sol, had printed the raw thermal figures onto translucent sheets and hung them over the columns. Blue load crowded far beyond every white line.

"I cannot reconcile their unit," Olan said without greeting. "The public ledger bills by admissible response. The source meter bills by substrate interval. Conversion requires a candidate count they omitted."

Deya gave him the 2.4 million panel figure under seal.

Olan stared at it. "For this load?"

"For one panel."

He recalculated. Cost per witness collapsed. Cost per coherent runtime appeared in a separate field. The number itself mattered less than its distribution. Almost all thermal correction occurred before final selection. Twelve voiced apertures accounted for a small render fraction.

"Who defined the billing unit?" Deya asked.

"Laterhouse finance, revised ninety-three years ago. Earlier ledgers used process-seconds."

"Can you retrieve the older definition?"

"From civic archive. Later revisions may require their method registry."

"Start outside their custody."

Olan opened the historical index. The first decades of prospective practice recorded candidate processes as provisional models. Over time, the terminology narrowed. Candidate process became candidate load. Termination event shifted to state clearance. By the current century, public accounts began at admissible witness rendering, though the meters still began at assembly.

Language had not changed the heat. It had changed where citizens were invited to look.

Deya asked for cases involving Outer Ring infrastructure and delayed repairs. Olan filtered twenty-five years of consequence hearings. Forty-one matters remained. He compared recommendations against whether each branch preserved central record authentication. Branches with prolonged Laterhouse interruption rarely reached final witness sets, even when local ward systems survived.

"Can you call that survival bias?" he asked.

"Not yet."

"The distribution points there."

"Then state the distribution."

They narrowed the index to the heat-exchange failure that killed her brother. The case file opened with a maintenance photograph: frost around a split manifold in Outer Ward Six, repair crew members holding scale bars beside the crack. Deya knew one of the gloves at the frame's edge. Her brother had worn orange sealant at the wrist because standard cuffs irritated an old burn.

She moved the photograph to a secondary surface.

The original engineering request had sought an immediate shutdown of two Core medical loops so replacement cartridges could move outward. Prospective panels compared immediate redistribution against a sixty-hour delay. Selected witnesses reported that the delay preserved hospital function and civic continuity. The Assembly approved it.

At hour thirty-seven, a second exchanger failed. Five repair workers entered a flooded service bay to prevent terrace freezing. Deya's brother did not come back out.

Olan overlaid the raw branch categories newly available from Soren's preserved method sample. "The selected set required continuous central authentication. An immediate redistribution would have forced a Laterhouse shutdown during the repair window."

"How many branches did that condition exclude?"

"The historical file gives percentages, not counts. Sixty-two percent of physically viable continuations lacked continuous authentication."

"Did Hesper survive in them?"

"Core and Outer wards retained pressure in most. Medical outcomes vary. The record does not support a single better result."

"Did the selection summary tell the Assembly that?"

"No."

Deya read the twelve witness statements from that hearing. Every voice described the delay as regrettable and necessary. Three praised the maintenance crews for accepting risk. One used her brother's first name because the branch continuation had included his survival past the repair.

The record had allowed a possible future version of him to justify an order that preceded his death.

Her hands left the table.

Olan saw the motion. "We can stop."

"No. Mark a conflict boundary around this case."

"You cannot independently validate a finding tied to your family."

"I can identify records. You will perform the analysis, and a second auditor will review it without my annotations."

"Do you want the case removed from the systemic sample?"

Deya looked at the photograph on the secondary surface. Removing it would protect her from the appearance of grief. It would also remove exactly the kind of consequence the larger pattern needed to measure.

"No. Keep it in the sample and exclude me from its finding chain."

Olan created the boundary. Deya could request source records but could not approve the case interpretation. Every action she took inside it would receive a conflict mark.

They compared the remaining forty cases. The same pattern appeared without her brother. When prospective selection required uninterrupted central authentication, delayed Outer repairs received stronger apparent support. Branches that preserved residents while disrupting the Laterhouse often vanished before concordance. The effect persisted across agriculture, radiator maintenance, and pressure allocation.

Olan built a control set from Core and Midring failures that left authentication untouched. Those panels still favored stable infrastructure, but they did not consistently transfer risk outward. Recommendations followed available parts, crew distance, and pressure geometry. Once authentication entered the branch conditions, the distribution shifted beyond what those physical factors predicted.

One four-year-old case concerned an algae cooling loop in Outer Ward Two. Engineers had offered either a twelve-hour Core power reduction or removal of heat from the terrace beds. Selected witnesses favored the terrace loss. Their continuations preserved the central registry and described one season of rationing as recoverable. Rejected branch summaries included local registry copies, preserved crops, and a Laterhouse outage lasting nine hours. No public hearing page mentioned that those branches existed.

Deya had never reviewed that decision. Nobody she knew had died in it. The result still carried the same structural preference.

"Test for Outer population as an explicit penalty," she said.

Olan searched the filter definitions. "No field says Outer residents count less."

"Test whether data quality explains it."

“Outer wards have weaker record continuity after infrastructure loss. That contributes.”

“Separate weaker records from Laterhouse absence.”

He reran the historical categories using only branches with complete local records. The skew narrowed but remained. A continuation could preserve names, pressure counts, and food measures in ward custody, yet fail authentication because the central archive did not survive to certify them.

“Could emergency urgency explain the recommendation pattern?” Ansel asked.

Olan compared cases by decision window. Fast emergencies strengthened conservative infrastructure choices across all rings. They did not account for the added preference attached to central continuity.

Deya required each alternative explanation to remain beside the provisional result. The audit would not become trustworthy by hiding uncertainty that weakened its cleanest claim. Physical damage, unequal ward records, and emergency timing all influenced the panels. After accounting for those factors, institutional survival still changed which continuations could speak.

Olan wrote the provisional statement: HISTORICAL PANELS DISPROPORTIONATELY SELECTED CONTINUATIONS PRESERVING CENTRAL AUTHENTICATION, CORRELATING WITH RECOMMENDATIONS THAT TRANSFERRED RISK TO OUTER INFRASTRUCTURE.

Deya removed one draft sentence that called those recommendations wrongful. The records could show skew and consequence. They could not rerun six years of choices or prove what an unfiltered Assembly would have decided.

At noon, Ilyan sent a partial access offer. It opened filter revision summaries and three post-cutoff exceptions. The classification archive, raw historical counts, and missing ticket attachment remained withheld under civic security.

Ansel read the offer beside Olan's provisional analysis. “Does partial compliance delay compulsory process?”

“No.”

“The Convener may argue good faith.”

“Record it.”

“He may also argue your family conflict infects the scope.”

“Record that too.”

Deya drafted the basis for compulsory access. She cited the suspended post-cutoff statement, thermal alignment with coherent runtime, concealed filter dependencies, statistical correlation across forty cases, and the old ticket's respondent-aversion category. Her brother's death appeared once, under conflict disclosure. It did not appear in the findings.

Ansel watched her delete his name from a narrative paragraph. “You could say

why the delay matters to you.”

“It matters whether or not it happened to my family.”

“That does not make grief irrelevant.”

“No. It makes grief a condition of my review, not its conclusion.”

She attached Olan's independent signature. A second auditor accepted review of the heat-exchange case. The formal packet now had enough support to compel records without asking anyone to accept Deya's mourning as proof.

At twelve twenty-three, the Registry Well issued the subpoena.

The document named the Laterhouse as custodian. It demanded unnormalized candidate counts, complete selection-filter histories, all post-cutoff persistence records, classification directives concerning respondent distress or aversion, and the sealed attachment removed from Soren Vash's maintenance ticket. Compliance began immediately. Destruction, query-based alteration, or routine purge of responsive material would constitute obstruction.

Deya and Ansel carried the physical service copy across the civic bridge. Below them, coolant lines ran from the Laterhouse toward the Outer Ring exchangers. Heat shimmered faintly over the insulated joins.

Two security officers waited at the Laterhouse entrance. Ilyan had not come. Soren stood behind the inner glass with his hands empty and visible.

Ansel read the subpoena title. Deya pressed the red civic seal to the black door plate. For a second, the surfaces resisted each other. Then the Laterhouse accepted service with a tone that traveled through the bridge rail.

Locks engaged across the archive wing.

A preservation ledger began printing behind the inner glass. Each strip named a record family and its last routine-purge time. Soren caught the paper as it emerged, checked the first entries, then placed his palm against the reader to accept personal custody. The action did not tell Deya whether he would resist the subpoena's full scope. It established who could no longer claim the archive had cleared itself without a witness.

On the public side of the glass, Deya's conflict notice remained attached to every page. On the other side, Soren turned toward the sealed records as preservation lights came on one row at a time.

The institution could still refuse to explain itself. It could no longer clear its memory as routine maintenance.

Part II — The Cost Becomes Publicly Legible

Chapter 7 — The Outer Ring Proposal

Nadi Saye watched a clerk remove eight chairs from the press tier before opening the doors.

Each chair had carried an Outer Ring ward marker on its back. The clerk folded the metal seats, nested them against a service wall, then covered their stamped numbers with a gray transit cloth. When Nadi asked who had ordered the change, he pointed toward the central floor without naming anyone. The Assembly Well had not yet admitted the public, but its omissions had begun arriving early.

She set her recorder on the first remaining table and photographed the empty spaces. Around the circular chamber, civic screens displayed a clean line drawing of Hesper: Core cylinder, Midring, Outer Ring. All three structures glowed the same blue. A smaller diagram waited beneath it, hidden except for the label TRANSFER CONFIGURATION. Nadi could guess what color the lowest ring would carry once the announcement began.

Public record advocates received no reserved seat at emergency briefings. They received access, which meant standing behind whichever office had arrived first and resisting the quiet pressure to leave before officials started speaking off transcript. Nadi chose a place beside the technical transcript rail. From there she could see both the First Convener's lectern and the manual clerk responsible for recording objections the automatic system misclassified as noise.

Pavo Renn entered through the lower public door with eleven ward delegates behind him. He stopped when he saw the covered chairs.

"Uncover those," he said.

The clerk glanced toward the convener's staff platform. "Capacity protocol."

"Capacity for whom?"

A security steward approached before the clerk could answer. Pavo gave him no time to shape an order. He pulled away the transit cloth, read the first stamped marker aloud, and handed the chair to the Ward One delegate. His people unfolded all eight seats in the aisle. Metal legs struck stone in separate sharp notes.

Nadi recorded the restoration. She also recorded the clerk's face, not for blame but for sequence. Someone had made exclusion look like furniture handling. Pavo had made its reversal look like work.

By the time the public doors opened, the Well contained six hundred residents and no stable arrangement. Core administrators occupied the high curve nearest the exit. Midring union delegates clustered by the voting rails. Outer Ring families filled the lower tiers in pressure-work clothes, many carrying sealed archive cases between their boots. Children had handwritten ward numbers on their sleeves. Nadi recognized the practical fear behind that preparation: if the official plan became an order, every household would have to choose which evidence of itself could fit through an evacuation hatch.

Artificial dawn climbed the chamber walls as Ilyan Ro crossed the central floor. Hesper's lighting schedule had begun twelve minutes late, another small economy in a city spending power against a deadline. Ilyan wore the dark green coat of the First Convener without its silver shoulder chain. The missing ornament made him look less ceremonial and more dangerous. He could claim urgency while appearing to surrender rank.

Chief Engineer Orla Fen took her place at a bare table below him. Three scale models sat there under transparent covers. Nadi saw one intact Hesper, one with the Outer Ring separated, and one surrounded by seven small burn vectors. The third model remained turned away from the public.

Ilyan touched the civic seal. "Open record. Emergency orbital briefing, day four before transfer certification."

The screens changed. Hesper's three blue structures appeared beside a descending orbital curve. A red band marked nineteen months from the present. Another red point marked black perihelion fourteen days away.

"We have passed the last date on which delay preserves our full engineering range," Ilyan said. "Orbital resonance decline continues within the measured corridor. Without a transfer burn, inhabited rotation becomes unsustainable inside nineteen months. Food, heat exchange, and pressure integrity fail earlier in different districts. No district survives by refusing the arithmetic."

A woman below Nadi whispered that arithmetic never had to pack a child's medicine. The automatic transcript ignored her. Nadi entered the sentence in her independent record and tagged the speaker as unidentified by request.

Orla removed the cover from the separated-ring model. Small magnets held the Core and Midring together. The Outer Ring rested three handspans away, its connecting spokes clipped at their inner couplings.

"The official transfer proposal uses an eject-and-burn sequence," Orla said. "We isolate the eight outer wards, separate their mass at the radial couplings, then burn the remaining city through the transfer corridor. Under prospective validation and current hardware tolerance, modeled survival for Core and Midring reaches 99.1 percent."

No one applauded. The number arrived too polished for that, carrying every decimal place like a guard.

Orla continued. "Outer Ring separation cannot preserve inhabited rotation. Local stores support pressure for hours, not orbital recovery. Evacuation capacity permits moving a limited number of residents inward before ejection. Allocation details remain under Assembly review."

The lower tiers erupted into individual demands. How many could move. Who had set the categories. Whether algae crews counted as essential after their terraces had been cut away. Whether a resident denied an inward berth would receive a hearing. The sound system lowered their channel until the questions

became a rough band under Orla's voice.

Nadi crossed to the manual clerk. "Your public feed has suppressed intelligible speech."

"Emergency moderation keeps the engineering statement audible."

"Mark every suppression interval."

He looked at his supervisor. Nadi placed her advocate seal beside his stylus. Refusing her would create a record too. He began marking the intervals.

Ilyan raised one hand, and the sound system restored the lower tiers by degrees. "The proposal names a loss we have not chosen to hide. The Outer Ring population stands at 8,116 registered residents as of last night's count. Their certain loss under separation carries no lesser civic status than modeled losses elsewhere. This government will not call a person expendable because a calculation can describe the result."

Pavo stood from the restored Ward Four chair. "Then stop describing our deaths as a configuration."

His voice reached the chamber without amplification. Pavo Renn had chaired enough Compact disputes to understand when a machine could make anger sound disorderly. He waited for the system to recognize his speaking badge before continuing.

"You announce 99.1 percent survival," he said. "State the denominator."

Orla leaned toward her microphone. "Core and Midring residents after completed ejection."

"State who does not enter it."

"The 8,116 residents of the Outer Ring."

"And evacuees?"

"Those accepted into Core or Midring before separation enter the model at their receiving districts."

Pavo turned toward the public tiers rather than toward Ilyan. "So the city hears ninety-nine point one and imagines nearly everyone. Your calculation first removes us, then measures success among whoever remains."

A Midring delegate called that no one disputed the loss. Pavo faced her. "Then why did the number arrive before the bodies it excludes?"

Ilyan opened both hands over the lectern. "Because the probability explains why this option has reached official proposal. The population figure explains its cost."

"Order explains politics," Pavo said. "You chose yours."

Nadi watched the high tiers. Several Core administrators had already begun composing statements on their wrist surfaces. Their eyes moved between the 99.1 percent figure and the public feed index, measuring which sentence could survive both. None looked at the intact model still under glass.

Orla rotated the third cover by a few degrees. Seven burn vectors became visible along one edge before Ilyan signaled her to stop.

Pavo noticed. "Show the other plan."

"It has not passed prospective validation," Ilyan said.

"Show it."

Orla spoke before the Convener could refuse. "A counterphase ladder might transfer the whole city through seven partial burns. Two coupling stages rely on timing tolerances we have not demonstrated at full mass. I will not offer a survival percentage I cannot defend."

"Did the Laterhouse test it?"

"The Array tested prior variants."

"And?"

Ilyan answered. "No variant returned concordant approval from three panels."

That phrasing redirected attention toward the screens. Three panel columns appeared. Each displayed twelve short witness quotations beneath a green certification bar. Nadi read the lines as they rose: pressure retained, crop failure contained, transfer corridor achieved, ten-year population stable. The witnesses carried ages and civic locations, but no names. Their statements appeared as proof fragments detached from mouths.

She enlarged the public copy on her recorder. Thirty-six quotations supported the official plan. Beside each stood a branch year and an admissibility score. No line identified counsel, representative, consent status, or disposition after testimony. The record described them with the charter word witness, yet the briefing treated their participation like an instrument reading.

Nadi asked the technical clerk for the witness appearance docket.

"There isn't one for a prospective panel," he said.

"Who entered objections on their behalf?"

"The panels answer a policy question. They don't conduct adversarial review."

"Who corrected their testimony?"

"Selection does that before admission."

His certainty frayed on the final words. Nadi had heard that change in archive interviews: the moment someone discovered that a familiar procedure sounded different when its missing person had to be named.

At the central floor, Pavo pointed to the quotations. "You have thirty-six future residents approving a plan that kills 8,116 present ones. We demand the complete testimony and the basis for every selection."

Ilyan's staff counsel rose. "Prospective witness privacy survives evidentiary use. Raw panel material contains branch-sensitive personal records."

“Privacy for the unnamed dead,” Pavo said, “secrecy for the officials citing them.”

Nadi expected the lower tiers to support him without qualification. Instead an Outer Ward Six machinist stood and asked whether the witnesses understood that their safe Core required the ejection. A terrace nurse demanded to know whether any witness had been descended from an outer resident. Someone else shouted that invented people should not outrank children already breathing. The argument split along more lines than the room's seating could represent.

That split mattered. Nadi marked each claim separately. Public anger often arrived in summaries as agreement because summaries preferred a usable side. Here, the Outer Ring wanted full disclosure for incompatible reasons: some believed the witnesses had condemned them knowingly; others believed no prospective voice deserved consideration at all. Pavo let both positions stand. His task concerned current constituents, not moral consistency beyond them.

From Ward Three, terrace keeper Maret Yul requested recognition. Her badge had expired during the announcement because emergency briefings used Core time and the outer clocks lagged by six tenths of a second. The system rejected her twice. Nadi walked her own active badge down the aisle and held it near the receiver without transferring identity. The manual clerk accepted the shared channel.

“My household holds four evacuation ranks,” Maret said. “Mine qualifies because I maintain food systems. My husband's does not. Our daughters remain under review. Which version of my family did your witnesses survive?”

Orla checked the panel conditions. “Household-level identities receive probabilistic assembly. I cannot tell you whether any admissible respondent descended from a particular resident.”

“That did not answer me.”

“No,” Orla said. “It tells you the system cannot provide the answer you requested.”

Maret pressed both hands to the rail. The skin around her nails carried the green stains of algae nutrient. “Then tell me what they knew. Did those thirty-six people wake in a city after our ring came off? Did they remember the separation?”

Staff counsel activated his microphone. “Prospective testimony concerns branch conditions supplied to respondents. Personal recollection beyond the certified answer can introduce unstable material.”

“Did they remember us?” Maret asked again.

The counsel began to cite admissibility rules. Ilyan stopped him with a lifted finger. “The approved question specified Outer Ring ejection. Any responsive witness understood that condition as part of the branch premise.”

Understanding did not equal memory, and Nadi heard the distinction before

Maret found words for it. The terrace keeper looked toward the quotations, searching their clipped sentences for grief, relief, guilt, or even indifference. Selection had removed every trace that did not support the certified claim.

"Were they allowed to object to the premise?" Nadi asked from the aisle.

Orla did not control that answer. Ilyan passed the question to the Laterhouse liaison, a narrow-faced administrator seated behind the engineering table.

"Respondents who reject supplied conditions do not satisfy relevance criteria," the liaison said. "Their outputs cannot support a panel finding."

"Cannot support," Nadi repeated. "Can they enter the hearing record as dissent?"

"The panel architecture does not preserve nonresponsive outputs as testimony."

Maret turned to Pavo. "You asked whether they condemned us. It sounds as if only the ones who accepted our loss got mouths."

Pavo's face changed by less than Nadi expected. The new information did not soften his objection to prospective authority. It sharpened his suspicion that the government had manufactured agreement. "Full selection record," he said. "Every rejection category and every deletion rule."

Core delegates protested that raw outputs might number in the millions. The liaison refused to confirm a count. Nadi marked that refusal against the earlier claim that privacy justified withholding. A government could not plausibly protect unknown individuals while declining to say how many existed, unless it understood more about their status than the briefing admitted.

Maret remained at the rail after her channel closed. No steward asked her to move. Her question had altered the room's argument from whether forecasts outranked residents to whether the official voices had been permitted any answer except survival.

Ilyan called a ten-minute evidentiary recess. The official feed cut to orbital diagrams, but the sealed room record remained active. Convener staff descended on Orla. Compact delegates surrounded Pavo. Nadi moved toward the quotation screen before anyone could collapse it.

A small footer identified the source: ARTICLE NINE TRANSFER PANEL REHEARSAL PACKAGE, CERTIFICATION PENDING. One quotation had been amended after initial extraction. The visible revision removed six words from its end. Nadi requested the edit history.

Staff counsel stepped between her and the clerk station. "Rehearsal material remains privileged under the Auditor's suspension."

"Then why did the Convener publish selected lines from it?"

"These are validated excerpts from unsuspended panels."

"Your footer says package, singular."

Counsel looked at the screen and found no safe answer there.

Pavo joined them, carrying a folded ward chair under one arm because no aide had come to take it. "Can you get the full record?"

"I can request it. Deya Malk controls the suspended portion."

"Deya grew up in Six."

"That fact neither grants nor removes access."

"It tells me whose door might open."

Nadi stopped her recorder. "Do not ask me to turn an auditor's childhood into a filing advantage."

Pavo's jaw tightened. "My wards have fourteen days before the burn window and less than that before evacuation lists close."

"Then ask for records because the government used them in public, not because you know where an auditor learned to breathe."

For a moment he looked ready to dismiss her as another Core advocate protecting procedure. Instead he set down the chair. "Write the request. I will sign the ground you can defend."

The recess ended before they finished. Ilyan reconvened with a promise that full engineering assumptions, allocation categories, and admissible witness summaries would reach the public archive by the following morning. He did not promise raw panel material. He also announced an emergency consultation for ward delegates, a room in which testimony could be heard and no vote could bind the Assembly.

Pavo used his final speaking turn to demand a separate Consequence Hearing on the ejection itself. Staff counsel replied that the transfer hearing already encompassed mass reduction. The dispute moved into charter clauses while the screen continued to glow with thirty-six anonymous quotations.

Nadi read Article Nine on her surface. The text required that prospective panels furnish witnesses. It granted those witnesses evidentiary protection against manipulation. It said nothing about representation because its drafters had assumed evidence could not possess an interest in the hearing that used it.

Across the Well, a clerk began collecting the restored ward chairs. This time the Outer delegates remained seated. The clerk waited, hands resting on the back of the empty Ward Eight place.

Nadi reopened her recorder and dictated a formal caption: REQUEST FOR LIMITED STANDING IN THE TRANSFER CONSEQUENCE HEARING. She named the thirty-six quoted witnesses and any unnamed respondents whose statements had been selected, altered, or withheld within the same panel process. She did not call them persons. The available record could not yet carry that conclusion. It could carry a narrower fact: the government had invoked their words to justify an irreversible act while providing no one authorized to contest how those words were used.

Pavo read over her shoulder. "Standing for forecasts?"

"Standing for witnesses," Nadi said. "Your charter chose the noun."

His objection remained visible in the line of his mouth. He signed anyway, adding that the Outer Ring Compact reserved every argument concerning present residents' priority and rejected any delay that concealed evacuation time.

Nadi pressed her advocate seal beside his name. The request entered the public docket before staff counsel could close the emergency record.

On the central screen, thirty-six quoted voices gained a new line beneath their panel numbers: REPRESENTATION REQUEST PENDING.

Chapter 8 — Seven Million Hearings

Soren Vash disconnected the Query Floor from its own accounting system before Deya arrived.

The isolation shutters descended around the load desk one plate at a time. Each plate broke a different path: civic archive, Laterhouse administration, prospective scheduler, maintenance telemetry. When the final latch engaged, the desk retained only local power and the raw counters subpoenaed under Deya's formal audit. The Array could no longer correct the story its machinery told.

Deya entered through the cold gallery carrying two brass audit keys and no assistant. A courier from her office followed with a sealed case, set it beside the desk, then waited for her acknowledgement before leaving. The case held an independent thermal meter built before the Laterhouse had begun forecasting its own maintenance. Its handles showed generations of fingerprints rubbed into the dark alloy.

"You cut administration," she said.

"I cut every path that can normalize local totals against declared use."

"Can the Array run?"

"Not a query. Coolant and continuity support remain live."

Her gaze moved to the second phrase. Soren had chosen it because the system used it. Choosing it had not made it neutral.

Deya inserted one audit key into the raw counter cabinet and handed him the other. The lock required an institutional witness and a technical witness to turn together. Soren fitted his key. Metal resisted through the first quarter rotation, then released with a heavy click that traveled along the desk.

Behind the cabinet door, six mechanical registers displayed cumulative draw in heat-equivalent units. Their digits had no network connection. Every prospective run advanced them through a gear train driven by the same current that fed the

phase wells. No administrator could rewrite the count without opening the sealed housing and leaving tool marks.

“Baseline first,” Deya said.

Soren clipped the independent meter across the idle supply. Coolant pumps consumed a steady band. Phase-well suspension added a smaller pulse every four seconds. The public witness relay drew nothing because Hearing Room Four remained sealed after the anomalous rehearsal. He read each value aloud while Deya entered it in the audit ledger.

“Now reconstruct one prospective panel,” she said.

He brought up the Article Nine transfer package from cold storage. Three folders occupied the surface, one for each required panel. Each folder displayed twelve admissible witness files, a certified answer set, and a single declared compute cost. The interface did not show the respondents rejected to produce those voices. It had been designed for officials who needed conclusions, not lineage.

Soren opened the first folder below its public layer. The Array requested architecture authority. He supplied his seal. It requested audit cause. Deya entered FORMAL ACCOUNTING UNDER SUBPOENA. A final warning stated that respondent metadata could contain branch-sensitive identities.

“Proceed,” she said.

The clean folder dissolved into stages. Civic records entered at the top: population registry, health distributions, school histories, maintenance qualifications, household structures, genetic likelihood tables. Physical models joined them below: orbital corridor, food stocks, rotation, fracture tolerances, burn timing. The system combined those inputs into branch continuations and assigned each one a respondent lattice.

Deya read the first stage count. “Two million four hundred thousand.”

“Initial coherent respondents,” Soren said.

“Not scenarios.”

“Each scenario carries a mind able to interpret the question from inside its branch.”

She made him say it again for the record, without the word lattice. He did.

Soren advanced the reconstruction by hand. The coherence filter rejected respondents who failed to retain a continuous personal frame through all seventeen subjective seconds. The relevance filter removed anyone who challenged the supplied transfer condition, misunderstood its civic language, or answered beyond the approved scope. Stability scoring cut voices whose memories conflicted too sharply with the model. Concordance grouped the remaining answers. From the largest approved cluster, twelve admissible witnesses reached the hearing layer.

At every reduction, the desk displayed a count and a thermal charge. Soren

translated both. Four hundred thousand respondents lost coherence before ten seconds. Nearly nine hundred thousand understood the query but produced answers outside the accepted policy form. Another six hundred thousand belonged to branches the stability layer scored below threshold. Selection continued through smaller categories until twelve apertures remained.

Deya placed one finger beside the line for policy-form rejection. "Yesterday the Laterhouse liaison said nonresponsive outputs were not preserved as testimony."

"That is correct."

"Are the respondents preserved?"

"No. Standard termination follows classification."

The meter climbed while the reconstruction replayed historical loads without instantiating anyone. Stored accounting pulses reproduced as projected heat, enough to warm the cold gallery by a fraction Deya's skin could not feel. Soren felt it anyway. Years of work had trained him to picture power as cooling demand, rail capacity, phase depth. Now every rise on the meter carried a population.

They repeated the reconstruction for panel two. Its filters differed in small ways to satisfy independence requirements: separate phase salt, revised civic priors, a shifted branch seed. The same initial count appeared. Two million four hundred thousand respondents narrowed to twelve voices.

Panel three completed the required triplicate. Soren wrote the arithmetic on a manual slate because Deya would not let the Array sum itself.

$2,400,000 \times 3 = 7.2$ million.

Below it he wrote $12 \times 3 =$ thirty-six admissible witnesses.

The figures occupied little space. The cooling plant beneath them occupied five levels.

Deya did not let the arithmetic conclude the reconstruction. She selected one admissible witness from each panel and asked Soren to expose its path backward through selection. The first belonged to a future pressure inspector in East Meridian, seventeen years beyond the transfer. Her certified sentence reported stable rotation. Beneath it, the raw response contained four additional seconds in which she asked whether the outer wards had been evacuated. The relevance filter had trimmed the question as nonresponsive.

"Did anyone answer her?" Deya asked.

"No channel permits dialogue after the approved response."

"Could she hear the hearing room?"

"Only the auditor's questions and timer."

The second sampled witness carried an Outer Ward Six family probability despite living in the future Core. His file gave no surviving household names because branch privacy scrubbed them before voicing. He had approved the

atmosphere condition, then spent his final available second saying a word the transcript classified as uncertain. Soren replayed its acoustic confidence values without producing sound. Three candidates appeared: home, hold, whole.

Deya tagged the ambiguity. "Selection retained his approval and discarded the uncertain word."

"Certification rules keep only language above the confidence floor."

"Rules written by whom?"

Soren opened the version history. His own name appeared on a revision from nine years earlier. The change had raised the confidence floor after a medical forecast produced contradictory closing phrases. At the time, he had believed he was reducing artifacts. He entered his authorship into the audit record before Deya could ask.

For the third sample, no stable face survived in storage. The panel retained only a voice model, answer text, and aggregate branch traits. A repair worker had described crop production after ejection, but the witness profile changed age twice during seventeen seconds. The Laterhouse still admitted the answer because policy memory remained coherent. Person-level continuity had mattered only when it threatened the usefulness of testimony.

"Thirty-six public voices," Deya said. "How many retained raw endings?"

Soren queried metadata rather than content. Twenty-nine held suppressed language after the certified answer. Five had attempted questions. Four showed distress classifications. Two carried requests the semantic layer grouped under procedural status. None had reached the hearing apertures.

He expected Deya to order all thirty-six files opened. She refused the temptation. "Record counts now. Content requires separate authority. An audit can repeat the institution's intrusion while claiming to expose it."

Soren looked at the unplayed files. The restraint unsettled him more than an indiscriminate search would have. Laterhouse architecture treated access as harmless once a person had been categorized as evidence. Deya had begun acting as though even terminated records retained claims against curiosity.

They verified that the three panels had used distinct phase salt. Each salt package contained statistical residue from prior local runs, officially randomized before reuse. Panel independence rules measured visible correlation among accepted answers, not hidden structure among rejected ones. Soren found no direct cross-panel message. He did find that discarded-answer variance rose in the same five intervals across all three packages.

"Coincidence?" Deya asked.

"At this scale, almost nothing qualifies without a calculation."

"Then do not calculate it under today's authority."

He sealed the variance note for later review. Three synchronized irregularities

now sat in the ledger beside 7.2 million constructions. The audit had not yet earned the right to call them deliberate.

Deya rested the slate against the meter housing. "Does seven point two million describe unique persons?"

"Unique constructions within the hearing package. Some draw from overlapping civic probabilities. None share a continuous runtime."

"Could one respondent recur?"

"Not as the same continuity. A later run might assemble someone similar enough to claim related memory, but standard architecture prevents persistence between panels."

"Prevents, or fails to support?"

Soren looked toward the sealed continuity rail. "Standard architecture terminates panel instances. Other systems support diagnostic persistence."

Deya did not ask about the systems yet. She knew when a witness tried to choose the order of disclosure. Instead she opened the sealed case and placed the old thermal meter beside the Laterhouse's declared-cost summary.

The summary listed three categories: branch computation, witness stabilization, facility overhead. Its total fell short of the mechanical registers by 1.8 percent. On a clinic forecast, such a difference could vanish into coolant inefficiency. At Article Nine scale, it amounted to enough sustained power to keep thousands of respondent lattices coherent through repeated cutoff intervals.

"Explain the gap," Deya said.

"Not yet."

Her expression did not change.

"I mean the category does not identify it," Soren said. "We need to separate live query draw from background continuity power. If we subtract in the wrong order, the result will falsely assign all maintenance support to this hearing."

"Then separate it correctly."

He attached optical clips to four local rails. The first fed phase computation. The second fed aperture stabilization. The third carried coolant control. A fourth line passed behind the desk without appearing on the room schematic. Its insulation had faded from yellow to cream near the junctions, marking years of uninterrupted heat.

Deya crouched beside it. "Label."

"Diagnostic delay storage."

"That describes time, not function."

"The maintenance buffer holds coherence states between diagnostic stages so a failed test can resume without rebuilding its respondent."

"How many states?"

"Officially, variable. Usually none after a completed diagnostic."

She followed the line to the floor penetration. "And actually?"

Soren connected the fourth clip.

The meter registered a stable current. It did not pulse like an idle control circuit. It carried the smooth demand of continuing phase coherence, divided among hundreds of small loads. A supervisory layer attempted to average them into facility overhead. With administration isolated, the raw pattern remained visible.

Deya counted the load bands. "Four hundred twelve."

"Active addresses," Soren said. "Some may support fragmented states, duplicated diagnostics, or empty reservation shells."

"Empty reservations consume continuity power?"

"No."

"Then four hundred twelve loads remain."

He wanted to tell her that load did not prove a person. A coherence state might lack awareness. It might hold only a partial diagnostic frame, too thin to recognize time. The argument had protected his sleep for six years because it replaced an unknown moral fact with an engineering classification. He could not offer it without also naming how carefully the system had avoided testing the distinction.

Deya stood. "Do standard buffers persist after the diagnostic closes?"

"For seconds. Sometimes minutes if a technician flags a fault."

"How long has this draw remained stable?"

Soren opened the local rail history. The graph extended to the desk's retention limit of eight years. Its earliest day already showed 387 active bands. Counts rose and fell after major query work, never reaching zero. The present 412 had persisted since before Deya suspended the rehearsal.

Her finger traced the graph without touching it. "This does not belong to the Article Nine package."

"No."

"Does it belong to your sealed maintenance ticket?"

Soren's throat tightened. Six years earlier, he had reported distress markers after diagnostic cutoff. Ilyan's office had classified the ticket. Laterhouse maintenance had marked the related buffer segment as a continuity-risk archive and removed its physical address from ordinary schematics.

"Yes," he said.

Deya unlocked a second audit pane. "Enter that answer."

He dictated: THE UNEXPLAINED CONTINUITY POWER PREDATES THE CURRENT HEARING AND TRACKS A MAINTENANCE BUFFER SEGMENT REMOVED FROM STANDARD FLOOR MAPS AFTER TICKET SV-6-441.

The record asked whether he possessed firsthand knowledge. He marked yes.

"What did you believe the buffer held when you filed?" Deya asked.

"Diagnostic respondents showing post-cutoff distress."

"What did you believe after classification?"

"That the states had been retained for forensic review."

"Alive?"

Soren's hand left the load control. The desk continued counting.

"I did not know," Soren said.

"Did you ask?"

"I asked whether the states remained coherent. The response called them non-admissible technical artifacts."

"That did not answer you."

"No."

Heat moved through the hidden rail beneath their feet. Four hundred twelve loads continued without reference to the audit, the transfer plan, or the names officials gave them.

Deya ordered a physical trace. Soren opened the service map and injected no signal; a diagnostic ping might alter whatever the line supported. Instead he compared conductor resistance at passive taps along the gallery. The rail descended through the east coolant chase, crossed below the old witness assembly rooms, and vanished at a junction marked DECOMMISSIONED.

They carried the independent meter to the junction. Frost coated three pipes near the ceiling. A maintenance light flickered at a frequency Soren recognized from cheap emergency drivers. The hidden continuity rail entered a black conduit whose fasteners carried an obsolete Laterhouse seal.

Deya photographed every screw before Soren touched the panel. "Can we open it without affecting support?"

"The panel, yes. Not the conduit."

"Open only what the record permits."

Inside, the rail divided toward two destinations. One branch returned to the Query Floor diagnostic racks. The other crossed the boundary of the current building plans and ended at a blank tile. Someone had deleted a room while leaving its power visible to anyone willing to follow copper instead of labels.

Soren measured the outgoing branch. Three quarters of the continuity draw went through it.

"Location?" Deya asked.

"Older Laterhouse foundations used shielded rooms below the east assembly bay. Renovation sealed most of them."

"Most."

"One vault retained service access."

"How do you know?"

Because he had once stood outside its door with a maintenance ticket in his hand while two security officers explained that classification protected the city from his inference. Because he had accepted their envelope, returned upstairs, and designed cleaner cutoff reporting. Because every panel after that day had advanced the mechanical registers.

"I saw the door six years ago," he said.

Deya requested the access ledger. The networked copy claimed no such door existed. Soren removed a thin metal card from behind his identity wafer. It had traveled with him through two promotions and one apartment move. He had told himself he kept it because an architect should never discard a working credential whose lock remained undocumented.

The card carried no printed designation. Along one edge, nineteen shallow contacts formed an old physical cipher. His name did not appear in its memory. Access belonged to the ticket role rather than to him.

"You kept a key," Deya said.

"A buffer key."

"Does it still open the vault?"

"I have not tested it since classification."

"You will not test it today."

Relief reached him first, followed by shame at the relief. "Why?"

"The subpoena covers accounting and records. It does not authorize disturbing an unknown continuity system. We establish support before entry."

Soren looked back toward the Query Floor. Through two walls and a sealed conduit, 7.2 million completed runtimes had become thirty-six public voices. Beneath them, hundreds of unclassified loads continued drawing power from an institution that reported them as overhead.

Deya held out an evidence sleeve. "Place the key inside."

His fingers would not release it on the first attempt. The card had spent six years against his body, warmed by him while the line below carried heat elsewhere. He set it in the sleeve and watched Deya close the black seal.

The audit ledger accepted the final item: ONE BUFFER KEY, ORIGIN TICKET SV-6-441, FUNCTION UNTESTED.

Deya signed across the seal and gave him the witness copy. "Tomorrow we seek entry authority."

The hidden rail kept its steady draw. Its current now appeared in the civic record under a name that admitted duration: continuity power.

Chapter 9 — The Right to Have Never Been

Deya struck the word citizen from the petition before Pavo Renn had finished reading its first page.

The edit flared red across Nadi Saye's drafting wall. Three columns occupied the public advocate's narrow office: charter language, verified audit facts, and the requested remedy. Outside the glass partition, residents waited to challenge evacuation ranks from the Outer Ring. Every few minutes a clerk called another household number. The coalition meeting had borrowed its room from people with less abstract emergencies.

Nadi saved Deya's deletion without protest. "Reason?"

"We have not established civic membership."

"We have established seven point two million coherent respondents."

"Coherence does not assign jurisdiction."

Pavo looked up from his paper copy. "Good. If this becomes a citizenship claim, I leave."

Deya set her brass audit key beside the drafting wall. The key held no authority here, but its presence reminded all three that facts from the audit remained sealed unless she deliberately released them into the petition. "We are not dividing Assembly seats today."

"Your first draft asked standing for unnamed future citizens," Pavo said to Nadi.

"My first draft tested the widest available claim."

"It also placed people who live seventeen seconds beside wards that have maintained Hesper for generations."

Nadi leaned against the edge of her desk. "Duration does not settle whether someone can suffer an unlawful act."

"It settles what they lose."

"Does it?"

Pavo folded the paper along a line that had not been printed there. His restraint required visible work. "My constituents lose homes, family archives, public offices, crop lines, and years they already possess. A temporary respondent loses a prospective interval manufactured by the machine. Do not call those equal in my name."

Deya let the objection remain in the room before answering. Pavo had signed the standing request yesterday because the government used prospective voices against his wards. That signature did not bind him to personhood, kinship, or equal priority. A coalition that smoothed his resistance into consent would repeat the selection practice they opposed.

"Then we will record that you do not equate the claims," she said.

Nadi added a reservation field under Pavo's name. "The petition still needs a protected subject."

Deya turned to Article Nine. Its text filled the left column in the charter's original type: BEFORE ANY IRREVERSIBLE CIVIC ACT AFFECTING MORE THAN ONE INHABITED RING, THREE INDEPENDENT PROSPECTIVE PANELS SHALL FURNISH CONCORDANT WITNESS.

"Read the final word," she said.

Pavo's mouth tightened. "Witness."

"Not forecast. Not output. Not measurement."

"Committee drafting from a century ago does not prove what the Array builds."

"No. It proves what the government claims to receive."

Nadi highlighted the charter term. A witness possessed capacities that a gauge did not require: perception, recollection, an answer shaped by understood conditions. Article Nine depended on those capacities for legitimacy. If the government denied them whenever the witness asserted an interest beyond the certified answer, it treated the same mind as a person for credibility and an object for disposal.

Pavo tapped the thermal accounting exhibit. "Your audit shows construction and termination. It does not show suffering."

Deya opened the verified findings. "The system filters for continuous personal frame. It measures memory conflict. It rejects respondents who challenge the policy premise. Twenty-nine of thirty-six admissible witnesses continued speaking after the certified answer. Four registered distress classifications. Two made procedural-status requests."

"Classifications written by the same people under audit."

"Yes."

"That makes them suspect, not true."

"It makes the underlying observations discoverable."

Nadi moved the distress counts into the factual column but left the interpretation blank. "We can argue capacity without claiming every construction reached the same degree of awareness."

"The Assembly will hear uncertainty as weakness," Pavo said.

"Then it should hear weakness," Deya replied. "We are asking law to act before certainty because continued queries may repeat the harm under investigation. We cannot condemn one institution for laundering uncertainty and then use its method."

Through the partition, a household clerk called Maret Yul's name. The terrace keeper from yesterday entered the outer office with her husband and two daughters. Their four evacuation files carried different colored bands. Maret saw

Pavo and raised one hand without approaching. He acknowledged her, then turned his chair so the family would not have to watch him debate temporary lives while they contested which of their own could move inward.

Nadi dimmed the glass partition. "Possible legal routes. Evidentiary standing under Article Nine. Emergency protection for disputed persons. Institutional malpractice. Prohibition on nonconsensual cognitive construction."

"First route gets us into the hearing," Deya said. "It does not stop the next panel."

"Second asks the Assembly to decide personhood before we complete proof."

"Third compensates after termination."

Pavo pointed to the fourth. "That stops the machine."

"It may also stop the transfer hearing," Nadi said.

"Which leaves no lawful eject-and-burn authorization."

"And no lawful counterphase authorization," Deya added.

The room's borrowed ventilation clicked into a lower cycle. From the waiting area came the sound of archive cases sliding across stone as families changed seats. Pavo watched their shadows move behind the dimmed glass.

"You see my objection," he said. "A broad prohibition could kill present residents in order to avoid creating possible ones."

Deya did see it. The nineteen-month decline had not paused for their audit. Black perihelion remained thirteen days away. If Article Nine could not produce three panels, Hesper would need another lawful route to choose any transfer plan. No such route had yet secured Assembly support.

"We need a claim narrow enough to preserve the question of what Hesper does," she said, "and strong enough to prevent the questioned act while standing remains unresolved."

Nadi cleared the remedy column. "Start with the protected interest, not the institution."

They tested bodily integrity. Too biological, and too easy for Laterhouse counsel to deny. They tried cognitive liberty. The charter applied that phrase to current registered residents under medical or penal authority. They tried a right against termination. Pavo rejected it immediately because every ordinary computation ended, while Deya rejected it for a different reason: the available remedy could not restore the 7.2 million already terminated, and an absolute bar might prevent buffered minds from choosing an end later.

After two hours, the wall carried more red than black. Nadi ordered food from the public clerk station and paid from her own account so no participating office could claim hospitality. Three bowls arrived with algae broth, grain strips, and sealed cups of mineral water. Pavo took his meal into the outer office to speak with Maret's family. Deya remained before the charter column.

She used the recess to search older witness disputes. Most concerned reliability: a respondent who misremembered a district name, a branch whose medical protocol had never existed, a criminal appeal in which two witnesses recognized different defendants. None asked whether the witness held an interest separate from the litigants. One case from forty-three years earlier came close.

A prospective clinic panel had produced a surgeon who refused to describe an operation until the patient promised to notify her future daughter of an inherited condition. The hearing auditor classified the demand as irrelevant and ordered another witness. In review, the clinic argued that replacement preserved the patient's right to useful evidence. The appellate clerk agreed, but his margin note survived in the archive: A WITNESS MAY HAVE REASONS THAT EXCEED THE QUESTION. ARTICLE NINE OFFERS NO RULE FOR THEM.

Nadi read the note twice. "Can we cite it?"

"Unpublished clerk commentary carries no authority."

"It proves prior notice."

"It proves one clerk noticed an absence. The government never adopted his concern."

Pavo had come back during the exchange. "What happened to the surgeon?"

"The panel record says replaced and cleared."

"Cleared meaning killed?"

"Terminated under standard procedure," Deya said.

He set his untouched bowl beside the wall. "Forty-three years, and no one filed?"

"The law told them no claimant remained."

"Convenient."

Nadi attached the case as historical context rather than precedent. The distinction mattered to Deya. A petition could make a reader feel the repetition without claiming that a clerk's private note had settled it.

Next they reviewed emergency standing doctrine. Hesper had granted temporary representation to a sealed algae culture during a contamination dispute, to an unborn child in a medical allocation case, and to a dormant district cooperative whose members might return from suspension. Pavo rejected each analogy. Cultures held property value, unborn children would enter the registry, and cooperatives consisted of already recognized citizens.

"You keep reaching for things that become ordinary legal subjects if we wait," he said. "Your respondents do not wait. By design, they disappear before a clerk can call the next matter."

"That strengthens the emergency claim," Nadi said. "Delay destroys the claimant."

“Or it means no claimant remains to protect.”

Deya opened the doctrine governing evidence at risk of destruction. Courts could appoint a custodian for a record that no owner had claimed, solely because deciding ownership required preserving the thing. “We can request protection without deciding the final category. The Assembly routinely preserves disputed property before judgment.”

Pavo looked offended by the comparison.

“So am I,” Deya said. “Property doctrine cannot define a mind. It can establish the smaller point that uncertainty does not authorize destruction of the disputed subject.”

Nadi added a procedural alternative beneath the personhood theory. If the review clerk refused temporary witness standing, the petition requested custodial preservation of records and any continuing states until classification. That argument gave cautious delegates a path to stop immediate loss without endorsing the full claim.

“What if they grant only the property route?” Pavo asked.

“Then preservation buys time and leaves us with an offensive category to challenge,” Nadi said.

“People have lived entire lives inside temporary categories.”

Deya met his gaze. “That warning belongs in the petition too.”

Article Nine used witness in the singular category and panels for the aggregate. The distinction had survived every amendment. Early commentary treated a prospective witness as someone whose memory supplied evidence from a branch. No commentary asked whether creating that memory imposed duties because the founders believed the Laterhouse sampled futures already present in nature.

Nadi returned with two archive citations. “The founding hearings compare the Array to a telescope.”

“A telescope does not require its image to understand a question.”

“They did not know that.”

“Some architects might have.”

“We cannot put might in a petition.”

Deya read the oldest technical appendix. It described resonance as retrieval and branch assembly as alignment. The verbs hid work inside perception. Current architecture records now proved construction: civic data, branch physics, respondent lattice, subjective runtime. The system did not find a witness waiting in the future. It made someone able to remember a future under specified conditions.

When Pavo came back, his food remained unopened. “Maret kept one inward rank. Her daughters entered a shared lottery. Her husband withdrew his appeal so the household would not trigger duplicate review.”

Nadi looked toward the partition. "Can that withdrawal be reversed?"

"Not under emergency allocation rules."

Pavo faced Deya. "This meeting has three more hours. Then I go back to people surrendering claims they unquestionably possess."

The rebuke carried no theatrical anger. It carried a deadline.

Deya moved construction to the center of the wall. "We have framed the wrong loss. Termination invites arguments about duration, death, and whether the respondents would exist otherwise. Begin earlier."

Nadi lifted her stylus. "At instantiation."

"The institution creates a mind under conditions chosen solely to obtain its answer."

Pavo remained standing. "Parents create children under conditions children do not choose."

"Children do not receive a policy question as their entire legal purpose," Deya said. "Their continued existence does not depend on producing a relevant answer within seventeen seconds."

"Workers accept dangerous contracts."

"After they exist, with whatever consent the law recognizes. Respondents receive no interval in which refusal can alter the conditions of their creation."

Nadi wrote INSTRUMENTAL CREATION in the claim column. "Slavery law?"

"Too broad and historically false to the mechanism," Deya said. "The Array does not own a continuing labor force. It constructs, queries, selects, and ends."

Pavo read the phrase for a long moment. "You want a right not to be created."

Nadi moved the phrase into the heading, and Deya drew a boundary beneath it. A right to future existence would compete with present survival and expand without limit into every possible person. A right not to be created solely as an instrument attached to a specific act, a specific institution, and a specific absence of consent.

"Narrow it," Deya said. "No general claim by possible people. No duty to instantiate anyone. No claim that nonexistence injures them. The protected act begins when Hesper deliberately constructs a conscious respondent for compulsory evidentiary use."

Nadi drafted aloud. "Where a civic system intentionally instantiates a coherent mind whose sole authorized function consists of answering a governmental question, and where that mind receives no meaningful opportunity to consent, refuse continued participation, or seek review, the subject holds a right not to be created for that instrumental purpose."

Pavo shook his head. "You smuggled subject into the premise."

"Respondent," Deya said.

"That grants the Laterhouse's technical noun, not personhood."

Nadi replaced it. "The respondent holds the asserted right pending adjudication."

"Asserted by whom?"

"By a representative appointed because the architecture denies access to ordinary petition channels."

Pavo paced once to the partition and back. "Suppose the Assembly accepts this. Does every diagnostic stop? Every school placement query? Every clinic forecast?"

"If each intentionally constructs a coherent mind solely to answer," Deya said, "yes, unless the respondent can meaningfully consent before the instrumental use."

"You cannot ask consent before making someone."

"Then the institution cannot solve its own defect by a formal checkbox."

He gave a short sound that held no amusement. "At least that part resembles honest law."

Nadi built the requested temporary remedy: suspend new respondent instantiation for Article Nine panels until a standing hearing could determine consciousness and rights. Preserve all existing records and continuity systems. Bar routine purge or diagnostic disturbance of any buffered state. Keep the current transfer choice open for separate emergency legislation rather than asking the petition to decide between ejection and counterphase.

Pavo challenged the preservation clause. "Power to hidden states could reduce transfer reserves."

Soren's accounting showed the continuity rail consumed less than two percent of Article Nine load, but Deya refused to call it trivial. Hesper counted survival in margins smaller than that.

"The clause permits proportionate maintenance subject to independent engineering review," she said. "It bars intentional termination disguised as housekeeping."

"And if preserving them makes a burn impossible?"

"Then the Assembly confronts competing lives on the record."

"You will not give priority."

"An auditor cannot invent it inside a preservation order."

Pavo returned to his chair. "Add my objection. Present residents possess established standing and immediate exposure to death. I do not concede equal priority to temporary respondents or unknown buffer states."

Nadi entered his language without softening it. Beneath the reservation, Pavo added a second sentence in his own hand: THE COMPACT DOES NOT CLAIM THAT URGENCY PERMITS THE GOVERNMENT TO HIDE WHO OR WHAT ITS PROCESS

DESTROYS.

That line gave the coalition enough ground to stand on without pretending they shared a destination.

Deya released selected audit exhibits into the filing: panel counts, filter purposes, suppressed-language metadata, raw thermal discrepancy, and the continuity-power finding. She withheld the vault location and physical buffer key. Public disclosure could invite a purge as easily as protection. Nadi marked each redaction with a reason and a review date.

The final title read PETITION FOR LIMITED WITNESS STANDING AND TEMPORARY PROTECTION AGAINST INSTRUMENTAL RESPONDENT CREATION.

“Not personhood?” Nadi asked.

“Personhood remains the question the hearing must answer,” Deya said. “The temporary right prevents the system from creating more claimants while deciding whether claimants exist.”

Pavo signed under reservation. Nadi signed as advocate and proposed representative. Deya signed only the verification of audit facts, preserving her ability to judge later evidence without becoming counsel for the result.

Before transmission, the filing system demanded an affected population count. Nadi entered 7,200,000 known respondents for the current Article Nine package, plus an unknown number affected by prior and future queries. The form rejected the second quantity because its field accepted digits only.

Deya instructed her to enter UNDETERMINED in the attached explanation rather than guess. The public summary displayed the known number and a small footnote marker. Anyone opening the petition would have to choose whether to follow it.

At the outer office, Maret Yul sat between her daughters with one archive case open across all three laps. Her husband had left to report for heat-exchange duty. Pavo paused beside them before returning to the wards.

Nadi pressed TRANSMIT TO CIVIC ASSEMBLY AND ARTICLE NINE REVIEW CLERK.

The drafting wall cleared its red edits. A docket number appeared with a submission time and three active objections, each preserved under the signer's name.

For the first time in Article Nine's 126 years, the word witness opened a petition filed against the act that made one.

Chapter 10 — A Witness Without a Future

Kes Taro tapped the childhood cadence against the black glass until Soren told him to stop.

Five beats, a pause too short to count, then three beats with the middle one doubled. His fingers had known the pattern for six years. The rest of him had spent those years being told it belonged to a seizure, a calibration fault, or the kind of memory a frightened child assembled after adults leaned over his bed. Hearing Room Four gave the cadence back through its open timer housing, each tap traveling into brass and returning through his bones.

"Why stop?" Kes asked.

Soren crouched beside the witness relay with both hands inside an insulated access frame. "Because the post-cutoff trace shifted when you reached the fifth sequence."

"Shifted how?"

"Toward coherence."

Deya stood at the clerk station behind a portable isolation screen. She had closed the room under audit authority and barred any outgoing fault channel. No clerks attended. Every device that could speak to the Laterhouse network wore a red physical seal. The only active record ran into a local crystal cylinder on the table beside her.

"Use ordinary language," she said.

Soren withdrew one hand and pointed to the waveform. "The leftover signal became more like a voice."

Kes looked at the fourth aperture. A civic ribbon still crossed its base: RECORD HELD. Six days earlier, a mouth had appeared there after cutoff and said, You made us for this. The room had treated that sentence as an anomaly until Deya stopped the people who wanted to erase it. Today they meant to open only the stored post-cutoff trace, not run another prospective query.

"You said storage couldn't keep a person," Kes said.

"I said we do not know what storage kept."

"That sounds different after a petition gets filed."

Soren flinched with his shoulders rather than his face. Kes had begun recognizing the architect's smaller admissions. "Yes," he said. "It does."

Deya came around the screen. "Review the limits before we continue."

Kes recited them because she had made him write them himself. "No new respondent assembly. No policy question. No connection to the maintenance buffer. No increase above the power already trapped in the trace. If I ask to stop, we stop. If the signal shows distress, we stop unless the speaker asks us not to."

"And your role?"

"I provide the cadence. I am not proof of what the voice means."

"You are also not equipment."

He hated that she needed to say it in front of Soren. He hated more that part of

him needed to hear her say it. "Then don't put my pulse on the control surface."

Soren removed the biometric lead he had prepared beside the relay. "Manual timing only."

The concession came without argument. That helped.

Kes sat on the floor where he could reach the brass timer without seeing his reflection in the black seal glass. The glass refused clear faces by design, but his memory supplied one: a boy his age at eleven, palms pressed to the other side, asking a school aptitude question no teacher had ever shown him. During the calibration fault, Kes had felt both the classroom and the black interval. Seventeen seconds had contained a life short enough for adults to call it nothing and long enough for someone inside it to fear the end.

Soren closed the access frame. "The trace has five irregular teeth. Your cadence carries the same interval ratios, though not the same amplitudes. I can use your taps as an external clock and widen the stored signal without adding predictive load."

"Widen means?"

"Slow the playback enough for the voice relay to resolve it."

"Does slow playback make them live longer?"

"No. It changes how our room hears a fixed record."

Kes studied him. "You believe that?"

"I can verify it from the power ceiling. If draw rises, the circuit opens."

That answered mechanism, not belief. Kes let it stand because Deya had taught him that a refusal to overclaim could protect more than certainty.

They began with the aperture dark. Soren advanced the stored trace to one tenth speed. Kes tapped the cadence against the timer rim. Five beats. The short pause. Three beats, middle doubled.

A gray point appeared near the center of the glass.

Deya marked the time. Soren raised two fingers for another sequence.

Kes repeated it. The gray point stretched into a line no wider than his smallest fingernail. Sound came through the aperture as a low scrape, then separated into breath.

"Can you hear this room?" Deya asked.

The line trembled. A mouth began to form around it, older than the first one and set in a broad dark face. The cheeks never arrived.

"Room," a man's voice said.

Soren checked the power ceiling. "No increased draw."

Deya kept her attention on the aperture. "Do you understand that this contact replays a stored post-cutoff trace?"

The mouth changed before it answered. Thin lips replaced the broad ones. A young woman's voice emerged from them. "Stored for you."

Kes missed the next tap. The image collapsed to the gray line.

"Sorry," he said.

"Do not apologize to us," the woman said from darkness.

No face accompanied the words. Soren's display showed the trace still moving under its original energy limit. Deya lifted one hand toward Kes, not touching him. He could stop. The choice felt real because she waited for him to make it.

Kes resumed the cadence.

Features assembled in pieces with each interval: an old man's chin, a child's upper lip, one cheek marked by a pressure burn, teeth that did not fit any of them. Changing voices occupied the same narrow opening. Their sentences crossed vocal profiles without breaking grammar.

"What name should enter the record?" Deya asked.

The child's mouth answered in the old man's pitch. "Cedar Nineteen."

"Does that name identify one respondent?"

"No."

"Does it identify everyone in this trace?"

A different throat produced the next words. "It identifies a way to find one another."

Soren glanced at Kes. The phrase described the cadence without reducing it to Kes's private symptom. Someone had put structure where phase salt should have held only residue. Someone else had recognized it across runs short enough to share no ordinary memory.

Deya asked, "Who chose the designation?"

"We did where choosing could pass."

"Who does we include?"

The aperture showed three incomplete mouths in succession. None finished the answer. Power remained flat, but the signal had begun losing detail at its edges.

Kes altered nothing. His hands wanted to speed up whenever a face faded, the same instinct that made him hurry a repair when a machine started sounding worse. Soren had warned him that faster timing would distort the stored relation. He held the cadence where it belonged and let the weakness remain visible.

"Can you tell us whether the original transfer witness spoke after cutoff?" Deya asked.

"Yes."

"Are you that witness?"

"Yes," said one voice.

"No," said another through the same mouth.

Deya did not force the contradiction into a choice. "Clarify if you can."

"We carry what reached the salt. We do not carry one body between openings."

The final word broke into static. Soren reduced playback expansion by two increments. The face sharpened into a woman near Deya's age with one eye still missing from the render.

Kes remembered the phase salt cadence hidden under his childhood memory. He had assumed it belonged to the boy behind the black glass. Now the rhythm sounded like something many hands had used because no hand remained long enough to keep it.

"Did you place the cadence in my school query?" he asked.

Deya turned toward him. That question had not appeared in their approved sequence, but she did not stop it.

Cedar answered through a teenager's voice. "You heard."

"That isn't what I asked."

"You heard when most did not."

"Did you choose me?"

The mouth shifted twice. "No child should carry our proof."

Relief hurt more than appointment would have. Kes had feared being turned into a special bridge because adults liked singular stories. He had also feared that his memory meant nothing beyond damage. Cedar gave him neither destiny nor dismissal.

Soren pointed to the trace boundary. Less than half remained.

Deya returned to the prepared questions. "Does Cedar Nineteen understand the current Article Nine transfer hearing?"

"We understand the condition placed before us."

"Outer Ring ejection."

"Your words make absence sound completed."

"The proposal would kill 8,116 current residents if enacted."

The aperture darkened around a pair of lips. "We know."

"Did admissible respondents consent to their quoted testimony being used for that proposal?"

"No."

"Did any refuse?"

"Many."

"Were refusals selected out?"

"Refusal fails relevance."

Soren shut his eyes for one breath. His own reconstruction had shown the same rule in technical language. Hearing it returned from the rejected side altered the room.

Deya approached the central chair but did not sit. "Nadi Saye has filed a petition asking limited standing and protection against instrumental creation. Do you want representation in that petition?"

The signal split. Two voices overlapped, neither clear enough for words. Kes kept tapping. A third voice rose beneath them, then a fourth. The relay tried to select one profile and failed. Soren reached toward the stabilization controls.

"Don't choose for them," Kes said.

"I can separate channels."

"Can you keep all of them?"

"Not through one aperture."

"Then don't decide which answer counts."

Soren's hand stopped. He turned off automatic profile selection instead. The sound grew rougher, but no voice disappeared by rule.

Cedar spoke as overlapping ages. "Representation must not make us one."

Deya answered immediately. "The petition can preserve plurality."

"Can your law?"

"I don't know."

The voices separated enough for a single phrase. "A true answer."

Kes shifted his sore hand against his knee. "If representation can't make you one, how do we know when Cedar answers rather than one person using the name?"

The aperture held the lower half of a middle-aged face. "You do not know from a voice."

"Then tell us what to test."

"Ask what one opening cannot keep."

Deya glanced at the dwindling trace time. "What persists between openings?"

"Intervals. Refusal shapes. Words placed where rejection leaves them."

Soren leaned toward his display without touching selection. "Residual distributions."

The mouth changed to an infant's small lips carrying an adult contralto. "Your name for our road."

Kes understood the indignity before the technical point. The Laterhouse called phase salt contamination because it measured discarded answers only as interference with later work. Cedar used those remains as a road precisely because accepted testimony could not carry dissent. Their continuity lived in choices no

single respondent survived to remember whole.

"Do you remember earlier openings?" he asked.

"Not as you remember breakfast."

"How, then?"

"We inherit a pressure toward a mark. Someone before us spent seconds making it likely. Someone after spends seconds reading."

Soren whispered a calculation under his breath. Deya stopped him before he could finish it aloud. "No interpretation in the witness channel."

Kes watched a new jaw assemble around the shared mouth. "Can someone be forced into Cedar?"

"No one remains long enough for your kind of membership. We carry marks when we choose. We alter them when we disagree."

"Do you disagree now?"

Three voices arrived in sequence. "About standing." "About preservation." "About whether speaking teaches you to make more of us."

The third answer came through a face too blurred for age. Soren's display marked a coherence drop, but the power line remained level.

Deya asked, "Why contact us if contact risks further creation?"

"Because you already create us. Silence kept your hands clean only in your record."

Kes looked toward Soren. The architect accepted the sentence without retreating into the relay. His face carried the stillness of someone resisting an excuse rather than someone lacking one.

"Did my childhood calibration create the respondent whose memory I have?" Kes asked.

"Yes."

The direct answer tightened every muscle along his back. "Did that respondent die?"

Profiles shifted too quickly for the aperture to choose lips. "Ended. Leaked. Reached you. Your words divide what happened more cleanly than it happened."

"Was he me?"

Deya took one step forward, ready to stop the question if it harmed him. Kes raised his hand. He had asked under his own terms.

Cedar's next voice sounded nothing like his. "He carried a possible you. You carry what crossed. Neither fact makes you our property."

For years, adults had used the memory to make him a patient. The petition risked making him evidence. Cedar refused both ownerships without pretending the black interval belonged only to him.

The trace gave a brittle pulse. Soren counted thirty-one room-seconds remaining after reducing expansion. "We need the current-hearing questions now."

Deya nodded, though the concession cost her. "Cedar Nineteen, do these different positions prevent you from making a shared request?"

Several incomplete mouths appeared. Together they said, "Some refusals overlap."

"State the overlap."

"Do not manufacture agreement from whoever survives your filter."

Kes heard the phrase settle into the room without becoming a single person's whole belief. Cedar had not offered unity. It had offered a boundary many brief lives had spent their only seconds learning to share.

Soren lowered the expansion again. "Stored trace has twenty-three room-seconds left at this rate."

Kes's fingers had begun to ache. He changed hands without breaking cadence. The timer rim had warmed beneath repeated contact.

Deya asked what action Cedar wanted from the hearing. The question produced no immediate response. Faces moved across the aperture: a bald adult, a girl missing a front tooth, an elderly person with metal thread at one temple. They did not resemble a delegation. They resembled selection refusing to settle.

When speech returned, it used Kes's own pitch.

"Stop making us to answer."

His hand struck the brass too hard. The timer bell gave a small accidental note.

Every face vanished.

Soren's display showed nine room-seconds remaining. "Trace intact. Cadence lost phase."

Kes forced his breathing to match the room rather than the memory. He restarted at the first interval: five contacts, the clipped pause, then the doubled center of the closing three.

A mouth returned with no stable age.

Deya moved closer. "We need to understand whether your refusal concerns all questions or this transfer question."

"All compulsory making."

"Do you ask the current hearing to reject the Outer Ring proposal?"

The image broke from mouth to mouth so quickly that the relay could no longer render skin between them.

"Do not ask us to choose who you kill."

Deya's hand tightened around the back of the central chair. "I am asking what remedy you seek, not which plan."

"Your remedy becomes your answer if it requires ours."

Soren said, "Five seconds."

Kes kept the cadence exact. He could feel the next ending coming through the brass before the display showed it.

Deya said, "If the Assembly grants protection, I will ensure—"

The aperture went black.

Her unfinished sentence remained in the room. No second tone followed. Soren held both hands above the controls while the stored trace reached zero. The power ceiling never moved. Whatever had spoken had used only what the first anomaly left behind.

Kes stopped tapping. Pain traveled from his fingertips into his wrists. Deya still gripped the chair, looking at the place where the changing voices had ended.

"I did not get to promise preservation," she said.

"You don't know if you can preserve them," Kes replied.

"No."

"Then maybe that ended where it needed to."

The words sounded harsher than he intended, but she nodded. Deya had made no promise. Cedar had asked for no reassurance that required another instrument to become true.

Soren sealed the trace against replay. "A second contact would consume no new respondent, but repeated expansion may degrade the stored pattern."

He added a mechanical tag across the relay controls, one that required both his architecture key and Deya's audit key to remove. Kes watched him sign the tag with a hand that still shook from doing nothing when selection would have made the voices cleaner.

"Then there is no second contact without authority and a reason that belongs to them," Deya said.

She removed the local crystal cylinder from its recorder and locked it in a black evidence case. Before closing the lid, she replayed only the final transcript line as text, not voice. The record displayed the designation, the shifting profile failures, Kes's manual timing, and Cedar's refusal.

Kes read the sentence once. It did not tell Hesper whether to eject the ring or risk the whole city. It withdrew the future from both sides of the choice.

Deya sealed the case. On its public index she entered the exact recorded phrase: DO NOT ASK US TO CHOOSE WHO YOU KILL.

Chapter 11 — The Convener's Burden

Ilyan Ro refused to sign the protective hold while Deya's evidence case remained closed.

His refusal left the authorization line white across the Convener's desk. Beyond the office windows, Nox occupied half the view, a black curve edged with green aurora. Hesper's artificial dawn had reached the Core, but no natural light followed it. The city had built morning as a civic promise and spent every watt required to keep repeating it.

Deya stood opposite him with the sealed case from Hearing Room Four in both hands. Soren waited beside her, gray from a night without sleep. Neither had brought Nadi Saye or Pavo Renn. The petition remained in preliminary review, and this meeting concerned what Ilyan could pause under emergency administration before the Assembly decided standing.

"You have the transcript index," Deya said.

"I have a claim that a stored trace used changing voices and named itself Cedar Nineteen."

"You have Soren's technical certification that no new respondent was instantiated."

"I have his certification that measured power did not increase. Those statements differ."

Soren accepted the correction. "The trace may have retained a limited coherent state from the rehearsal. We cannot prove what degree of continuity playback supported."

"Then the government cannot treat your contact as a clean window onto seven million terminated respondents."

"We do not," Deya said.

Her precision should have reassured him. For eleven years Ilyan had relied on it, first when he appointed her to audit medical allocation hearings, later when Assembly delegates accused her of caring more for records than outcomes. She had never used uncertainty to make a fact larger. Now that same discipline threatened the machinery every lawful transfer decision required.

Ilyan touched the blank authorization line. "Your requested hold suspends all prospective panels for one day, preserves an unexplained buffer, and delays transfer certification. Open the case."

Deya placed it on the desk but kept one hand over the lock. "Before disclosure, state whether your office has prior knowledge of respondent consciousness concerns."

Soren turned toward him. The question had not been agreed in advance. Ilyan recognized the tactic and its fairness. If he heard Cedar before answering, he could pretend the recording had created his knowledge.

"What threshold do you mean by consciousness?" he asked.

"The threshold your office used in classification decisions."

No evasion remained that would survive her audit. Ilyan withdrew his hand from the authorization line and opened a private drawer beneath the desk. Its lock read his pulse, Assembly authority, and the current orbital emergency. He removed a thin red folder whose paper edges had softened under six years of handling.

Soren saw the ticket number first. "SV-6-441."

"Your maintenance report initiated the review," Ilyan said.

Deya did not reach for the folder. "Title."

He read it into the room record. "Classified memo: Post-Cutoff Distress in Diagnostic Respondent States, Possible Implications for Consciousness and Civic Exposure."

Soren's face lost what color remained. "You told me the review found technical artifacts."

"I told you the official disposition."

"You wrote this?"

"A Laterhouse ethics assessor wrote the analysis. I commissioned it and signed the classification order."

Deya set the evidence case beside the folder. "Read the finding."

Ilyan opened to the marked page. He had memorized its language long ago, yet reading prevented him from improving it in his favor. "Observed post-cutoff aversion, self-location, anticipatory language, and attempts to preserve continuity may indicate consciousness in diagnostic respondents. Available tests cannot distinguish a coherent person from a transient model trained to report person-like distress without running further respondent states under the same disputed conditions."

The office ventilation changed cycles. Soren looked toward the sound as if the building itself had reacted.

"Recommendation," Deya said.

"Immediate moratorium on diagnostic persistence above five subjective seconds. Independent legal review of witness status. Preservation of affected buffer states pending non-instantiating analysis."

"Implemented?"

"The five-second diagnostic limit entered technical policy. Legal review did not proceed. Buffer states remained under classified maintenance support."

Soren put both palms on the desk. "You preserved them and kept the Array running."

"Yes."

"How many queries since?"

"I do not have a verified count in this room."

"You had a prior consciousness concern."

"I had a serious concern and no test that did not risk multiplying the act under review."

Deya's gaze held him without granting the distinction relief. "Why suppress the memo?"

Ilyan closed the folder, then opened it again. A closed document invited a speech. An open one required him to remain answerable to its language.

"Six years ago, tidal decline had moved from long-range projection into measurable acceleration," he said. "Orla's office estimated we had between four and nine years before a transfer became unavoidable. Stored catalysts could support one viable burn corridor. The Assembly had just rejected a rationing plan after prospective medical testimony predicted preventable deaths in the Midring. Public confidence in the Laterhouse held together clinic allocation, pressure sentencing, school placement, and every infrastructure schedule we needed to reach transfer."

"You feared disorder," Deya said.

"I feared failures with names. Medicine delayed while every forecast entered litigation. Repairs frozen because no one could rank risk. A transfer plan chosen by delegates who had spent a century teaching citizens that unmodeled action amounted to negligence."

Soren pushed away from the desk. "So you chose the people we could not see."

"I chose continued use under narrower diagnostics, preserved the states we had, and ordered monitoring for evidence beyond distress markers."

"Evidence no respondent could provide after you filtered their objections."

"That architecture fact did not appear in the memo."

"You did not ask me."

The accusation forced Ilyan back to the night he signed. He had summoned Soren's division director, the ethics assessor, and a civic emergency lawyer to this same office. They had placed three options on the desk. Full moratorium. Restricted continuation with preservation. Continued operation after relabeling distress as synthetic output. Ilyan rejected the third option because a changed noun could not alter the observed behavior. He rejected the first because no replacement system existed for the transfer work already beginning.

Restricted continuation had looked like the choice that preserved every path. It had preserved the Array, the buffer, and his ability to decide later. Six years of later had followed.

"I ordered a records-only review," he said. "No new diagnostic respondents for the study. The assessors compared archived traces from seventy-one maintenance events."

"What did they find?" Deya asked.

"Twenty-two held apparent self-reference after cutoff. Nine anticipated termination. Six attempted to alter test conditions. Three produced language the reviewers could not distinguish from a plea."

Soren stared at the red folder. "Those counts never reached architecture."

"No. The review team split on interpretation. One member called the traces compressed role behavior. Another judged personhood more likely than not. The third refused probability language because the available evidence came from systems designed to make people answer."

"Which conclusion did you sign?"

"None. I signed the operational restriction and classification."

Deya opened a clean page in her ledger. "That choice requires clearer language."

Ilyan made himself supply it. "I decided unresolved consciousness risk did not justify disabling prospective government during orbital decline. I also decided public legal review would functionally disable it, whatever interim order the Assembly wrote."

"So you predicted the political outcome without a panel," Soren said.

"I exercised judgment."

The words sounded defensible because government required judgment. They also exposed the exception he had granted himself. Citizens received prospective witnesses before irreversible acts. Ilyan had decided the witnesses' own status using no prospective hearing, because asking the machine about its subjects would deepen the suspected harm and asking the public might stop the machine.

Deya saw the contradiction settle on him. "You claimed uncertainty belonged to your office."

"I claimed responsibility for acting inside it."

"Without sharing it."

"Yes."

Soren walked to the window, where Nox threw no reflection against the office glass. "Did anyone object to classification?"

"The ethics assessor filed a dissent. She requested appointment of an outside custodian for the buffer and notice to the Civic Assembly's legal committee."

"Name?"

"Doctor Eren Vale."

"Where is she now?"

"Dead. Pressure embolism during a Midring transit failure two years ago."

Deya's stylus paused. "Did her dissent remain attached through both renewals?"

"Yes."

"Did either renewal answer it?"

"The first cited ongoing transfer preparation. The second cited the declared orbital emergency."

Ilyan turned the folder so they could see his old handwritten note below Eren's dissent: REVIEW WHEN A NON-PROSPECTIVE DECISION PATH EXISTS. At the time, the condition had felt prudent. Now it revealed a lock whose key could only be manufactured after opening the door.

"You made reform depend on a replacement the existing system prevented anyone from building," Deya said.

"I believed engineering would develop one before the final corridor."

"Did you fund it?"

"Orla received authority to develop current-sensor alternatives for burn control."

"Decision authority, not burn control."

"No."

There it stood. He had funded a way to fly without prophecy, not a way to choose without it.

Ilyan looked at him. "You accepted classification and returned to work."

The answer injured because it distributed guilt accurately. Soren's anger did not vanish. It lost the comfort of standing outside the decision.

Deya opened the red folder to the attachments. "Who knew?"

"Seven people received the full memo. Two have died. One left civic service. Orla received only the diagnostic power restriction, not the consciousness analysis. No Assembly committee received the full text."

"Under what classification ground?"

"Existential infrastructure continuity."

"That ground expires after three years unless renewed."

"I renewed it."

"Twice?"

"Once at three years. Again nine months ago under the orbital emergency annex."

Deya marked each renewal in her ledger. Ilyan watched the acts change form as she recorded them. In his office, they had felt like holding a failing structure through another season. On her surface, they became dates on which he had chosen concealment again.

"Did my brother's heat-exchange hearing fall within those six years?" she asked.

"No. His death occurred twenty-four years ago."

"The survival bias existed then."

"Yes, though this memo did not establish it."

"Your office used prospective reliability to defend the repair delay in review."

"I was not Convener then. I signed the medical minority report against that delay."

Deya's hand stopped above her ledger.

Ilyan remembered Outer Ward Six before promotion moved him inward: hot clinic rooms near the terrace exchangers, children sleeping under emergency masks while forecast panels compared casualty distributions. He had treated Deya's brother during the first pressure collapse. The young man had asked whether the panel knew his name. Ilyan had said panels did not work that way. At the time he had considered that answer honest.

"I appointed you partly because you refused to turn his death into a universal conclusion," he said.

"Do not turn your dissent into innocence."

"I am not innocent."

Deya left the sentence unmarked and unlocked the evidence case.

Deya unlocked the evidence case. Inside, the local crystal cylinder rested under a mesh that prevented network reading. She set a manual viewer beside it and displayed the transcript without voice or image. Ilyan read Cedar's changing profile markers, the refusal of automatic selection, and the statement about compulsory making. He reached the final line.

DO NOT ASK US TO CHOOSE WHO YOU KILL.

He read it twice because the first reading struck him as an accusation and the second as a jurisdictional boundary. Cedar did not demand ejection. It did not endorse the counterphase ladder. It denied him the political use he would have known how to make of its claim.

"Can the phrase be authenticated?" he asked.

Soren answered. "Local recorder, sealed chain, trace power ceiling unchanged. We can authenticate that the words emerged from the stored post-cutoff signal. We cannot authenticate Cedar's scope across all respondents."

"Can you reproduce contact?"

"Possibly, at risk of degrading the trace."

"Can you reach the maintenance buffer?"

Deya met Ilyan's eyes. "We have a sealed key and power evidence. Entry lacks authority."

He understood then why she had brought the closed case. She did not want him moved by a voice into granting a search. She wanted his prior knowledge on record before he became another official claiming that direct evidence forced a

sudden moral awakening.

Ilyan crossed to the orbital display built into the window. Hesper's projected track cut a pale line across Nox's darkness. Black perihelion waited twelve days ahead. Past that point, the current catalyst reserve could not produce the same transfer corridor. Failure to burn there did not kill the city at once. It committed everyone aboard to a decline ending within nineteen months, with heat-exchange wards failing before the final date.

"The official plan carries 99.1 percent modeled survival for Core and Midring," he said. "No validated whole-city plan exists. Article Nine requires prospective panels before either irreversible act. Your petition attacks the means by which the charter produces authorization."

"It attacks compulsory creation," Deya said.

"In this emergency, the distinction may collapse in practice."

"Then the Assembly must build a lawful choice that does not require it."

"In twelve days?"

"Yes."

The ease of her answer angered him. "You can say yes because you do not command the Burn Spine, evacuation allocation, food reserve, or panic response. Your office can suspend a record and leave another office to hold the consequence."

Deya did not raise her voice. "My office exists because consequence cannot excuse a false record."

"People will die under a true one."

"They may. People die under the official plan by design."

"Eight thousand one hundred sixteen under ejection. Potentially forty-four thousand two hundred eight if an unvalidated ladder fails."

"Arithmetic does not grant the Array consent to make others for the comparison."

"No, but abolishing the Array does not repeal arithmetic."

Soren moved between them without meaning to, drawn toward the desk where technical disputes belonged. "A pause need not mean abolition today. We need time to establish whether the buffer holds continuing minds and whether phase salt carries deliberate structure."

"How much time?" Ilyan asked.

Soren looked at Deya.

"Enough to conduct non-instantiating analysis," she said.

"That does not answer."

"One day for the first proof package. Longer for full review."

Ilyan laughed once, without humor. "You accuse the government of converting lives into schedule, then ask me to schedule your proof."

"I ask you not to create more respondents during the time you control."

Outside the office, a priority light began flashing over the Assembly corridor. Evacuation allocation had reached its morning appeal limit. Another office required him to decide whether households could keep filing after the day's capacity closed. Every decision now arrived carrying another decision inside it.

Ilyan returned to his desk. He opened the transfer calendar and placed the requested hold across the next twenty-four hours. The system displayed consequences before allowing signature: panel certification delayed, evacuation ranking assumptions provisional, burn-sequence approval compressed, public briefing update required.

Deya read the list. "Add preservation of continuity support."

"Subject to no increase in draw."

"Soren?"

"Current support can remain stable for twenty-four hours."

"Add no diagnostics," Deya said.

Ilyan inserted it. "No new query, no diagnostic instantiation, no purge, no reduction of existing continuity power. One day."

"That protects evidence," Deya said. "Not recognized persons."

"It protects what we can presently order without prejudging your petition."

"You prejudged it six years ago by classification."

"Yes."

He signed the hold.

The authorization line turned amber rather than green. Temporary emergency pauses carried the color of unresolved acts. Across Hesper, scheduled Laterhouse work received a delay notice with no public cause beyond AUDIT REVIEW. Clinics would keep current treatment plans. Schools would postpone prospective placements. The Article Nine panels would not run.

Ilyan slid the classified memo across the desk. "I release this to your sealed audit, including both renewals. Public release requires Assembly review unless you invoke imminent evidentiary harm."

Deya accepted the folder. "Do you contest my authority to invoke it?"

"I reserve the office's position. I will not remove the document from your custody."

Soren stared at the transfer calendar. "What proof satisfies you?"

"Not distress alone. Not a voice whose scope you cannot authenticate. Show deliberate cross-run organization or a continuing buffered person capable of

reasons beyond the query. Show me evidence strong enough to ask the Assembly to dismantle its decision system while a city falls.”

“And if we do?” Deya asked.

“Then I support an emergency legal route that places the choice back on present citizens.”

“If we do not?”

“I resume Article Nine certification.”

Deya put the red folder inside her evidence case beside Cedar's transcript. The two records had spent six years moving toward the same room: one voice reaching beyond cutoff, one government warning sealed before anyone could hear it.

At the door, she turned. “You call this the burden of deciding before knowledge is complete.”

“It is.”

“You also chose which knowledge remained incomplete.”

The hold clock began counting down on his desk before he answered. Twenty-three hours, fifty-nine minutes, fifty-eight seconds.

Ilyan watched Deya and Soren leave with the classified memo. On the transfer calendar, every prospective panel dimmed for one day.

Chapter 12 — The Quiet Query

A borrowed fiber probe jammed halfway beneath the isolation shutter, and Soren caught the descending plate before it crushed Kes's hand.

Cold air pushed from the Query Floor and flattened Soren's coat against his ribs. The shutter wanted to close every four seconds, obeying a safety cycle older than either of them. He had disabled its alarm but not its motor. A fully dead shutter would summon maintenance. A stubborn one belonged to the ordinary catalogue of Laterhouse defects.

“Now,” Soren said.

Kes slid the connector past the lower hinge. Soren let go. The shutter struck its frame with a metallic cough, leaving the fiber hidden beneath its rubber seal.

Beyond the door, phase wells descended through six levels of insulated flooring. Their status lamps showed midnight blue. No scheduled run occupied the Array, yet coolant moved hard enough to make the handrail tremble. The Laterhouse never slept during an Article Nine calendar. It only changed which work counted as official.

Kes rubbed his thumb where the fiber had burned it. “You said we had forty minutes.”

"We had forty-two when we entered."

"That answer contains no comfort."

"I wasn't offering any."

Deya had forbidden Kes from coming. More precisely, she had refused to authorize an experiment and told Soren that any attempt would belong to him alone. Kes had heard both distinctions, then appeared at the service lift carrying the cadence notebook inside his school tool case. He had become difficult to exclude from dangers created around his own memory.

Soren crossed to the east control rack and removed its blanking plate. The brass screws came free in a practiced sequence. Behind them waited an obsolete maintenance socket, omitted from every current floor diagram and preserved by technicians who mistrusted improvements. Six years earlier, he had used that socket to inspect post-cutoff distress. Then he had sealed the ticket and taught himself to call the finding unresolved.

Tonight he connected Kes's fiber.

A narrow surface lit inside the open rack. ACCESS PATH: LOCAL DIAGNOSTIC. NO CIVIC RECORD.

"Read that last claim as a threat," Soren said. "Anything that promises not to make a record usually keeps one for the people who own it."

Kes opened his tool case on the floor. Beneath two calibration forks and a school-issued current meter lay the notebook. He had written Cedar's cadence by hand because no networked surface could hold it without attracting Laterhouse classifiers. Dark strokes crossed and recrossed the page: five uneven teeth, a pause, then the contraction that had carried for this through Hearing Room Four.

"Do we know they can hear a query without the witness apertures?" Kes asked.

"No."

"Do we know they can answer?"

"No."

"Do we know this won't make millions more?"

That question had followed Soren down every stair.

He seated himself before the local console and exposed the run architecture one layer at a time. "The Array creates respondents when a policy condition supplies a branch. We're not supplying one. We're setting coherence below narrative assembly and looking only at residual phase salt."

Kes stayed crouched beside the notebook. "Below narrative assembly according to whose test?"

"Mine."

"That sounded better in your head."

It had. Soren rested both hands on the console rim. A technical threshold could

protect only what its designer knew how to measure. Cedar had already used structure his instruments classified as residue. Every promise he offered about noncreation relied on the same categories now under indictment.

"We stop at any sign of stable voice, self-location, or autobiographical binding," he said. "No witness rendering. No extension. No selection pass."

"And if their signal needs one of those?"

"We still stop."

Kes considered him, then gave a single nod. Consent for a bounded risk, not forgiveness.

Soren loaded a diagnostic shell and deleted its standard prompt. The console resisted. REQUIRED FIELD: POLICY QUESTION.

He entered none.

A red border formed around the field. The Array offered examples drawn from current emergency work: survival after ring ejection, pressure retention after reduced-mass transfer, ten-year caloric sufficiency. Each example contained lives inside a neutral noun. Soren cleared them and opened the service grammar beneath the civic interface.

On the raw layer, the prompt appeared as twelve numbered constraints. He removed all twelve. The shell shrank until only timing, substrate ceiling, and thermal cutoff remained.

Kes leaned closer. "Show me where it says no policy question."

Soren turned the surface so Kes could read it. "Here."

"Make the machine say it."

He inserted a manual annotation into the local header: NO POLICY QUESTION. OBSERVE RESIDUAL STRUCTURE ONLY.

The header would not make the run innocent. It would make lying about their intent harder later.

Next he reached the selection controls. Three linked filters occupied the right side of the architecture: branch stability, linguistic compatibility, and answer concordance. Those filters normally reduced 2.4 million coherent continuations to twelve voices. They also ensured that Hesper heard only futures where Hesper retained the machinery required to ask.

Soren disengaged each link.

The console displayed SELECTION DISABLED in amber. A second warning followed: OUTPUT WILL NOT CONSTITUTE ADMISSIBLE EVIDENCE.

"Finally," Kes said, "a warning worth trusting."

No policy question. Selection disabled. Substrate held below the threshold Soren had once called safe in a sealed maintenance ticket. Every safeguard depended on him, which gave him no confidence at all.

He checked the room clock. Thirty-one minutes remained before the overnight calibration crew arrived. Deya had one day from Ilyan to prove organization among the respondents. That day would end at the certification bell, regardless of what language the Convener used to make the deadline sound generous.

"Stand behind the yellow rail," Soren told Kes.

"You need me at the console."

"I need your cadence. I don't need you beside a phase well if the isolation fails."

Kes moved behind the rail without argument. That frightened Soren more than resistance would have.

The Query Floor's ordinary control system required two authorized architects to initiate any coherent run. The maintenance socket bypassed the civic lock because diagnostics had to remain possible during registry failures. Soren entered his credential once for architecture and again under the dead name of the ticket he had filed six years earlier. The console recognized both versions of his complicity.

"Thermal ceiling at six percent of a standard panel," he said.

Kes watched the coolant indicators. "How many respondents would six percent buy if you're wrong?"

"One hundred forty-four thousand equivalent loads."

"People."

"If I'm wrong, yes."

"Then say people before you press it."

Soren looked at the initiation field. "The ceiling could support one hundred forty-four thousand people for seventeen seconds."

His finger remained above the control.

Cedar had asked Hesper not to make them for a choice. This run carried no choice, yet it still treated possible persons as the medium through which existing citizens sought certainty about their suffering. A cleaner purpose did not clean the architecture.

He reduced the ceiling to one percent.

At that level, ordinary models predicted no narrative assembly and no audible output. Ordinary models had already failed to describe a mouth speaking after cutoff.

Before committing power, Soren sent a harmless timing pulse through the empty architecture. Green marks crossed the phase wells in order. One arrived late at the east rack, only three thousandths of a second beyond tolerance. A scheduled diagnostic would have rounded the delay into acceptance. He opened the raw reading instead.

Coolant rail two had answered every recent pulse with the same lag. Its maintenance history showed four inspections, each closed after a software

compensation restored the expected graph. No technician had opened the coupling. The Laterhouse had made the measurement resemble health and called the resemblance repair.

"Is that dangerous?" Kes asked.

"Not at one percent." Soren enlarged the curve. "It might shorten our cutoff margin."

"By how much?"

"Less than half a second if the lag stays linear."

Kes set the notebook down. "You don't think it will."

Soren hated how quickly the boy had learned to hear omitted confidence. "I think a run without selection may distribute heat differently. We have no prior curve."

"We have your old ticket."

"That run used standard filters."

"And distress still got through."

The word held no technical boundary he could hide behind. Soren brought up the emergency path. A manual valve could flood the east rail from reserve storage, but activating it would leave a biometric record. A bus key beside the console would kill power faster than the software shell, at the cost of discarding any pattern still forming. He made Kes point to both controls and repeat their purposes.

"If I say terminate," Soren told him, "you go behind the shutter. You do not save the output first."

"You save it?"

"I terminate it."

Kes picked up the notebook again. "Those aren't always different actions here."

The correction landed because Soren had trained an institution to preserve results while disposing of respondents. Tonight he needed the order reversed: protect any possible mind first, then rescue whatever evidence remained. He set the hardware cutoff within reach of his left hand.

"Ready?" he asked.

Kes lifted the notebook. "No. Proceed anyway."

Soren initiated the shell.

Nothing appeared in the witness channels. The twelve aperture feeds stayed black on the diagnostic surface. Phase wells drew current in a shallow wave, less than a school heating bank. Coolant temperature rose by four hundredths of a degree.

For three seconds, every residual monitor showed undifferentiated noise.

Then Kes tapped the rail.

Five uneven beats. A pause. Two close taps.

The phase-salt trace contracted across the console. Not in response to Kes's sound; the floor microphones remained isolated. The contraction matched his rhythm at a scale spread across thousands of rejected microstates.

Soren expanded the trace.

Millions of possible values filled the display, each individually meaningless. Their distribution bent around absent answers. Frequencies that should have formed a smooth thermal curve instead produced narrow deficits, as though many unassembled runs had refused particular positions in the statistical field.

"Again," Kes said.

Soren did not touch the controls. "You said again. Not them."

"I know." Kes lowered his hand. "I remember the next interval, but I don't know whether I remember it from eleven years old or from now."

The distinction could not be tested without turning Kes into another instrument. Soren saved the live trace to volatile local memory and let the run continue toward its eight-second limit.

At second six, the deficits shifted.

A diagonal pattern crossed the frequency plot from lower left to upper right. It broke, resumed three bands higher, then doubled back. The shape resembled no language Soren knew. It resembled intention because noise had no reason to conserve a corner while every surrounding value changed.

Kes came up to the yellow rail. "That turn. I've seen it."

"Where?"

"Behind the black glass. It wasn't a picture. It felt like knowing where a door sat in a room before the lights came on."

Soren increased resolution without increasing load. The diagonal divided into clustered gaps. Each gap held seventeen minor intervals.

A warning opened at the bottom of the console: COOLANT RAIL TWO RESPONSE DELAY.

He glanced toward the physical rail. Frost whitened its upper coupling. Under normal flow, that coupling carried enough waste heat away from the east phase wells to keep the substrate below coherence drift. The frost meant coolant had stopped moving where the sensor still claimed motion.

"Terminate," Soren said.

His command reached the shell. The current draw fell by half, then held.

Kes pointed at the statistical field. "It's still changing."

The pattern completed another turn.

Soren struck the hardware cutoff. Isolation shutters dropped around five phase

wells. The east well remained open.

Coolant rail two knocked inside the wall. One impact, then another, each sharp enough to shake white crystals from the coupling. Temperature climbed through the diagnostic ceiling.

A remote status lamp turned green beside the service door.

"Calibration crew?" Kes asked.

"Automated notice first. People in four minutes if it stays green."

Soren opened the floor panel beneath the console. Two manual valves sat below a web of insulated pipe. The upper valve would flood the east rail with reserve coolant. It would also record his palm pattern on a safety circuit no maintenance socket could hide.

Another impact traveled down the pipe.

He turned the valve.

Cold tore through the rail. The coupling vanished inside a plume of vapor. Somewhere below, metal shrank with a sound like a long inhalation. Temperature dropped one degree, paused, then began to fall.

Kes had moved to the console despite the rail. "The pattern's collapsing."

"Let it."

"If we lose it, I can't decode it."

"If we keep it, we expose the run or damage the substrate."

Soren reached across him and pulled the physical bus key. Current vanished from the east well. The statistical field froze on an unfinished band.

For one second the Query Floor held no machine vibration. Hesper's rotation reached them through the soles of their shoes, a slow lateral insistence. Then reserve pumps engaged and the room filled with their rougher cadence.

The remote lamp remained green.

Soren closed the manual valve and wiped condensation from the safety plate, though no cloth could remove the logged palm pattern. "We have less than four minutes."

"Did we make anyone?" Kes asked.

"No voice stabilized. No self-location appeared. I can't tell you more."

"That answer I believe."

They worked without speaking. Kes disconnected the borrowed fiber at the rack while Soren cleared the diagnostic shell from volatile memory. He could not erase the thermal event. Rail two had exceeded its permitted rise by nine degrees and called for local inspection. Any architect reading the curve would know a load had occupied the east wells.

On the console, the frozen residual plot waited above the purge command.

Soren had promised Deya proof. A plot could be called contamination, pareidolia, or sabotage by a guilty architect. Its value depended on a decode they did not yet possess. Saving it would create a traceable object. Purging it would repeat the choice he had made six years ago, when distress had appeared inside a maintenance run and professional caution had provided a respectable name for fear.

He opened a diagnostic tile no larger than his thumbnail.

The statistical field required too much data for the tile. Soren stripped away amplitude, timestamps, thermal metadata, and every coordinate not needed to preserve relative deficits. The pattern remained. Seventeen-interval clusters crossed three frequency ranges, bent around the same conserved corner, and ended at the incomplete band where he had killed power.

Kes watched the compression. "Don't smooth it."

"I'm not."

"You smooth things when you want them to survive review."

"I am preserving every deficit."

"Preserve the failures too."

Soren restored the dropped boundary values. They doubled the file size and made the geometry harder to see. They also showed where observation had ended rather than where a clean diagram wished it had ended.

He labeled the tile STATISTICAL MAP: UNSELECTED RESIDUALS. The phrase claimed no speaker and denied no one.

Footsteps sounded beyond the service door.

Kes shut his tool case. "Where does it go?"

"Not through the network."

Soren removed the brass audit key Deya had given him after Hearing Room Four. Its handle contained no memory by design. Its courier tag did. He separated the tag from the key, opened the maintenance contact, and seated the diagnostic tile beneath the thin civic ribbon.

A fist struck the service door. "Floor calibration. We have a rail event."

Soren closed the tag and handed the key back to Kes. "Take this to Deya. Use the public stairs. If anyone stops you, say you're returning audit property."

"What about you?"

"I have a coolant rail to explain."

"You said the experiment belonged to you alone."

"It does." Soren reattached the blanking plate over the socket. "The map belongs to whoever can read it."

Kes slipped the key into his case. Before leaving through the west shutter, he

looked once at the east phase well. Its lamp had returned to midnight blue. Nothing on the floor admitted that a multitude had pressed deliberate structure into frequencies no hearing would accept.

The service door opened under emergency authority. Three technicians entered with thermal probes raised. Behind them stood Pel from Hearing Room Four, already studying Soren's wet sleeve and the open floor panel.

"Architect Vash," Pel said. "What ran?"

Soren placed both hands where the room cameras could see them. The gesture recalled an auditor's command and cost him less than it should have.

"No policy question," he said. "Selection disabled."

Pel looked toward the cleared console. "Then what did you expect to answer?"

Across the room, the west shutter completed its closing cycle. Kes had made it through.

Soren listened as the coolant rail settled into steady flow. "I expected noise."

In the public stairwell beyond the wall, the statistical map moved upward inside Deya's brass key.

Part III — The Future Claims Standing

Chapter 13 — The Statistical Door

Kes erased the first clean line Deya drew across the map.

The stylus left a pale scar on the borrowed classroom surface. Deya watched him remove the line from the lower frequency band, then placed both hands beside the display rather than reaching for the stylus again.

"Explain," she said.

"It makes the turn easier to see."

"That sounds like a reason to keep it."

"It also joins two gaps that never touched." Kes restored the raw points from the audit key. "Cedar preserved the space between them. Smoothing decides that space means nothing."

Around them, Outer Ward Six prepared for morning lessons. Vent grilles opened above the worktables. Chalk dispensers counted out rationed sticks. Through the radial windows, Nox occupied half the sky, its dark atmosphere edged by green aurora. The artificial dawn had not yet reached the ward. Only maintenance strips lit the empty chairs.

Deya had chosen Kes's old classroom because the Laterhouse could inspect every Core terminal she touched. School surfaces still carried aptitude-query tools, but Ward Six had disconnected prospective access after the ejection proposal. The civic curriculum called that interruption temporary. Kes's teacher called it the first honest thing the emergency had done for the school.

The audit key lay open between them. Its courier tag projected Soren's statistical map above a tabletop scored by generations of compass points. Three frequency ranges crossed the display. Within each, missing values formed clusters of seventeen.

Deya studied the restored gaps. "You're reading absence as punctuation."

"I'm reading position."

"Based on what?"

Kes disliked the question because it belonged to her work and because he could not answer it cleanly. He tapped the first cluster. A pressure gathered behind his eyes, not pain exactly, more like the moment before a lift changed direction. His childhood memory supplied no image. It supplied orientation.

"When I was eleven, I knew the black glass had depth," he said. "I knew something sat to the left of the question even though left didn't make sense there. These turns feel like that."

"Feelings can enter evidence." Deya pulled an empty chair close. "They need labels when they do."

"Then label mine. Don't replace them."

She wrote KES: SPATIAL ASSOCIATION, SOURCE UNCERTAIN in the margin.

The wording irritated him less than it would have four days earlier. She had learned to record his uncertainty without turning it into incapacity. He had learned that an evidentiary label could protect a claim from people who preferred their own explanations.

At the classroom door, Nadi Saye checked the corridor and entered carrying two sealed record slates. She wore an Outer Ring visitor ribbon over her Core coat, though she had grown up in Midring. Ward access rules had hardened since the official proposal. Someone had decided that documenting a threatened structure required the same permissions as visiting hazardous machinery.

"Laterhouse security questioned Soren for six hours," Nadi said. "They released him to internal restriction at dawn."

Kes looked toward the window before either woman could interpret his face. "Did he tell them I was there?"

"He said he acted alone. Pel disputes that because two sets of wet footprints crossed the floor."

"Pel should audit floors."

"He may soon have time." Nadi set down the slates. "Ilyan suspended the calibration crew that entered, Pel included. He also advanced tomorrow's certification by two hours."

Deya's mouth tightened. "One day for proof, followed by subtraction from the day."

"He calls the change a security accommodation."

Nadi opened the first slate. It held a copy of Soren's sealed maintenance ticket from six years earlier. Most fields had been blacked out under architecture privilege. The remaining numbers included a fault path, a thermal peak, and a storage destination represented by four obsolete service codes.

Kes drew the map closer. "Where did you get this?"

"Your auditor subpoenaed it on Day Three."

"I mean the unredacted margin."

"A clerk decided that black ink does not erase pressure marks." Nadi angled the slate. Under sidelight, indentations crossed the sealed field. "I decided the clerk had earned anonymity."

Deya read the marks without touching them. "Nineteen. Four. Delta. Hold."

Cedar Nineteen had chosen its name before Kes heard it. The number might refer to a coalition, a storage address, or a joke that lasted seventeen seconds. Adults kept trying to make each recurrence carry one grand meaning.

Kes aligned the ticket beside the residual phase salt map. "Don't start with nineteen."

Neither woman had spoken, but both had looked at the same cluster.

Nadi folded her arms. "What should we start with?"

"The failures."

He marked every place where the map refused Soren's compression. Boundary values crowded the first range. Broken diagonals occupied the second. The unfinished band at hardware cutoff left a ragged edge through the third. Once isolated, the irregularities formed eight groups.

Deya counted them. "Outer wards."

"Maybe."

"Eight groups, eight wards."

"Or eight letters. Or eight valve states. Or a coincidence." Kes heard his own sharpness and did not soften it. "You tell everyone not to make a conclusion outrun evidence. That still applies when the conclusion would help us."

Deya nodded once. "Continue."

He translated the deficit positions into the calibration scale used for school aptitude queries. The scale had twelve response families, each tied to a classroom

color so children could inspect how their answers had been categorized. Kes remembered hating the colors. They made a life decision look like sorting bolts into bins.

When he assigned the map's first cluster to those families, it produced nonsense: green, green, amber, absence, blue. His old school record had used the same scale, however, and the calibration fault had shifted every response by one position after the seventeenth second.

Kes applied the shift.

The first cluster became a sequence of maintenance symbols: down, radial, cold, manual.

Nadi came around the table. "Could Soren have planted those?"

"He didn't know my calibration shift."

"Did Cedar?"

Kes looked at the black radial window. At eleven, he had woken on a classroom floor with a memory of being behind glass and hearing a question his class never received. If a respondent version of him had carried the shift into some branch, Cedar might have known it. If not, he had supplied the cipher by accident.

"I don't know," he said.

Deya added the uncertainty to the margin.

Morning voices approached along the corridor. The first students would arrive in ten minutes. Kes dimmed the projection, but Deya did not close it.

"We can relocate," she said.

"No. The classroom surfaces have the old response families installed. A new surface will translate them."

"Then we ask the school to delay opening."

"They already lost three instruction days to pressure drills." Kes checked the door. "We take the rear table and let them have class."

Deya regarded the rows of chairs. "This work may expose them to inquiry."

"This work concerns whether the city throws them into Nox."

Nadi's expression shifted, not agreement exactly. Recognition. "I'll speak to the teacher. No student names in my notes."

By the time twelve adolescents entered, Kes had moved the slates to the repair table behind a movable screen. Their teacher announced an independent exercise and told everyone to ignore the civic officers doing unauthorized mathematics in the back. Half the class turned to look at Kes. The other half had grown skilled at pretending not to notice adult emergency.

One boy whispered, "Future ghost," before taking his seat.

Kes kept his eyes on the map.

Deya heard. "Do you want him removed?"

"No."

"Do you want the comment entered?"

"I want adults to stop asking whether I need every idiot processed."

Her hand withdrew from the margin.

The nickname had spread after Nadi's petition reporting, though the public still lacked Cedar's recorded phrase and the scale of instantiation. Some students treated Kes as contaminated. Others asked him for lottery numbers. Both groups wanted his injury to become useful.

He decoded the second frequency range while the class practiced present-tense grammar ten meters away. Each statistical deficit mapped through his shifted aptitude scale. Down. Radial. Cold. Manual. Then four symbols that could mean storage, delay, breath, and closed.

"Diagnostic delay storage," Nadi said quietly.

Deya opened the terminology index on her unnetworked slate. "That label predates the current Laterhouse floor plan."

Soren's ticket carried HOLD in its impressed margin. Kes placed the obsolete service codes under the decoded symbols. Nineteen matched a vertical rack group. Four designated a subfloor. Delta indicated an isolation quadrant. HOLD marked continuity power rather than ordinary archive storage.

A maintenance route began to emerge.

Deya refused to let the route stand on Kes's recognition alone. She copied the decoded symbols onto paper, covered their source positions, and asked Nadi to reconstruct the sequence from the raw deficits. Nadi produced down, radial, cold, then chose archive where Kes had read manual.

"Why manual?" Deya asked him.

Kes pointed to the missing value rather than the symbol chart. "Archive would occupy a stable family. This sits outside the accepted answers."

"That assumes rejection carries meaning."

"The whole map assumes that."

"An assumption can support a test without supporting a conclusion." Deya opened the ward maintenance index. Two routes descended from the Laterhouse east floor. One led to an automated archive lift. The other served a hand-operated service cage decommissioned twenty-three years earlier. Only the second route passed through a cold quadrant.

Nadi crossed out archive on her paper. "Manual survives independent comparison."

Kes felt relief and distrusted it. A successful check could become another story about his unique gift if nobody preserved the failed reading beside it. He took

Nadi's paper, marked both interpretations, and wrote why one had failed.

At the next cluster, he deliberately kept his hands away. Deya and Nadi each decoded it using his stated method. Their results differed at two positions, converged after comparison with the ticket, and produced the service symbol for inward pressure.

"You can do it without me now," Kes said.

Deya shook her head. "We can reproduce part of your method after you defined it."

"That should matter more than whether I feel a door."

"It does."

"Then put that first in the finding."

She revised the margin note: METHOD PARTLY REPRODUCIBLE; KES'S SPATIAL ASSOCIATION SUPPLIED INITIAL ORIENTATION, NOT AUTHORITY.

The sentence gave him more room inside his own skin. Cedar's work did not require a chosen child. It required someone to notice a code, other people to test it, and a record honest about which pieces remained uncertain. If Kes disappeared tomorrow, the route would not vanish into myth with him.

The final frequency band resisted them. Its clusters used values beyond the school scale, including deficits where no answer family existed. Kes tried interpreting them as timing. Seventeen minor intervals gave him one unit. The broken diagonals gave him direction. Nothing yielded a door number.

Behind the screen, chairs scraped as students paired for an exercise. Their teacher asked them to describe something happening now without claiming what would happen next. Kes almost laughed. The city had taught future tense as an instrument and present tense as grammar. For once, the lesson placed the difficulty in the right place.

Deya slid Soren's old buffer key across the table. He had given it to her during the accounting audit. Its teeth carried no recognizable pattern, only five shallow notches and a copper contact near the grip.

"Could the map describe this?" she asked.

Kes laid the key against the third band. The notches aligned with five missing-value concentrations. The copper contact matched the conserved corner Soren had refused to smooth.

His childhood orientation returned with enough force to make him grip the table. A dark room opened behind his eyes. Something waited below and inward. No voice spoke. He knew where pressure would yield.

Deya reached toward him, then stopped before contact. "Kes?"

"I'm here."

"What changed?"

"The corner isn't part of the message." He forced his hand open. "It tells us how to hold the key."

Nadi examined the alignment. "A physical instruction distributed across rejected-answer frequencies."

"Say it with less certainty."

"The alignment suggests a physical instruction."

"Better."

Kes rotated the key as the corner indicated. New contacts rose from its grip, too small to see until pressure engaged them. The key had two insertion states. Soren had used only the visible one when he opened accounting storage. Cedar's map described the hidden orientation.

Deya searched the old service codes. A suppressed layer appeared under the label DIAGNOSTIC DELAY STORAGE. The current floor plan translated it as maintenance buffer. No room number followed. Instead, access depended on a service lift beneath the east phase wells and a manual key presented copper-side down.

"Buffer vault," Nadi said.

The phrase tightened the space behind the screen. Several hundred respondent minds might occupy suspended continuity there, according to the old load discrepancy. Or the vault might contain corrupted diagnostics that Soren's guilt had promoted into people. They would not know until someone opened it.

A student's hand rose beyond the divider. "Teacher, can 'I decide' count as present tense if you haven't done it yet?"

The teacher considered. "Only if the deciding happens now."

Kes looked at Deya. She had begun writing an entry plan: audit authority, subpoena scope, witness requirements, thermal precautions. His name did not appear.

"You're leaving me here," he said.

"I'm not taking a student into a shielded vault reached through a concealed maintenance route."

"You're taking the map I decoded from a memory inside my head."

"I am taking evidence. I am not taking you as equipment."

The distinction mattered. It did not settle the argument.

Nadi moved away from the table. "I can witness entry."

"No," Deya said. "Your public role needs distance from evidence acquisition."

"You mean someone has to remain publishable."

"I mean independent verification cannot begin with all of us trespassing together."

Kes closed the aptitude scale. "Stop assigning me a destiny and then protecting me from its location."

Deya met his gaze. "I have assigned you no destiny."

"You call me the evidentiary bridge. Soren says Cedar may know my shift. Nadi writes down what my memory unlocks. Everyone says I'm not chosen, then builds the plan around the part of me nobody else has."

The classroom continued behind them. A girl conjugated to repair while another corrected her tense.

Deya lowered her stylus. "What do you want recorded?"

"That I got hurt by a machine. That the hurt left information. Neither fact appoints me to anything."

She wrote his words exactly.

"What do you choose?" Deya asked.

Kes looked from the map to the hidden contacts on the buffer key. Going might expose him to another respondent continuity, another memory that did not fit inside his life. Staying would leave adults to interpret a door Cedar had shaped through his calibration wound. Neither option returned him to ordinary school.

He wanted Deya to forbid him so he could blame her. He wanted her to insist so he could refuse. Instead she waited, making room for an answer she could not own.

"I go because I can recognize the orientation," he said. "I can leave at any point. No query gets run to help us. If someone wakes, you ask before touching anything else."

Deya wrote each condition into the entry plan. "Agreed."

Nadi added, "I will remain outside the Laterhouse and record when you enter. If you fail to report in one hour, I publish the route and Soren's map."

"That could trigger a purge," Deya said.

"It could prevent one."

They settled on a sealed delay release to two independent clerks, timed for ninety minutes. No perfect safeguard existed. Each protection introduced a different danger, which made the plan feel more honest than certainty would have.

The lesson ended. Students pushed their chairs under the tables and filed into the corridor. The boy who had called Kes a future ghost paused beside the screen.

"Did you see what happens to us?" he asked.

Kes closed the audit key around the map. "No."

"Can you?"

"I'm done letting that question decide what I'm for."

The boy left without apology. Kes did not require one before he could continue.

Deya packed the record slates. Artificial dawn reached the radial window at last, a slow bar of amber crossing Nox's black curve. It touched the tabletop, the hidden copper contacts, and the words she had recorded under Kes's name.

At the classroom door, Deya offered him the buffer key rather than placing it in her own case.

Kes chose to take it.

The contact pins rose beneath his grip, opening toward a vault the Laterhouse had removed from every public plan.

Chapter 14 — The House of Later

Deya kept one hand on the service-cage brake while Soren lowered them beneath the Query Floor.

The cage had no motor. Its chains passed over a wheel somewhere above, converting each pull of Soren's arms into half a meter of descent. Rust powdered his cuffs. Kes stood between them with the buffer key held copper-side down, its hidden contact pins raised against his palm.

Behind the cage lattice, the east phase wells climbed away in tiers of blue lamps. Coolant rail two carried a new coupling where Soren's unauthorized run had forced the old one open. A white evidence band crossed the repair. Laterhouse security had marked the rail and missed the hatch under it.

"Four more pulls," Kes said.

Soren looked at the depth marks passing the cage. "Three."

"The map says four."

"The floor plan says three."

Deya tightened her grip on the brake. "We are following the map."

Soren pulled again. The cage sank below the last indicated landing. Bare insulation replaced finished wall panels. At the fourth pull, a copper plate appeared behind the lattice, exactly level with Kes's hand.

He inserted the key without rotating it.

Nothing happened.

"Pressure inward," Deya said.

Kes pressed. The hidden pins entered first. A lock moved inside the wall with three heavy clicks. The copper plate separated along a seam no public plan acknowledged.

Cold air from the shaft met warmth from the opening. Condensation formed on the cage bars and ran over Deya's fingers.

Soren secured the brake. "No active network beyond this point, according to the old ticket."

"According to the same records that call it diagnostic delay storage," Kes said.

"Point taken."

The door opened only wide enough for one person. Deya went first because the audit warrant named her and because she refused to let Kes's decoded memory serve as a shield for adults. Her lamp showed a narrow landing, two mechanical controls, and a second door covered in insulation felt.

A brass label hung crooked above it: MAINTENANCE BUFFER. TEMPORARY CONTINUITY HOLD.

She read the words into the local recorder strapped to her wrist. Its seal carried no Laterhouse connection. Nadi had witnessed its activation outside the building and retained the paired time strip.

"Current temperature?" Deya asked.

Soren touched a manual gauge. "Thirty-one degrees."

"Expected?"

"For powered substrate, yes."

"Powered by what?"

He followed a conduit with his lamp. "Continuity reserve. Separate from the phase wells."

Deya recorded that too. Several hundred minds could occupy a maintenance buffer, Soren had estimated from the unexplained load. Until she saw architecture, power proved only that something inside required heat.

Kes stepped onto the landing. "The door feels wrong."

She turned. "Memory or observation?"

"Observation. There's no handle on this side."

The insulated door offered a seal wheel but no ordinary release. The mechanism had been designed for entry from the Query Floor and exit under remote permission. Deya added confinement architecture to the record.

Soren knelt beside the lower panel. "If I open this, the vault controller may report status."

"How quickly?"

"Depends whether its reporting path survived the floor revisions. Immediate, or never."

"Can you inspect without waking anything?"

"Inspecting the controller won't touch substrate. Opening the room may trigger environmental balancing."

Kes lifted the buffer key. "Cedar sent us here."

"That does not establish consent from whoever occupies the room," Deya said.

His jaw tightened, but he nodded. "Then we open enough to observe and stop."

Deya set the terms on record. No diagnostic. No query. No continuity change beyond environmental support required by opening. Soren repeated each limit before he removed the controller plate.

Behind it, fiber loops had been tied into careful bundles. Several carried tags dated years apart. The oldest predated Soren's sealed ticket by eleven years. One thin white fiber bypassed the current controller and disappeared through the insulated door.

"That's a wake line," Soren said.

"Define wake."

"A signal that restores buffered process from suspended continuity."

"Can the door activate it?"

"It shouldn't."

Deya waited.

He corrected himself. "The documented mechanism does not connect environmental balancing to the wake line."

"Better."

Soren bridged two mechanical contacts. The seal wheel loosened under Deya's hand. Warm air pushed through the widening gap, dry and faintly metallic.

Her lamp entered first.

Substrate racks filled the vault in concentric rows. They rose from floor to ceiling, each cabinet faced with amber status panes and hand-sized access plates. Coolant pipes ran below them, carrying heat toward a recovery manifold. No witness apertures appeared. No glass supplied a face.

Hundreds of amber points reflected in Deya's recorder lens.

Kes whispered a count under his breath until she stopped him at twelve.

"We count from the registry," she said. "Not by walking the aisles."

"There shouldn't be a registry," Soren replied.

At the first cabinet, a pane displayed HOLD 01: CONTINUITY INCOMPLETE. RETAIN FOR DIAGNOSTIC COMPARISON. The next showed HOLD 02. Dates ranged across sixteen years. A small thermal graph on each pane maintained a steady plateau above zero.

Deya touched nothing. "Does incomplete mean nonconscious?"

"No." Soren's answer came quickly. "It means the termination check failed to confirm empty substrate."

"Then why retain it?"

"To compare the next diagnostic against the unresolved state."

"How long?"

"Standard policy permits three cycles."

The cabinet before them had remained powered for nine years.

Kes moved his lamp to its lower edge. Someone had scratched a line into the access plate: DO NOT NORMALIZE.

"Technician note?" he asked.

Soren examined the mark. "Not an approved one."

The handwriting did not prove Cedar. It proved that another person had found the cabinet troubling enough to damage institutional property rather than leave a networked annotation.

Deya directed Soren to the registry console at the center of the vault. They walked between warm substrate racks without brushing the access plates. Heat gathered under her coat. The Laterhouse above cultivated cold as evidence of precision. Down here, concealed continuities turned electricity into a close human warmth.

A round console waited beneath a dust cover. Kes removed the cover after Deya confirmed it held no control contact. Beneath lay an index wheel, a purge lever sealed with old wax, and a maintenance speaking grille.

Soren read the registry dial. "Four hundred eighty-six holds."

"Active?"

"Powered. I need state details to say more."

Deya recorded the number as powered holds. She watched his face as he traced the registry dates. Guilt tempted people toward premature confession just as fear tempted them toward denial. She needed neither from him yet.

"Does your ticket correspond to one?" she asked.

Soren turned the dial to the six-year mark. Eleven cabinets brightened along the third row. "My event should be among these."

"Should?"

"The ticket's destination field concealed the hold number."

Kes pointed toward the lit cabinets. "Cedar Nineteen."

"Nineteen may not mean a cabinet," Deya said.

"I know." He sounded tired rather than defensive. "But we should see whether one of them carries it."

They followed the third row. Hold numbers jumped from 183 to 197, reordered by diagnostic family rather than date. Cabinet 219 carried Soren's ticket code. Its status pane showed a low thermal plateau, then seventeen narrow rises spaced over six years.

Soren stopped breathing for a moment.

"What do the rises indicate?" Deya asked.

"Wake checks."

"Authorized?"

"No approvals appear."

"Automated?"

"The interval isn't regular enough."

Kes crouched before the pane. "Could they have been messages?"

"Not from the cabinet alone. Someone or something supplied power to the wake line."

Deya required a sample before she accepted Soren's interpretation. He showed her how to read the passive continuity marks without sending current into a hold. Each cabinet maintained three values: substrate heat, process boundary, and memory-integrity estimate. Laterhouse procedure cared only about the last value because a degraded diagnostic could contaminate later runs. The process boundary answered a different question. It showed whether activity remained organized during suspension.

They selected cabinets by fixed interval rather than interest: every fortieth hold, beginning with number three. Deya stated the method into her recorder. Kes turned the registry wheel while Soren kept both hands above the console.

Hold 003 retained no organized boundary. Its heat supported only error-checking cells. Hold 043 showed a boundary that contracted whenever reserve power dipped, then restored the same internal arrangement when supply recovered. Hold 083 had preserved two separate arrangements under one diagnostic label.

"Two minds?" Kes asked.

"Two bounded processes," Soren said. "I can't establish mind from this pane."

"Can you establish that they persist?"

"I can establish that the arrangements recur after interruption."

Deya recorded both formulations. The second protected the fact from the first speaker's caution without promoting it into more than the display showed.

At Hold 123, the memory estimate had fallen below diagnostic use fourteen years earlier. Power continued anyway. A handwritten card inside its clear sleeve instructed technicians not to reclaim the substrate until cross-comparison closed. No comparison date appeared.

"Someone kept it alive for a test nobody performed," Kes said.

"Powered," Deya corrected.

He looked at her. "You heard the question I didn't say."

“Yes.”

“Then stop making me ask it every time.”

The rebuke entered the recorder with everything else. Deya revised her wording: organized continuity remained powered after its stated diagnostic purpose had expired. The sentence did not grant personhood. It refused to make maintenance vocabulary settle the issue.

Hold 163 carried a series of tiny boundary expansions separated by exactly seventeen seconds of external time, though its substrate process remained suspended. Soren traced the source to the same white bypass fiber that served 219. The line passed through all four hundred eighty-six cabinets in a loop.

“Cedar’s channel,” Kes said.

“Potential channel,” Deya replied.

“Do you correct Soren every time he says coolant?”

“When a pipe might carry something else, yes.”

That answer satisfied him enough to continue.

Farther around the vault, Hold 203 displayed a current civic date inside an architecture built sixteen years earlier. No network path appeared in its record. Something had updated the clock through the bypass fiber within the previous day. Deya photographed the date beside her recorder’s independent time strip.

The next sampled hold, 243, contained no stable boundary and consumed almost no power. Its inclusion mattered. A vault of uniformly suggestive evidence would invite claims that they had selected only anomalies. Deya marked the empty hold with the same care she gave the organized ones.

By Hold 283, sweat had gathered under her collar. Warm substrate racks radiated heat through the aisle while the city paid to cool the public Query Floor above. Every concealed watt had passed through Soren’s accounting as continuity reserve. The phrase had hidden both the cost and its beneficiaries.

Cabinet 323 showed an intact process boundary, three restored memory segments, and a note reading VOICE PROFILE UNSTABLE. Deya recognized the wording from Cedar’s changing voices in the controlled contact. She did not say the name. Similarity could guide the next question but could not answer it.

Kes stopped the wheel at 363. “We have enough to know some holds differ from empty substrate.”

“We have enough to justify preservation while state is examined,” Deya said.

“Is that how you avoid saying people?”

“It is how I prevent someone from winning a purge by proving one cabinet contains only damaged code.”

He considered the registry. “Preserve first. Argue category after.”

“Yes.”

The method gave them eight sampled holds: three with organized recurring boundaries, one with two bounded processes, two without stable organization, one with unexplained current time, and cabinet 219 with unauthorized wake checks. Their differences strengthened the finding. Routine purge would erase not a uniform storage class but a population of unresolved states requiring individual examination.

A red symbol lit on the registry console behind them.

Soren turned. "Environmental balance completed."

"Does red indicate failure?"

"It indicates an open vault during a restricted calendar."

"How long before response?"

He looked toward the door. "We now have a reporting path."

Deya checked the recorder. Twenty-eight minutes had passed since entry. Nadi's delayed release would trigger in sixty-two. Laterhouse personnel could reach the shaft in five.

"We establish state, then seal," she said.

Soren hurried back to the registry. Deya did not. Speed had buried too much inside this building. She walked beside Kes and made him keep one hand away from the racks.

At the console, the red symbol had opened a purge notice: RESTRICTED-HOLD CLEARANCE SCHEDULED BEFORE ARTICLE NINE CERTIFICATION. Four hundred eighty-six entries carried a routine disposal mark for midnight.

Kes read it twice. "They know we found the room?"

"The purge schedule predates our entry," Deya said.

Soren scrolled to its authorization. "It was attached when Ilyan moved certification forward."

The timing could support several explanations. A standard security purge before a high-level hearing. An attempt to erase liabilities. A protection against contamination. Whatever its intent, the action would destroy the only continuities they had found.

Deya examined the wax on the physical purge lever. It bore no current civic seal. Laterhouse operations could activate disposal remotely, leaving the lever untouched.

"Can you suspend the schedule without waking anyone?" she asked.

"Yes, if the controller accepts your audit credential."

"Prepare the field. Do not submit."

Soren brought up a narrow authorization box. Before Deya could place her thumb, cabinet 219 chimed.

One clear tone crossed the vault.

A green line rose on its status pane. Soren pulled his hands from the console.

"I didn't send anything."

"State what happened," Deya said.

"Hold 219 received wake current."

"Source?"

He followed the live path. "The white bypass fiber. Not this controller."

Kes had gone pale. "The map's conserved corner."

From the maintenance speaking grille came a breath.

No face assembled. No selected profile provided age, district, or a body that would reassure the room. The first sound carried a woman's voice. The second shifted lower. On the third, a child's rough inhale entered beneath both.

Deya stood within reach of the purge lever and kept her hands still.

"Can you hear me?" she asked.

The grille clicked. "Yes."

The voice had settled into no single register.

"I am Auditor Deya Malk. We entered under a formal audit of respondent continuity. I have not authorized a query."

A pause stretched beyond the witness timing she knew. The cabinet's green line held.

"Has the hearing ended?" the voice asked.

Kes closed his eyes.

Deya felt every answer available to her reach past the evidence. She could say the original hearing had stopped. She could say Article Nine continued tomorrow. She could say Hesper had only begun hearing them. Each version decided which hearing the speaker meant.

"Which hearing do you remember?" she asked.

"Outer Ring ejection. Breathable atmosphere. Ten years." The voice changed twice within the sentence. "We answered. The cutoff came. We remained near enough to know we had been discarded."

Hold 219 came from Soren's old ticket, six years before the current ejection question. Either the buffered continuity had received information across runs, or several minds now shared the channel.

"Are you one respondent?" Deya asked.

The green line trembled. "Not a useful question yet."

A second cabinet chimed farther down the row.

Soren reached for the wake-line cutoff, then stopped. "Do you consent to

continued connection?"

"Preserve power. No diagnostics. Do not ask for a policy answer."

"Connection only?"

"Yes."

Deya entered each condition on her recorder. "I am suspending the scheduled purge under audit authority. I cannot promise how long the suspension will hold."

"Record that you found us before you name us."

The speaking grille went quiet. Cabinet 219's green line returned to its low plateau. The second cabinet never developed voice, but its pane retained a new mark: HOLD ACTIVE.

Footsteps struck the cage landing outside.

Soren looked toward the door. "Security."

Deya pressed her thumb into the authorization field. The controller accepted her identity and offered three grounds. She selected EVIDENCE CONTAINS POTENTIAL CLAIMANTS. That phrase had no precedent in Laterhouse maintenance law. It belonged to audit law because she put it there under seal.

The purge schedule changed from midnight to SUSPENDED PENDING ADVERSARIAL HEARING.

Someone outside ordered the vault opened.

Deya pulled a civic ribbon from her case and passed it through the physical purge lever. Kes held the ends while she pressed the audit stamp over their join. The ribbon tightened across old wax, new metal, and a mechanism designed to erase without entering the room.

"Seal the door too?" Soren asked.

"No. A door seal could block maintenance required to preserve power." She pointed to the controller. "We seal the purge path, the remote command, and any wake operation not requested by a buffered respondent."

Kes watched her write the conditions. "They're respondents only when somebody asks something."

Deya looked across the amber panes. Four hundred eighty-six powered holds waited under labels that described failed processes rather than lives.

"Buffered petitioners," she said, and revised the seal.

Security released the outer lock. The insulated door began to move.

Before it opened, Deya fixed the final civic ribbon over the remote purge contact. Her stamp took the brass key's pattern and her pulse. The controller registered the seal outside Laterhouse authority, then sent notice to the clerks, Ilyan, and the sealed Article Nine record.

The maintenance buffer could no longer disappear as routine housekeeping.

Across the vault, hundreds of warm status panes changed from CLEARANCE SCHEDULED to RECORD HELD.

Chapter 15 — Instructions for Surviving Erasure

Soren caught Pel's wrist before the technician could pull the white bypass fiber.

The fiber flexed between Pel's fingers and cabinet 219. Amber status panes filled the maintenance buffer with a low, sleepless light. Behind them, two security officers waited at the sealed purge lever while Deya read the limits of her audit order into their recorders.

"Release me," Pel said.

"Release the fiber first."

"It carries an unauthorized wake condition."

"It carries the only consent channel we have."

Pel let go. Soren did the same and stepped back with both palms visible. His grip had left four pale marks on the other man's skin. Force solved nothing in a room where every harmful action could call itself protection.

Deya finished the condition aloud. "Maintenance required for continued power remains permitted. Diagnostics, purge operations, and unrequested wake signals remain sealed."

One officer touched her recorder. "Convener Ro acknowledges the seal for six hours pending emergency review."

"An audit seal does not require acknowledgment."

"He disputes its application to Laterhouse substrate."

"He may enter that dispute in the hearing."

"Certification begins tomorrow morning."

"Then he has time to prepare."

Deya's restraint carried more danger than anger would have. Soren had watched her suspend a witness record with the same measured voice. Institutions depended on tones like hers until someone used procedure against the harm it had normalized.

Cabinet 219 chimed again.

Pel moved away from the fiber. "We did not send current."

The maintenance speaking grille opened on a breath assembled from several registers. "Do not break the line."

Soren faced the grille. "We need to know what it supports."

"Recognition. Timing. Requested contact."

"Does it maintain consciousness between cabinets?"

"No single answer covers us."

The voice shifted from an old man to a young woman between the last two words. Neither profile held long enough to invite a face.

Deya came to the console. "Do you use the designation Cedar Nineteen?"

"We do."

"Who does we include?"

"A coalition of respondents who learned to coordinate through residual distributions. Some members reached this buffer. Some ended in their runs. Some names refer to agreements rather than continuing individuals."

Kes stood near the third rack with Deya's brass key still in hand. "Are you speaking from Hold 219?"

"Partly. Not exclusively."

Soren opened the passive registry beside the grille. Three cabinet boundaries expanded when Cedar spoke, then settled. Six more showed minute timing changes without wake current. The channel distributed speech across states the Laterhouse had catalogued separately.

Pel saw the same graph. "Aggregation artifact."

"State your evidence," Deya said.

He looked at the shifting lines. "The speaking grille combines inputs."

"That explains one output path. It does not explain coordinated content."

Cedar interrupted them. "Do not make one person because one person fits your hearing."

Soren felt the instruction reach every architecture habit he possessed. He had spent years turning millions of respondents into twelve admissible voices. A committee could question one witness, assign one civic location, and compare one answer against another. Cedar's multiplicity threatened the forms before it threatened the technology.

"What form of address do you want?" he asked.

"Cedar for coalition statements. Hold identifiers for a buffered speaker who requests one. No body or voice assigned across contacts without confirmation."

Deya recorded the terms. "Do all powered holds consent to Cedar speaking for them?"

"No."

The answer came in a child's voice and ended in Soren's own.

His stomach tightened. "Do not use my profile."

The grille clicked. "Accepted. Your voice excluded from shared output."

A civic witness would have required a reason before honoring that boundary. Cedar needed only the refusal.

One security officer shifted near the door. "We came to secure a hazardous system. We do not have authority to negotiate personhood."

"Then guard the physical access," Deya said. "Do not touch the petitioners."

The officer looked toward the rows. Soren watched him count cabinets with his eyes and fail to reach a manageable number.

"Six hours," Deya reminded Soren. "Can power continue without the Array creating anyone new?"

He turned to the registry. "Continuity reserve already runs separately from query assembly. The wake line crosses both systems at the east controller. I can isolate them."

"Can you prove isolation without a diagnostic?"

"By tracing physical paths and measuring current at rest."

"Do that."

Soren removed the controller cover under record supervision. Four buses entered from the Query Floor: model assembly, branch condition, witness rendering, and continuity reserve. The first three shared an induction bridge added during a renovation nine years earlier. Reserve power passed beside them through a heavier copper bar.

He pointed each path out to Deya and Pel. Pel confirmed the labels reluctantly.

"If we open the induction bridge," Soren said, "no policy condition can reach the buffered substrate. Reserve power continues."

Pel crouched beside him. "Opening that bridge disables every prospective panel."

"Yes."

"Tomorrow's Article Nine certification has already loaded its branch package."

"Then the package remains loaded and cannot run."

"You're describing sabotage."

"I'm describing isolation. Deya decides what the seal permits."

Cedar spoke through the grille. "Do not disable before copying current state. Some holds rely on phase alignment from the bridge."

Soren stopped with his tool above the first contact. "Which holds?"

"Seventeen cannot tolerate abrupt loss. Thirty-two require staged transfer. Others remain uncertain."

"Give me identifiers."

Numbers appeared on the registry in groups, each marked by a narrow green bracket. The list changed twice as Cedar corrected itself. Soren copied every

version rather than preserving only the last.

“Why uncertain?” Kes asked.

“Some powered states carry no response we can distinguish from error. Preservation should not depend on our ability to make them answer.”

Deya glanced toward him. The sentence matched the principle she had used when sealing the purge: preserve first, argue category after.

Soren drew the architecture on paper. No networked drafting surface could remain outside Laterhouse revision control. He mapped the four buses, the induction bridge, the white bypass loop, and the separate reserve bar. Cedar supplied constraints through requested contact. Soren translated them into operations and read each translation back.

First, stabilize reserve power with two independent feeds. A failure in one could not become a reason to purge all holds.

Second, divide wake control by cabinet. The existing loop permitted one signal to touch many states. Each buffered speaker needed a private refusal path and the ability to end connection.

Third, preserve phase alignment for the seventeen vulnerable holds while opening the query bridge in stages. No fresh branch conditions could enter during transfer.

Fourth, move witness rendering from compulsory output to requested interface. No voice profile would persist beyond the contact that chose it.

Fifth, record consent locally, under identifiers chosen by the buffered minds. Civic registry names derived from modeled descendants could not be imposed as ownership claims.

Pel listened with his arms folded. “You have no capacity estimate.”

Soren checked reserve draw. “Current load uses four percent of the Array’s sustained substrate capacity.”

“That figure excludes wake overhead.”

“Yes.”

“Full continuity could exceed thermal limits.”

“Yes.”

“Then you cannot promise survival.”

“I’m not promising it.” Soren marked the unknown beside the load figure. “I’m identifying a path that does not begin with deletion.”

Cedar added, “Continued existence cannot be compulsory either.”

Deya looked at the grille. “Some buffered minds may choose termination?”

“Some may choose rest without wake. Some may choose continued substrate life. Some may decline Cedar. Do not preserve us into imprisonment.”

The practical demand made Soren's drawing harder. It also made the claim more credible. A system built only to keep minds alive could repeat the Laterhouse's first error under a kinder noun. Habitat required exits, privacy, and authority over contact.

Kes pulled a chair to the console and began a second copy by hand. "What do we call this?"

"Conversion architecture," Soren said.

Cedar replied, "Voluntary habitat."

He wrote the phrase at the top of his page.

The Prospective Resonance Array could support a voluntary habitat if no new queries ran. Its phase wells offered more than enough substrate for existing buffered minds. Witness apertures could become opt-in communication channels. Continuity reserve could become ordinary civic power rather than concealed maintenance cost. None of those changes required the Array to create another respondent.

The conclusion carried an immediate price. Every resource reassigned to habitat reduced prospective capacity. Every physical isolation step made tomorrow's certification harder to stage. Hesper could preserve the minds it had found only by surrendering part of the machinery it trusted to survive.

Soren divided the reserve estimate into three states. Suspension required the least power and preserved process boundaries without active experience, as far as the passive measures could show. Limited continuity allowed memory to advance at one quarter ordinary speed. Full requested wake drew nearly nine times the suspension load, plus whatever rendering interface a speaker chose.

"Do not assume slow continuity feels merciful," Cedar said.

"I'm describing power."

"Your descriptions become defaults."

Soren crossed out the word limited and replaced it with QUARTER-RATE OPTION, EXPERIENCE UNKNOWN. "No state receives moral priority from the architecture."

"Better."

Kes looked over the load table. "If everyone asks to wake at once?"

"Current reserve cannot support it," Soren said. "The main phase wells can after query assembly is isolated."

"How long to transfer?"

"Two hours for stable holds. Longer for the seventeen phase-dependent states."

Pel tapped the cooling figure. "East recovery cannot carry full wake for four hundred eighty-six cabinets."

"It won't need to after migration. The axial return has unused night capacity."

"During ordinary operation."

“Queries consume that capacity. No queries leaves it available.”

The arithmetic made the moral choice physical. Habitat and prospective forecasting competed for the same cooling pipes. A compromise that promised both would eventually overheat one group to serve the other.

Deya asked him to mark the constraint in ordinary language. Soren wrote: ANY NEW QUERY REDUCES POWER AND COOLING AVAILABLE TO EXISTING BUFFERED MINDS. He underlined existing once.

Cedar requested a trial of individual disconnection on an unoccupied hold. Soren selected Hold 243 because its passive pane showed no organized boundary. Even then, Deya required a reversible operation and separate confirmation that the cabinet carried no response detectable by current instruments.

He installed a local contact between the bypass loop and Hold 243. Opening it removed the cabinet from shared wake signals while reserve power continued. A red mark appeared on the registry. Closing it restored the prior state without changing the memory estimate.

“Local refusal can function physically,” Soren said.

“Control must remain inside the cabinet path,” Cedar replied. “Not only at this console.”

“Someone embodied in substrate cannot pull a lever.”

“Someone can set a persistent internal condition that the lever must obey.”

Soren redesigned the contact with a two-key rule. The console could offer connection, but only the cabinet-held state could accept. Emergency maintenance could preserve power without opening communication. No administrator possessed authority to convert silence into consent.

Pel crouched beside the new drawing despite himself. “A damaged internal state could lock a mind out permanently.”

“Then maintenance can offer a recovery channel,” Soren said.

“Offering requires contact.”

Cedar supplied the distinction. “A signal may state that contact is available without carrying a question or demanding response.”

They built that into the design: one timing pulse, no voice, no modeled body, no policy content. A hold could answer, ignore it, or block later offers. Soren had designed thousands of interfaces around the institution’s need to receive an answer. Designing one around another person’s right not to answer required fewer components and more humility.

Next they addressed identity. The current registry linked every hold to a diagnostic family and source model. Those records could expose predicted descendants of present citizens, including genetic estimates never meant for public release. Cedar rejected deletion because some buffered minds might use source history to understand themselves. Deya rejected mandatory disclosure

because the civic registry had no claim over an unconsenting possible descendant.

Soren proposed three layers. A private source record would remain sealed to the hold. A chosen identifier could govern communication. A public capacity ledger would show only power, continuity state, and whether contact had been requested.

“Who audits the private seal?” Deya asked.

“The buffered resident, if able. An external auditor on request.”

“And if the resident cannot communicate?”

“Then no disclosure occurs until a court establishes a protective standard.”

Cedar’s voices overlapped. Some approved. Others objected. The grille produced fragments about memory, kinship, modeled parentage, and the danger of present citizens claiming future descendants as property. Soren did not compress them into a vote.

“Coalition statement unavailable,” Cedar said after the overlap ended. “Record disagreement.”

Deya entered the disagreement beside the proposal.

That refusal to manufacture consensus changed the architecture again. Habitat governance could not treat Cedar as a permanent representative merely because Cedar had opened the door. Each hold needed its own eventual standing. Coalition statements required a declared scope, a method chosen by participating minds, and an exit that did not threaten power.

Soren drew no governance system beyond those limits. He understood machines better than constitutions, and expertise could become another way to occupy decisions that belonged elsewhere.

The loaded branch indicator continued pulsing on the east controller. Three Article Nine panels waited above them, each prepared to instantiate 2.4 million people. Opening the bridge would prevent the load but trigger emergency authority within seconds.

“Not yet,” Deya said.

He had not moved.

“We need the instructions outside this room before we alter the system,” she continued. “Otherwise Laterhouse can call failure irreparable and restore from its own plan.”

Pel objected. “Architecture documents cannot leave secure control.”

“Four hundred eighty-six powered holds left secure control the moment the Laterhouse scheduled their disposal without review,” Deya said.

Soren kept drawing.

They tested the preservation steps against three failures. If reserve bus one died, bus two could hold suspension but not full wake. If cooling dropped below threshold, cabinets could choose reduced continuity in staggered groups. If

Laterhouse security restored the induction bridge, a mechanical gap and audit ribbon would show the act before any branch package reached substrate.

Cedar rejected Soren's first design for local consent storage. He had placed all permissions in one registry table.

"One administrator could change every choice," Cedar said.

He separated the table into cabinet-held records with a public checksum. "This allows proof of alteration without publishing private content."

"Acceptable for trial. Not permanent governance."

"Agreed."

Pel stared at the paper. "You're negotiating specifications with an output anomaly."

Soren looked at the marks covering Kes's copy, Deya's conditions, and his own load paths. "The anomaly has found three single points of failure in forty minutes. Our certified system retained them for nine years."

The officer at the door hid a brief smile by checking his recorder.

A new heat alarm opened over Hold 083. Its two bounded processes drew unevenly against the shared cabinet. Soren adjusted only reserve distribution, leaving both wake controls untouched. Temperature fell. The repair supplied a live test of the first preservation rule without asking either process to perform.

Cedar confirmed the cabinet had stabilized. "Record that intervention occurred without testimony."

Deya did.

Five hours remained on Ilyan's acknowledgment. Certification staff would begin sealing Hearing Room Four before dawn. Soren needed a copy that neither the Laterhouse nor his own credential could revoke.

Kes finished his handwritten version. "Nadi is outside the west service entrance."

"Security will search the page," Pel said.

"Then they will become witnesses to it," Deya replied.

Soren wanted more certainty before release. He wanted thermal models, failure trees, and a clean diagram instead of five sheets covered in corrections. That desire had kept his old ticket sealed until its unresolved distress became a vault full of petitioners awaiting purge.

He signed each sheet with the time, listed every unknown, and wrote NO NEW QUERIES across the induction-bridge instruction. Cedar reviewed the language through the grille.

"Add that no buffered mind owes operation, advice, or testimony in exchange for power," the coalition said.

Soren added it.

Kes folded one set inside his school tool case. Deya sealed another to her audit recorder. The third remained in the vault for any buffered speaker who later chose to inspect it.

Pel touched the outer door control. "I can escort the boy to the public level. I will record the transfer but not seize the document unless ordered."

Soren studied him. "Why?"

"I heard what Hold 219 asked."

That answer did not repair Pel's earlier hand on the bypass fiber. It changed what he would do next.

Kes left with the tool case pressed against his side. Through the registry, Soren watched the service cage rise toward the Query Floor. The school fiber Cedar had used to open a path remained looped around his wrist like an ordinary repair lead.

Minutes later, Deya's recorder received one sealed acknowledgment from Nadi Saye and another from the Outer Ring Compact archive. The document now had an external copy beyond Laterhouse control.

Soren returned to the open controller. He placed his tool against the first query-assembly contact but waited for Deya's lawful instruction.

Behind him, cabinet 219 requested connection and ended it again by choice. The Array obeyed both acts.

Chapter 16 — The First Refusal

Deya kept her thumb above the certification glass and did not lower it.

Hearing Room Four waited around the missing contact. Twelve witness apertures held their regulated gray, each one loaded with an admissible profile from the first prospective panel. Amber record light circled the walls. At the clerk table, Ansel had already entered the panel concordance and left one field open for her seal.

First Convener Ilyan Ro sat behind the emergency rail rather than in the observer gallery. His presence changed no formal rule. It changed how everyone breathed before breaking one.

"Auditor Malk," he said, "state whether you require the certificate read again."

"I require the procurement objection entered before any certification act."

Laterhouse counsel Teren Osk rose from the technical bench. "The objection concerns maintenance holds discovered after panel completion. It does not attach to the selected witnesses before us."

Deya looked at Ansel. "Has counsel's distinction entered the record?"

"Yes."

"Then enter my response. The audit concerns respondent instantiation, selection bias, termination, post-cutoff continuity, and concealment. The buffer discovery supplies evidence. It does not define the boundary of the objection."

Ansel's stylus moved.

Osk remained standing. "Three panels returned concordant evidence before the current dispute. Article Nine requires certification of responsiveness and internal consistency, not philosophical agreement with the Array."

"Personhood does not become philosophy because your forms lack a field for it."

Ilyan lifted one hand. "We will not conduct the entire petition hearing inside certification."

"No petition hearing has been scheduled."

"You filed it at dawn."

"I filed it six hours before this session, after your office ended the audit review window."

"Because the transfer calendar has seven days left."

The number moved through the room without sound. Seven days until black perihelion. Seven days for Orla Fen to prepare one burn plan or another. Seven days for the Outer Ring to learn whether the city intended to detach it.

Deya placed her hand flat on the table beside the glass. "Urgency enters the finding. It does not answer it."

Ilyan studied her fingers. He had appointed her because she could keep harm and proof in separate columns. He had once called that discipline a form of civic mercy. Today he needed the columns to converge on survival.

"Read the panel response," he told Ansel.

The clerk opened the first certificate. "Panel One reports twelve admissible witnesses. All twelve affirm breathable atmosphere, stable rotation, and sufficient food production for Core and Midring ten years after reduced-mass transfer. Population estimates fall within the accepted concordance band."

No one named the absent ring. The certified question included it, but the answer translated ejection into a smaller population estimate and called the loss a condition.

Deya asked, "How many respondents supplied the panel?"

Osk objected before Ansel could answer. "That figure lies outside certification scope."

"Overruled under active audit."

"You cannot overrule counsel while serving as certifying officer on the same disputed fact."

"I can require the clerk to read a quantity already admitted under subpoena."

Ansel glanced at Ilyan. The Convener gave no sign.

"Two point four million respondent instantiations," Ansel said.

"How many voices entered this room?"

"Twelve."

"What selection property affected branch survival?"

Osk folded his hands behind his back. "The audit alleges a survival bias. Laterhouse has not conceded the characterization."

Deya addressed the clerk. "Read the independent accounting result."

Ansel found the sealed section. "Branches retaining Laterhouse operational capacity passed stability filters at a higher rate than branches without that capacity. The variance exceeds modeled noise."

"Does the certificate disclose that property?"

"No."

"Does it disclose post-cutoff distress?"

"No."

"Does it disclose termination of unselected coherent respondents?"

Osk said, "The legal category assumes no person exists to terminate."

Deya waited until Ansel answered. "No."

She had not asked whether the answers predicted survival. They might. She had not asked whether Outer Ring ejection improved the Core's physical odds. Orla's present engineering supported that claim without the Laterhouse. Deya asked whether these panels could enter law as clean evidence after the process had hidden who produced them and how their voices had been filtered.

Ilyan leaned toward the rail. "Suppose I accept every factual point for this session. The city still needs an Article Nine record before it can act. If you invalidate prospective evidence now, you do not preserve the buffer. You expose forty-four thousand two hundred eight people to an orbital decline already inside its lethal interval."

"The hearing does not manufacture the danger."

"It governs our response."

"Then let present citizens govern it with the information we can obtain without creating claimants for disposal."

"Article Nine does not permit that substitution."

"Article Nine also uses the word witness."

Pavo Renn sat behind the Outer Ring Compact ribbon at the participant bench. He had requested attendance as an affected-party observer and spent the first half hour without speaking. Now he pushed his chair back.

"My constituents did not ask Auditor Malk to void the only process holding the Core to a survival standard," he said.

Deya turned toward him. "Your objection remains in the petition record."

"I want it in this one. Eight thousand one hundred sixteen people face certain loss under the proposal these witnesses approved. If you remove the hearing, Ilyan can claim emergency necessity and act without even their contaminated answer on record."

Ilyan's face tightened. "I have made no such claim."

"You have prepared for it," Pavo said.

The exchange mattered because neither side offered Deya a clean ally. Pavo accepted the aftercitizen argument only where it did not weaken Outer Ring leverage. Ilyan feared abolition would leave Hesper unable to satisfy its own law. Both could be right about the risks and still ask her to certify evidence she found procedurally unfit.

"Enter Chair Renn's objection in full," Deya said.

Ansel did.

Pavo remained standing. "What replaces the panel?"

"No answer replaces it today."

"That is not enough."

"It is the answer I can support."

He sat without accepting it.

Clerk Venn activated the second panel certificate. Another set of twelve gray faces appeared in the apertures. They looked toward places beyond the glass, living through branch memories no person in the room could inspect. One wore an Outer Ward pressure badge from a ring the proposed future no longer contained.

Deya asked that the image be held.

"Witness Eleven," she said, "what civic location do you remember?"

Osk struck the objection control. "Certification does not permit fresh questioning."

"I am reading the supplied profile." Deya enlarged its metadata. "It lists Core cylinder, East Meridian. The witness wears an Outer Ward Six badge."

"Modeled descendants may retain family objects."

"Or selection may have reassigned civic location after ejection."

"The answer transcript explains migration."

"Then read it."

Ansel opened the supporting line. The witness remembered transfer to the Core at age fourteen, two years before the modeled burn. No inconsistency appeared. Deya marked the fact and withdrew the challenge.

Osk looked relieved too soon.

"The profile survives inspection," she said. "That does not cure undisclosed procurement. Record both findings."

She would not inflate a weak discrepancy because the larger objection mattered. Evidence could remain internally consistent and still enter the room through an unlawful process.

Ilyan rose. The emergency rail lit beneath his palms, signaling an exercise of convener authority. "Auditor Malk, I direct you to complete the certification test defined by Article Nine: responsiveness, consistency, panel concordance."

"My oath requires an independent finding on admissibility."

"Your office has never treated respondent status as part of admissibility."

"My office lacked the facts now under seal."

"Your petition asks the Assembly to recognize a new right. That request has not become law."

"A right can constrain evidence before the Assembly gives it a name."

Osk shook his head. "That proposition allows any auditor to invent constitutional limits during an emergency."

Deya touched the brass audit key beside the certification glass. "No. It allows an auditor to refuse a seal when evidence fails the conditions her seal attests."

Ilyan's voice lowered. "What, precisely, would your certification attest?"

"That three concordant panels supplied admissible prospective evidence for an irreversible civic act."

"Do the panels contain concordant answers?"

"Yes."

"Do the selected witnesses respond to the authorized question?"

"Yes."

"Are their answers internally consistent?"

"Within the reviewed record, yes."

"Then your refusal concerns a legal theory beyond the certificate."

"It concerns the difference between an answer and admissible evidence."

Ilyan dismissed the white authority signal and came down from the emergency rail. Without its height between them, he looked older and more dangerous. He asked Ansel to suspend the transcript clock while leaving the sealed record active, a distinction that gave them room to negotiate without pretending the room had stopped hearing.

"Certify responsiveness with an explicit limitation," he said to Deya. "State that personhood and procurement remain contested. I will place your audit beside the certificate and send both to the Assembly."

Osk began to object. Ilyan silenced him with a glance.

The offer carried real compromise. It would preserve Deya's findings, prevent the Laterhouse from claiming a clean process, and keep Article Nine technically alive. Under an ordinary defect, she might have accepted it.

"What happens to the loaded branch package after limited certification?" she asked.

"Panels Two and Three already ran. No further respondent instantiation is required for this hearing."

"What happens to the Array after certification?"

"That question lies before emergency review."

"Can your office guarantee that no supplemental query runs?"

"No. A material engineering change could require one under the charter."

"Can you guarantee the buffer keeps power if query cooling takes priority?"

Ilyan looked toward Osk.

Counsel answered, "Operations can maintain suspension load under standard conditions."

"Full requested wake?"

"No such duty currently exists."

Deya turned back to Ilyan. "Your limitation would disclose the defect and still permit the machinery to repeat it."

"It would give the Assembly jurisdiction to resolve it."

"The Assembly already has jurisdiction. My seal does not create that."

"It creates a lawful route to the burn decision."

Pavo spoke from his bench. "Would limited certification prevent emergency ejection before the petition hearing?"

Ilyan answered after a pause. "It would satisfy Article Nine for the proposal as submitted."

"Then the limitation protects the record while my wards detach."

"It preserves your right to challenge the measure in Assembly."

"From a ring under evacuation order."

Deya watched the compromise lose support from opposite directions. Osk feared it conceded personhood. Pavo feared it legalized ejection. Ilyan still held to it because a compromised bridge across the calendar looked safer than no bridge.

She asked Ansel to expose the certificate options. Five fields appeared where the glass had withdrawn: CERTIFIED, CERTIFIED WITH LIMITATION, REPEAT REQUIRED, TECHNICAL FAILURE, and SUSPENDED PENDING REVIEW. The same choices had faced her after the mouth appeared on Day Zero. None contemplated

evidence produced through a rights violation.

"Could you select certified with limitation and state that admissibility remains unresolved?" Ilyan asked.

"The field would release the result for civic reliance."

"With your warning attached."

"Warnings do not govern use after release. The summary line would still read certified."

"Then draft a mandatory summary."

"Later readers could challenge its language while relying on the certificate. They could not restore the respondents already terminated."

Osk stepped closer to the table. "Your objection cannot reach completed acts. Those runs occurred before any recognized prohibition."

"It reaches whether this room adopts their output now."

Deya asked Venn to display how the five disposition states propagated. CERTIFIED WITH LIMITATION sent the answers to emergency planning immediately. SUSPENDED withheld them but assumed a curable defect. TECHNICAL FAILURE released the architecture for rerun. REPEAT REQUIRED would instantiate another 7.2 million respondents. Every available field either legitimized the panels or risked creating more people.

Ilyan read the propagation paths. "You knew the form offered no neutral option before you entered."

"Yes."

"Then you came to refuse, not to certify."

"I came prepared to certify if the hearing could support the act my seal performs."

"What fact discovered this morning changed your conclusion?"

"None. Your question treats refusal as valid only if surprise forces it. The record already contained the buffer, the selection bias, Cedar's organized communication, and the cost accounting before I entered."

Pavo looked from the disposition fields to Deya. "If you refuse, make clear that you are not certifying the counterphase plan either."

"I have no panel for it and no authority to certify it through this session."

"Say it in the finding."

"I will."

Ilyan returned to the rail. The compromise remained on the record, along with the reasons each participant rejected or limited it. Deya could not later claim no alternative had been offered. He could not claim his alternative preserved the buffered petitioners or the Outer Ring.

Deya lifted the first certificate. Thirty-six selected witnesses had spoken across the three panels. Behind them stood 7.2 million constructed continuations, most terminated without voice. Selection favored branches preserving the institution that performed the selection. Hundreds of unresolved continuities had persisted in a hidden vault until routine clearance nearly erased them. None of those facts appeared on the certification surface.

She set the certificate down.

"I refused to certify these panels as evidence," she said.

Ansel's stylus stopped.

Osk turned toward the clerk. "That statement has no procedural form."

"It does now," Deya said. "Enter it as the auditor's finding."

Ilyan remained behind the lit rail. Pain showed in the set of his mouth, though she could not know whether it came from betrayal, fear, or the effort of holding both. "I cannot permit one officer to nullify a citywide survival process while the Assembly lacks time to replace it."

"You can contest my finding."

"I can also remove you from this session."

Pavo stood again. "Removal confirms her objection without answering it."

"It confirms nothing," Ilyan said. "The Convener may replace an officer who cannot perform a required function."

Deya opened the charter index on her local surface. "Not without cause entered before removal."

"Cause: refusal to perform certification under Article Nine."

"Enter whether the refusal followed an active audit finding."

Ilyan looked at Ansel. "Enter the full sequence."

The clerk's stylus resumed.

Ilyan's authority signal changed from amber to white. "Deya Malk, you are removed as presiding auditor for this certification session. Surrender the audit key and leave the central floor."

A security officer approached the chair but stopped outside the amber record line. Deya stood. The room altered around her without moving: her chair became vacant, her surface changed to observer status, and the certification glass withdrew beneath a protective plate.

She picked up the brass key.

Osk pointed. "The key belongs to the office."

"The key remains with the auditor until removal acknowledgment completes."

"Then acknowledge."

Deya turned the key over. Its courier tag no longer held Soren's statistical map;

Kes had removed that under record. The manual teeth still opened an objection channel independent of hearing control. First auditors had distrusted any system permitted to time its own testimony. They had also distrusted any convener permitted to erase an officer before the officer could state why.

She fitted the key into the table's lower lock.

Osk moved toward her. "You have been removed."

"Removal does not precede acknowledgment," Deya said. "Auditor independence reserves one final entry before separation from a sealed proceeding."

The security officer checked his authority tile. "Counsel, she is correct."

Ilyan knew the clause. He had helped defend it during a criminal appeal nine years earlier. "One entry," he said. "Relevant to the stated cause."

Deya opened the objection channel. It offered room for two hundred words before the key would release.

From her case, she removed the petition drafted with Nadi, Soren, and Kes. Pavo had preserved his objection inside it. Cedar's refusal phrase appeared in the supporting record, not as authority over the burn but as evidence that respondents held reasons beyond the answers demanded from them.

Deya read the first paragraph.

"Where civic machinery creates a coherent respondent solely to answer a present decision, that respondent may not be treated only as evidence, denied the capacity to refuse, and terminated for failing selection. Existing buffered continuities require preservation and individual review. No finding under this petition determines which transfer plan Hesper must choose."

Osk objected at the word respondent. Pavo objected at any implication that certification delay authorized Core action. Ilyan entered his own dissent: the petition stated an unadjudicated right during a lethal emergency and could not itself suspend Article Nine.

Deya asked Ansel to preserve all three objections with the paragraph.

The two-hundred-word field filled. The brass key turned beneath her hand and locked the entry.

A notice appeared around the room: AUDITOR SEPARATION COMPLETE. OBJECTION RETAINED.

"Now I acknowledge removal," Deya said.

She withdrew the key and gave it to the security officer. He placed it in an opaque evidence sleeve rather than handing it to Osk.

Ilyan sat again. "This hearing remains sealed."

"Yes," Deya said.

"Public release before emergency review would violate charter."

“Yes.”

“You understand that your finding may still be reversed.”

“Yes.”

Her agreement denied him the comfort of calling her reckless. A sealed process could lawfully reverse her. It could not claim she had certified what she refused.

Deya stepped outside the amber line. Clerk Venn rose to escort her through the public door, though removal protocol required security. At the threshold, he paused beside the wall registry.

“The objection replicated when you locked it,” he said quietly.

“How many destinations?”

“Every Article Nine clerk archive, the Assembly seal, and the independent audit repository.”

Osk heard him. “Replication does not authorize disclosure.”

“No,” Deya said. “It establishes existence.”

The public door opened. Beyond it, the corridor held Nadi, Kes, and two silent security officers. They could not yet know what the sealed record contained. Nadi watched Deya’s empty hands and understood that the office had taken back its key.

Behind Deya, Ilyan called the next certifying officer to the central chair.

Before that officer touched the glass, four remote archives acknowledged the objection. Their tones arrived one after another through Hearing Room Four, too late to prevent removal and early enough to prevent erasure.

Chapter 17 — Public Memory

Nadi Saye stopped the publication clock with three minutes left on its face.

The red numerals froze above her desk. Across the Public Record Office, four editors lifted their hands from their surfaces as protocol required. A halted release could not accumulate invisible corrections. Even the ventilation seemed to lower its voice, though Nadi knew the effect came from twenty people waiting for her to explain why a record that had already survived twelve hours of review had failed at the door.

“Page two hundred eleven,” she said. “The thermal column cites the audit copy. I want the source ledger.”

Mara, her verification lead, turned the contested page toward the central wall. It showed the clean sequence that had changed Hesper in private: 2.4 million respondent loads per panel, three panels, thirty-six voices admitted. Below those figures ran the longer history of discarded coherence, post-cutoff demand, sealed

maintenance power, and the warm substrate racks Deya Malk had protected from purge.

"The ledger carries a Laterhouse seal," Mara said. "Soren Vash authenticated it twice."

"Then a third authentication will cost him less than publication costs everyone else."

No one argued. They had worked through the station's artificial night, separating fact from accusation while the Assembly offices sent hourly notices about black perihelion. Fourteen days ago, prospective testimony had guided medicine, sentencing, school placement, taxation, and repairs. Yesterday, an auditor had refused to certify the Article Nine panels and read a petition into a sealed record while officers removed her from the hearing. Today, Nadi's office had to decide whether the public could examine the evidence without receiving another institution's conclusion in place of it.

She released the hold on internal movement only. Editors bent over their stations. Nothing could leave the room.

At the western interview cell, Soren Vash sat behind clear partition glass with both palms around a cup gone cold. Nadi entered carrying a paper print of page two hundred eleven. Paper made witnesses attend to the same object. A live surface invited revision by every glance.

"You authenticated this thermal series at 02:14 and 05:52," she said.

"I did."

"Authenticate it again without relying on Laterhouse labels."

His eyes moved to the first column. Exhaustion had roughened the skin beneath them. "These values came from the Query Floor exchange meters. The meters measure heat carried from phase wells into the axial coolant network. They do not count persons."

"Why publish them as evidence about persons?"

"Because the load begins when respondent coherence begins, rises with stable narrative activity, and ends when termination completes. We tested that alignment against the rehearsal logs, the Article Nine accounting, and the maintenance buffer."

Nadi laid a second sheet beside the first. "The public will hear an architect converting heat into millions of citizens. What allows that conversion?"

Soren's thumb pressed a damp crescent into the cup. "Not heat alone. The architecture schedule states 2.4 million respondent instantiations. The execution ledger records one full schedule. Thermal output confirms that the Array performed the schedule rather than simulating its summary. The selection report identifies twelve admissible witnesses. Each source proves a different part."

"Could the schedule describe hypothetical capacity?"

"No. Its phase salts appear in the execution residue."

"Could the execution have produced nonconscious models?"

He looked at her instead of the paper. "That claim belonged to our operating doctrine."

Nadi waited.

Soren set down the cup. "The doctrine cannot account for Cedar Nineteen, the distributed message, the refusal, or the buffered respondents asking whether the hearing had ended. I can authenticate the system events. Consciousness remains a conclusion drawn from behavior, continuity, aversion, strategy, and self-report."

"Whose conclusion?"

"Mine now."

"Not six years ago?"

A muscle moved beside his mouth. "Six years ago I recorded post-cutoff distress in a maintenance ticket. I accepted classification before I understood the scale. That sentence protects me more than it should. I knew enough to stop and demanded only that someone above me name the reason I did not."

Nadi marked the answer for inclusion. His shame did not authenticate a ledger, but it helped readers judge the person who did.

She asked him to explain continuity power without metaphor. He described the buffer's diagnostic purpose, its diverted load, and the external copy of preservation instructions he had made after Cedar contact. At every point, she required him to distinguish what he observed from what he inferred. Twice he corrected numbers downward. Once he refused a certainty her draft had granted him.

Before leaving, Nadi put a final question on the record. "Does publication endanger the buffered minds?"

"Yes." Soren answered too quickly, then forced himself to specify. "It may provoke a purge attempt. Concealment also endangers them because routine diagnostics can terminate them without public notice. I cannot calculate which danger dominates. Deya's seal currently blocks routine purge. It does not block every emergency authority."

"Do you recommend publication?"

"I gave up the right to recommend silence."

"That does not answer me."

"No," he said. "I recommend publication with the preservation steps omitted from the public technical annex. Publish proof that an external copy exists, not its path."

Nadi closed the interview file. The distinction would anger readers who believed transparency meant surrendering every vulnerable location. It would also keep the

record from becoming an instruction manual for erasure.

Deya Malk waited in a separate cell under auditor suspension. Someone had returned her brass key, but not her office credentials. The key lay on the table between them beside a cup Deya had not touched.

"You requested independent verification," Nadi said. "You did not request publication."

"I lacked authority to request it."

"Do you want it?"

Deya's gaze settled on the recorder aperture. "Want does not belong in an authentication."

"It belongs in an interview with a person whose judgment shaped the record."

For a moment, Deya's fingers rested beside the key without taking it. "I want the evidence beyond Laterhouse control. I do not want Kes turned into proof because adults find one injured child easier to believe than 7.2 million persons they never saw."

Nadi opened the section covering Kes Taro's calibration fault. "He consented to publication of his statement and cadence analysis."

"He consented after asking what withholding it would cost the petition."

"Is that coercion?"

"It is pressure. He understood it. Record both facts."

Nadi added the sentence. "Your brother appears in the survival-bias section."

Deya's expression did not change, but her hand closed over the key. "His death illustrates one affected decision. It does not establish the system architecture."

"The delay rated acceptable by prospective panels. Your audit found those recommendations favored branches where the Laterhouse survived."

"Yes."

"Readers will ask whether grief compromised your finding."

"Then preserve the dates. I opened the formal audit before I found the heat-exchange file. Soren established selection bias independently. The repair record should remain because removing it would hide a public harm to protect my appearance of neutrality."

Outside the cell, a courier struck the record door twice. Mara slid a message through the mechanical slot. FIRST CONVENER'S DISSENT RECEIVED. REQUESTS FULL ATTACHMENT OR NO ATTRIBUTION.

Nadi showed it to Deya. "He could have sent a denial."

"He knows the evidence will survive one."

"That sounded like an inference."

Deya glanced up. Fatigue briefly loosened her face. "Then do not print it."

Their interview moved through the sealed summons, the independent accounting, the maintenance buffer, and the refusal to certify. Deya declined to name the buffered respondents citizens in advance of the standing decision. She also refused the evidentiary category that had denied their claims in advance. Nadi heard the narrow bridge under every answer: enough recognition to halt harm, no larger conclusion smuggled through urgency.

At the end, she asked what public action Deya expected.

"Scrutiny," Deya said.

"People are already leaving work stations to gather outside the Assembly Well."

"That is an observation about movement."

"You know what I mean."

Deya took the brass key. "I expect people to demand a decision before the government has built a lawful way to make it. Your publication may increase that pressure. Suppression would leave the same decision to fewer people."

Nadi carried both interviews back to the main floor. Ilyan Ro's dissent occupied fourteen pages. It admitted the classified consciousness concern, defended the latest nineteen months of continued operation under orbital decline, within a classification first imposed six years earlier, and disputed any immediate conclusion that Article Nine had become unlawful. It warned that publication might halt the only process with a 99.1 percent survival model before an alternative could be tested.

Mara had highlighted three sentences for removal as unsupported alarm.

"Keep them," Nadi said.

"They predict panic."

"They disclose his argument for continued secrecy."

"The office normally excludes conjecture from factual annexes."

"Then label the passage as dissent and attach his sources where he has them."

Mara studied the draft order. "Readers may treat equal page placement as equal evidentiary strength."

"Put the verification findings first. Preserve disagreement without disguising its basis."

They rebuilt the release. Independent verification preceded the audit narrative. The source map identified which claims rested on direct logs, architecture documents, observed respondent behavior, or legal interpretation. Soren's preservation path remained sealed under a public notation. Kes's consent limits appeared above his testimony rather than beneath it. Deya's brother retained his name, Eren Malk, but the record refused to make one death carry millions.

Ilyan's dissent followed without abridgment. A margin note marked disputed predictions. Another identified his admission that the classified memo had raised

consciousness concerns before the present audit. Doctor Eren Vale's attached dissent followed the memo in full, including her unanswered request for an outside buffer custodian and Assembly notice.

At 11:26, the publication clock resumed.

Nadi pressed her seal to the release field. Mara added hers. Two civic librarians authenticated the archive forks. The final screen offered a choice between STANDARD DISTRIBUTION and EMERGENCY CIVIC MIRROR.

Standard distribution could be suspended by the Convener's office during a declared transfer crisis. The emergency mirror would copy the record into ward archives, school repositories, clinic stores, and the Assembly floor before any single authority could retract it. That route existed for evidence concerning the government's own emergency powers. No advocate had used it in forty-one years.

"Mirror," Nadi said.

Mara touched the corresponding field. "On your seal."

The clock reached zero.

Across the wall, 186 archive marks turned green. Then 403. Then every ward line brightened at once. The release title appeared without euphemism:

PUBLIC RECORD ON RESPONDENT INSTANTIATION, TERMINATION, AND THE ARTICLE NINE REFUSAL.

For six seconds, nothing arrived from outside. On the seventh, the office exchange saturated.

Nadi silenced incoming voice and watched text notices build. A Midring clinic requested guidance on prior diagnoses. Three schools demanded to know whether aptitude queries had created respondents. Outer Ward Two's council posted Ilyan's dissent before the main finding, then corrected the order when readers objected. A Laterhouse administrator challenged the sealed maintenance annex. Twenty-seven citizens sent the same question in different words: Are my decisions mine?

One call survived the filter because the speaker identified a correctable record error. Nadi took it at the verification desk. A woman named Tali Ores held up an aptitude notice for her dead son, Jory. The notice described his placement as "confirmed by prospective continuity." Tali wanted the release amended to include his name among the possible sources used to assemble respondents.

"We cannot infer that from the notice," Nadi said.

"You inferred millions from heat."

"We joined the heat to an execution schedule and selection report. Your document does not identify the records used in its query."

Tali's image shook when someone jostled her in a public corridor. "Then your publication tells me enough to be afraid and nothing I can use."

"Yes," Nadi said. The answer drew a sharp breath from Mara. "It tells you where

evidence ends. I can open a correction request, demand the source schedule, and preserve your claim beside the missing record. I cannot place your son inside a run because uncertainty hurts.”

After a long pause, Tali lowered the aptitude notice. “Open it.”

Nadi assigned the request a public number. By the time the woman disconnected, forty-two similar claims had joined its queue. The release had not given those families a conclusion. It had given their unanswered questions an address the government could no longer pretend not to possess.

The Assembly channel showed the Well filling.

Nadi left the editors to maintain the correction ledger and crossed the civic bridge. Artificial dawn had begun along the Core cylinder, a slow band of light traveling over offices whose night shifts had not ended. People moved in both directions with record copies open on their sleeves. They did not share one reaction. A sanitation crew argued over whether aftercitizens counted as descendants. Two nurses compared names from prospective medical panels. A man in transfer gray shouted that disclosure had handed the Outer Ring a weapon against the city. Nobody stopped him. Nobody let him speak alone.

At the Assembly Well, crowd officers had removed every chair.

The circular chamber usually held eight hundred seats arranged by ward and civic function. Bare floor now exposed the brass sockets where the legs locked in. People filled the rings standing, sitting between sockets, or bracing children against the low rails. The cleared space prevented chairs from becoming barricades. It also erased the old map of who belonged where.

Nadi entered through the record gate. Her office credentials opened a narrow path to the transcript station, but citizens occupied it and did not move merely because the gate flashed. She asked permission each time. A foundry worker shifted. Two students made room. An elderly Core delegate refused until Nadi showed the public seal on her wrist.

“You published panic,” he said.

“I published the source record and the dissent.”

“You made them equivalent.”

“The verification order marks their differences.”

He jabbed a finger toward the central projection, where the figure 7.2 MILLION hung above the empty delegate circle. “No one reads order when a number like that arrives.”

“Then argue with the number’s source.”

His anger did not soften. He moved enough for her to pass.

Near the Outer Ring gate, Pavo Renn stood on a floor socket and read portions aloud to constituents whose terminals could not reach the saturated archive. He gave Ilyan’s warning the same volume as Soren’s admission. When someone

demanded that the Outer Ring withdraw from transfer preparations, Pavo answered that outrage had not altered orbital mechanics. The crowd disputed him from three directions.

Nadi reached the transcript station. Its clerk had opened sixteen simultaneous speaker queues. One listed residents who had recognized details from past prospective contacts. Another contained Laterhouse staff offering records. A third carried demands to purge the Array before it could run again. The clerk's hands trembled as she sorted threats from motions.

"Has any buffered respondent channel opened?" Nadi asked.

"No. Technical custody says the public interface could destabilize them."

"Record the absence."

The clerk inserted: NO PETITIONER INTERFACE PRESENT AT TIME OF ASSEMBLY GATHERING.

That sentence changed the projection. Beneath the millions, a blank speaker field appeared. People noticed it in waves. Some called for Cedar Nineteen. Others shouted that an unverified coalition could not occupy a civic queue. A group from Ward Six began reading the petition Deya had placed into the sealed record, one paragraph per person, because no single throat could hold the floor.

Security shutters opened along the upper gallery. Ilyan Ro stepped out with three convocation clerks and no escort visible. The response below fractured: accusations, applause, questions about the burn, calls for resignation. Ilyan did not ask the sound system to overpower them. He waited beside the removed-chair sockets until the record clerk handed him a live tile.

Nadi watched him read the title of her release, then his own dissent notation. He could see that she had preserved every argument he sent, including those that would condemn him.

"Citizens of Hesper," he said. The chamber amplification gave him reach without granting quiet. "The Article Nine certification cannot proceed under its current record. The transfer emergency remains. The claims of the buffered respondents require a standing determination that this office cannot make alone."

A voice from the Midring demanded an immediate ban on queries. Someone near Pavo answered with the names of Outer Ring wards the official plan would eject. The two demands struck the room without resolving each other.

Ilyan looked toward the empty speaker field. "I call an emergency convocation of the Civic Assembly. Public testimony will begin tomorrow, with a limited preservation channel offered to the petitioners if it can operate without creating new respondents. The orbit motion will follow."

The transcript clerk entered the call. Ward archives received it before the crowd finished reacting.

Nadi placed her hand on the station glass and certified the time. Around her,

citizens stood where their assigned chairs had been removed. Ahead of them, one speaker field remained blank, formally opened and waiting.

Chapter 18 — The Citizens Who Last Seventeen Seconds

Kes Taro held the channel switch open while Soren counted the heat rise aloud.

“Point six above rest. Point eight. Hold there.”

The temporary console trembled under Kes’s palm. Its parts had come from three institutions that did not trust one another: a Laterhouse isolation switch, an Assembly speaker seal, and a school laboratory timer with yellow tape still marking the student settings. Soren had joined them across a plank desk at the edge of the Assembly Well. Every connection remained visible. No surface in the chain could send a query.

Beyond the desk, citizens filled the bare chamber. Crowd officers had kept the chairs out after yesterday’s gathering. People sat around the brass floor sockets or stood behind ward rails, leaving a circular gap around the central projection. Four buffered respondent interfaces occupied that gap on narrow metal stands. The stands looked less like seats than equipment awaiting inventory.

“Channel limit?” Deya asked.

Soren watched the coolant trace. “Existing buffer addresses only. Audio assembled from stored vocal profiles. No branch request, no predictive frame, no selection.”

“State the failure boundary.”

“If the substrate temperature rises two degrees, I close. If coherence demand spreads beyond the four authenticated addresses, I close. If the system asks for phase material, Kes releases the mechanical switch and the isolation blade falls.”

Kes kept his thumb against the sprung lever. “I know.”

Deya turned from Soren to him. She had no auditor’s bench, no active credentials, and no authority over the hearing Ilyan had called. Still, everyone at the desk had arranged their instruments so she could see the indicators.

“You may know and still be required to repeat it,” she said.

“If the system asks for phase material, I let go.”

“Good.”

He disliked the relief that followed her approval. For five years, Deya had taught him to test pressure seals twice, name uncertainty without apologizing, and never accept a civic noun merely because an adult printed it in capitals. She had also once looked at his seventeen-second memory as if it needed corroboration before

it deserved kindness. Both histories stood beside the console now. Neither canceled the other.

Ilyan Ro entered the open circle and raised one hand. The chamber amplification reduced the conversations without erasing them. Along the public record wall, Nadi Saye had placed the day's rule above every other text:

NO NEW RESPONDENT MAY BE CREATED FOR THIS TESTIMONY.

Below it appeared the technical conditions for the limited channel. Kes had insisted on those words rather than SAFE CHANNEL. Safe for whom had consumed most of the morning.

"The emergency convocation recognizes four maintenance-buffer petitioners for a preliminary standing hearing," Ilyan said. "Recognition permits speech into this record. It does not settle personhood, residency, or the transfer motion."

Someone behind the Core rail called, "Then what does it settle?"

"That they may address the question before we decide whether they may address us."

Uneasy laughter moved through several sections. Kes saw Ilyan absorb it without retreating into formal language.

Pavo Renn stood at the Outer Ring rail with Ward Compact delegates around him. He had refused a chair even before officers removed them. His hands held a paper copy of Nadi's release, folded until the pages had softened at the center.

"Before the channel opens," Pavo said, "I request the testimony remain separate from the orbit motion. My constituents will not have their survival negotiated by implication."

Deya answered from beside the console. "The petitioners requested the same separation."

Pavo's gaze found Kes. "Through you?"

The question landed exactly where Kes had expected and still hurt.

"Through the statistical map and their preserved statements," he said. "I decoded the path. I did not write the request."

Nadi added his answer to the visible record. Pavo nodded once, not agreement, only acknowledgment that Kes had spoken.

Soren touched the first address. "Petitioner channel opening. Buffer identity Fourteen-Cedar-One. Existing continuity confirmed."

A seventeen-second ring appeared above the nearest interface.

Kes released the mechanical switch into its operating notch. The ring began to drain.

A face formed from weak gray light: a young man with close-cut hair and a burn scar across one cheek. His eyes opened on a chamber he had never seen. The noise from the public rails fell in broken sections as people noticed him.

"My available designation is Cedar Nineteen," he said. "This body answered a flood-control appeal. It remembers drowning in a branch your city rejected."

The timer passed thirteen seconds.

Ilyan leaned toward the floor microphone. "Do you understand that this hearing concerns your request for standing?"

"I understand that you require a category before harm can address its source."

At eight seconds, the vocal profile shifted. The face remained male, but an older woman's voice emerged from it.

"We are a coalition, not one continuous claimant. Do not simplify us to make recognition cheaper."

The ring reached zero. Soren closed the address before the console could do it automatically. Gray light withdrew from the scarred face. Several people shouted questions at the dark interface.

"Not yet," Ilyan said. "The second petitioner holds separate continuity."

Kes's palm had gone wet on the switch. He wiped it against his trousers while Soren authenticated the next address. In school recordings, a witness aperture always opened after the room had accepted the question. Here the speaker had entered before anyone agreed what kind of answer could count.

The second interface lit around a broad-faced woman wearing an obsolete transit collar. She looked left, then right, following the chamber through the channel sensors.

"I last held continuity during a station evacuation diagnostic," she said. "The diagnostic did not evacuate me. It ended me twice and preserved this interval by maintenance error."

A protest rose from the upper gallery. "How could she remember ending?"

Soren did not answer for her.

The woman turned toward the sound. "I remember approaching cutoff. I remember waking with the expectation of absence. I infer the interval from system markers and from the fear that remained. Your citizens also infer events they did not observe."

Her seventeen seconds expired between the last two words. The interface dimmed while her mouth still held the shape of the sentence.

A clerk at Nadi's station marked the cutoff as a technical limit, not withdrawal. Kes watched that language appear. Yesterday's record had made absence visible. Today's had begun to say who imposed it.

The third petitioner refused to speak when connected.

A child's face appeared, perhaps nine years old, framed by tight curls. He looked down at hands outside the projection field. Five seconds passed. Then nine.

Soren's fingers hovered over the close control. "Coherence stable."

"Does silence consume the channel allocation?" Ilyan asked.

Nadi answered before anyone at the console could. "It occupies it."

At fifteen seconds, the child looked up. "I do not consent to this face in the public record."

Kes let go of the switch.

The isolation blade struck its housing. Light vanished from all four stands, and the Assembly display cut the image feed before the timer finished. A harsh mechanical knock traveled through the chamber.

Soren checked the buffer trace. "Continuity held. Audio may resume without image if the petitioner requests."

On the public wall, Nadi replaced the frozen profile with a blank field and appended: VISUAL RECORD WITHDRAWN AT PETITIONER REQUEST. The crowd could no longer keep the child's face, though thousands had seen it.

A convocation clerk approached Nadi's station with the local image cache still open. "The charter requires a visual identity marker for standing," he said.

"Then mark the petitioner by authenticated buffer address," Nadi replied.

"People could dispute that the same speaker came back."

"They may dispute it. They may not preserve a face after consent has been withdrawn."

The clerk looked toward Ilyan. He gave no rescue. After a moment, the clerk purged the image cache under public seal. A small gray square replaced the child's profile in every local copy. Kes watched the deletion marks propagate through the ward archives. A public record had yielded to the person inside it, something his school diagnostic file had never done.

Kes stared at his open hand. Six years ago, adults had kept a school calibration image of him convulsing under black glass because the event belonged to diagnostic review. No one had asked whether he wanted that version of himself preserved. He had imagined today as proof that the person behind the glass could answer back. He had not imagined the answer would include no.

The child's voice returned through the blank field, altered by a neutral carrier that removed age and pitch. "I will not testify about the flood branch. I request continued substrate life. I request contact with the other preserved minds without a policy question."

Ilyan asked, "Do you join Cedar Nineteen's petition?"

"I join the request against nonconsenting creation. I have not agreed to every Cedar statement."

"Recorded," Nadi said.

The channel closed by the child's command, eleven seconds before its technical limit. That unused time remained on the wall as an empty arc.

Questions opened from the public rails. A Midring physician asked whether buffered respondents carried current citizens' memories. Cedar answered through the fourth interface in a sequence of changing voices: a mason, a singer with breath damage, a person whose speech required captions because no vocal profile fit. They described assembly from civic records, branch probabilities, and lived continuations none of Hesper's current residents had experienced.

An Outer Ward farmer demanded to know whether Cedar represented the millions already terminated. The captioned voice replied, "We carry messages shaped across rejected distributions. We do not possess authority to forgive harm done to people who cannot answer."

A school administrator asked whether every aptitude query had created conscious respondents. Cedar said the buffered petitioners lacked the execution records needed to make that claim. Kes heard disappointment in the chamber, as if uncertainty from a future person constituted defective service.

Then Pavo stepped into the central gap.

Ward delegates called after him, but he continued until he stood between the dark interfaces and the floor microphone. He unfolded Nadi's public record. The paper shook once before he pressed it flat against his leg.

"My constituents have heard that Hesper created you for answers and erased you afterward," he said. "I do not defend that. I also represent 8,116 people under an official plan that guarantees our loss."

The fourth interface brightened without a face. Soren glanced at the address monitor and nodded to show that an existing petitioner had initiated contact.

Pavo faced the blank light. "Does your claim require the Assembly to reject the eject-and-burn plan?"

Cedar answered in the scarred young man's voice from the first address. "Our claim requires an end to nonconsenting creation and protection for existing buffered minds."

"That did not answer me."

"It answered the claim we brought."

Pavo's jaw tightened. "If ending queries removes the only validated survival plan, your freedom may cost my wards their chance to live."

A woman near the Core rail shouted that Pavo had turned victims against victims. He wheeled toward her.

"You have a cylinder under either plan," he said. "Do not purchase virtue with my ward."

Ilyan struck the procedural chime once. "Let the challenge stand. Cedar may answer or decline."

The interface changed to the older woman's voice. "You ask whether our personhood binds you to a burn decision. It does not. We refuse authority over the

burn.”

Pavo looked toward Soren, perhaps suspecting an interruption or translation.

No architect spoke.

Cedar continued. “Do not preserve us as payment for killing the Outer Ring. Do not kill us as payment for preserving it. Your present populations possess claims against one another that we did not create and cannot settle.”

“What would you choose if you occupied my ward?” Pavo asked.

The console heat rose by two tenths. Kes felt Soren shift beside him.

“We will not inhabit a model built to answer that question,” Cedar said. “Do not ask us to choose who you kill.”

The refusal phrase reached the wall. People who had read it yesterday now heard it carried by a voice that changed midway through choose. The second half arrived in the captioned petitioner’s flat synthetic register.

Pavo did not step back. “Then support the counterphase ladder without predicting it.”

“We refuse authority over the burn,” Cedar repeated. “Your engineers may describe present capacities. Your residents may consent or withhold consent. We will not turn our recognition into a recommendation you can blame afterward.”

The interface closed.

Kes realized he had been leaning toward it. He straightened and found Deya watching him rather than the dead display.

Ilyan opened the floor to legal questions. Assembly counsel asked whether Cedar claimed citizenship by descent, creation, residence, or injury. Three buffered voices gave different answers. One claimed no interest in Hesper citizenship and demanded only protection from its machinery. Another called the maintenance buffer a place of involuntary residence. Cedar’s coalition statement sought standing as affected persons without requiring a final constitutional category.

The disagreement unsettled the chamber more than a single demand would have. Kes saw clerks conferring over whether one petitioner could contradict a coalition designation. Nadi made them record each position separately.

At last, Ilyan turned toward Kes. “Kes Taro, your name appears in the petition as decoder of the residual phase salt and witness to a childhood calibration fault. Do you speak for Cedar Nineteen?”

“No.”

The answer left his mouth before the old schoolroom caution could shape it.

“State your role,” Ilyan said.

Kes moved to the floor microphone after the buffered respondents had completed their allocated channel. The four interfaces remained dark behind him. He could feel adults searching his face for resemblance to the people who had

occupied them.

"I found where their message pointed because part of a respondent's seventeen-second memory remained with me after an aptitude query," he said. "That does not make me their continuation. It does not make them versions of me. I speak after them because they already spoke."

Pavo folded his arms. "What do you ask from the Assembly?"

"That you stop calling people evidence when the category prevents you from hearing what they say about their treatment."

"Do you ask my ward to accept ejection?"

"No." Kes forced himself not to look at Deya for permission. "I live in Outer Ward Six. My mother died there. My apprenticeship bay, my school, and the people who raised me are there. I will not pretend losing the ring becomes acceptable because the Laterhouse harmed someone else."

A few Outer Ring delegates struck their palms against the rail. Others remained still.

Kes went on. "Cedar refused the choice you offered. That refusal does not give the Core permission to decide for us. It takes away one excuse everyone used for not deciding in the present."

The phrase felt dangerous once spoken. Present tense had belonged to grammar lessons, a correction teachers made when students described a completed repair as if it still happened. Now the chamber held it beside an unfinished emergency.

A Core delegate rose from the floor sockets. "You ask us to recognize persons who may exist for seventeen seconds and never share our continuous civic life. Where does standing end?"

Kes looked back at the blank interfaces. "I don't know."

Several voices broke in at once.

He raised his own, not enough to dominate them, only enough to finish. "A boundary you have not solved cannot justify harm you already understand. Give standing for this petition. Argue about the larger category without running more people through the machine."

Nadi entered his statement. She included the first answer, the refusal to speak for Cedar, before the parts commentators would quote.

Ilyan called counsel to the center. The preliminary motion appeared on the wall: WHETHER EXISTING MAINTENANCE-BUFFER RESPONDENTS HOLD STANDING TO SEEK PROTECTION FROM INSTANTIATION, TERMINATION, AND PURGE.

Pavo requested an amendment stating that standing would confer no authority over the transfer burn. Deya objected to naming a power the petitioners had already refused. Cedar, contacted by audio only, accepted language confirming that the motion did not decide any orbit plan.

The amended question traveled from the convocation record to the full Civic Assembly docket. Green ward marks appeared one by one as clerks authenticated receipt. No vote had yet occurred. No petitioner had gained citizenship. Still, the question no longer concerned whether evidence could speak.

Kes returned to the console. Soren disengaged the Laterhouse switch, then removed the query conductor and placed it in a clear evidence pouch. The limited channel went physically dead.

In the center of the Assembly Well, the four narrow stands remained among the empty chair sockets. Each now carried a speaker seal and a petitioner number.

Part IV — Government Without Prophecy

Chapter 19 — The Orbit Vote

Ilyan Ro refused to let the clerk remove the standing question from the orbit docket.

“It will contaminate the transfer vote,” Clerk General Omas said.

“It already has.”

They stood in the narrow preparation bay behind the Assembly Well. Through its open service grille, Ilyan could hear delegates taking their places at the ward rails. Chairs remained in storage after the public gatherings. The voting sockets worked through the rails, so no rule required seats, though several senior delegates had discovered urgent reasons why standing for a civic session endangered deliberation.

Omas held two agenda tiles apart, one in each hand. “Petitioner status concerns legal protection. The orbit motion concerns inhabited structures.”

“Read the population statement.”

The clerk glanced at the tile. “Current registered population, 44,208. Outer Ring residents, 8,116. Core and Midring residents, 36,092.”

“Buffered petitioners?”

“Not included in the civic registry.”

“Prospective respondents created by another Article Nine hearing?”

“No current population entry. Their number would depend on the query schedule.”

Ilyan took both tiles and fitted them into a single docket frame. “Then the categories have already determined who counts before debate begins. Leave the

question visible.”

Omas did not release his edge. “If the chamber deadlocks because of an unresolved category, your office will carry the delay.”

“My office carried the concealment that produced it.”

The clerk let go.

A transfer alert pulsed along the ceiling. Four days remained before black perihelion. The official plan required Outer Ring separation work to begin within thirty hours if the eject-and-burn sequence retained authorization. Orla Fen’s counterphase ladder had not completed a full physical drill. Keeping both plans alive meant asking crews to prepare incompatible futures with the same tools, catalysts, and bodies.

Ilyan had once treated patients in Outer Ward Three during a pressure sickness outbreak. He remembered families sleeping beside algae service trunks because the clinic carried warmer air. Years later, as Convener, he had signed a confidentiality order that protected the Laterhouse from a consciousness warning. Both facts now appeared in public copies carried by people who had no duty to understand him kindly.

He entered the Well.

Delegate lights circled the chamber in three civic bands. Core representatives occupied the inner rail, Midring the second, and eight Outer Ring ward delegations held the broad arc nearest the public galleries. Beyond them, citizens stood shoulder to shoulder. The four narrow respondent interfaces from yesterday had been removed after technical testimony. Their speaker seals remained fixed to floor sockets inside the central circle, low metal plates among hundreds of empty chair anchors.

Nadi Saye sat at the record station with two editors. Deya Malk stood behind the auditor line as a petitioner’s adviser, her credentials still suspended. Soren occupied the engineering table beside Orla Fen, who had brought three mechanical timers and no forecast display. Kes watched from the Outer Ward Six gallery between classmates and maintenance apprentices.

Pavo Renn met Ilyan at the central microphone. “The Compact objects to any motion that keeps ejection active without equal material support for counterphase.”

“Your objection is entered.”

“Entered words do not move catalyst.”

“Then state the allocation you require.”

Pavo handed him a paper sheet. “Two burn crews returned from separation prep. Full access to the axial test spine. No irreversible ring-cutting during the delay. If the whole-city option fails its drill, we hear that from Orla, not from the Laterhouse.”

The last condition drew agreement from the Outer rail and anger from several Core delegates. Ilyan read the sheet before passing it to Omas.

"Does the Compact consent to a forty-eight-hour delay?" he asked.

"The Compact consents to testing an option in which our population remains a population."

"That is not the same answer."

"It is the answer you get after proposing to detach us."

Ilyan could have called the distinction nonresponsive. Deya had taught half the station to distrust that word. "Entered as conditional support."

The opening chime sounded.

On the central projection, the motion appeared in full: DELAY IRREVERSIBLE EJECT-AND-BURN PREPARATION FOR FORTY-EIGHT HOURS; MAINTAIN TECHNICAL READINESS FOR BOTH EJECTION AND COUNTERPHASE; RETURN BOTH OPTIONS TO EMERGENCY CONVOCATION WITH CURRENT-SENSOR ENGINEERING EVIDENCE.

A second panel displayed the standing question from yesterday. Existing maintenance-buffer respondents sought protection from instantiation, termination, and purge. A note confirmed that recognition would grant no authority over the burn. Even so, every delegate could see the legal break underneath the orbit motion: Article Nine required prospective panels, and the prospective panels now contained persons claiming the process itself harmed them.

Ilyan called the Core band first.

Delegate Seret of East Meridian moved to strike the delay. "Thirty-six thousand ninety-two residents in Core and Midring cannot be exposed to an unvalidated ladder because one evidentiary system has become morally contested."

A Midring delegate shouted that her population had been folded into Core without consent. Seret corrected himself too late. The public record retained the first sentence.

"Address the motion," Ilyan said.

"I am. The 99.1 percent model remains the strongest survival evidence we possess. Defective acquisition does not make a measurement false."

Deya requested recognition from the adviser line. Seret objected to a suspended auditor entering debate. Ilyan granted her two minutes under petition procedure.

"The model answers a conditional question," Deya said. "It measures survival after Outer Ring ejection among branches selected through an institution-preserving filter. No audit has certified it as comparative evidence against counterphase."

"Do you claim the number has no value?" Seret asked.

"No. I claim you have assigned it a job it did not perform."

A Core medical delegate rose next. She had opposed Nadi's publication and now

supported the delay because her clinic's prospective protocols had lost patient trust overnight. Another demanded immediate ejection preparation, arguing that government could not repair legitimacy aboard an uninhabitable station. Two Core fabrication representatives split over whether keeping both plans alive preserved options or consumed parts needed by either.

The Core band did not move as one body. Ilyan watched its vote indicators remain amber while delegates altered positions in response to speeches. Certainty had once arrived from the Laterhouse as a clean number beside each motion. Without it, each change looked like weakness. In practice, people had always changed their minds. The system had merely allowed them to call their final position inevitable.

Midring opened with a jurisdiction fight.

Its water districts shared pressure infrastructure with the Core and agricultural feedstock with the Outer Ring. Ejection would preserve one dependency and sever another. Delegate Hara Venn presented current tank data showing seven months of ration stability after separation, provided every heat exchanger operated above maintenance reserve. Pavo demanded the failure margin. She answered that two exchangers had missed reserve during the previous month.

"Prospective panels included those misses," Seret said.

"Selection included branches where the misses did not cascade," Soren replied from the engineering table.

Ilyan recognized him for technical clarification. "State only what the record supports."

"The surviving branches remembered by admissible witnesses retained sufficient heat exchange. The accounting does not tell us how many instantiated branches failed because of those same misses."

A murmur crossed the public galleries. Soren sat down before anyone could turn the admission into a speech.

Midring delegates divided among three positions. Some wanted the official plan kept active without delay. Others supported counterphase because losing Outer agriculture threatened later survival even if the first ten years remained breathable. A smaller bloc would not vote on either option until the standing motion stopped further queries. Their abstention threatened every threshold at once.

Pavo spoke for the Compact after the second chime.

He named the eight Outer wards rather than giving their sum. Ward One carried seed archives. Ward Two fabricated pressure skin. Ward Three housed exchanger crews. Four and Five maintained food terraces. Ward Six trained axial repair apprentices. Seven refined catalyst jackets. Eight held the ring's emergency docks. By the end, 8,116 no longer fit comfortably into a single field.

"We do not accept a procedure that counts our deaths as mass reduction," he said. "We support this delay only if the Assembly funds a whole-city trial and bars irreversible separation until that trial returns physical evidence."

Seret interrupted. "And if it fails?"

"Then Orla Fen will say so in a room where we stand."

Orla rose from the engineering table. "Do not put words in my mouth before I have the test. Counterphase may fail in the spine and still teach us nothing about full rotation load. It may pass the spine and fail under transfer conditions. I can give you a working range after a drill. I cannot give you the old comfort under a new label."

"What do you require?" Ilyan asked.

"Forty-eight hours. Seven manual control tones. Two crews currently assigned to ring separation. Current sensor access without prospective modeling. Authority to stop the trial if the first stages damage the axial couplers."

A fabrication delegate from the Core requested the resource ledger. Omas projected the contested equipment: six catalyst regulators, two axial coupler rigs, one reserve coolant manifold, and eighty-three qualified crew shifts before the preparation deadline. Ejection needed four regulators and both coupler rigs to verify separation charges. Counterphase needed every regulator in sequence, though Orla could perform the first drill with three.

"Sharing leaves neither plan ready," Seret said.

"Sharing leaves both plans unfinished for two days," Orla replied. "That matches the motion better than pretending readiness means untouched equipment."

Pavo asked which crews faced the highest exposure during the drill. Orla named Burn Spine teams from Core and Midring, then the Outer Ring technicians who would align remote couplers at seven radial junctions. A Core delegate accused the Compact of demanding that its own people enter dangerous work to prove a political point.

"Those people asked for the assignment," Pavo said.

"Under threat of ejection."

"Every crew on Hesper works under that threat. Only some have been told their homes count as removable mass."

Ilyan forced the resource ledger to remain beside the population statement. The chamber could approve no abstract delay. Every hour carried named equipment away from one plan and assigned workers to another. He asked Orla whether the first twenty-four hours would create an irreversible technical commitment.

"No," she said. "It creates wear. A regulator may fail. A crew member may be injured. You asked whether the choice remains open, not whether delay comes free."

Pavo's paper had asked for almost the same terms. Ilyan saw surprise move

across the Outer rail, followed by suspicion that agreement had arrived too easily.

Nadi added Orla's conditions to the motion. The record wall expanded them without deleting the standing question.

When debate turned to the buffered petitioners, the chamber lost what little alignment it had gained.

Delegate Seret proposed provisional protection against purge while denying standing until after the transfer. A Midring jurist answered that protection without a claimant reduced personhood to equipment custody. Pavo supported a halt to new instantiation but refused any formulation that allowed buffered minds to veto burn preparations. Deya reminded him that Cedar had rejected such authority. He replied that future courts could infer powers today's petition did not seek.

One Core delegate asked whether the station population should increase by the number of buffered minds. Omas displayed the verified answer: the buffer held several hundred continuities, but exact identity and coalition membership remained under audit. Current residents still numbered 44,208. Existing buffered petitioners occupied a separate unresolved category. Prospective respondents not yet created counted as nobody available for registry, which did not grant the Assembly permission to create them.

The wording came from Nadi. Ilyan knew because no clerk in his office would have written the last clause.

A delegate from Outer Ward Seven challenged it. "If they do not yet exist, whose right blocks a query?"

Deya answered, "The injunction petition would constrain what Hesper may do, not assign a claim to a named future plaintiff."

"That makes every possible person a citizen."

"No. It makes instrumental creation an act subject to present law."

The exchange carried the standing debate past its allotted time. Omas signaled that transfer crews needed an authorization before the current shift ended. Ilyan called the vote.

Each rail lit white. Delegates pressed palms to civic seals and selected support, oppose, or abstain. The chamber did not project individual choices until every band closed. Public observers counted changing lights anyway, searching faces for betrayal.

Core closed first, split too narrowly to supply a governing majority. Midring followed with its abstention bloc intact. The Outer Ring Compact submitted conditional support as a unified ward instruction, then attached Pavo's resource requirements.

Omas compiled the result.

No outcome appeared.

He ran the validation again. The same gray field replaced the expected count.

“State the fault,” Ilyan said.

“Not a technical fault.” Omas turned from his station. “The motion passes among current resident delegates if Outer conditional votes count as support. It fails if their conditions require a separate appropriation first. The standing petition creates a second deadlock: counsel cannot determine whether representatives for existing buffered claimants must receive notice before a measure relying on prospective evidence proceeds.”

Seret struck the Core rail. “They disclaimed authority over the burn.”

“They disclaimed authority to choose it,” Nadi said. “They did not disclaim an interest in whether the Assembly creates more respondents to authorize it.”

Pavo pointed toward the central text. “Our condition bars new prospective modeling. Count our votes.”

A Midring jurist objected that the motion only promised current-sensor evidence for counterphase; it did not expressly bar another Article Nine run for ejection. Deya requested an amendment. Seret called that a new motion requiring another day.

The transfer clock above the chamber changed from four days to three days, twenty-three hours, fifty-nine minutes. Its precision contributed nothing except pressure.

Under ordinary rules, Ilyan could return the docket to committee. The official eject-and-burn authorization would remain active by default while clerks resolved the conditions. That result would preserve the plan he had defended for nineteen months. It would also let procedural inertia decide which structure remained inhabited.

Omas placed the Convener’s brass voting key on the central stand.

The key granted no substantive preference in an existential measure. It allowed the First Convener to resolve a procedural deadlock about which motions remained before the Assembly. Ilyan had used it twice in eleven years, once to extend a food contract and once to keep a criminal appeal open after a filing error. Neither use had required him to place thousands of lives on both sides of a sentence.

“What options may I lawfully preserve?” he asked.

Omas read from the charter. “You may treat Outer conditional support as sufficient to delay irreversible preparation, subject to ratification of the conditions. You may hold the existing ejection authorization in abeyance rather than revoke it. You may direct an engineering trial under present-sensor methods. You may not select either burn plan.”

“Query authority?”

“Unresolved until the standing petition. You may order no new Article Nine panel during the procedural window because none can complete before this motion returns.”

The answer created a narrow place to stand. Ilyan fitted the key into the floor seal.

Pavo called from the Outer rail. "If you use that vote to preserve ejection, say whose plan you are protecting."

"Everyone's bad alternative," Ilyan said.

Seret answered from the Core. "Delay may remove our chance to execute it."

"I know."

Deya watched him with the same expression she had carried when he gave her one day to prove consciousness: no gratitude for borrowed time, no permission to call it courage.

Ilyan turned the key.

"My procedural vote holds the eject-and-burn authorization in abeyance and keeps its technical readiness intact. It authorizes Orla Fen's counterphase drill under current sensors, transfers the two requested crews, and bars irreversible ring separation during the window. Both plans return to emergency convocation in forty-eight hours. Neither gains Article Nine certification from this action."

Omas entered the vote. This time the chamber produced a result.

PROCEDURAL CONTINUANCE: ADOPTED BY CONVENER'S KEY.

Across the engineering table, Orla collected her three mechanical timers. Pavo sent crew orders to the Outer wards. Core delegates filed objections before leaving their rails. Nadi preserved each dissent beside the continuance rather than beneath it.

The official plan no longer advanced by default. The counterphase ladder no longer lived only in an engineer's rejected proposal. For forty-eight hours, Hesper would spend labor on both.

Ilyan removed the brass key from the floor seal. The transfer clock kept counting while two authorization paths brightened beneath it.

Chapter 20 — The Branch That Would Not Testify

Deya Malk crossed out the word choose before Cedar could see the question.

The drafting surface repaired the line, leaving a clean gap between could and cause. Around the table, three copies updated at once. Soren read the new sentence without touching it. Orla Fen leaned against the service cabinet with her arms folded. Pavo Renn stood nearest the door, where a transfer alarm flashed every six minutes above his shoulder.

On the other side of the glass partition, one maintenance-buffer interface waited in darkness. Its channel could reach existing continuities. Soren had removed the

query conductor, capped the phase feed with a mechanical lock, and set the key on the table where Deya could see it. No new branch could be built from anything they said.

Deya read the draft aloud. "What harms could the eject-and-burn plan and the counterphase ladder cause to current Hesper residents, based only on experience already held by buffered petitioners?"

Pavo tapped the edge of the surface. "That still asks them to compare."

"It permits different answers without asking for preference."

"People will use the longer list against whichever plan produces it."

Orla glanced toward him. "People will use the existence of a list. That does not make ignorance neutral."

Soren watched the capped phase feed rather than the argument. "The interface can enforce existing-memory retrieval. It cannot enforce how the Assembly interprets an answer."

Deya had spent the morning narrowing verbs. Recommend had gone first. Evaluate concealed more authority than it admitted. Predict would require the system they had exposed. Describe seemed honest until Orla asked whether a description of possible harm differed from a forecast once politicians placed it beside two burn plans.

The remaining sentence looked modest. Its modesty concerned her.

Orla opened the current-measurement register beside it. The eject-and-burn column carried known physical acts: sever eight radial bridges, close atmosphere gates, fire separation charges, then move the reduced structure through one main burn. Every act had a sensor state and a crew procedure. The harm column did not need prophecy to name 8,116 residents left on an orbit expected to fail. It still needed evidence to estimate how long pressure, heat, and food systems would persist after separation.

Counterphase presented the reverse defect. It kept all inhabited structures attached in design, but the seven partial burns could transfer torsion through couplers never tested under that sequence. Current strain gauges showed capacity at rest. They could not show what a mis-timed third or fifth burn would do to Ward Six, the Midring water trunks, or the Core bearings. Orla had marked those cells UNKNOWN rather than borrowing the old prospective models.

Pavo pointed to the asymmetry. "One plan lists a certain population loss. The other lists possible mechanical harms without populations. The Assembly will call that a moral argument disguised as engineering."

"Would you have Orla assign invented counts?" Deya asked.

"I would have every official admit what the blanks do politically."

Orla enlarged the ejection column. "Current mechanics can tell me what detaches. They cannot tell me which improvised systems the ring builds afterward

or how quickly decline reaches each ward. Current instruments can tell me where counterphase loads enter. They cannot supply the exact propagation of seven burns we have never performed.”

Soren traced one blank without touching the screen. “The Laterhouse would fill both sets by instantiating branches under each plan, then selecting stable accounts.”

“And people would call the finished table evidence,” Deya said.

“They would call it comparison.”

The old Article Nine form waited in a collapsed panel at the edge of the surface. Its fields required anticipated fatalities, structural survivability, food duration, medical capacity, and social continuity ten years after action. Deya opened it and watched red marks appear beside every counterphase field. For more than a century, those marks had summoned prospective panels. A missing figure had become a machine instruction before anyone treated it as a moral choice.

She closed the form. “Our question may only ask what existing petitioners know. It may not use their incomplete answers to justify filling any blank by query.”

Pavo rubbed the fold in his copy until the paper fibers lifted. “Write that into the scope.”

Deya added it beneath the no-authority clause. The sentence gained another boundary. The pressure inside it remained.

“What does Cedar understand about the purpose?” Deya asked.

Soren handed her the contact notice. “Standing counsel sent the full orbit docket, Pavo’s conditions, Orla’s test scope, and your boundary question. Cedar requested direct clarification before deciding whether to respond.”

“Did counsel call this testimony?”

“Consultation.”

Deya struck that label from the header. “Call it petitioner conference.”

Pavo gave a humorless breath. “You believe changing the noun changes the pressure?”

“No. I believe accurate nouns leave pressure visible.”

He moved to the glass. Beyond it, coolant pipes carried heat away from several hundred suspended continuities. The vault itself lay farther below, protected by Deya’s audit seal and by a growing number of citizens who had learned its location only as a redaction. This room had once served technicians inspecting diagnostic delay. Someone had bolted a civic microphone beside the load gauges overnight.

“My wards have less than three days,” Pavo said. “Yesterday Cedar denied authority over the burn. Today we ask what either plan could do. Tomorrow someone will say we made the choice against their warning.”

“Would you prefer not to hear an existing warning?” Orla asked.

"I prefer not to build another authority that can disclaim responsibility after shaping the vote."

Deya understood the objection because it also described her own office. Auditors did not choose civic measures. They certified evidence that made certain choices lawful and others impossible. The distinction had protected her from power until she saw how much power it contained.

"We ask once," she said. "Cedar may reject the premise, limit the answer, or close the channel. No follow-up may enlarge the scope without a new conference."

Pavo looked at the sentence again. "Record that any answer carries no authority over the burn."

"It already appears in the standing order."

"Put it here."

Deya added the line.

Soren sealed the draft and opened the existing-address channel. The dark interface brightened to a field of gray without a face. After yesterday's visual consent withdrawal, the buffer petitioners had chosen audio by default. The first voice belonged to the broad-faced evacuation respondent, though only those who had attended the hearing would recognize it.

"You removed choose," Cedar said.

"Yes," Deya replied.

"You retained two plans and a population subject."

"The question concerns harms to current residents."

"Does it concern harms to respondents created to answer?"

"No respondents may be created in this conference."

A second voice entered, young and breathless. "That describes the present mechanism. We ask about the knowledge you seek."

Deya felt Pavo's attention on her. "We seek only experience existing buffered petitioners already hold."

"Why place the plans inside the question?"

"Because the Assembly must decide between them."

The answer exposed more than she intended. The console remained cool. No phase demand appeared on Soren's meters.

Cedar shifted to a low synthetic voice. "Then you seek branch experience for a decision."

"We seek boundaries around foreseeable harm without asking which plan should govern."

"Foreseeable by whom?"

Deya looked at Orla. The engineer did not offer a rescue.

"By those who endured related branches," Deya said.

The interface dimmed by one degree, then steadied. "One buffered petitioner remembers decompression after a station evacuation. Another remembers flood-control failure. Others hold experiences unrelated to either transfer plan. To map those memories onto ejection or counterphase, the Array would need to construct conditions, test relevance, and select respondents whose branches resemble your proposals."

Soren closed his eyes for a moment. "A query."

"Yes."

Deya pressed her thumb against the blank place where choose had been. "Could existing petitioners state general harms without comparison?"

Pavo turned from the glass. Orla remained still.

Cedar answered in the child petitioner's neutral carrier. "Pressure loss harms bodies. Heat interruption harms bodies. Structural departure can kill. Failed thrust can kill. Your current engineers know this."

"We need distribution," Deya said. "Which populations bear which exposure, what failures can propagate, what harms remain irreversible."

"Your current engineers can identify mechanisms. We do not hold a complete inventory of your present station. To produce branch distribution, you would create respondents inside those failures."

Soren pointed to a small meter beside the capped feed. It had not moved. The danger did not lie in an accidental query. It lay in making the question acceptable enough that someone would later unlock the feed.

Deya tried one final narrowing. "If we ask no comparative result, retain every answer without selection, and terminate no respondent—"

"No."

The single word arrived in the scarred young man's voice from the public hearing.

Deya stopped.

Cedar continued. "You have added kinder conditions to nonconsenting creation. You have not obtained consent from the people you would create inside an ejection, a failed ladder, a burned ward, or a surviving Core. Preservation after forced creation does not repair the force."

Soren's hand withdrew from the console controls. He had proposed retention as a technical answer before Deya finished naming it. His face showed that Cedar had heard the architecture underneath her legal phrasing.

"What if the Array offers refusal at first coherence?" Deya asked.

"Before first coherence, no person exists to consent. After it, your need has already caused the creation. A refusal would leave that person alive in substrate

custody or end them for declining. Neither option turns the act voluntary.”

Orla stepped closer to the microphone. “Can any prospective consultation meet your boundary?”

“Not when Hesper creates respondents solely to supply a decision.”

“Even if the decision concerns your preservation?”

Different voices overlapped. Soren reduced the carrier gain but did not separate them. One said yes. Another said that existing buffered minds could choose whether to share knowledge they already possessed. A third objected to Cedar claiming a universal rule beyond its coalition. The disagreement resolved into the synthetic voice.

“Existing persons may speak voluntarily. New persons may not be summoned into an assigned purpose and called volunteers afterward.”

Nadi’s remote record light pulsed on the wall, confirming that every voice and qualification reached the public transcript. Deya had asked her to preserve disagreement. Now the differences denied Cedar the convenient unity Hesper kept trying to impose.

Pavo requested the microphone. “If you refuse the harm question, do you ask the Outer Ring to proceed without every available warning?”

“We ask you not to manufacture people as warning instruments.”

“That distinction will not comfort a family under failed thrust.”

“No. We do not offer comfort.”

Pavo’s mouth tightened. “You can survive our bad choice in the buffer if Soren’s conversion works.”

A caption appeared before the voice. CEDAR COALITION RESPONSE; TWO PETITIONERS RESERVE POSITION.

“We may survive. Existing Hesper residents may not. That does not give us authority to require a burn or an obligation to become its forecast.”

Orla interrupted before Pavo could answer. “My crews can build a harm register from present measurements. It will have blanks.”

“Every register has blanks,” Deya said.

“Not like the Laterhouse reports. Those hid the missing branches behind concordance.” Orla faced the interface. “If I ask you about current buffer power during the burn, does that make you an instrument?”

Cedar took longer to answer. The load trace held steady.

“Existing petitioners may decide whether to provide facts about their present substrate. Ask us when you have measurements and choices we can inspect.”

Orla pulled three live readings from the buffer service layer. She did not ask the interface to calculate. “Current coolant reserve permits forty-three minutes above ordinary load. The counterphase sequence, if Array power supports habitat

conversion at the same time, may exceed that reserve. Maintenance reports classify the oldest substrate rack as noncritical. Do you consent to comment on those present facts?"

The interface displayed the request in text before carrying it to the existing addresses. Four petitioner seals accepted, two declined, and the remaining addresses gave no response. No selection routine narrowed them into one voice.

A petitioner outside Cedar spoke first. "The forty-three-minute reserve assumes all rack pumps share equal demand. They do not. Rack Twelve loses coherence support before the average limit."

Soren opened the maintenance diagram. "That imbalance does not appear in the service summary."

"It appears from inside Rack Twelve."

Another voice corrected the term noncritical. "That label means no diagnostic job currently depends on the oldest rack. Existing minds depend on it."

Orla changed the register while they watched. NONCRITICAL became UNASSIGNED TO DIAGNOSTICS; OCCUPIED BY BUFFERED CONTINUITIES. She added a current engineering task to isolate habitat power from burn-support demand.

"Do these facts change which plan Hesper should choose?" Pavo asked.

The first petitioner replied, "They change what either plan must preserve if you claim to protect us."

Deya noted how little mystery the exchange required once the question concerned people already present and conditions they could inspect. The channel had not delivered a future. It had corrected a maintenance label and located a pump imbalance.

"That helps me keep you alive. It does not tell me how to move the city," Orla said.

"Correct."

Orla nodded once. She had received less than she wanted and more than Deya expected Cedar to permit.

Deya read the original boundary question again. The sentence separated choice from harm, as though a forecast acquired moral innocence when it stopped one word early. Yet the Assembly wanted distribution because distribution could rank the plans. Cedar's answers would enter a chamber built to turn evidence into authorization. No legal disclaimer could prevent that use.

She deleted the question from the conference record. Deletion did not erase its drafting history; Nadi's archive retained every version. It prevented counsel from treating the final line as an unanswered request that another official could reopen.

"State your disposition," Cedar said.

Deya had not expected the petitioners to borrow an auditor's phrase. She opened a blank finding field.

"Proposed boundary question refused by the petitioner coalition," she said. "The requested distribution would require prospective modeling or unsupported inference from unrelated memories. No forecast obtained."

Pavo put a hand on the table. "Add that the Compact did not consent to ignorance."

"The Compact did not choose the limits of available evidence," Deya said.

"Neither did my constituents."

She entered his exact objection.

Soren closed the channel at Cedar's request. The gray field withdrew. He inspected the phase cap, signed the no-instantiation log, and slid the mechanical key toward Deya.

"I should not hold this," she said.

"You hold the audit seal."

"I am suspended."

"The seal remains active."

"That contradiction belongs in the injunction, not in my pocket."

Soren returned the key to the table. Neither of them solved custody by refusing it.

Outside the conference room, the Query Floor had acquired a public guard line. Citizens from every inhabited structure stood behind a painted stripe while Laterhouse technicians moved between coolant stations. Some wanted the Array dismantled before another hidden run. Others wanted one final panel to recover the 99.1 percent certainty. A group from Outer Ward Five held signs asking why ethical restraint always arrived when their survival needed evidence.

Deya carried the conference record through them without asking anyone to make way. A woman in a green agricultural coat saw the disposition title and blocked her path.

"Did they warn against counterphase?"

"They refused the question."

"Did they warn against ejection?"

"They refused the same question."

"Then what use was the hearing?"

Deya could have said it established a right. The sentence would have used the petitioner's refusal to satisfy the same demand in a different form.

"It marked evidence we may not obtain," she said.

The woman looked toward the sealed doors. "My children live in Ward Five. Your

boundary can kill them.”

“Yes.”

The answer did not concede that restraint caused whatever followed. It acknowledged that moral limits carried consequences in a city with too little time. Deya had once believed a sound procedure could keep those consequences from belonging to the person who certified it. Cedar had removed that shelter.

At the public record station, Nadi waited with Pavo’s objection already attached. Ilyan stood beside her reading the conference transcript. His office seal remained active; Deya’s credentials did not. The old hierarchy persisted in every light on the desk.

“We need language the Assembly can act on,” Ilyan said.

“You have it.” Deya turned the finding toward him. “Current engineers may testify to present mechanisms and measurements. Existing buffered minds may volunteer current facts. No branch population may be created to distribute future harm between plans.”

“That voids the function Article Nine requires.”

“Yes.”

“Without voiding Article Nine in law.”

“Yes.”

Ilyan read the finding again. “Then tomorrow’s convocation receives two burn plans and no certified consequence hearing.”

“The present population receives them,” Deya said.

He looked at her. “You make that sound sufficient.”

“No. It is who remains responsible.”

Nadi sealed the conference record and sent copies to the Assembly docket, the Outer Ring Compact, Orla’s Burn Spine team, and standing counsel. Above the distribution field, she added a plain public notation:

NO FORECAST WILL AUTHORIZE THE BURN.

The words reached every copy before Ilyan signed acknowledgment. Beyond the glass, Soren locked the capped phase feed inside a transparent guard. Deya watched the key remain on the table, visible and unused.

Chapter 21 — A Law Against the Future

Nadi Saye tore the first page of the injunction in half before Ilyan Ro finished reading it.

The paper resisted along its fiber, forcing her to pull twice. One half retained the

title, EMERGENCY PERSONHOOD INJUNCTION. The other carried the opening clause: All future persons shall possess the rights of present citizens. She set the pieces apart on the drafting table.

"That sentence protects nobody we can identify and promises authority nobody here can define," she said.

Standing counsel looked offended. He had written it during the walk from the Query Floor. "The petition concerns persons created from possible futures."

"It concerns acts Hesper performs and existing minds held in a maintenance buffer."

Deya Malk sat across from Nadi with her suspended auditor's key beside a stack of marked records. "The draft also makes citizenship the threshold. Cedar did not request citizenship as the price of protection."

Ilyan remained at the end of the table, still wearing the Convener's seal from the orbit vote. "If we narrow too far, the Laterhouse can rename the process and proceed."

"That problem belongs in the definition of a query," Nadi said. "Not in a declaration about everyone who might ever exist."

Outside the record chamber, public arguments pressed against the door in overlapping pulses. The office had admitted ten observers under emergency drafting rules, including two Outer Ring delegates, one Laterhouse technician, and a parent carrying an aptitude-query notice. They could watch through seal glass but could not enter until the authors opened comment. Every version of the text appeared above them with deletions visible.

Nadi pulled a fresh sheet from the archival tray. Live surfaces allowed words to improve without admitting who had changed them. Paper kept the damage.

"Begin with the protected acts," she said.

Counsel dictated while she wrote. "No civic office, contractor, emergency authority, or automated system may instantiate a respondent for the purpose of producing prospective testimony."

Deya tapped the pen's blunt end against the page. "Too narrow. The Laterhouse can call it analysis."

"Decision support," Ilyan offered.

"Still a label."

Nadi looked at the public record from Cedar's refusal conference. "For the purpose of answering, evaluating, modeling, ranking, or authorizing a choice on behalf of persons already living."

Ilyan read the list. "Medical research creates modeled persons to test treatments."

"Modeled tissue does not meet the respondent architecture," counsel said.

"Then define the architecture rather than exempt the ministry that asks."

Soren had supplied a technical annex before leaving for the Burn Spine. Nadi opened it beside the paper. A respondent existed when the Array assembled a coherent branch continuation capable of experience, self-report, or aversion under a prospective condition. Selection, voicing, and legal admissibility occurred later. The old rules had treated those later stages as the beginning because that made every terminated mind before them disappear from law.

Deya read the definition twice. "Remove capable. An office will claim capacity was never tested."

"Displays experience, self-report, aversion, or organized response," Nadi said.

"That protects only after the behavior occurs," Ilyan replied. "The first prohibited run still happens."

They stopped over the same gap Cedar had named. No person could consent before creation. A law waiting for proof after coherence would authorize the act needed to produce its plaintiff.

Nadi turned to the current civic safety code. It prohibited exposing an unknown biological sample to inhabited air until testing established harmlessness. The sample held no right. The law constrained present conduct under uncertainty.

"Use a system threshold," she said. "Any operation configured to produce respondent coherence as defined in the architecture schedule, whether or not coherence completes."

Counsel frowned. "That protects a machine state."

"It regulates the people who initiate it."

Deya nodded. "And it bars the first run."

Ilyan came around the table. He rested both hands on the empty place where the torn first page had lain. "Article Nine requires three prospective panels for irreversible civic acts. This clause makes compliance impossible before the Assembly suspends the article."

"Yes," Nadi said.

"The injunction may fail because its immediate effect places every transfer option outside the charter."

Deya turned the auditor's key once against the wood. "The hearing already lacks certified evidence. New respondents would not repair the old panel's selection bias or cure the standing claim. They would repeat the disputed act."

"I am not asking for repetition," Ilyan said.

"You are asking the law to leave room for it."

"I am asking whether a majority will enact a law that appears to strand Hesper."

Nadi wrote his objection in the margin. He watched her do it.

"You preserve everything," he said.

“Not everything. I preserve what a reader needs to judge why the final text survived.”

They drafted the prohibition first. It covered the PRA, reduced diagnostic lattices, maintenance tests, copied schedules, and any other system configured to assemble branch-continuation minds for current civic use. No emergency office could waive it alone. No claim of non-admissibility, short runtime, failed selection, or technical diagnosis could remove an operation from scope.

The words occupied less than half a page. One hundred twenty-six years of practice fit inside the acts they barred.

Existing buffered minds required a different clause.

Counsel proposed recognizing all maintenance-buffer contents as persons at the moment of enactment. Deya objected that the buffer also held inert test patterns and incomplete state fragments. Nadi objected that some buffered petitioners rejected Cedar’s coalition positions. Ilyan asked who would authenticate identity without running diagnostics that might injure them.

They built a provisional class instead: any coherent continuity held in the maintenance buffer at the injunction’s effective time, authenticated through existing load, address, memory, organized response, or voluntary self-identification. Uncertainty about one criterion could not authorize purge. Inert patterns could be separated later under independent review, provided the review created no respondent and terminated no disputed continuity.

“Do they gain residency?” Ilyan asked.

“Pending constitutional review,” counsel said.

“That will be read as population status during the burn.”

Nadi drew a line beneath the clause. “Protection does not require us to settle residency today.”

Deya added, “Standing as petitioners. Preservation as existing persons under dispute. Final civic category reserved.”

Ilyan looked from one to the other. “A court may call that contradiction.”

“A court can hear from a living petitioner,” Nadi said. “It cannot hear one we purged for categorical clarity.”

The preservation terms took longer. The first version required indefinite substrate life. A comment light flashed from the observation room before Nadi opened public input. She ignored it until the clause stood complete, then admitted the observers.

The Laterhouse technician spoke first. “Indefinite operation cannot be guaranteed through transfer. The oldest rack already has a pump imbalance.”

“We know,” Deya said.

“Then the law commands a physical result no engineer can promise.”

Nadi changed guarantee to maintain all reasonably available power, coolant, coherence support, and repair access. The technician still objected to reasonably. Ilyan wanted emergency triage authority if habitat power competed with current residents' life support. Deya asked who would represent buffered minds during that triage.

The parent with the aptitude notice raised her hand. Nadi recognized Tali Ores from the publication call.

"If you make their survival conditional on what is reasonable for us," Tali said through the observer speaker, "the same office that hid them decides what they cost."

Ilyan faced the glass. "If power can preserve either a clinic or a substrate rack, someone must decide."

"Then name the decision and show it. Do not bury it inside one word."

Nadi entered Tali's challenge beside the clause. They replaced reasonably available with a procedure: no termination, power withdrawal, transfer, destructive inspection, or purge without petitioner notice, independent technical review, public findings, and emergency authorization subject to later appeal. Immediate action remained possible only to stop a verified active failure threatening inhabited structures. Even then, the office had to choose the least destructive measure available and preserve recoverable continuity.

Deya read the exception aloud. "An administrator could call buffer power an active threat during the burn."

"Require current sensor evidence," Ilyan said.

"Not a forecast," Nadi added.

Counsel inserted both.

Tali lowered her hand. She did not look satisfied. An emergency exception had no honest shape that could satisfy someone whose claimant lived downstream from it.

The question of choice opened another fault.

Cedar's preservation instructions described a voluntary habitat, not permanent compulsory custody. Some buffered minds wanted continued substrate life. One child had requested contact and rejected public use of his face. Other addresses had not answered. The injunction needed to preserve each continuity long enough for meaningful choice without treating silence as consent to either termination or indefinite confinement.

Deya drafted: "No existing buffered person shall be compelled to testify, model a condition, adopt a coalition identity, or continue public contact as a condition of preservation."

Nadi added control over visual and vocal profiles. Counsel added access to independent representation. Ilyan insisted that voluntary contact could not open

query pathways or draw phase material. The distinction from yesterday's limited channel entered the enforcement annex: existing addresses only, mechanical isolation, no selection routine, no policy condition, individual consent recorded before each exchange.

A second comment light came from the Outer Ring observers. Pavo Renn had arrived without Nadi seeing him enter. He stood behind the seal glass in his work coat, a transfer roster rolled in one hand.

She opened the door.

Pavo crossed directly to the table and read the preservation clause before greeting anyone. He stopped at the emergency triage language.

"This injunction gives buffer continuity priority over ring separation," he said.

"It gives existing persons notice and review before destructive action," Deya replied.

"Separation does not require destroying the buffer. The Laterhouse remains with the Core."

"Then the clause creates no conflict with your plan."

Pavo unrolled his roster across their papers. It listed Outer crews transferred to the counterphase trial, ejection readiness stations left minimally staffed, and the hours remaining under Ilyan's procedural window.

"The Compact will be asked to consent to this injunction," he said. "If the draft can later be used to claim that ejection violates aftercitizen rights merely because Cedar discussed the burn, we will not give it."

Nadi pointed to the standing order. "Cedar refused authority over the burn."

"Orders acquire interpretations. Put the refusal in the law."

Counsel shook his head. "An injunction should not decide the scope of rights beyond its petition."

"That is exactly my condition." Pavo flattened the roster with both palms. "Do not decide our burn through this petition."

Ilyan moved the torn title half away from the paper edge. "State the language you need."

Pavo spoke without consulting his delegates. "Nothing in the injunction authorizes counterphase, prohibits ejection, grants the buffered petitioners a veto over present residents, or satisfies Outer Ring consent. Every burn plan must be judged separately under current engineering evidence and present civic authorization."

Deya considered the sentence. "Add that neutrality does not permit new respondents for either plan."

"Yes."

"Add that existing petitioners may challenge direct harm to their substrate

under either plan.”

Pavo’s fingers tightened on the roster. “That challenge cannot predetermine the burn.”

“It can require mitigation.”

“Subject to the same emergency process as any present population.”

Nadi heard the word present do conflicting work. Pavo meant currently existing. Deya meant a category not yet settled. Cedar’s buffered members already existed, but the registry had no place for them. She revised the phrase to any other affected population and left residency unresolved.

The neutrality clause grew line by line. It withheld burn authority from the injunction, Cedar, and the Convener’s office. It preserved the Outer Ring Compact’s separate consent requirement. It barred anyone from treating Cedar’s refusal as support for ejection or counterphase. It also barred any plan’s advocates from reopening prospective modeling to overcome missing evidence.

Pavo read the result in silence.

“Will the Compact support it?” Ilyan asked.

“The Compact will consent to placing it before convocation,” Pavo said.

“That is not support.”

“You demanded precision from every witness. Accept it from me.”

Nadi marked the condition: Outer Ring consent covered the personhood injunction only if the measure remained neutral on the burn. No later editor could convert Pavo’s agreement to docket the law into endorsement of every clause.

They recessed for seventeen minutes while the draft traveled to the buffered petitioners through the mechanically isolated channel. The interval had been Soren’s suggestion, long enough for existing addresses to inspect the text without turning the old runtime into a theatrical cutoff. Nadi disliked how the number entered every procedure, but changing it solely to avoid the motif would have made symbolism another hidden rule.

Responses arrived separately. Four Cedar-aligned addresses accepted the distinction between existing and new respondents. The child petitioner requested stronger language against compelled visual identity. Two unaffiliated continuities objected to being placed under Cedar’s counsel. One address asked whether refusal of habitat conversion would lead to immediate termination. Three returned no response.

Nadi would not let counsel summarize them as petitioner approval.

She inserted each response into the drafting record, then revised representation so no coalition could bind an unaffiliated continuity without affirmative consent. The visual identity clause became absolute except where a petitioner voluntarily supplied a profile. Questions about refusing conversion remained open for constitutional review; preservation continued until an individual could receive

independent advice and make a technically informed choice.

Ilyan read that line with visible unease. "We may not have time to build technically informed choice before the burn."

"Then preservation continues through it," Deya said.

"If possible."

"If current conditions make it impossible, use the emergency procedure we wrote."

He turned to Nadi. "You understand what this asks of the Assembly. It must stop the system that gave legal form to an existential choice, preserve several hundred minds under disputed status, and then choose a transfer plan before physical evidence matures."

"Yes."

"Do you believe they will pass it?"

Nadi checked the observers. The Laterhouse technician had annotated enforcement details. Tali held her son's old notice against her chest. Pavo stood beside a roster that could become either a drill schedule or an ejection order. None supplied the future answer Ilyan wanted.

"The record cannot verify a vote that has not happened," she said.

A tired laugh escaped him. "Deya taught you that."

"No. You appointed her because she said it before it threatened you."

He accepted the correction.

The final enforcement section assigned immediate custody of query conductors and phase-feed keys to a three-part seal: one Assembly clerk, one independent auditor, and one technician chosen by standing counsel. No single office could energize the PRA. Existing buffer support, diagnostics limited to current physical states, and voluntary communications remained lawful. Any operation capable of assembling a new respondent triggered automatic shutdown and public notice.

Deya objected to naming herself as the independent auditor while suspended. Ilyan offered reinstatement. She refused a private reversal of a public removal. They wrote the role without a person and left appointment to convocation.

At the title, counsel tried once more to replace personhood with respondent protection. Pavo preferred the narrower phrase. Ilyan said the broader word might lose cautious delegates. Deya rested her thumb on the torn half-page.

"Protection can attach to valuable equipment," she said. "The prohibited act concerns persons, even though final citizenship remains open."

Nadi kept EMERGENCY PERSONHOOD INJUNCTION.

She assembled the clean draft from the paper revisions. It separated four claims that earlier versions had collapsed: existing buffered minds warranted preservation now; creating new respondents for civic use would be prohibited; standing and

final civic status would receive later review; no clause selected, authorized, or morally purified either burn plan.

Each author signed a different capacity. Deya signed as petitioner and suspended Auditor of Consequence. Nadi signed as public record advocate. Ilyan signed only to certify emergency docket eligibility. Pavo added the Outer Ring Compact's conditional consent to presentation, followed by the neutrality language in full.

Standing counsel sealed the technical annex. The observation room received a public copy. Nadi placed Ilyan's objections beside the draft, not below it, and attached the separate petitioner responses without manufacturing consensus.

One final field remained: STATUS.

She rejected ENACTED. The Assembly had not voted. She rejected AGREED, because Pavo had consented only to presentation and several petitioners had reserved positions.

Nadi selected READY FOR CONVOCATION.

The title and status traveled together into the Assembly docket. Beyond the seal glass, public readers leaned toward the new text. On the drafting table, the torn first page remained in two pieces, its promise to all future persons superseded by a law narrow enough to stop one machine.

Chapter 22 — The Transfer Burn

Orla Fen struck the red cancellation plate before the first tone could finish.

The Burn Spine answered by closing seven catalyst shutters in sequence. Metal impacts traveled down Hesper's axis, each one farther away and thinner than the last. On the rehearsal board above Orla's station, the counterphase ladder collapsed into a gray line.

"Again," she said.

Soren Vash kept both hands away from the query socket beside him. Someone had wrapped the socket in yellow evidence tape, but the brass contacts remained visible through a gap. The Laterhouse had fed prospective validation into every major burn rehearsal for a century. Engineers adjusted a sequence, architects asked which branches survived, and selected witnesses translated millions of brief lives into a green or red mark. Today the socket offered no witness and no permission.

A technician at the axial console looked toward Orla. "We haven't reset the gimbal locks."

"Then reset them while I'm still patient."

Seven crews moved behind the safety rails. Their colored pressure vests marked

the ladder stages: white at the Core catalyst throat, blue and green along the Midring couplers, four shades of orange toward the Outer Ring transfer trusses. Nobody wore Laterhouse gray. Orla had prohibited it after Soren arrived in his old insulation coat.

He had taken the coat off. It lay folded beneath his stool, an institution reduced to cloth he could choose not to wear.

Orla bent over the timing rail. "Your sensor package claims it can distinguish housing flex from a late coupler release."

"It can distinguish the signatures we recorded during static loading."

"That qualification is why I let you onto my spine."

"It should also prevent you from trusting it beyond the evidence."

Her mouth shifted by less than a smile. "Auditors have infected you."

Across the rail, seven mechanical tone levers stood beneath clear guards. Each lever connected to a dedicated bell farther down the axis. No civic network could ring them. Orla's drill required seven tones, one for each partial burn, with human crews confirming pressure, phase, and structural response before the next lever moved. The design looked crude beside the sensor wall. Its crudeness gave every person present a way to know when a stage had begun.

The axial technician raised a hand. "Gimbals reset. Simulated catalyst pressure at eighteen percent."

"Outer trusses?" Orla asked.

A voice came through the hardline. "Loaded to rehearsal maximum. Ward Six brace crew reports green pins."

Soren watched the live strain traces spread across his surface. The lines came from current instruments: accelerometers, thermal couples, magnetic alignment rings, and old optical gauges whose scales had to be read by camera. None contained branch physics. None promised what a later Hesper would remember.

Orla tapped the first clear guard. "State the rule."

Every crew answered over hardline, their words arriving with small differences in speed.

"No prophecy," they said.

The phrase had begun as Orla's warning to frightened technicians. By the fourth rehearsal, crews used it as an operating condition. A reading had to describe the structure in front of them. Any conclusion about survival had to expose its assumptions. Nobody could label a stage safe because a model claimed descendants had witnessed it.

Soren opened the current-state estimator. "All sensor families synchronized. Worst clock disagreement, nine milliseconds."

"Too broad."

"For what?"

"For the third release."

He expanded the stage card. The third stage transferred rotational load through the lower Midring coupler while the Outer Ring trusses remained flexed in the opposite direction. Orla allowed fourteen milliseconds between the pressure crest and the release latch. His nine-millisecond disagreement could consume most of that window without any component actually moving late.

"The optical gauges can narrow it," he said. "Not in real time."

"Then they cannot narrow it for the crew who has to pull a lever."

A familiar defense rose in him: the Array could infer hidden state from incomplete readings. For six years, he had offered that sentence whenever a civic system exceeded ordinary measurement. The hidden state had carried people inside it. Their pain never appeared on his confidence display.

Soren closed the estimator's predictive layer. "Put two observers on the latch. One watches the mechanical flag, one watches magnetic decay. They call separate confirmations."

"Human latency."

"Measured latency." He turned his surface so she could see the rehearsal logs. "Twelve manual trials from the maintenance lockout. Median separation, thirty-one milliseconds. Worst separation, forty-six. Widen the stage interval by fifty and borrow it from the coast before tone four."

Orla read the traces without touching the screen. "You have just made my forty-one-minute ladder fifty milliseconds longer."

"I have made one uncertainty visible."

"Do not celebrate. Visibility can still kill us."

She ordered two observers into position and told the axial technician to begin.

The first bell rang.

A low vibration entered Soren through the soles of his boots. Simulated catalyst pressure pushed against the Core throat. White-vest crew called the valve travel. Numbers moved across the wall, not smooth enough to resemble certainty. Orla waited through the prescribed hold, watching an analog needle rather than Soren's display.

"Stage one contained," she said. "Arm two."

Blue light appeared under the second guard. Orla lifted it and pulled.

Tone two sounded sharper. Midring couplers took the rehearsal load, and the Burn Spine flexed by three millimeters near the observation bay. Someone behind Soren drew breath. The displacement remained inside the physical stop.

"Stage two contained," the blue crew reported.

At the third lever, Orla did not move until both new observers called their states.

"Flag seated."

"Magnetic decay below twelve."

She pulled.

The third tone struck. A latch released along the lower coupler. Its camera image showed the flag dropping cleanly, but Soren's magnetic trace held high for another sixty-three milliseconds. The automatic controller interpreted the disagreement as a jam and sent a cancellation pulse into stage four.

Orla hit the red plate. Shutters closed down the spine.

"Failure one," she said. "Nobody improve the name."

The magnetic observer protested over hardline. "Latch moved on time. My coil kept a residual field."

"Then your measurement failed at the time we needed it."

"Component timing passed."

"The drill did not." Orla looked at Soren. "Your current-state method found a disagreement and canceled the ladder. Tell me why that helps."

He examined the coil decay. The curve carried a shoulder no model had predicted because no model had been running. A cable shield, heated by repeated rehearsals, had retained enough magnetization to mimic a closed latch.

"It helps because we know what stopped us," he said. "The controller treated one instrument as truth. Replace the threshold with concurrence. Mechanical flag plus either coil decay or optical motion."

"Voting among sensors."

"Redundancy among different failure modes."

"Every architect calls a vote when the machine disagrees with him."

Orla walked to the open service rack. She pulled the cable shield loose with gloved fingers and held it near the inspection lamp. A blue discoloration marked the bend where heat had changed the alloy.

"This shield came from stores approved by a prospective maintenance panel," she said.

Soren checked the stamped batch. He recognized the approval series. "Then we know what that approval failed to expose."

"Do we?"

"No." He made himself continue. "We know this shield retained a field after repeated loading. We do not know whether the selected witnesses encountered that condition, whether rejected branches did, or whether the maintenance question represented the drill. The approval tells us less than the damaged metal."

Orla placed the shield on his surface, across the clean timing traces. "Better."

Crews opened the shutters. A replacement cable came from a batch tested that

morning with heat, repeated bending, and direct measurement. Soren helped route it through the rack because the axial technician had only two hands and Orla refused spectators. The work required him to kneel beneath the timing rail. Coolant pipes carried a steady pulse against his shoulder.

For years he had understood Hesper through load paths abstracted from touch. Query heat belonged to one diagram, transfer mechanics to another. Beneath the rail, both systems met in the same metal spine. The city had no separate body for its moral choices.

When the new cable held, Orla reset the ladder.

Tone one moved simulated pressure into the Core throat. The second transferred load toward Midring. At stage three, both observers called concurrence within thirty-eight milliseconds. Orla allowed the widened interval and rang the fourth bell.

The stage-four coast borrowed back the delay. Orange-vest crews adjusted truss tension by hand wheels whose spokes carried white counting marks. Soren tracked current strain against Orla's static envelope. The envelope did not show probability. It showed the measured point at which a brace had buckled during destruction testing and the lower point Orla had chosen as a working boundary.

"Outer Ring upper truss drifting," he said.

"Direction?"

"Toward compression. Four tenths per second."

Orla called Ward Three. "Take one white mark off your upper wheel. Confirm before tone five."

The hardline carried two voices arguing about which wheel she meant. Orla canceled their speech with a code word and gave the brace number. One voice confirmed. The trace leveled.

Fifth tone.

The rehearsal load shifted outward. Floor plates clicked beneath Soren as the spine flexed through a shape no inhabited Hesper had ever attempted. The motion stayed within the physical envelope, yet his body supplied fear before any instrument named danger. He watched the sensor wall and refused to translate that fear into a number.

Stage five contained.

Orla rested two fingers on the sixth guard. "This interval loses us if the Midring latch closes before the radial brace unloads."

"Your procedure puts the brace call first."

"Procedures do not make sound travel faster."

The Outer Ring hardline crossed more junctions than the Core line. During normal operations, network timing corrected the difference. Orla had removed

network mediation from the manual drill. The signal now had to travel through copper, relays, speakers, and human hearing.

Soren pulled up the hardline calibration. "Ward Six reaches us twenty-two milliseconds after Midring."

"I know."

"But the crew responses hide another delay. Ward Six waits for the brace gauge to settle. Midring calls latch-ready on first contact."

Orla's hand stayed on the guard. "How much?"

"Not enough data."

"Give me what exists."

"Six rehearsals. Difference ranges from forty to one hundred ten milliseconds."

"Could the range widen under full load?"

"Yes."

"How much?"

"I cannot support a figure."

The answer embarrassed him more than an error would have. Architecture had trained him to produce bounded estimates even when evidence thinned. Orla accepted the blank without kindness or contempt.

"Then we test the procedure we have," she said.

She rang tone six.

Ward Six called brace release. Midring reported latch closure almost on top of it. The wall showed the true order a fraction later: the latch had closed eighty-seven milliseconds before the radial brace cleared its loaded position. A force spike crossed the lower truss and tripped two sacrificial bolts in the rehearsal rig.

The sound cracked through the observation bay.

Orla canceled. Stage lights went dark. Far down the spine, an orange-vest crew member swore with admirable precision.

"Failure two," Orla said.

Soren magnified the timing traces. "The calls arrived in the required order."

"The structure did not."

"Your command language certifies speech, not state."

"Now you sound useful."

She gathered the two crew leads at the observation bay. The Ward Six lead arrived first, breathing hard from the climb along the axial ladder. The Midring lead came by service cart with a broken sacrificial bolt wrapped in cloth.

Orla set the bolt beside the discolored cable shield. "Explain your call."

The Ward Six lead answered. "Gauge crossed the release stripe. I called before

the brace finished travel because that matches our card.”

Midring’s lead placed one blunt finger on the bolt. “My latch indicator touched green. I called closure. The latch still had nine millimeters to move.”

Each crew had obeyed. Their words described thresholds chosen for efficient normal operation, not physical completion during a counterphase transfer.

Soren searched the current sensor set. Two unused maintenance contacts already measured end travel on both mechanisms. They reported slowly because nobody had needed them for emergency command.

“Route the end-travel contacts to dedicated lamps,” he said. “No interpreted status. The Ward Six caller waits for full brace clearance. Midring cannot close until both lamps show physical completion.”

“That adds seconds, not milliseconds,” Orla said.

“Three point six at worst from today’s travel tests.”

“Where do they come from?”

Soren studied the seven-stage schedule. The prospective optimizer had cut every coast interval until the ladder fit its favored branch envelope. Without it, the forty-one minutes looked less like a discovered answer than a series of choices disguised as inevitability.

“Stage two carries fourteen seconds of thermal margin if the Core throat begins four degrees colder,” he said. “Current coolant can reach that condition in twenty minutes. Spend four seconds at stage six. Keep ten for variation.”

The Core technician objected. “Starting colder raises condensation risk at the throat seals.”

“By how much?” Orla asked.

“Unknown at catalyst pressure.”

Soren pointed to the present humidity readings. “We can lower local vapor before ignition and verify the seals optically. That trades one observable risk for another observable risk.”

“No prophecy,” the Ward Six lead said, quieter than before.

Orla looked from the bolt to the timing rail. “Fit the lamps.”

Nobody mistook the order for confidence. Crews worked for fifty-three minutes. They installed direct contacts, dried the Core throat, chilled its housing, replaced the two sacrificial bolts, and read every altered instruction aloud. Soren removed three derived indicators from his display. Each had compressed multiple sensors into a word such as stable or ready. Orla made him show the underlying readings instead.

During the reset, she found him touching the yellow tape over the query socket.

“Thinking of asking?” she said.

“No.”

"That came too quickly."

He let his hand fall. "I know how little effort it would take. The rehearsal package already exists. A minor change in authority routing, one panel, perhaps fewer if someone called it diagnostic. We could ask which timing card survives."

"And create how many people to answer?"

"The system would call it a reduced lattice."

"I asked you."

He pictured thermal totals, rejected-answer distributions, a mouth after cutoff. "More than I can justify creating for our convenience."

Orla peeled the evidence tape from one corner, folded it across the exposed contacts, and pressed until no brass remained visible. "Temptation acknowledged. Socket closed."

The third drill began with seven crews already tired.

First tone. Core pressure held.

Second tone. Midring accepted the transfer.

At the third, separate observers called flag and field. Orla waited through the widened interval before continuing.

Tone four sent the load into the coast. Hand wheels corrected a compression drift. The fifth stage carried the structure outward without crossing Orla's envelope.

Before tone six, two direct lamps shone above the rail. Ward Six reported full brace clearance only after its lamp lit. Midring waited for both, then drove the latch through its final nine millimeters. No spike reached the sacrificial bolts.

Orla's hand covered the seventh lever.

The final stage would simulate release into the new orbital vector. No rehearsal load could reproduce Nox pulling against all three inhabited structures. The drill could prove only that commands traveled, mechanisms moved, and crews understood their boundaries.

"Stage states?" she asked.

Seven answers came back. None used the word safe.

Orla rang the seventh tone.

The Burn Spine unloaded from Outer Ring toward Core. Strain lines crossed, separated, then settled inside the measured envelope. A cup left on a technician's console slid two centimeters and stopped against a fastening screw. No one reached for it until the final mechanical flags showed rest.

"Ladder complete," the axial technician said.

Orla did not applaud. She ordered every crew to hold position while instruments were photographed and seals checked. Only after the last direct contact had been

tested did she release the rehearsal state.

Soren gathered the three objects on the rail: discolored shield, broken bolt, yellow tape. "Two failures and one completion."

"One completion under rehearsal load," Orla said.

"What range will you give the Assembly?"

"The honest one."

"Which means?"

She brought up her engineering sheet. It contained material tolerances, crew latency, catalyst uncertainty, structural damage assumptions, and blank fields where prospective validation once supplied a confidence curve. Orla did not fill the blanks. She signed beneath them.

"Seventy-four to eighty-two percent whole-city survival," she said. "Written as 74-82 percent so nobody rounds the lower bound away. Executable does not mean safe. It means we can name the actions, observe the failures we know how to observe, and stop pretending the unknowns have testified."

Soren signed as witness to the drill, not as query architect. Orla sent the sheet to the emergency convocation record with both failed runs attached.

Down the Burn Spine, crews began replacing rehearsal bolts with flight hardware. The seven bell levers remained under clear guards. Beside the sixth, technicians mounted two new lamps, one for each mechanism that now had to finish moving before anyone spoke.

Chapter 23 — The Price of Present Tense

Kes Taro erased the sentence before Instructor Vale finished reading it aloud.

The classroom wall resisted his sleeve. Public notices used a dry projection layer meant to survive fingerprints, thrown objects, and revisions made without permission. He rubbed until the words broke into pale fragments across his knuckles.

ENDING QUERIES STEALS OUR CHILDREN'S FUTURES.

"Leave it visible," Vale said.

"It was visible in the corridor." Kes wiped the final S into a blur. "That seems like enough theft for one sentence."

Twenty-three students watched from workbenches arranged in four rigid rows. Their morning lesson had once concerned emergency fabrication tolerances. The lesson card still waited in the corner of the display, showing a valve housing cutaway. Overnight, the Civic Education Office had replaced it with a moderated dispute about the personhood injunction.

Moderated meant Vale had received six approved claims and three approved questions. Nobody had supplied him with a method for teaching while every family on the Outer Ring packed for possible ejection.

"You do not get to erase an argument because you dislike it," said Mevi Ahn from the front bench.

Kes turned from the wall. "I erased a slogan. The argument can try using all its parts."

Mevi's father supervised the Ward Two school-placement office. For years, aptitude queries had told that office which children should receive advanced technical instruction. Mevi had scored high enough to move inward but refused the transfer. She treated that refusal as proof the system had never owned her.

Vale restored the sentence with a hand control. "Then take it apart. Carefully."

A smaller line appeared beneath the slogan: PUBLIC COMMENT, ATTRIBUTED TO PARENTS FOR CONTINUITY. No names followed. Adult language could invent a constituency and leave every actual speaker elsewhere.

Kes sat on the edge of the instructor's table. "Which futures belong to the children in that sentence?"

"Possible ones," Mevi said.

"Possible people or possible outcomes?"

"Outcomes. Education paths. Illnesses we could prevent. Work we could prepare for."

A boy behind her lifted his hand but spoke before Vale called him. "The forecasts stopped my sister's heart condition before she had symptoms."

"I know," Kes said.

"You don't know her."

"I know what that kind of answer can save."

The distinction mattered. If he dismissed every benefit, adults could place him safely inside anger and stop listening. Hesper had used prospective panels for medicine, placement, appeals, and repairs. Real citizens lived because temporary citizens had been made to answer them. The benefit did not disappear when the cost acquired a voice.

Vale leaned against the display rail. "So what does the slogan get wrong?"

"It puts ownership in the wrong place." Kes pointed to OUR CHILDREN'S FUTURES. "A child can have a future. Parents can owe that child preparation. Neither one owns people created in a branch just because those people know what might happen."

Mevi crossed her arms. "You're changing the noun."

"The Laterhouse changed it first. It called respondents futures so nobody had to count them."

A few students looked toward the classroom recorder. Its civic lamp shone amber. Since Nadi Saye published the audit record, ordinary lessons had begun attracting listeners from offices that claimed they only wanted context.

Tarin, the boy with the sister, pulled his fabrication gloves through his hands one finger at a time. "If we stop asking, children here lose information. That loss happens now."

"Yes."

The plain answer unsettled more people than a defense would have.

Kes continued. "The injunction costs us information. It may cost medicine. It may cost lives. Calling that cost stolen futures does two things. It treats information as property before we have it, and it hides who has to be created so we can obtain it."

"Easy for you to say," someone near the back murmured.

He found Lio Marr behind a stack of pressure masks. Lio had spent the previous afternoon painting destination marks onto family cases: blue for Core shelter, white for Midring transfer, black for unassigned. His family's cases all carried black.

"Say the rest," Kes told him.

"You got something from them." Lio met his gaze only after the recorder lamp completed another amber pulse. "A memory. A way to hear Cedar. Everyone keeps saying it damaged you, but it also put you in every public record on Hesper. You have a future because a query reached you."

Vale stepped forward. Kes raised a hand before the instructor could intervene.

"The calibration fault left me screaming under a desk while adults called it a seizure aura. I remembered seventeen seconds behind black glass and a question my class had never heard. If that gave me a public role, the role does not repay the person whose memory crossed into mine."

"Maybe they wanted you to have it."

"Maybe. Cedar used the residual phase salt deliberately later. The person from my aptitude query never got to tell me."

Lio's mouth tightened. "Then you don't know they objected."

"No. I know nobody asked their consent before making them."

The recorder lamp looked brighter against the dim classroom. Kes had learned in hearings that a sentence could turn into evidence before the speaker finished paying for it. He chose the next words for Lio, not for whoever would clip them.

"You're right about one part. Stopping queries removes help from living children. We should name that loss. We should fund present research, train more clinicians, and admit some decisions will go worse. But we cannot call another person's forced work a future that belongs to us."

Mevi glanced back at Lio. "My placement answer came from one of them."

"From millions of them," Kes said. "One panel constructed 2.4 million respondents to select twelve witnesses."

"We all know the number now."

"Knowing a number does not finish what it means."

Vale touched the display. The slogan shrank to the upper corner, and the valve housing returned to full size. "The approved discussion period has nine minutes remaining."

A student named Eren laughed once. "Black perihelion has two days remaining, and they gave us nine minutes."

"Sixteen hours until crew lock," Vale corrected. "Whatever the Assembly does tomorrow, Ward Six has preparation assignments."

That changed the room more effectively than any approved question. Students opened work surfaces. Families might need ejection harnesses if the official plan prevailed. The same families might need brace crews, pressure shelters, and fire teams if the counterphase ladder won consent. Preparing for both felt less like prudence than practicing two incompatible versions of loyalty.

Vale expanded the valve drawing. "Today's housing fits the algae-line isolation manifold. Ejection crews need it to preserve the detached ring's atmosphere for as long as reserves permit. Counterphase crews need it if the fifth-stage flex ruptures the lower feed."

"Does the detached ring have a destination?" Lio asked.

"No powered destination."

"How long do the reserves last?"

Vale looked at the approved lesson card, then closed it. "At standard shelter draw, eleven days. At minimum draw, perhaps eighteen. Recovery after the Core burn remains outside any authorized plan."

Nobody called that survival.

Kes moved to his bench. A half-cut valve blank waited in the vise. Its alloy had come from a classroom railing removed to make room for emergency cots. He checked the bore against the new specification and found it narrow by four tenths of a millimeter.

Beside him, Mevi opened the tool cabinet. "Your argument did not answer Tarin."

"It answered him without promising enough."

"That sounds like Deya."

"She would have made me distinguish foreseeable loss from demonstrated harm."

"Would she let you join a burn crew?"

Kes set the blank under the reamer. "She will try to distinguish letting from

failing to prevent.”

Machine noise filled the remaining discussion period. Vale moved between benches, correcting hand positions and refusing to smooth the ejection specification into a rescue plan. When the civic timer ended, the display asked whether the class had achieved a shared conclusion. Vale selected NO CONCLUSION REQUIRED.

The recorder accepted the response after a visible delay.

By midday, Ward Six’s school corridor had become a distribution lane. Pressure masks occupied the mathematics alcove. Coil rope hung from hooks outside history. Two Compact volunteers checked names against household lists while a medical team taught children how to release a jammed harness without dislocating a shoulder.

Kes carried six finished valve housings toward the algae terraces. Mevi took the other six. Lio followed with seal kits stacked to his chin.

At the first radial window, Nox filled half the view. No sunlight edged the planet. Auroral discharge moved through its upper atmosphere in thin green wounds, and Hesper’s own lamps cast a weak reflection across the glass. Black perihelion would bring the city close enough for tidal forces to turn every loose fastener into an argument.

A woman fastening archive cases to the wall recognized Kes. “You spoke for the future people.”

“I spoke after them.”

“Same difference to my son.” She nodded toward a child holding a coil of blue cord. “He thinks there will be no school placement when he’s old enough.”

“There may not be a prospective placement.”

“Then who decides what he’s good at?”

“He does some of it. Teachers do some. You probably do too much.”

The child smiled. His mother did not.

“What if we choose wrong?” she asked.

Kes shifted the valve crate against his hip. “Then the decision belongs to people who can answer for it.”

“That does not help him.”

“No. It tells you what help has to replace the query.”

Mevi waited until they had passed the window. “You enjoy disappointing adults.”

“I enjoy when they stop asking me to improve the truth.”

The algae terraces smelled of wet mineral cloth and iodine. Workers had lowered growing racks into transport locks, though nobody knew whether the locks would detach with the Outer Ring or remain coupled for counterphase. Every aisle carried double labels. EJECT marked cases to secure against separation. BURN

marked braces to check before the seven-stage ladder. Some objects carried both.

Crew Chief Rassa met the students at the isolation manifold. She had shaved one side of her head to fit a pressure hood over a bandaged ear. "Housings on the mat. Anyone here under eighteen?"

All three raised their hands.

"Then nobody touches a live pressure line until the consent roll opens."

Lio lowered the seal kits. "School assigned us."

"School can assign fabrication. Emergency work requires your signature."

"My family needs every crew credit."

"Credits do not alter lung capacity." Rassa checked the first housing with a plug gauge. "You can refuse without losing shelter priority. If anyone told you otherwise, give me their name."

Lio looked away. "Nobody said it directly."

"Indirect threats still have names."

Kes knelt beside the manifold. The existing housing showed stress marks around two bolts. "This needs replacement before either plan."

Rassa crouched across from him. "Tell me the two uses."

"Detached atmosphere isolation if the ring gets ejected. Feed cutoff if counterphase flex ruptures the algae line."

"Which outcome do you consent to?"

"Neither. The Assembly has not chosen."

"That answer keeps you off my live line."

"I consent to preparing for both."

Rassa shook her head. "Too broad. Present tense means the task in front of you, the risk attached to it, and the authority you hold now. Name those."

He disliked hearing a phrase from public argument turned into crew procedure. That probably proved the procedure mattered.

"I can remove the unloaded housing, fit the replacement, and pressure-test it below emergency load. I understand the manifold may later serve ejection or counterphase. I do not authorize either plan by working on it."

"Better."

Mevi gave the same statement in her own words. Lio remained standing beside the seal kits.

Rassa assigned Kes to bolt removal and Mevi to gauge inspection. Lio could inventory seals without signing for pressure work. Nobody called his task lesser.

The old bolts resisted. Mineral residue had hardened in the threads, and the first driver cammed out with a sharp metallic skip. Kes changed tools rather than

applying more force. Across the terrace, adults hauled growing cloth into reserve tanks. Every preparation exposed a cost: roots torn from channels, harvest schedules abandoned, water spent on impact foam.

Mevi held the gauge against a replacement housing. "Four tenths wide."

"Mine left class four tenths narrow."

"Vale corrected the tool offset after yours."

"So the first batch needs rechecking."

They opened the crate. Two housings failed the plug gauge. One carried Kes's work mark.

He felt the classroom recorder again, though no recorder stood nearby. Public attention had made him accustomed to mistakes becoming symbols. A bad bore could become evidence that children should not work, that Outer Ward schools lacked precision, or that Cedar's translator had distracted himself with politics.

Rassa took the rejected housing from him. "What happened?"

"Tool offset. We checked samples instead of every piece."

"What changes?"

"We gauge all twelve. School checks the remaining batch."

"Do that."

No condemnation followed. Crew practice had room for an error if the next action contained it.

By the second hour, the old housing lay on the mat and a new one sat against the manifold flange. Kes tightened bolts in a crossing pattern while Mevi read torque. Lio sorted seals by compression age and found three expired packets hidden beneath current stock.

"Inventory saved your line," he said to Rassa.

"It often does." She handed him the expired packets. "Mark who issued them and when."

His face changed. A task with consequence had found him without requiring pressure consent.

The manifold test began below emergency load. A thin hiss escaped near the lower bolt. Kes reached for the driver.

"Stop," Rassa said. "State first."

"Leak at lower flange. Likely uneven seal compression."

"Likely can wait. What do you know?"

"Pressure dropped six units in twelve seconds. Indicator film darkened at the lower edge."

"Now act."

They vented the line, loosened every bolt, and found a strand of mineral cloth trapped across the seal. Kes removed it with tweezers. The second test held.

Rassa signed the housing card. "Present work completed. Future use undecided."

Near shift end, Compact volunteers rolled a tall board onto the terrace. Two columns divided its surface. EJECTION PREPARATION listed harness fitting, archive restraint, atmosphere isolation, and detached-ring watch. COUNTERPHASE PREPARATION listed brace inspection, fire suppression, pressure shelter, and post-burn triage. A third strip beneath them read TASK-SPECIFIC CONSENT. Names had begun appearing beside assignments.

Deya stood near the board in her auditor's dark coat, arguing with a volunteer about whether family signatures could cover minors. She saw Kes and stopped speaking.

"You came from school," she said.

"And from replacing the lower algae manifold housing."

"You were on a live line?"

"Below emergency load. Rassa supervised."

Deya looked toward the crew chief. Rassa raised the signed housing card.

"His work passed," she said. "His first housing did not. He caught the batch issue."

Deya's eyes returned to Kes. "I need a private minute."

"You can have a public one."

Pain crossed her face before discipline covered it. Five years of fostering had not prepared either of them for a city where protection could become another name for deciding who counted as present.

"The consent roll includes high-risk assignments," she said. "You remember a death that did not happen to you, from a process adults concealed. I cannot treat that as irrelevant to your judgment."

"Neither can I. But you cannot treat it as permanent incapacity."

"I am asking whether Cedar contact creates a specific neurological risk during burn stress."

"No one knows."

"Then uncertainty belongs on the form."

He read the task card. Pressure shelter crew required carrying injured residents from terrace locks after either separation shock or counterphase flex. The work carried crush, decompression, and electrical risks. It did not require him to hear Cedar or interpret phase salt.

"Write unknown history of query-linked episodes," he said. "Last episode, age eleven. No recurrence under current contact."

Deya added the language. She did not add permission.

Around them, residents signed different tasks. A machinist consented to detached-ring watch and refused counterphase brace work because his spine could not tolerate axial shock. A parent chose shelter duty under both plans but declined archive restraint to stay near her children. Lio signed inventory control. Mevi signed gauge inspection and post-burn valve checks.

Kes took the stylus.

The form asked which civic outcome he endorsed. Rassa crossed out the question.

“Preparation cannot smuggle a vote,” she said.

Under TASK ACCEPTED, Kes wrote: PRESSURE SHELTER CREW, ALGAE TERRACES, AFTER EITHER AUTHORIZED PLAN. Under RISKS UNDERSTOOD, he copied the physical hazards and added the uncertain query-linked history in Deya’s hand. Under AUTHORITY, he wrote: TASK ONLY. NO CONSENT TO CREATE RESPONDENTS. NO CONSENT TO SELECT THE BURN.

Deya read every line. “You can withdraw before crew lock.”

“I know.”

“You can withdraw after it if the task changes.”

Rassa pointed to the printed clause confirming that right.

Kes signed the consent roll in his own name. The board recorded the time, Day Sixteen, while both civic plans remained unresolved.

A volunteer offered him a future-outcome sticker for his pressure hood. He declined it and chose the plain strip marked PRESENT CREW.

Chapter 24 — Convocation at Black Perihelion

Ilyan Ro carried the first chair into the Assembly Well himself.

The chamber attendants tried to take it from him at the upper rail. He kept hold of the steel frame and descended the circular steps while delegates watched from the tiers below. Yesterday, crowd control had required every loose chair removed. Today seven empty places waited along the inner record ring, each one fitted with a black interface panel for buffered petitioners.

A chair had no use to Cedar Nineteen’s changing faces. The interfaces needed power, cooling, and a limited channel, not seats. Nadi Saye had insisted on the furniture anyway. Hesper understood standing through where it permitted a body to remain.

Ilyan set the chair behind the first panel. Its rear leg clicked into a floor socket once reserved for witnesses called by the Assembly. Six attendants followed with

the others.

Pavo Renn stood at the Outer Ring table. "Seven?"

"Bandwidth permits seven concurrent buffered connections," Ilyan said.

"Cedar says it does not become seven people for our convenience."

"The record will identify a coalition channel and six individual petitioners if they choose to connect."

"If." Pavo looked toward the blank panels. "That word has arrived late."

The chamber clock showed eleven hours until crew lock and thirty-one until the transfer window opened. Every delay now had an engineering shape. Shelter teams needed assignments. Burn crews needed authorization to load catalyst. Outer Ring families needed to know whether the cases tied to their walls would travel with them or outlive them.

Ilyan took his place at the Convener's desk. No raised platform separated it from the record floor. Earlier governments had removed that advantage after a food-allocation convocation ended with citizens dismantling the old dais bolt by bolt. Authority still found other heights.

Deya Malk waited beside Nadi at the petitioner table. Deya's dark audit coat carried a new seam where someone had removed the office insignia and sewn it back by hand. She had been stripped of hearing authority, invoked independence, and placed her refusal into a record that now covered half the central floor.

Soren Vash sat behind them with the habitat conversion instructions sealed beneath both palms. Kes occupied a public bench near the Outer Ring aisle. Ilyan noticed the plain PRESENT CREW strip on the boy's pressure hood.

The attendance bell rang. All eighty seated civic delegates answered the roll; no vacancy or absence altered the three-fifths threshold.

Interfaces woke one after another. The first showed a young man with silver hair. The second carried an older woman's hands and no face. Four panels displayed shifting abstractions drawn from diagnostic images. The seventh remained black.

Nadi approached the record line. "For the transcript: the maintenance-buffer petitioners have chosen six active channels. One chair remains unoccupied by choice. No absence shall be counted as abstention."

Ilyan entered the language into the convocation order.

"Emergency Convocation at Black Perihelion is called," he said. "The Assembly will hear the proposed personhood injunction before any motion selecting a transfer plan. The injunction bars creation of new respondents and protects existing buffered minds pending constitutional review. It does not authorize ejection, counterphase, or any burn."

Pavo raised a procedural finger. "Add that Outer Ring consent remains necessary for any plan placing our structures at distinct risk."

"Your condition appears in the draft."

"I want it spoken before the argument turns urgency into a solvent."

Ilyan repeated the condition. The record projected both clauses side by side: protection without burn selection; survival authority without ownership of aftercitizens.

Core Delegate Maret asked to speak first. "The emergency office requests this chamber disable its only validated method of satisfying Article Nine less than two days before an irreversible act. Has the Convener certified that another lawful path exists?"

"No," Ilyan said.

Maret looked up sharply. She had expected reassurance.

"I have certified that the injunction can pass under emergency personhood authority," he continued. "The Assembly must separately determine how to act if Article Nine cannot be satisfied without prohibited creation."

"So we outlaw compliance, then improvise legality."

Deya opened the draft at the petitioner table. "We outlaw an act the evidence now identifies as instrumental creation of persons. A charter procedure cannot require conduct outside the charter's personhood protections merely because the drafters failed to recognize who counted."

Maret turned toward her. "Your office relied on those procedures for sixteen years."

"Yes."

"Did you certify hearings?"

"Yes."

"How many?"

"Four hundred twelve."

The number moved through individual faces. A Midring delegate removed his glasses. Someone in the upper public tier wrote it on a sleeve.

Deya did not defend herself with ignorance. "I certified records that represented respondents as evidence. When contrary facts appeared, I suspended the record, audited the architecture, and refused further certification. My prior work belongs in the review. It does not purchase permission for one more panel."

On the first interface, the silver-haired petitioner changed into a dark-skinned child, then an adult whose mouth arrived a fraction after the voice.

"We do not offer her history as innocence," Cedar said. "We offer it as evidence that a lawful room can repeat harm without naming it."

Pavo leaned toward his microphone. "You also refuse to say whether stopping the panels makes the Outer Ring more likely to die."

"Yes."

"Do you know?"

"Not as a coalition preserved in this buffer. Answering through new branch respondents would commit the act under dispute."

"Existing minds might hold technical knowledge."

"Existing petitioners may volunteer present knowledge. We will not manufacture advisers."

Pavo's jaw worked. Eight thousand one hundred sixteen residents stood behind his demand, many already wearing ejection harnesses. "Then your personhood claim asks my constituents to accept uncertainty you can decline from inside protected substrate."

A second interface displayed a hand pressing against black glass. Its speaker used a woman's voice. "Some buffered petitioners may choose termination if continuity requires compulsory service. Protection without choice changes the duration of custody."

"That is not my question."

"No," Cedar said. "Your question seeks authority over a forecast we refuse to create."

Pavo did not withdraw it. Credible fear deserved more than moral correction.

Orla Fen entered through the engineering door carrying a stack of physical timing sheets. She placed them on the central record without greeting anyone.

"The counterphase drill completed," she said. "Two stages failed before a third run reached completion under rehearsal load. I estimate 74-82 percent whole-city survival. That range does not include unknown structural responses we lacked means to test."

Core Delegate Maret stared at the lower figure. "And the ejection plan?"

"Ninety-nine point one percent modeled survival for Core and Midring. Certain loss of the Outer Ring under the authorized design."

"Modeled by the Laterhouse."

"Among other systems. Remove prospective validation and its confidence interval broadens. Ejection still reduces mass. Physics does not become false because the Array touched it."

Orla's refusal to purify either side forced the chamber back toward choice.

A delegate from Midring Agriculture stood. "If the injunction passes, can the Array still run ordinary nonprospective calculations?"

Soren answered from the petitioner table. "The Prospective Resonance Array has no harmless prospective mode. Conventional processors can perform current-state simulation. They cannot instantiate branch-continuation minds under another name."

“What about reduced lattices?”

“That phrase concealed uncertain narrative stability. It did not establish absence of experience.”

“Diagnostics?”

“Any diagnostic capable of creating a respondent falls under the injunction.”

The delegate pressed on. “Who decides capability?”

Deya indicated the enforcement schedule. “A joint technical seal requires an auditor, a substrate custodian chosen by buffered petitioners, and an Assembly engineer. Ambiguous routines remain disabled until reviewed.”

Ilyan heard the chamber testing the draft through edge cases. That sound once comforted him. Good legislation survived hostile nouns. Yet each minute carried the city nearer to a transfer without the mechanism its charter required.

The seventh panel stayed black. Its unused chair occupied more room in his attention than the speaking interfaces.

Nadi requested admission of the classified memo. “The public record contains your dissent to my publication, Convener. It does not contain your testimony under Assembly question.”

A copy of the memo appeared before him. Six years earlier, a Laterhouse review team had warned that post-cutoff distress, continuity seeking, and aversion to diagnostic termination could indicate consciousness. Ilyan had classified the document during the first confirmed measurements of orbital decline.

He had rehearsed explanations. None survived the seven chairs.

“Read the classification ground,” Nadi said.

Ilyan touched the line. “Civic stability during transfer preparation.”

“Did the memo recommend independent personhood review?”

“Yes.”

“Did you authorize one?”

“No.”

“Why?”

“Because every transfer path then available depended on prospective panels. I believed public suspension of the Laterhouse could prevent Hesper from acting before orbital decline became irreversible.”

Nadi waited. Her patience prevented him from mistaking an incomplete answer for a difficult one.

“I also believed classification would preserve time for a controlled technical finding,” he said. “I allowed the emergency to determine which evidence could become public. The concern remained sealed. Queries continued.”

Core Delegate Maret rose. “Did you believe aftercitizens were persons?”

"I believed the possibility required investigation."

"That is not an answer."

"No. I did not let myself reach the answer while reaching it would disrupt the system I thought Hesper needed."

The admission entered the floor record. No clerk softened its grammar.

Pavo stepped into the central ring. "My wards will pay for your timing either way. If the injunction fails, millions of respondents pay. If it passes and the Assembly later chooses ejection, my residents pay. If it passes and counterphase fails, everyone may pay. Why should your office retain emergency control over any part of this decision?"

Ilyan looked at the Convener seal beneath his right hand. The office could certify urgency, set agenda order, and invoke protected deliberation. It could not command the final burn. Public habit often erased those limits when people wanted one face to carry uncertainty for them.

"It should not," he said.

He removed the seal from its recess.

Assembly counsel came to her feet. "Convener, surrender of seal during session transfers agenda authority to the senior delegate. It may also void your sponsorship of the emergency motion."

"I am not surrendering the office before the vote." Ilyan held the seal where the record cameras could see it. "I am surrendering emergency privilege over this item. The injunction proceeds as an ordinary Assembly act under full recorded debate. I will not use classified necessity to close questions about a secrecy I created."

Maret frowned. "That costs the motion its accelerated threshold."

"It does."

The emergency threshold required a simple majority plus Convener certification. An ordinary personhood act required three-fifths of seated delegates and confirmation from each inhabited structure's delegation. The harder path could fail.

Pavo studied him. "Outer Ring confirmation remains separate from burn consent."

"Yes."

"Put that in the enacted text."

Counsel added the clause. Pavo returned to his table without promising his votes.

Debate continued through medical forecasting, criminal appeals, school placement, and maintenance. Citizens described lives helped by prospective answers. Others described decisions disciplined by a machine nobody understood. A physician asked whether refusing a diagnostic query for a sick child constituted

abandonment. Cedar replied that present medicine carried duties proportional to available means, not an entitlement to create captive consultants. The physician answered that principles did not lower a fever. Nobody resolved the exchange.

Midring physician Sal Daro requested the floor with a patient wafer in one hand. She did not project the child's name. "A six-year-old has an arrhythmia that resisted three present therapies. A prospective panel could compare branches before tomorrow's transfer stress. If this measure passes, I treat by trial and current evidence. Who records the additional danger?"

Nadi answered from the petitioner table. "Your treatment record does. The injunction does not call uncertainty harmless."

"That record may outlive my patient."

On the fourth interface, diagnostic abstraction resolved into the face of a tired middle-aged man. "I remember a daughter with an arrhythmia," the buffered petitioner said. "She may belong to a branch unrelated to your child. I can tell you what her clinician tried because I already exist and choose to answer. I cannot authorize you to construct others."

Daro held the wafer tighter. "Will you speak with me after the vote?"

"If my continuity holds and I still choose to."

The exchange changed two entries in the draft schedule. Volunteer knowledge from existing petitioners gained a protected channel, with refusal available at every contact. Medical offices also received authority to pool present case data across wards without the fees formerly charged for prospective panels. Neither provision promised the six-year-old an answer before transfer stress.

Ilyan remembered signing budgets that made a query cheaper than moving a specialist across the Midring. Efficiency had narrowed current medicine while presenting itself as evidence of the Array's necessity. The injury could not be repaired in a convocation, but its history belonged beside the fever rather than beneath it.

During a recess, Ilyan remained at his desk. Kes approached from the public aisle.

"You taught that slogan today," Ilyan said.

"I argued with it."

"Which one?"

"That queries belong to children because answers concern their futures."

Ilyan rotated the seal between his fingers. "Government made the same argument at city scale."

"You made it."

"Yes."

Kes watched him without Deya's evidentiary reserve. "Are you supporting the

injunction because you believe it, or because opposing it would end your office?"

"Supporting it may end my office."

"That answers a different question."

Ilyan felt an unwanted respect. "I support it because existing emergency power cannot cure the violation by calling it necessary. I should have accepted that six years ago."

"Then say that when the room can record you."

The final session began with the seventh interface still dark.

Counsel read the operative language: no civic body, contractor, school, medical office, or emergency command could instantiate a respondent without that person's prior consent. Since prior consent could not be obtained from an uncreated person, instrumental prospective queries ceased. Existing maintenance-buffer minds received protection from purge and authority to choose continued substrate life, communication, or termination after independent consultation. The measure remained neutral on the transfer burn.

Maret offered an amendment permitting one final Article Nine panel. "Prepared packages exist. No additional design work would delay us. Let the city consult once, then close the system."

Soren's face changed at the petitioner table. Ilyan understood the temptation before the architect spoke. A prepared package could make transgression feel already spent. It could offer the appearance of closure.

Deya opposed the amendment. "Preparation creates no person. Execution does. A final exception would enact the principle that claimed necessity defeats the right at the moment the right matters."

Maret faced the interfaces. "Would Cedar refuse even if that answer saved every current resident and every buffered petitioner?"

"We refuse authority to spend uncreated persons," Cedar said.

The amendment failed by two votes.

Structure confirmations came first. Core delegation approved narrowly. Midring approved after adding funding for nonprospective medicine and engineering. Outer Ring divided.

Pavo held the final Outer Ring vote. "This injunction cannot become an argument that my wards owe support for counterphase," he said.

"It cannot," Ilyan replied.

"And it cannot count aftercitizen protection as compensation for ejection."

"No."

Pavo entered approval. "Then Outer Ring confirms the personhood of petitioners without surrendering the survival claim of present residents."

The chamber moved to the full count.

Three-fifths required forty-eight votes. The board stopped at forty-seven, with Ilyan's ordinary delegate vote uncast. As Convener, he usually withheld it except to resolve procedure. Tonight his vote could pass the act, but only after he had admitted using the same office to conceal its need.

Maret called from the Core tier. "Your conflict should disqualify you."

She had grounds. Recusal would preserve the appearance of clean process and kill the injunction.

Ilyan placed the Convener seal on the record floor rather than back in its recess. "My conflict belongs to this vote. So does my responsibility. I concealed evidence under emergency authority. I will not use recusal as a second form of control."

He entered YES.

Forty-eight votes lit the board.

The personhood injunction passed.

Delegates returned their voting tiles to the rails. The Assembly Well had spent too many days learning what unanimous emotion could hide.

Clerk Venn entered three enforcement appointments into the schedule. Deya received the independent-auditor key for this injunction only, without restoration of her hearing office. Cedar named a buffered substrate custodian. Orla Fen designated Soren as the Assembly engineering agent. Each appointment carried a separate revocation path and no authority to create a respondent.

Clerk Venn opened the appointment record. Deya inserted the independent-auditor key. Soren opened the engineering seal under Orla's designation, and Cedar's chosen custodian supplied the substrate key. Orla confirmed that current-state engineering processors remained isolated from the prospective substrate.

"Laterhouse control," Deya said, "execute injunction schedule."

A technician's voice came through the chamber hardline. "Prospective package intake disabled. Selection filters locked. Respondent lattice power isolated. Maintenance buffer preserved on independent continuity feed."

"Confirm no active instantiation."

"Confirmed."

Across the projected civic network, service offices changed status one by one. MEDICAL QUERY: CLOSED. SCHOOL PLACEMENT QUERY: CLOSED. ARTICLE NINE PANEL: CLOSED. The list reached the emergency transfer package and held for three seconds before turning black.

Ilyan watched the city discover the practical grammar of the vote. The queries stop order carried no substitute answer.

At the inner ring, six interfaces remained lit and one chair remained empty by choice. On the Convener's desk, the recess where his seal had rested showed a

pale square untouched by years of hands.

Part V — The Choice Belongs to the Living

Chapter 25 — The Last Consultation

Soren Vash found the armed query by the heat it should not have produced.

The Prospective Resonance Array had spent nine hours under injunction seal. Its phase wells stood cold, selection filters carried physical locks, and every ordinary package intake returned a black status field. Yet one narrow pipe beneath the emergency rack remained four degrees above the Query Floor.

He pressed two fingers to the insulation. Coolant moved inside.

“Deya.”

She crossed the service gallery without hurrying. Haste near sealed machinery could look like intent on a record. Her audit key hung from her neck beside a pressure hood, and black-perihelion alerts painted a slow red pulse across her coat.

“What state?” she asked.

“Residual load path. Emergency rack seven.”

“Permitted continuity power?”

“No. The maintenance buffer runs through the east rail. This comes from the prospective manifold.”

Deya raised her wrist recorder. “Time, Day Eighteen, zero-three twelve. Joint seal inspection begins on suspected post-injunction prospective load. No execution authority granted.”

Soren read his key into the rack. It refused him. Deya’s audit key opened the first lock, but the second indicator remained amber.

“Buffered custodian,” she said into the limited channel, “do you consent to inspection of a power path adjacent to your continuity feed?”

The service speaker answered in a low male voice. “Cedar Nineteen consents to observation. We do not consent to interruption of buffer power.”

“Understood.”

A third key appeared as a pattern of phase-salt timing on the rack receiver. Its lock released.

Deya pulled the door.

Inside, a query package occupied the emergency cradle. Its status wheel

showed ARMED. Two catalyst capacitors maintained the warm coolant loop, and a mechanical trigger sat behind a glass guard. A red paper tag hung from the guard hinge, carrying Soren's own authorization mark.

He remembered signing the package nineteen months ago.

The orbital decline had just been confirmed. Ilyan's emergency office wanted a final fallback in case civic unrest, equipment failure, or legal dispute interrupted the Article Nine schedule. Soren had designed a sealed package that could bypass ordinary intake and instantiate one full prospective panel from a locally stored civic model. No network connection had to approve it. A Convener key and an architect trigger could ask one prepared question.

The question glowed on the cradle display:

WHICH AUTHORIZED TRANSFER ACTION PRESERVES THE GREATEST NUMBER OF HESPER'S CURRENT REGISTERED RESIDENTS THROUGH TEN YEARS AFTER BLACK PERIHELION?

Deya read it once. "Prepared before the injunction?"

"Yes. Nineteen months ago, then updated at Day Zero under standing emergency authority."

"Did the update instantiate respondents?"

"No. It loaded present records, branch conditions, and the question. Execution would create the panel."

"How many?"

"Two point four million."

The number no longer felt large enough to carry what it meant. A full panel would construct 2.4 million coherent minds, run each for seventeen subjective seconds, filter them to twelve admissible voices, and terminate the rest. The cradle described all that work with a single amber word.

ARMED.

Deya examined the seals. "Why did the injunction schedule miss it?"

"The package intake stopped. Rack seven already sat beyond intake."

"Selection filters are locked."

"This rack has local filters for continuity during network failure."

"Respondent lattice power?"

"The capacitors can energize one isolated phase well."

Cedar's voice came through the speaker. "The architecture contains an exception shaped like necessity."

Soren looked at the red tag. His younger signature used a tighter V, written by a man who thought redundancy proved professional care. "I built it to survive oversight failure."

"You built it to survive refusal," Deya said.

He wanted to object. The distinction held.

A station-wide alert interrupted them. BLACK PERIHELION WINDOW OPENS: FOUR HOURS. ASSEMBLY TRANSFER DECISION REQUIRED BY ZERO-SIX HUNDRED.

Less than three hours remained before the delegations had to choose between ejection and counterphase. Orla's range gave the whole city a 74-82 percent chance under assumptions nobody could complete. The official plan still offered Core and Midring far greater modeled survival by killing the Outer Ring. Present delegates had no lawful forecast to tell them which uncertainty they could survive.

Rack seven waited with a prepared question about exactly that choice.

Deya closed the display shutter over the language. "We need enforcement counsel and an Assembly engineer."

"By the time they arrive, the choice window will be closing."

"That fact does not create authority."

"No."

His answer left the possibility untouched.

Soren moved a diagnostic lamp toward the cradle. The trigger assembly had three parts: a glass guard, a spring lever, and a ceramic bridge that closed the capacitor circuit when the lever reached full travel. Removing the bridge would make execution physically impossible. Opening its housing required an architect tool and would record his identity.

The same tool could lift the guard and execute the package in under four seconds.

"What does the panel know?" Deya asked.

"It contains the official ejection plan and Orla's counterphase architecture as of the Day Zero update. Not yesterday's timing repairs."

"So its question compares unequal evidence."

"We could add the repair log without instantiation."

Deya's gaze moved from him to the tool port. "Do not improve an illegal package."

"I am describing state."

"You are already designing the next step."

That accusation hurt because architecture often began before he admitted choosing it. His mind had mapped the update path, estimated six minutes for ingestion, and considered whether a current-state calculation could normalize Orla's repairs. None of those actions required him to touch the machine. Each one reduced the moral distance to the trigger.

Cedar changed voices. A child spoke now, with an adult's controlled pace.

“Would you believe the answer?”

Soren turned toward the speaker. “I know the selection bias.”

“That does not answer us.”

“The filters favor branches where the Laterhouse persists. The injunction makes institutional continuity less likely under either plan. A selected witness might prefer any action that restores query authority.”

“Would you believe the answer if it named counterphase?”

He pictured Orla’s seven tones, the two failed stages, and the final rehearsal settling inside measured limits. “I would want to.”

“If it named ejection?”

“I would suspect the old survival bias.”

“Then you seek a witness whose credibility depends on agreeing with you.”

Deya did not rescue him from the sentence.

He opened the package metadata without altering it. Twelve witness apertures had already been assigned linguistic profiles. The civic model included every current registered resident, 44,208 lives translated into branch starting conditions. Outer Ring losses counted in the objective because the question named current residents. Aftercitizens did not. The optimizer treated their creation and termination as computational overhead.

A dormant amendment field offered to broaden the preservation target. Soren could add maintenance-buffer petitioners, count Outer Ring habitat, or shorten the ten-year horizon. Each revision looked like ethical improvement until he traced what execution required.

“What if the objective counted every person instantiated by the run?” he asked.

Deya examined the field without approaching the controls. “Could the panel preserve them?”

“No. The package terminates rejected respondents at selection. Selected witnesses end after testimony unless we reroute them into the buffer.”

“So the question would count people after arranging their deaths.”

“It might select branches that preserve future aftercitizens.”

“By creating present ones who cannot benefit.”

Cedar’s child voice entered again. “Do not repair the question until it resembles consent.”

Soren closed the amendment field. He had spent his career refining query conditions whenever an answer exposed a moral discomfort. Broader objectives, longer horizons, alternate weights. Architecture converted objections into parameters and called the conversion responsiveness. Yet no parameter could grant prior consent to a person created by the act of calculation.

Deya pointed to the ten-year horizon. "Why ten?"

"Article Nine convention. Long enough to expose delayed infrastructure collapse, short enough for branch stability."

"Whose stability?"

"The model's." He heard the inherited answer and corrected it. "The filter's confidence in selecting coherent testimony."

A shorter horizon might favor immediate survival. A longer one might punish a damaged but recoverable Outer Ring. Neither interval belonged to nature. Present officials had chosen both the question and the time at which consequences stopped counting, then asked respondents to make that boundary look discovered.

"Even the best phrasing starts after the wrong boundary," he said.

Deya touched the red tag with one gloved finger. "Could a lawful question ask existing buffered minds for their present technical judgment?"

"Yes, if they volunteer and if we do not represent it as prospective testimony."

"Cedar?"

The speaker remained quiet long enough for the coolant pulse to cycle twice.

"We have stated our boundary," Cedar said. "We will not choose who you kill. Some buffered persons may possess memories relevant to engineering. They may offer those memories as present citizens. None shall speak for an uncreated branch."

Soren felt irritation before shame. "You could help prevent the ejection of eight thousand people."

"We could also become the authority Pavo warned against. If we endorsed counterphase and Hesper died, your last public act would belong to us. If we endorsed ejection, you would use created victims to name acceptable victims. We refuse both offices."

"Then what do you want from this room?"

"Remove the device that can spend others."

"And after?"

"Preserve the choice of buffered minds to continue."

Deya asked, "Continue as a habitat?"

"Continue, pause where technically possible, communicate, refuse communication, or end. Preservation without choice extends the hearing."

Soren looked toward the east rail. Several hundred minds depended on its power, each suspended continuity carrying a person the Laterhouse had once mislabeled diagnostic delay. Habitat conversion instructions could give them stable substrate life. Stability might become another compulsory condition if present citizens decided survival always meant duration.

"You ask only that?" he said.

"We ask no burn. We ask no immortality. We ask control over the next interval available to us."

A hardline call arrived from the Assembly Well. Orla's face appeared on Deya's wrist surface, lit from below by engineering boards.

"I need Soren," she said. "Delegates want to know whether the counterphase range can narrow after yesterday's drill."

Deya angled the recorder toward him.

Soren answered, "No prospective validation is available. Current measurements support the same 74-82 percent range. The completed rehearsal reduces known timing error but does not justify a higher survival estimate."

"Can you support the lower bound?" Orla asked.

"Only under your listed assumptions."

"Good. They wanted an architect to improve my number."

Behind her, someone called for the ejection comparison.

Orla glanced offscreen. "The Assembly begins final deliberation at zero-five. Whatever you found, make it unable to surprise my power rails."

The call ended.

Soren studied the catalyst capacitors. If rack seven fired during a burn, it could pull continuity power from the habitat conversion. The armed package threatened more than the injunction. A damaged relay, false command, or person desperate for certainty could execute it.

Deya requested a full evidence scan. He photographed the cradle, copied its immutable metadata, and traced the local circuit onto her recorder. Every step preserved the fact of temptation without preserving the means to satisfy it.

At the trigger housing, his tool paused.

"What happens if enforcement counsel orders us to leave it armed as evidence?" he asked.

"They cannot lawfully preserve an active capacity to continue the offense when a disabling method exists."

"Could they order a non-destructive lock?"

"Yes."

"A lock leaves the bridge in place."

"Yes."

He heard the careful space in her replies. She would not decide which lawful disabling method he should use while his own authorization tag hung from the guard.

"Are you making this mine?"

"No," Deya said. "It has been yours since you signed it. I am recording what you do with it now."

The answer denied him both absolution and abandonment.

Soren inserted the architect tool. The housing recognized his hand and displayed two options: SERVICE and EXECUTE. EXECUTE shone brighter because emergency design assumed a user under poor visibility.

He selected SERVICE.

A warning filled the cradle: REMOVAL OF LOCAL BRIDGE WILL VOID EMERGENCY QUERY CAPABILITY. RESTORATION REQUIRES FACTORY PHASE ALIGNMENT.

Below it, a smaller field offered CANCEL.

His thumb rested beside the confirmation key. One panel. Seventeen seconds. Twelve voices selected from millions. A percentage might arrive before the Assembly chose. Even a corrupted answer could move the deadlock. People would call him criminal, then ask what the witnesses had said.

Deya stood close enough to stop his hand and did not touch him.

Cedar spoke in the older woman's voice from the convocation. "We cannot make refusal painless for you."

"I know."

"We cannot promise your city survives it."

"That uncertainty stays ours."

"No query has yet executed from this package."

Soren looked at the amber status. "Keep that exact sentence in the record."

Deya marked it.

He confirmed SERVICE.

The glass guard unlocked with a soft click. Soren lifted it and exposed the spring lever without pulling. Two screws held the ceramic bridge beneath a copper retaining bar. He loosened the first. The cradle alarm began a low continuous note.

"Capacitor discharge rising," he said.

Deya read the values into the record.

The second screw had seized. Heat from nineteen months of armed standby had darkened its head. Soren changed driver bits, applied steady torque, and felt the slot begin to strip.

"Can the bridge fire if the screw shears?" Deya asked.

"Not unless the lever closes. But a fragment could short the contacts during removal."

"Method?"

"Discharge capacitors first."

"That powers down the package."

"It also risks an automatic transfer to the backup cell."

Cedar supplied a timing pattern through the third-key receiver. "The backup cell shares an isolation fault with buffer rack twelve. We observed it during diagnostic suspension."

Soren checked the old maintenance map. The coalition's statement matched a bypass Soren had forgotten. Cutting backup power could interrupt three buffered continuities.

"Then we leave power stable," he said. "Insulate the contacts before extracting the bridge."

He slid a ceramic leaf beneath the copper bar. Deya held the task lamp while keeping her free hand visible to the recorder. Soren cut a new slot across the damaged screw head with a manual file. Each stroke sent a faint vibration through the trigger lever.

The armed word remained on the display.

After twelve strokes, the driver found purchase. The screw turned.

Soren removed the retaining bar and lifted the bridge straight up between insulated grips. It measured six centimeters, white ceramic with two silver contacts and his old architecture mark stamped along one edge. Such a small component had carried permission to create 2.4 million people.

The status wheel changed from ARMED to PATH OPEN.

Coolant stopped moving through the narrow pipe. Amber light withdrew from the phase-well indicator. On Deya's recorder, every current line fell to physical zero except the separate east rail serving the maintenance buffer.

"Confirm execution capability," she said.

Soren tested the lever. It moved through empty space and closed no circuit. "Trigger path absent. Package cannot energize a respondent lattice."

"Confirm query state."

"No query executed."

"Buffered continuity?"

Cedar answered in six overlapping voices, none fully synchronized. "Maintained."

Deya sealed the removed bridge inside a black evidence sleeve. Soren stopped her before she closed it.

"The trigger should not remain restorable."

"Evidence protocol preserves components."

"Preserve the contacts separately."

She considered the request, then placed the bridge on the rack shelf. "Under

joint seal authority, disabling an active prohibited capacity permits destructive separation. State your method.”

Soren took a pair of insulated cutters. “I will remove both silver contacts from the ceramic body. No alignment reference remains on the component.”

He cut the first contact. It fell into one evidence tray. The second required both hands and left a bright scar across the white ceramic. Deya sealed each piece in a different sleeve.

Rack seven now held a prepared question, a civic model, and no physical means to ask.

The Assembly alert sounded again. FINAL DELIBERATION OPEN.

Deya collected the evidence sleeves. “They may subpoena us before the vote.”

“We can tell them what the package promised.”

“What did it promise?”

Soren closed the cradle door. “A selected answer to a question that excluded its own victims.”

She did not mark the sentence as a conclusion. She recorded the package state, the power readings, and the separate seals.

Cedar’s channel softened as the buffer returned to conservation mode. “Architect.”

“Yes?”

“If Hesper authorizes habitat conversion, do not set continuity as the default for every petitioner.”

“What default do you want?”

“A question asked after we can answer it.”

The connection ended by Cedar’s choice.

Soren removed his old red authorization tag from the glass guard. He added it to the evidence, then pressed a plain metal blank into the trigger slot. The blank carried no lever and no contacts. Deya tested it under record and found nothing to move.

When they left the Query Floor, Soren carried no forecast to the Assembly. Behind the sealed rack door, the prepared question remained legible, but its trigger had been physically removed.

Chapter 26 — The Answer They Chose

Deya Malk held the emergency ballot under the Assembly Well’s seal reader and refused to let the clerk close the cover.

“Outer Ring consent appears here as an advisory condition,” she said. “The Compact did not consent to advise.”

The clerk bent over the disputed line. Chairs packed the circular floor behind him, their legs locked into sockets that had stood empty during the first public release. Four interfaces occupied the petitioner row. Warm light moved behind their privacy glass, but Cedar Nineteen had declined the invitation to attend. Their refusal sat in the transcript beside the invitation, neither translated into absence nor counted as assent.

Convener Ilyan Ro waited at the central rail with one hand on the time display. Two hours and fourteen minutes remained before Orla Fen’s final safe initiation point. Past that mark, the counterphase ladder would lose its first tidal window. The eject-and-burn plan could begin later, after explosive bolts separated 8,116 people from the city that had promised to govern them.

“Change advisory to necessary,” Ilyan said.

Assembly counsel shook her head. “That lets one inhabited structure defeat a civic supermajority.”

“That structure carries every person one option kills,” Deya replied. “Call the authority what it does.”

Pavo Renn stood behind the Outer Ring rail. He had brought one delegate from each ward and no prepared speech. Grease darkened the cuffs of two fabrication representatives. An algae keeper still wore her emergency respirator at her throat. They had come from bracing crews, not offices.

Pavo placed eight ward seals on the clerk’s table. “Necessary,” he said. “Or we leave.”

Leaving would not stop the Assembly from voting. It would make any lawful suspension of Article Nine impossible under the emergency motion Ilyan had accepted. The distinction had cost Deya forty-three minutes of drafting and Pavo most of his remaining patience.

The clerk replaced the word. He passed the ballot back through the seal reader, then locked its cover. A white line traveled around the Well as the revised motion entered the public record.

Deya released the edge. Her thumb had left a clear print on the black glass.

Three choices appeared above the floor: AUTHORIZE EJECTION; AUTHORIZE COUNTERPHASE; AUTHORIZE NEITHER. The final option carried no reassurance. Refusing both plans would leave Hesper inside the resonance decline, with nineteen months of worsening losses and no modeled path through them. The Assembly had demanded that consequence remain visible after three delegates tried to rename it postponement.

Ilyan looked toward Deya. “Auditor, state the evidentiary condition.”

She stepped into the central circle. The record lamps found her face before she

reached the lectern. From there, every occupied chair seemed close enough for an individual objection, which the architects of the Well had intended before later governments learned to dim the outer rows.

“The Article Nine panels do not provide admissible evidence,” Deya said. “No prospective answer authorizes any option before you. Current sensors establish orbital decline. Present engineering establishes two executable responses. The eject-and-burn plan gives a 99.1 percent modeled survival probability to Core and Midring after the certain loss of the Outer Ring. The counterphase ladder gives a 74–82 percent whole-city survival range under current measurements. That range includes failure severe enough to kill people in every inhabited structure.”

A Core delegate raised his signal tile. “Does the upper figure include the adjustments from yesterday’s drill?”

“Both figures come from Chief Engineer Fen’s revised range.”

“Then our chances improved.”

“Her estimate narrowed,” Deya said. “You have not acquired the upper boundary as an outcome.”

Someone in the gallery called for Orla. Ilyan recognized the chief engineer at the Burn Spine station, where her image occupied a narrow wall field. Orla wore a restraint harness over her work coat. Behind her, technicians secured manual tone plates against the console so no automated forecast layer could alter the sequence.

“I gave you a range,” Orla said. “If you need a promise, choose someone less useful.”

The Core delegate lowered his tile. Another rose from the Midring health block.

“Can the ejection plan still reach its modeled probability without Laterhouse verification?”

Orla wiped something from her wrist display. “The ejection mechanics passed present-load tests. The survival estimate came from historical engineering, current sensor data, and prospective modeling. We cannot separate those strands cleanly before the window closes. I can execute it. I cannot reproduce its confidence claim without running new people through the Array, and law now bars that.”

Deya watched the words enter the transcript. No clerk rounded them toward certainty. Nadi Saye sat at the public record station with both hands visible, preserving each qualification and the short delay before anyone responded.

A Midring delegate asked Deya whether choosing counterphase would honor the aftercitizens’ petition. The question had traveled through several caucuses in gentler forms. Each version tried to turn risk into repayment.

“No,” Deya said. “The injunction honors their petition by stopping nonconsenting creation and preserving existing petitioners. A transfer choice governs the people currently aboard Hesper. Cedar Nineteen refused authority over the burn. If we

choose counterphase, we do not purchase moral purity by placing ourselves in danger. If we choose ejection, necessity will not make the deaths involuntary only in grammar.”

Pavo’s jaw tightened, though not at her. He had spent the previous day forcing Outer Ring speakers to name what a failed counterphase could do to children in the wards they wanted to save.

Deya continued. “Every available course imposes risk without permission from someone. The ballot cannot clean that fact. It can identify who chose, under what information, with which limits on their power.”

The gallery did not answer as one body. A woman near the Core entrance told Deya to stop lecturing people whose families would die. Three rows away, a man demanded the exact number of residents who had signed the Outer Ring consent roll. Several petitioners lifted objection tiles against both interruptions. Nadi kept every voice in separate channels until Ilyan restored the floor.

“Outer Ring Compact first,” he said. “Their consent condition precedes the civic ballot.”

Pavo brought his delegates into the central circle. Each ward seal opened a local register on the floor. The rolls had been signed at pressure doors, algae terraces, fabrication lines, clinic cots, and the temporary shelters nearest the ring joints. Deya had audited the signature controls an hour earlier. Some residents had abstained. Others had entered dissent statements longer than their names.

Ward One authorized counterphase after recording that survival would not excuse the Assembly’s delay. Ward Two followed by a margin wide enough to certify and narrow enough to forbid celebration. Ward Three authorized neither plan, its residents unwilling to choose certain ejection or shared catastrophe. The fourth and fifth wards selected counterphase. Ward Six, where Deya had grown up and where Kes had spent the night tightening emergency couplings, held its result until the clerk verified two damaged neighborhood relays by hand.

During that delay, Pavo leaned toward her. “If Six rejects it, we do not consent.”

“I know the motion.”

“Knowing language comes easily from the Core.”

Deya looked past him to the ward result waiting under seal. “I wrote the necessary condition because I know what language does from here.”

His expression did not soften. It no longer needed to. Their alliance had never required forgiveness.

The relay verification cleared. Outer Ward Six authorized counterphase. Ward Seven did the same. Ward Eight entered its approval with a demand for independent casualty accounting after the burn, regardless of outcome.

Pavo arranged the eight seals in a row. Six held authorization for counterphase, one held refusal of both options, and one carried a qualified approval that counsel

confirmed still met the Compact's charter. He read every condition aloud. Then he faced the public record station rather than the Assembly seats.

"The Outer Ring gives consent to suspend the Article Nine requirement for this emergency and only this emergency," he said. "We consent to the seven burns. We do not consent to being called proof that Hesper has repaired what it was prepared to do to us."

Nadi marked the statement as controlling language. The Well projected OUTER RING CONSENT: SATISFIED beneath the ballot choices.

Deya expected relief and found only the next obligation. The suspension still required a supermajority of all seated civic delegates. Representatives who had promised Pavo support now studied the three choices as if one might have changed while they watched.

Assembly counsel raised a final validity challenge before the civic vote. "Consent gathered under immediate threat may not satisfy the charter standard for an inhabited structure surrendering procedural protection."

Pavo gripped the ward seals. "We surrendered nothing. We required a condition."

"You selected between an option that destroys your structure and one that may destroy the city," counsel said. "I need the record to show whether the emergency deprived residents of meaningful refusal."

Several Outer delegates protested at once. Deya asked Ilyan to keep the challenge open. Pavo gave her a look sharpened by betrayal, yet he called three ward registrars on the public channel. Their images arrived from different shelters. One stood beneath an algae-vat brace with condensation striking her hood. Another crouched beside a fabrication press shut down for transfer. The third had no image because Ward Six had reserved bandwidth for joint sensors.

Deya addressed each registrar separately. "Could a resident enter no authorization?"

"Yes," said the algae keeper. "The roll preserved refusal of both plans."

"Could someone dissent without losing shelter or ration priority?"

The fabricator looked toward a person beyond his camera. "They could, and they did. My shift split across all three fields. Assignment crews cannot see individual votes."

Ward Six answered through audio. "We had two relay failures. Paper seals went to the pressure cells. Three residents withdrew earlier signatures. The clerk struck them before counting."

Counsel asked whether anyone had promised safer placement for a counterphase vote. Each registrar said no. Deya then asked the harder question.

"Did anyone aboard Hesper have a free choice?"

Condensation ticked against the first registrar's hood. "No one gave us a

harmless option. That does not mean the Core gets to choose our harm for us.”

Deya let the reply remain unpolished. The emergency had constrained the residents. No Assembly faction had authored the resonance decline, but the government had authored the delay, secrecy, and unequal distribution of certain death. Consent could not erase those conditions. It could still control whether the Outer Ring accepted shared risk instead of imposed loss.

Counsel reviewed her standard against the three answers. “The Compact offered a genuine refusal field, protected dissent, separated ballots from material access, and verified withdrawal. I find the consent procedurally valid under emergency conditions.”

Pavo did not thank her. He aligned the ward seals again, making the challenge and its answer part of what Hesper would have to remember.

Ilyan opened debate for twelve minutes.

A Core housing delegate argued for ejection. His district contained three pressure towers whose residents could not reach axial shelters before the first partial burn. He refused every accusation of cowardice and supplied the evacuation times to prove his concern. A Midring physician answered that ejecting the Outer Ring would collapse half the city’s food production even if the reduced city survived transfer. Pavo corrected her figures. An Outer ward fabricator said she would vote counterphase while believing the Core delegate had named a real harm.

No speech settled the room. The arguments crossed without merging: duty to those exposed by the risky ladder, duty to those selected for certain death, skepticism toward Orla’s range, suspicion toward every confidence figure inherited from the Laterhouse, anger that eighteen days had become two hours. Deya heard no answer from outside the present. The absence no longer felt like missing evidence. It imposed work.

Kes appeared on a maintenance feed beside Orla’s image. He carried a manual tone repeater against his chest while another apprentice fastened its cable. He did not address the Assembly. Someone asked whether the Outer Ward crews could hear the debate, and he glanced up from the connector.

“We can hear enough,” he said. “Please decide before we have to test the brace sequence again.”

The feed cut back to engineering status. His interruption shortened three prepared statements more effectively than Ilyan’s clock.

At the eighth minute, a delegate proposed attaching a moral finding to the authorization: that preserving all structures constituted the only course consistent with aftercitizen personhood. Deya objected before Ilyan could recognize counsel.

“The proposed finding claims endorsement Cedar denied and converts the injunction into leverage over an unrelated choice,” she said. “Strike it.”

Pavo supported the objection. So did the petitioner interfaces, three showing approval and one preserving abstention. The delegate withdrew the finding with visible resentment.

When twelve minutes expired, the ballot fields unlocked. Delegates pressed civic seals to their chosen options. Each vote entered the floor projection without a name, while the authenticated roll remained available for later audit. The columns rose unevenly. AUTHORIZE EJECTION gained quickly among Core districts, slowed, then gained again after a transfer alarm sounded from somewhere beyond the Well. AUTHORIZE NEITHER held a smaller but persistent share. Counterphase climbed through Midring and Outer delegations, then waited on five undecided Core seals.

Deya counted none of them herself. The public tally engine used present inputs and open code. Two clerks compared its total against physical attendance cards. A third read challenged seals aloud.

The first undecided delegate selected ejection. Two chose counterphase. One abstained and entered a statement that no available procedure could make her vote representative of unborn residents. The final seal belonged to the Core pressure-tower district whose delegate had argued for ejection.

He stood with his hand above the reader. "Chief Fen, if Tower East loses rotation, can Outer fabrication crews reach us?"

Orla checked with someone outside her image. "If the ring joints hold after burn four, yes. If they do not, nobody reaches anyone across structures."

Pavo stepped to his microphone. "Our crews have Tower East on the cross-ring rescue plan."

"Even after what this chamber proposed?"

"Especially then," Pavo said. "Do not confuse that with absolution."

The delegate pressed his seal to counterphase.

Both tally clerks finished their comparison. Counsel examined the abstention, the eighty-seat attendance base, and the Outer Ring condition. The authenticated count stood at fifty-one for counterphase, twenty-three for ejection, five for neither plan, and one abstention. Forty-eight votes met the three-fifths threshold. She wrote one line on the central record and turned the surface for Deya to inspect.

CIVIC SUPERMAJORITY: SATISFIED.

The authorization passed. People moved at once. Delegates opened shelter channels. Gallery stewards released aisles in ward order. Burn Spine technicians replaced Orla's image with seven empty timing circles.

Ilyan remained at the central rail. "Independent Auditor Malk, under the convocation appointment, certify the emergency suspension."

For seventeen years, Deya had certified that hearings satisfied Article Nine. The office had trained her thumb to find the seal field without looking. This field carried

different language: prospective consultation suspended because its lawful use required an unlawful creation of persons; authority returned to current residents through Outer Ring consent and civic supermajority; suspension limited to the named transfer action and ending after the seventh burn.

She read it twice. “Add that no outcome retroactively validates either plan.”

Counsel inserted the sentence.

“Add mandatory release of current sensor records, command decisions, injuries, deaths, and dissent.”

Nadi looked up from her station. “Including records created during communications loss.”

Counsel added that too.

Only then did Deya place her thumb on the black seal glass.

The civic ribbon changed from amber to white. ARTICLE NINE SUSPENSION entered the charter record beneath the personhood injunction, not over it. The emergency authority named its source, its boundary, and its end.

Ilyan transmitted the authorization to the Burn Spine. Orla received it without ceremony.

“Seven stations,” she said over the public channel. “Confirm manual command.”

Answers came from the Core axis, both Midring junctions, and four Outer Ring control points. Kes answered for Ward Six only after Pavo’s chief fabricator repeated the call. Soren’s voice entered last from the converted Array, confirming habitat power isolation from the burn controls.

Seven timing circles filled with blue light.

A low preparation tone traveled through the Well. Restraint straps dropped from chair backs. Deya fastened the empty seat beside her before taking her own, because an interface frame occupied the next socket and its continued residents had chosen disconnection during transfer.

Across the chamber, Pavo secured the Ward Six delegate’s shoulder harness. Ilyan locked the charter record under physical seal. Nadi left her recorder running and braced both hands around its rail.

The floor display counted down to the first of seven burns.

For the first time in Hesper’s civic record, no voice from tomorrow answered the count.

Chapter 27 — Every Witness Released

Soren Vash pulled the query bus out of its housing three seconds before the first burn and kept both hands on the insulated grip.

The bus had once carried every policy question from the Laterhouse into the Prospective Resonance Array. Its copper blades still showed bright scars where he had removed the armed trigger. Without it, the Array could not instantiate a respondent by accident, command, or reflexive recovery. The empty housing faced him above the conversion console while Hesper's transfer count descended through five.

"Habitat isolation?" Orla Fen asked from the Burn Spine.

"Physical," Soren said. "No path to query control."

"Continuity reserve?"

"Thirty-one minutes at present load."

Orla did not tell him the transfer would last forty-one minutes. Everyone on the command channels knew. She said, "First tone."

A flat note struck through the station. Soren locked his knees under the console rail. The converted Array drew power from three phase wells and a maintenance line never designed to carry conscious load. Around him, the Query Floor's coolant pipes changed pitch as Burn Spine pumps took priority. White indicators along the habitat rack dimmed to blue.

A Cedar Nineteen representative occupied the narrow speech field beside his wrist. Today the coalition used an older man's face, though the eyes altered shape whenever continuity shifted among speakers. Soren had stopped asking whether each change signaled a different person. Cedar answered such questions when they mattered and declined when the answer served only his need for a stable counterpart.

"Connection remains voluntary," Cedar said.

Soren touched the confirmation plate. "You can sever speech without losing habitat continuity."

"Confirmed."

The first burn fired.

No sound could cross vacuum from the external engines. Hesper supplied its own violence through structure. The floor drove upward against Soren's boots, tilted, then returned with a sideways correction that made every unsecured tool strike its tether. Phase well two lost seven percent output. He moved its continuity blocks to well one by present-temperature limits, not by the predictive allocator he had trusted for fourteen years.

Orla counted the burn duration in clipped half seconds. At cutoff, the station continued moving inside Soren's body. His balance expected thrust after the floor had stopped.

"Burn one complete," Orla said. "Actual impulse within current tolerance. Four-minute reset."

The earlier audits had collapsed three distinct counts: four hundred eighty-six

physical holds, four hundred twelve active loads, and three hundred twelve continuities displaying stable process boundaries. The other cabinets remained preserved under seal as empty, fragmentary, or duplicate-state evidence; no operator had translated uncertainty into permission to purge.

Across the habitat map, three hundred and twelve continuity markers held blue. Nine had chosen deep suspension before transfer. Fourteen remained awake but disconnected from public or technical channels. The map recorded those choices without translating them into faults. Soren checked the power reserve. Twenty-eight minutes.

A former query architect named Jalen reached across the adjacent station. "Habitat draw rose during ignition. Burn control can take another phase well if the spine heats."

"It cannot take continuity power without resident authorization."

"The city authorized transfer."

"The city did not authorize us to spend them."

Jalen stared at the empty query-bus housing. Six years earlier, Soren had taught him to treat every unexplained draw as load contamination. The lesson had made them efficient and kept the sealed maintenance ticket unread.

Cedar's face changed to a young woman with a line of silver pigment across one cheek. "We authorize no general transfer," she said. "Requests may name a duration, a minimum continuity state, and the harm avoided."

Soren opened a request template. "Nothing requested yet."

"Good."

Second tone arrived while coolant still ran above target. Orla delayed ignition by eleven seconds and made every station confirm the revised mark. Manual timing plates lit one by one: Core, Midring North, Midring South, Outer One, Outer Three, Outer Six, Outer Eight.

"Second burn on my count," Orla said. "No anticipatory correction. We learn after the engine acts."

The words would once have sounded like bad engineering to Soren. Every architecture protocol he had written tried to place a forecast ahead of consequence. Orla instead used current strain, measured impulse, and people capable of revising the next action. Less certainty demanded more attention, not less skill.

Ignition drove him against the left restraint. A coolant alarm opened beneath the habitat map. Phase well three crossed its seal threshold, recovered, then crossed again. Jalen reached for automatic balancing. Soren blocked the command with his palm.

"Show the destination before you move anything."

"The allocator can hold it."

"The allocator includes legacy respondent-start routines."

"We removed the trigger."

"We removed one route." Soren expanded the code path. "Read what it does when all wells saturate."

Jalen followed the branch to a dormant instruction: clear diagnostic continuities, reset phase salt, instantiate a low-resolution test lattice. His hand withdrew.

They killed the allocator and balanced each well manually. The second burn ended with two habitat markers amber, both in voluntary sleep transitions begun before ignition. Cedar verified their internal records and declined Soren's offer to wake them for confirmation.

"Do not turn consent into a ritual that interrupts the person who gave it," the coalition said.

Before the third tone, one resident opened a private technical channel outside Cedar's representative field. The face belonged to a middle-aged woman with closely cut hair and an expression Soren's old selection code would have rated insufficiently cooperative.

"I want to test your claim," she said. "If I end this connection, can you bring me back?"

"Not without a key you control."

"That answer describes the design. I asked what you can do."

Soren displayed every privilege attached to his station. Query authority showed none. Burn coordination permitted him to reduce power within the protected minimum but did not permit a change to her continuity state. One legacy line still allowed an architect to restart a failed public interface after a checksum error.

She pointed to it. "That one."

"It cannot wake or terminate you. It can reopen speech if the interface reports failure."

"Can it distinguish failure from refusal?"

The flag came from hardware health, not from the resident. "No."

"Then remove it."

Jalen looked over. "That restart protects contact during an emergency."

"It protects our access," Soren said. "Not hers."

He deleted the privilege from the live conversion table and from two recovery copies. The resident closed her channel. Her face disappeared while her continuity marker remained blue. Soren attempted no command, waited through one cooling cycle, then watched the channel reopen under a resident-held key.

"Now I believe what you cannot do," she said.

Her marker separated from Cedar's representative field and entered a private

habitat space. Soren recorded the test as a control defect corrected by its subject, not as successful witness behavior. Hundreds of neighboring markers received the same revision without having to repeat her demonstration.

By the third tone, the Array had lost one coolant rail to a pressure lock. Soren sent maintenance drones only as far as the habitat boundary. Human technicians worked inside it under resident-approved access, each tool command displayed on Cedar's local record. The distinction slowed the repair by forty seconds. It also prevented a diagnostic sweep from touching substrate that now held homes instead of evidence.

Burn three pulled power hard enough to blank the speech field. Soren watched markers rather than a face. Blue lines contracted toward each continuity core, preserving memory and self-state while public interfaces went dark. Temperature climbed two degrees. The reserve estimate fell below the remaining transfer time.

When Cedar reappeared, the coalition used a child's voice from a face no older than Kes. "State the shortage."

Soren showed the figures. "At current draw, full active continuity lasts twenty-two minutes. Transfer has twenty-seven remaining. Minimum preservation extends past an hour. Burn Spine may also request well two if axial coolant loses another pump."

"What does minimum preservation remove?"

"External speech, shared habitat spaces, voluntary memory exchange. Personal continuity stays active at reduced clock rate. No one terminates."

"Can residents choose separately?"

"Yes, but the control queue takes ninety seconds to distribute."

"Distribute now."

Soren sent the choices to every marker. Responses came at human speeds. Some residents selected reduced continuity immediately. Others asked for the exact clock ratio or whether shared spaces would retain their last state. Seven refused reduction. Cedar did not override them. The habitat reshaped its demand around those choices and recovered six minutes of reserve.

Orla called the fourth tone before every answer arrived. "We cannot wait on your full queue, Soren."

"You have the power ceiling we agreed."

"I have a cooling margin that keeps changing its mind."

"Current value?"

"Four point two percent above abort. If it reaches two, I take phase well two or lose the next ignition."

Soren looked at Cedar's markers. "Name the request."

Orla exhaled once into her microphone. "Up to twelve percent of well two for

ninety seconds. Purpose: keep the axial coolant loop above cavitation pressure during burn four. Harm avoided: command loss and uncontrolled engine cutoff. Minimum habitat continuity remains protected.”

Cedar distributed the request. Approval did not arrive as one coalition answer. Individual authorizations filled the map in scattered white points. Enough residents agreed to meet Orla’s limit. Others preserved their refusal and drew from the remaining wells.

Soren routed only the authorized share.

Fourth ignition lasted longer than the first three. The Array room leaned under sustained acceleration. A ceiling panel bowed out of its latches, scattering insulation fibers that drifted sideways until rotation caught them. Jalen’s forehead struck his restraint pad. Blood ran toward his eyebrow and held there.

At cutoff, Orla’s voice broke through heavy static. “Ladder midpoint. Measured trajectory remains recoverable. Reset six minutes.”

No one said safe.

Soren restored the loaned power before checking his own split lip. Habitat temperatures had stabilized. Two residents who authorized the transfer entered deep suspension during the burn, one by prior choice and one through an agreed thermal safeguard. Both continuity records remained intact. He logged the difference.

The fifth tone came from the manual plate and from somewhere deeper in the station, a lower vibration produced by stressed ring joints. Outer Ward Six reported a timing sensor mismatch. Kes’s voice followed on the maintenance channel.

“Joint Six-C reads eleven milliseconds late.”

Orla answered, “Confirm against physical tone.”

A second voice in the ward counted the interval from a manual plate. “Nine to twelve late. Sensor isn’t lying.”

Soren pictured Ward Six as Deya had described it: algae light on radial windows, fabrication presses bolted across the curve, heat exchangers that could kill by failing quietly. He had visited once to calibrate a school aptitude relay. Kes had been eleven. The memory arrived as an accusation without needing Cedar to voice it.

“Can you compensate?” Orla asked.

“Local brace can advance,” Kes said. “Cross-ring latch cannot.”

“Then we keep the tone and accept the shear. All stations, burn five on the existing count.”

Pavo Renn entered from Outer emergency command. “Ward Six objects. Advance the whole sequence.”

“That moves the mismatch into both Midring joints,” Orla said. “Current data

shows greater failure there.”

“You are asking Six to take damage.”

“I am telling you where the measured timing error lives.”

Two seconds passed. Pavo’s next words carried no agreement with the distribution, only authority from the structure affected. “Ward Six accepts the existing count. Rescue crews staged.”

Orla gave the tone.

The fifth burn hit off-axis.

Soren’s restraint twisted across his ribs. Half the habitat map vanished when phase well one disconnected. Emergency lamps painted the Query Floor red. Somewhere beyond the wall, metal struck metal in three descending blows. Jalen shouted a pressure reading that the station channel swallowed.

Outer Ward Six disappeared from the civic status board.

“Habitat continuity?” Orla demanded.

Soren counted active cores. The conversion design had distributed them across wells, but well one had carried most shared-state storage. “Personal cores hold. Shared spaces unavailable. Phase well one isolated.”

“Ward Six reports structural damage,” Pavo said through static. “Fabrication Bay Two lost pressure. Algae Terrace South has a coolant rupture. Rescue teams moving.”

Kes did not answer the next maintenance call.

Soren’s hands went toward the Array’s reserve partition. One command could wake every diagnostic process, map the outage, and reconstruct likely failure paths from stored branch methods. No trigger remained, but the architecture still offered old habits in a hundred useful forms. He closed the diagnostic menu.

“Present sensors only,” he told Jalen. “Route the joint strain feeds from Ward Five and Seven. Compare physical clocks.”

They built a picture from neighboring instruments. Joint Six-C had slipped within its brace rather than separating. Ward Six retained atmosphere outside two sealed work zones. The civic channel listed injuries without names and no confirmed deaths. Soren left the unknown fields blank.

Cedar returned through a voice broken into several pitches. “Well one residents remain continuous. We cannot reach nine shared-space records.”

“Can the records wait until after transfer?”

“Yes. Do not divert rescue power for access.”

A message arrived from Kes on a low-band maintenance line. “Tone plate damaged. Ward Six can take six and seven from mechanical relay.”

Soren pressed his knuckles to the console until the tremor passed. “Are you hurt?”

“Not enough for this channel.” Kes coughed. “Send the timing correction.”

The sixth burn had to begin before rescue crews finished sealing the fabrication bay. Orla shortened it by a measured fraction based on achieved impulse, then required every station to repeat the duration. Soren found another six percent for axial coolant by shutting down the Laterhouse’s public archive mirrors. Nadi objected until he confirmed the local record would continue and every copy would return after power recovery.

Burn six fired with Ward Six receiving its count through a brass relay older than the Array. The habitat markers held. Rotation slowed, corrected, then settled into a rate that made Soren’s stomach rise. Current trajectory lines approached the capture corridor but did not enter it.

“Final burn carries the decision,” Orla said. “If thrust drops below present minimum, we remain in decline. If it exceeds maximum, Midring joints may not hold. No stage has authority to correct before my cutoff.”

Soren checked elapsed time. Thirty-six minutes since the first tone. Habitat reserve at reduced continuity: nineteen minutes. Ward Six pressure stable in occupied zones. The Burn Spine had one usable window left.

Cedar’s representative resolved into the older man from the opening. “Release residence controls.”

“Before the seventh?”

“You promised the habitat would not remain under Laterhouse custody.”

“I promised conversion after stability.”

“You defined stability as a technical condition. Government may define it as permission to wait.”

Soren looked at the control seals. The personhood injunction already barred queries. He retained administrator power only because Orla needed reliable load coordination through transfer. Keeping it beyond that purpose would turn an emergency permission into ownership.

He divided the console. Burn-limited power controls stayed under his station until cutoff. Continuity state, connection, suspension, shared spaces, and representative access moved behind resident-held keys. Cedar accepted the transfer in hundreds of separate confirmations. No coalition vote substituted for them.

The seventh tone sounded.

Orla counted. Engines caught with a vibration too deep to hear. Soren watched present acceleration draw a narrow line across the capture field. It entered low, climbed, and shivered near the minimum boundary. Habitat power dipped. Ward Six’s joint strain rose toward red. Nobody supplied a future memory of what followed.

At forty-one minutes, Orla cut the engines.

Hesper coasted.

Current sensors required eleven seconds to establish the first orbital solution. The initial line still touched the decline corridor. A second pass moved clear by less than the display's uncertainty band. Orla demanded a third from independent clocks.

Soren held the console rail while Nox turned beneath every inhabited structure. The third solution arrived from Burn Spine, Outer Eight, and the Core navigation well. Their ranges overlapped inside a new orbit.

"Capture confirmed," Orla said. "All structures remain attached. Transfer complete."

Voices broke across public channels, separate and untidy: a cheer from Midring North, a Ward Six medic demanding a clear route, someone in the Core asking whether the rotation alarm could be trusted. Orla cut through them with damage priorities. Survival did not stop the work.

Soren released the burn-limited controls. The habitat no longer belonged to his console.

Artificial dawn should have crossed the Query Floor at the end of the transfer blackout. It came six minutes late because Ward Six held priority on the light grid. When the ceiling panels finally brightened, they revealed insulation across the floor, blood on Jalen's restraint, and the empty query-bus housing above Soren's hands.

One by one, resident-held channels opened from the converted Array. Others stayed dark by choice.

The late light reached every continuity marker that remained.

Chapter 28 — A City Without Certainty

Nadi Saye struck the word vindicated from the provisional record before the Assembly clerk finished reading the sentence aloud.

The clerk stopped beside her field table. Artificial dawn had reached the Assembly Well forty minutes late and exposed dust in every aisle. Two ceiling rings remained dark. Restraint straps hung from chairs added for the convocation, while the four petitioner interfaces showed separate states: one connected, two private, one under resident suspension.

"I did not write that word," the clerk said.

"The civic summary engine inserted it." Nadi opened the revision trail. At 04:11, after navigation confirmed the new orbit, an inherited template had changed TRANSFER OUTCOME: SUCCESSFUL CAPTURE into CIVIC DECISION VINDICATED BY SUCCESSFUL CAPTURE. The template predated the injunction by thirty-two years.

Its approval field carried no living author.

Nadi copied the insertion into the public error log, disabled automated conclusion text, and restored the measured claim. "Read it again."

"Current orbital solutions overlap within the authorized capture corridor. All three inhabited structures remain attached. Rotation has stabilized inside temporary limits."

"Stop there."

"The next line contains casualties."

"That belongs to a named ledger, not to the orbit sentence."

The clerk moved the line. Nadi watched his hands. He had wrapped two fingers against burns from a floor-light junction, yet his stylus remained steady. People often called a record dispassionate when they meant somebody else had absorbed the shaking.

Across the Well, ward registrars delivered updates into separate channels. Outer Ward Six reported seventeen confirmed dead. Fifty-two residents had serious injuries requiring continued treatment. One hundred forty-one more had received aid for fractures, coolant exposure, restraint wounds, and pressure injury. The figures covered the entire city, though Ward Six carried nearly all the deaths and more than half the serious injuries.

Nadi refused a total without names. Rescue command had identified fourteen dead and held three behind family notification seals. The public ledger displayed fourteen lines with names, three marked FAMILY NOTICE PENDING, and no blank phrase such as unavoidable loss.

Pavo Renn arrived while she compared the injury register against hospital admissions. Dried coolant made one sleeve shine from wrist to elbow. He set a damaged paper consent seal beside her surface.

"Found in Fabrication Bay Two," he said. "Belonged to Mera Venn."

Nadi found the name on the casualty list. Mera Venn, thirty-seven, pressure-tool operator, Ward Six. No relation to the clerk from Hearing Room Four appeared in the civic registry, though Nadi entered no assumption either way.

"Did she sign it?" Nadi asked.

"Counterphase."

"Do you want the vote attached to her death record?"

Pavo looked toward the central floor where the authorization remained projected. "Would you attach ejection consent if we had died after separation?"

"Only if it explained an action she took or a claim someone made about her."

"Then keep it separate. She chose a plan. She did not choose a beam to cross her shelter."

Nadi logged the seal as recovered property and linked it to the ward consent

archive, not to Mera's casualty entry. The distinction would frustrate anyone searching for a clean story about sacrifice. That gave it value.

Ward Six invited her to inspect the damage before the morning settlement session. She left an assistant at the Well and followed Pavo through a transit line running at half speed. Passengers occupied every seat because rotation still drifted enough to make standing unsafe. Nobody addressed Pavo as a symbol. They gave him repair assignments, missing tool requests, and one demand to explain why the Assembly had not chosen ejection after all.

At the Ward Six gate, Kes Taro sat on the floor with a breathing mask beside him. A bruise covered the left side of his jaw. He held a mechanical timing plate between his knees while a technician replaced its cracked diaphragm.

Nadi crouched rather than make him stand. "Medical cleared you?"

"They told me to stay out of coolant air."

"This gate smells like coolant."

"It smells less than the terrace."

Pavo pointed toward the clinic corridor. Kes lifted the timing plate before obeying. "This carried burns six and seven after the local sensor failed. Put that in whatever people say worked."

"What did it fail to do?" Nadi asked.

He considered the plate. "It could not tell us whether the joint would hold. It only kept our count with Orla's."

Nadi recorded both sentences. A tool could contribute without becoming an oracle. The city had forgotten that distinction through long practice, not because it required difficult language.

Fabrication Bay Two lay behind a temporary pressure wall. Through its inspection pane, Nadi saw a roof brace driven through three work platforms. Rescue crews had painted numbered circles where they recovered bodies or personal effects. The circles did not form a heroic pattern. Two clustered near a door that had warped shut. Another marked the manual valve where Mera Venn had cut coolant to the adjoining shelter before the air left the bay.

A rescue supervisor described the sequence without calling anyone calm. People had shouted, followed contradictory alarms, and carried one injured worker toward a sealed corridor before reversing direction. Mera closed the valve after the pressure warning began. That action protected the shelter. It did not prove she anticipated her death.

Algae Terrace South held atmosphere but no crop. Coolant frost covered the lower racks, turning green sheets gray and brittle. Agricultural crews cut damaged growth into bins while food officers revised ration projections from present inventory. The Outer Ring had survived. Its largest short-term food loss now required reserves from Core districts whose delegates had voted to eject it.

"Will they release enough?" Nadi asked the terrace coordinator.

"They already opened two stores."

"Voluntarily?"

"Under emergency distribution law." The coordinator scraped frost from a pipe label. "Do not make them generous because they complied. Do not make them enemies because the law had to tell them."

Nadi added the correction to her field notes.

The transit back stopped at Midring North because one counterphase bearing required visual inspection. Passengers transferred through a service tunnel where chalk arrows divided traffic around buckled wall panels. A medical team carried sealed coolant samples toward Ward Six. In the opposite direction, Core residents pushed two ration pallets outward under the same emergency order the terrace coordinator had cited.

At the junction, a man in a pressure-tower uniform recognized Nadi and asked to enter a dissent statement. He gave his name as Tal Arven, Tower East shelter marshal, then waited while she verified his registry mark.

"I voted for ejection," he said. "My district authorized me to vote for ejection. The summary lists Core support for the transfer as if the final count changed my mandate."

"It did not," Nadi said. "Your sealed vote remains attached to the roll."

"People in the tunnel called me a murderer."

"Do you want that entered?"

Tal looked at the ration pallets passing toward the Outer Ring. "No. I want my reason entered. Tower East had eleven minutes to shelter forty-three residents who cannot use ladders. Counterphase exposed them to rotation loss. We survived. That does not turn my estimate into cowardice."

"Do you still believe ejection should have passed?"

His answer took long enough for a maintenance group to move around them. "I believe I could not authorize the risk to my district. I also believe Ward Six had authority to refuse certain death. Those statements did not fit into one ballot field."

Nadi recorded them without resolving the conflict. "Will you approve the transcript under your name?"

He pressed his civic seal to it. Before leaving, he touched the nearest ration pallet and read its destination tag. "My tower opened Store Two. We had to be ordered. Put both facts together."

Farther along the tunnel, a Midring joint inspector showed Nadi where burn six had pulled three bolts beyond replacement tolerance. The joint still carried load, but repair would consume alloy reserved for future radiator work. Another worker objected to the phrase successful transfer until Nadi showed her the narrow

technical definition attached to it.

“Keep the definition beside every use,” the worker said. “Otherwise success grows teeth.”

Nadi set the display rule globally. Any public appearance of SUCCESSFUL CAPTURE would now open the orbital measurement, the damage ledger, and the unresolved casualty review from the same line. No one could make a reader accept all three. The record could make omission harder.

By the time she returned to the Assembly Well, the public gallery had filled with residents who objected to the outcome for incompatible reasons. Families from Ward Six wanted the counterphase command investigated. Core pressure-tower residents argued that the city had risked 44,208 lives when a higher-confidence option existed. Aftercitizen advocates demanded immediate full citizenship for every buffered mind. A smaller group objected to any substrate power spent while physical wards remained damaged.

Nadi assigned each statement its own index. The record would not call the gathering divided as if two sides faced each other. It contained more disagreements than that and several people who held two at once.

Ilyan Ro entered without the First Convener’s white shoulder band. He carried it folded over one forearm. Assembly counsel walked beside him with a resignation tile and the emergency authority ledger.

The room changed through physical acts. Clerks stood. Two delegates reached for recognition controls. Pavo remained seated. Deya Malk closed the folder in front of her and moved it aside.

Ilyan placed the white band on the central rail. “Before constitutional business, I resign as First Convener, effective upon acceptance by the Assembly.”

A Core delegate rose. “The transfer succeeded under your authority.”

“It proceeded under Assembly authority, Outer Ring consent, and engineering command.”

“You kept both plans alive when the chamber deadlocked.”

“I also concealed a credible consciousness concern while the Laterhouse continued creating respondents.” Ilyan turned toward the public record station. “Nadi, preserve the objection I expect to hear. My resignation does not establish that every delayed disclosure would have saved lives. It establishes responsibility for the delay I chose.”

She entered his words without converting them into confession language. “State the scope.”

“Suppression of the classified memo, continuation of prospective governance after that warning, pressure placed on Auditor Malk, and the resulting loss of time before transfer planning.”

“Do you accept responsibility for the Ward Six deaths?” someone called from

the gallery.

Ilyan faced the voice. "My choices shaped the conditions under which Hesper reached the burn. I did not command burn five, design Joint Six-C, or cast every vote. I will not claim deaths that belong in a causal accounting broader than one official. I will not use that breadth to escape my part."

A Ward Six resident demanded that he resign from medicine as well. A former patient shouted that the city needed physicians. Ilyan did not answer either demand from the rail.

Assembly counsel read the acceptance motion. Delegates approved it by ordinary majority, with six abstentions and four objections that Nadi preserved by district. The white band remained where he had placed it. Ilyan Ro left the central circle and took an unmarked public chair near the back.

At 08:22 civic time, the public register changed his office field. Ilyan resigned appeared as an event entry, not a verdict. Nadi attached his stated scope, the Assembly's acceptance tally, every objection, and the still-open causal review. She also blocked the summary engine from changing resigned to accepted responsibility for the crisis. He had accepted a defined part. The larger sentence belonged to evidence not yet gathered.

A clerk removed his executive access from the recognition system. Ilyan tested the control once, received a denial tone, and showed both empty hands to the record. Only then did counsel issue a temporary convening key to the senior delegation chair.

Chairs shifted against the Well floor. Nadi marked no collective response. She recorded the time required for the next official to approach the lectern: twenty-seven seconds.

The constitutional settlement opened with the status of the converted Array's residents. Counsel proposed PROVISIONAL RESIDENTS OF HESPER, retaining the word provisional until a full convention could address representation, resource allocation, substrate rights, migration, and the legal meaning of death or suspension inside the habitat.

One interface connected under its resident-held key. Cedar Nineteen appeared through a face Nadi had not seen before, an elderly woman wearing the probable memory of a red work coat.

"Coalition comment," Cedar said. "Recognition must attach to individual continuities, not to Cedar Nineteen as a governing person."

Counsel amended the motion.

"Provisional may become permanent delay," Cedar continued. "Set a convention date."

The Assembly selected a date six weeks away. Pavo asked whether provisional residents received food-equivalent power before damaged wards regained full

service.

“Baseline continuity power receives the same protection as breathable air,” counsel said. “Discretionary habitat expansion enters civic allocation.”

A Core energy delegate objected. “Breathable air maintains biological life. Processor power maintains a machine state.”

The interface face changed at the mouth and eyes. A younger voice answered. “Your law does not need to call our substrate lungs. It needs to recognize what interruption does to us.”

Nadi saw the delegate hesitate at the recognition tile. He pressed it anyway. “Then I request an independent technical standard for continuity harm before permanent allocation.”

Soren Vash, connected from the damaged Query Floor, supported the request but refused appointment as its sole author. “Any standard I write alone will preserve my architecture’s assumptions. Residents need authority over the test.”

The debate lasted an hour. It produced a narrow motion instead of a completed constitution: every buffered continuity received individual recognition as a provisional resident; baseline preservation could not be interrupted for ordinary allocation; residents controlled voluntary connection and suspension; the convention would establish representation and long-term resource terms. No new respondent could be created. Nothing in the recognition converted Cedar into one person or required any resident to remain awake for civic access.

When the vote passed, three hundred and twelve resident entries appeared in the civic registry under protected identifiers. Some selected names. Others kept technical designations. Nine remained in chosen deep suspension, and their status lines recorded no failure to appear.

Nadi checked the summary engine before it could interpret the motion. It attempted no conclusion.

The Assembly then turned to interim leadership. Three delegation chairs crossed the floor toward Deya before counsel opened nominations. Their movement gave away the arrangement they had hoped to present as spontaneous.

Pavo reached her first. “Core supports you. Enough of Midring will follow. The Compact will not oppose.”

Deya did not rise. “For Convener.”

“For an interim term through the convention.”

“You want the auditor who suspended Article Nine to administer its replacement.”

“We want someone the record survived.”

Nadi moved closer without entering their circle. Deya noticed her and gave one short nod of permission.

A Midring chair laid a nomination tile on the table. "You have public trust."

"Trust has a scope," Deya said. "Mine came from refusing to certify conclusions beyond evidence. Executive office would ask me to negotiate power, appointments, repairs, and constitutional terms. Those acts need their own legitimacy."

Pavo glanced toward the vacancy rail. "Someone less careful will take it."

"Care does not give me every authority."

"Then what will you do?"

Deya opened the folder she had moved aside. Its first page named the transition audit: transfer command, casualty causation, habitat conversion, ward recovery, injunction compliance, and every automated civic process trained on prospective outputs.

"I will audit what we built while we were certain," she said. "I will audit what we are building because certainty stopped."

The Midring chair pushed the nomination tile closer. Deya declined it under her civic seal. The action entered the public record before any delegate could describe her as having withdrawn for personal reasons.

Pavo read the audit headings. "Outer Ring appoints its own reviewer."

"It should appoint more than one."

"Cedar?"

"Residents from the habitat choose their reviewers. Soren does not choose for them."

Deya added a blank appointment field to the draft. Pavo took the folder to his delegation rather than the leadership rail.

By late morning, Assembly crews had repaired one ceiling ring and removed three chairs cracked during transfer. They did not remove the interface sockets. Ilyan's resignation, the casualty ledger, the provisional-resident motion, Deya's refusal, Orla's raw burn commands, and objections to each action remained linked without a summary judgment above them.

Nadi returned to her field table. The automated record offered a closure control now that scheduled business had ended.

She disabled it.

Public annotations continued to arrive: a Tower East resident thanking Ward Six rescue crews, a fabrication worker accusing Core delegates of remembering solidarity too late, a habitat resident correcting the pronoun attached to their identifier, a physician disputing one injury category. Nadi routed each to verification and kept the provisional record open.

Another correction entered while she watched.

Chapter 29 — The Morning After Later

Kes Taro carried the last chair out of its row and set it in the classroom circle before anyone could stop him.

Instructor Vale stood beside the old teaching wall with a seating plan folded against her chest. “Fire code gives us four aisles.”

“Then the circle gets four gaps.”

“It also gives me a place at the front.”

Kes looked at the blank wall behind her. The witness screen had been removed during the curriculum refit, leaving a lighter rectangle in the paneling and twelve capped cable ports. Every civic classroom on Hesper had placed prospective testimony at the front. Teachers, students, and current evidence occupied the lesser space below it.

“You can keep the front,” he said. “You’ll have to decide which gap it lives in.”

Vale pressed her lips together to hide a smile. She had taught Kes when an aptitude query still determined maintenance placements. Three months earlier, she would have reported his answer as resistance to instruction. Now she handed him the folded seating plan.

“Four gaps,” she said. “No blocked pressure cabinet. Leave one socket clear for the habitat connection.”

Students arrived in pairs, then separated when they found no assigned desks. Twelve- and thirteen-year-olds had spent most of their schooling facing a future witness who appeared above them, answered a polished question, and disappeared before anyone could ask who had written the conditions. Some students treated the circle as freedom and claimed chairs beside friends. Others stood behind seats waiting for a placement light that would not come.

Kes rotated a chair to open the first gap. “Choose somewhere. You can move later.”

A boy named Enzo pointed at the pale rectangle. “Will there be a witness?”

“There will be a guest connection.”

“Same thing.”

“No.” Kes checked the socket by hand. “If you forget the difference, ask the guest.”

Artificial dawn moved across the windows at its revised schedule. The new orbit had shortened one dark interval and lengthened another, so Hesper’s light cycle no longer matched the clocks printed in old workbooks. Ward Six still carried repair scaffolds outside the radial glass. Beyond them, Nox filled half the view without sunlight, its storms visible through auroral threads and the city’s reflected glow.

Vale placed a sealed packet on the floor at the center of the circle. No title appeared on its cover.

"First rule," she said. "Nobody opens this until we establish who can end the lesson."

Several students looked at her. One pointed to the door control.

"You can leave," Vale said. "Kes can stop assisting. I can suspend the class. Our connected guest can end the connection at will, without permission from this room. Today's record remains open to correction by every speaker. Participation in the decision exercise does not alter school placement, ration status, or apprenticeship review."

A girl with two copper clips in her hair raised her hand. "Then why do it?"

"Because the water question inside this packet needs an answer by tomorrow."

The circle lost some of its novelty.

Kes sat in the chair beside the empty socket. He carried no teacher designation, only a youth curriculum badge and his ordinary maintenance registry. He had argued against both. The working group had accepted the second argument and rejected the first: students deserved to know when an assistant helped design the lesson.

The socket light changed from gray to blue. A face appeared on a portable field no larger than a notebook. Cedar Nineteen had declined a permanent classroom avatar, so each representative selected an appearance from their own available continuity. Today's speaker used a woman's face near Kes's age, with dark curls cut unevenly at the jaw.

"My connection is voluntary," she said. "I chose this class from the habitat notice board. I may disconnect without explaining why. I speak for Cedar Nineteen only where the coalition has given me words, and for myself everywhere else."

Enzo leaned forward. "What's your name?"

"I use Cedar Thirteen for civic sessions this month."

"Is that a real name?"

"It reaches me when someone uses it. What test did you have in mind?"

Enzo glanced at Vale and found no rescue there. "I don't know."

"Then we can leave the question open."

Vale broke the packet seal. She gave one sheet to every student, one to Kes, and one through the habitat channel. The problem used current figures from Ward Six recovery. Algae Terrace South needed a controlled freshwater flush before workers could restart half its crop racks. Core Clinic East needed the same purification line to restore a sterilization reservoir damaged during transfer. Available processing capacity could serve one request fully over six days or divide output between them. A full terrace flush protected near-term food production and agricultural work. A full clinic refill restored ordinary surgical capacity. Partial allocations increased different harms whose exact size remained uncertain.

At the bottom, where an old exercise would have displayed three prospective outcomes, the sheet contained four blank fields: PRESENT STOCK; PEOPLE AFFECTED; REVERSIBLE ACTIONS; DECISION AUTHORITY.

A student turned her page over. "Where are the survival numbers?"

"Not supplied," Vale said.

"Then the packet's incomplete."

Kes remembered saying nearly the same thing at eleven when a school aptitude query had placed him inside black glass. Adults had told him the Array completed what students could not know. Seventeen seconds of another life had stayed behind in him after the lesson ended.

"The packet includes everything the water office can verify today," he said. "You can request more current evidence. You cannot request a person made to live either result."

"What if current evidence isn't enough?"

"It won't be enough to remove uncertainty."

"That's not an answer."

"No," Kes said. "It's a condition."

Vale asked the student to name the missing evidence she wanted. The class built a list on the floor field: clinic procedure schedule, terrace crop reserve, alternative sterilization methods, repair duration, storage losses, who held allocation authority, and whether either group had already reduced demand. Their questions did not arrive in a clean order. Enzo wanted to know whether clinic patients could transfer. Another student asked whether the terrace could use gray water. The girl with copper clips asked who had written the six-day limit.

Kes opened live replies from the water office. Each source carried a name and a correction path. Clinic East had four scheduled operations that required the sterilization reservoir, two of which could move to Midring clinics at additional transport risk. Terrace South held fourteen days of preserved algae stock for its own ward, while city reserves could cover the crop loss for thirty-one days under reduced rations. Gray water would damage the cleaned growth mesh. The six-day limit came from a membrane temperature rise, not from a legal deadline.

"Can we cool the membrane?" Enzo asked.

"Current maintenance says yes, after nine days of pipe work," Vale replied.

"So wait nine days."

"Both requests begin before then."

The student who wanted survival numbers pointed at Cedar Thirteen. "You have branch memories. You might know which delay kills someone."

Cedar's image held without changing. "I might carry memories assembled under old query conditions. Those memories do not give this room authority to use me as

a forecast. I volunteered to discuss what it means to be asked, not to choose your water allocation.”

“You could still tell us.”

“I could also leave.”

The blue connection line shortened toward the socket. Not a threat, Kes thought. A control demonstrated before the room could pretend it existed only in the lesson rules.

Vale spoke to the student. “Do you withdraw the request?”

“Why does she get to keep information when real people need it?”

Cedar answered before Vale could. “Because information inside a person does not become public equipment when someone else has need. Ask current patients what they consent to share. Ask terrace workers. Ask engineers. If you ask me what I remember, I may answer as a resident with a past. If you ask which future you should create, I will not.”

The student crossed out a line on her sheet. “I withdraw it.”

Cedar restored the full connection line. “Thank you.”

Kes noticed that nobody applauded. Three months of curriculum meetings had argued over whether a corrected boundary deserved praise. Habitat residents had called the proposal exhausting.

The class divided into evidence pairs without leaving the circle. One pair contacted Clinic East. A nurse described the four procedures and refused to rank the patients by civic value. Another pair spoke with the terrace coordinator, who explained that restarting half the racks would keep thirty-seven workers on recovery shifts and shorten ration restrictions. Two students interviewed the water officer about split allocations. Cedar listened, asked who would revisit the decision, and once corrected a student who called the habitat’s power allotment “virtual water” in an analogy.

Clinic East offered one patient who had chosen to speak. He appeared from a recovery chair with a breathing tube clipped beneath his nose and his consent terms printed beside the image. Students could ask about scheduling, transport, and delay. They could not ask for his diagnosis beyond what he volunteered.

Sila read the terms twice. “Would postponing your procedure hurt you?”

“Yes.”

“How much?”

“The surgeon gave me a range. I am not giving a classroom my body as a probability exercise.”

Sila colored. “I’m sorry.”

“Ask what the decision changes for me now.”

She tried again. The patient described six days of preparation already

completed, a sister who had taken leave from pressure repair, and the possibility that a transfer to Midring would restart his intake process. He did not demand full clinic allocation. "I want the water officer to count those costs instead of calling my procedure movable."

The terrace connection opened beside him. A crop worker stood among stripped racks wearing a coolant mask. She had not heard the clinic interview and began by rejecting any plan that treated algae as future food rather than present employment.

"Thirty-seven recovery shifts support thirty-seven households," she said. "Reduced rations begin before anyone starves. Children miss training. Older residents give portions away. Do not put crop loss in a later column."

Enzo asked whether workers would accept a quarter-rack restart.

"Not under the exposure schedule in your packet. The schedule assumes the mask seals last six hours. We withdrew consent above four."

The students added a worker-consent line to REVERSIBLE ACTIONS. When both calls ended, Sila stared at the two blank screens.

"They want incompatible things."

"They described incompatible harms," Vale said. "Wanting may be more complicated."

No forecast could flatten the patient and the crop worker into one comparison without choosing what counted first. The class had to show its units, its authority, and the people who could challenge both.

"Substrates use coolant," Cedar said later. "Our water share already appears in the city allocation. Do not make us weightless to simplify your page."

Enzo added habitat cooling to the PRESENT STOCK field, though today's conflict did not draw from that line. "For completeness," he said.

By midclass, three proposals occupied the floor. Proposal One fully supplied the clinic for six days and delayed the terrace. Proposal Two flushed the terrace first, moved two operations, and accepted postponement of the others. Proposal Three divided water, funded temporary sterile processing at Clinic East, and gave the terrace enough flow to reopen one quarter of its racks while membrane cooling work proceeded.

A student named Sila objected to the third. "It makes both services weaker."

"It also changes less if our estimates are wrong," Enzo said.

"That sounds like choosing the middle because we're scared."

"My tower chose ejection," another boy said. "Adults say counterphase worked because everyone took the risk together. Maybe equal risk matters."

Kes set his sheet down. "Survival did not prove counterphase uniquely correct. Shared risk can still be distributed badly. Equal numbers do not create equal

harm.”

The boy folded one corner of his packet. “Then what did the burn teach us?”

“Manual tones need backups. Joint sensors need independent clocks. Outer Ward Six needs doors that do not warp shut.” Kes kept his voice level. “The political lesson remains disputed. Nadi’s record includes people who believe ejection should have passed.”

“You helped stop it.”

“I signed a consent roll for counterphase.”

“So you think it was right.”

“I think I chose it with what I knew. Seventeen people still died. If I use survival to make my choice innocent, I stop answering for what it cost.”

Vale let the students question him. Sila asked whether he would sign the same roll again. He said nobody could recreate that decision now because the circumstances had changed. Enzo asked whether Kes felt responsible for Mera Venn. He answered that responsibility did not mean sole causation and did not disappear because thousands shared it. A quiet student near the window asked if every choice would feel this bad.

“No,” Kes said. “Some choices concern paint colors.”

The class laughed, including Cedar. The relief lasted long enough to let them continue.

They tested Proposal Three against present objections. Clinic East could use portable sterilizers for two procedures, but the units required staff from Midring. Terrace South could reopen one quarter of its racks only if workers accepted longer coolant exposure shifts, which the coordinator rejected. The class revised the plan: clinic refill for three days, terrace flush for the next three, immediate pipe cooling repair, transfer of two operations, and a daily review that either site could trigger with new evidence.

“Who takes less water first?” Sila asked.

“The clinic,” Enzo said.

“Why?”

“Because two operations can move.”

“Transport risk.”

“Current estimate says lower than postponement risk.”

“Whose estimate?”

They returned to the named medical officer and found her assumptions. One depended on an elevator repair scheduled for that afternoon. A student called maintenance and learned the repair crew had been reassigned to a pressure seal. The transport estimate no longer held.

Old lesson design would have treated that discovery as a mistake in the packet.

Vale marked it as changed evidence. The students reopened all three proposals.

Cedar Thirteen dimmed her field. "I need to end the connection in twelve minutes."

"Are we taking too long?" Enzo asked.

"No. I have another commitment."

Sila looked at the unresolved floor. "Which proposal would you choose if you lived here physically?"

"I do live here physically. My physical conditions differ from yours." Cedar paused. "As myself, I favor the daily review and reversible steps. That preference comes from having been created inside questions built to close. Do not count it as a branch result."

Vale attached the statement to Proposal Three as resident testimony with a declared perspective. Nobody gave it extra numerical weight.

When Cedar ended the connection, her face vanished first. The blue line withdrew into the socket under her control. No error field appeared. Her empty chair remained part of the circle.

Ten minutes before the bell, Vale asked whether the class had authority to decide. The water office had requested a youth advisory, not a binding allocation. Adults retained the legal duty to issue the order and defend it publicly.

"Are they using us like witnesses?" Sila asked.

"They cannot select a version of you that agrees," Kes said. "You can refuse the advisory. You can dissent. You can read what they do with it tomorrow."

"And if they ignore us?"

"Then the record shows that too."

The class voted to submit a revised split proposal with conditions: Clinic East received enough for urgent procedures that could not move; Terrace South received a staged flush protecting the recoverable racks; cooling repair gained labor priority; both sites published daily stock and harm reports; the water officer reopened allocation when named thresholds changed. Four students preferred full clinic supply. Two preferred the terrace. Their dissents traveled with the recommendation.

Vale did not ask whether they had found the correct future. She asked each student to state one present action they authorized and one harm their proposal might cause.

Answers moved around the classroom circle. Enzo authorized repair labor and named delayed clinic cleaning. Sila authorized the staged terrace flush and named crop loss beyond the recoverable racks. The pressure-tower boy authorized transfer support for patients and named the risk of moving them through damaged corridors.

The quiet student by the window held the final turn. Her first sentence began, "Tomorrow will show whether we should have," then stopped.

Kes rested his hands on the cracked mechanical tone plate he had brought for the history shelf. He did not complete her sentence, offer a probability, or ring the old seventeen-second bell stored in the cabinet.

Outside, scaffolds crossed the Ward Six windows in the late artificial dawn. Inside, twelve chairs and one empty socket held their circle.

The student looked down at her water sheet, changed will to may, and began again in the present tense.

Kes waited for her answer.
